

U P G R A D E Y O U R R E L A T I O N S H I P

MARRIAGE 2.0

S E A S O N O N E



W R I T T E N B Y

MAX SEBASTIAN

UPGRADE YOUR RELATIONSHIP

Marriage — it's so last century, right?

Think again.

This is **Marriage 2.0**

The modern relationship, **upgraded**.

In modern America, **nearly half of all married couples** end up calling in the divorce lawyers. The average marriage lasts only 8 years. And as for second marriages, around 80% end up in divorce.

But there is an alternative to the Great Break-Up.

Welcome to Marriage 2.0.

Marriage 2.0 has developed a proprietary technology based on **exhaustive experience** and **expensive research**, that can discover your inner desires, and those of your partner—even desires that are so secret, you might not have known you had them yourself.

And, based on your personal preferences and your **hottest, most erotic fantasies**, Marriage 2.0 will create adventures to completely transform your relationship—and re-light the flames of lust between you and your partner.

In this groundbreaking book, you will read about how ordinary couples are revolutionizing their relationships, bringing **red-hot passion** back to their marriages — all with a little help from Marriage 2.0.

- A powerful billionaire discovers that true happiness does not require a succession of ever-younger wives.

- A couple vacationing in Rome has their sex lives unexpectedly reinvigorated after finding their AirBnB apartment has been double-booked.
 - With conventional marriage counseling failing, a couple finds their desire for each other rekindled after being stopped by the police.
 - A husband and wife coming to terms with a failure to conceive discovers the unexpected delights of sexual liberation.
-

Bestselling erotica author **Max Sebastian** brings you illuminating erotic tales of husbands and wives exploring alternatives to their conventional monogamous relationships under the guidance of **Marriage 2.0**, an agency using the latest technology to rethink modern life.

Marriage 2.0

Upgrade Your Relationship

marriage-2-0.com

MARRIAGE 2.0

SEASON ONE

MAX SEBASTIAN

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Second Edition 2022 - *Revised for serialization at [Medium.com/marriage-2.0](https://medium.com/marriage-2.0)*

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INTRODUCTION

Welcome to Marriage 2.0 — the modern relationship, upgraded.

Marriage 2.0 is all about making life more thrilling for couples, particularly those who have been together for a while, and may need a little prompt to remember why they fell for each other in the first place.

After all, why shouldn't dating be as fun for those who have already met the right person, as for those who haven't?

Here is a little introduction to some of the couples who have used the program to reinvigorate their relationships. You'll find out more about them in **Marriage 2.0: Season One**.

Claire and Robert

Claire and Robert have been together 11 years, and while they have settled into a cozy marriage, over the years the passion between them has faded. They sign up to Marriage 2.0 to rediscover their passion for each other. Their Marriage 2.0 adventure takes them by surprise, beginning on a vacation in Rome, Italy.

Frank and Jenni

After being tempted to cheat on wife Jenni, successful businessman Frank goes to Marriage 2.0 seeking help to save his marriage and his family. Follow Frank as he goes through the Marriage 2.0 process, and discovers an unconventional way to rekindle the desire he and his wife have for each other.

Glenn and Emily

Glenn and Emily are young parents, and the stress of family life saps their desire for each other, and leads them into petty arguments that further eats at their sexual connection. Their Marriage 2.0 adventure comes as quite a surprise when it finally arrives.

Melissa and Adam

New Yorkers Melissa and Adam have been through a bad experience trying for kids through IVF, and felt like they needed something to spark up their romance again. After watching an ad in a movie theater, they decide to try Marriage 2.0 — but when their adventure comes, it is most unexpected.

Read on for more about our lovely, happy, Marriage 2.0 couples...

CLAIRE AND ROBERT

The apartment was just phenomenal.

Stepping out of the taxi after a long, sweaty ride from the airport, they entered a gateway and proceeded away from the street, through to a magnificent cobbled courtyard in the middle of the building.

The place looked like some wonderful museum — and this was just an apartment building. It had to be at least three or four hundred years old. Stone balustrades surrounded the open atrium on each floor, with potted plants spraying out a diffusion of relaxed vegetation as the stairs wound their way upward.

The only problem was there was no elevator.

The museum atmosphere didn't end when they reached the front door of the apartment itself. Inside, high ceilings drew the eyes up to fading but elegant frescoes that seemed impossibly luxurious for an ordinary residential home. The furniture was all antique, with plenty of polished walnut, mahogany, and teak. Clean, tall white walls hosted gilt-edged paintings and luxurious mirrors. Gilt-laden chandeliers hung from the roof.

'Wow,' Claire said as they reached the living room, only just managing to stay on their feet. Sweating and aching and seething after a long flight across the Atlantic, and an even longer-seeming journey in a battered old taxi from the airport into the center of Rome.

And Robert could only echo what she said.

'It's like a goddamn museum!'

They'd seen pictures on the Airbnb website, of course. But every place looks charming on AirBnB. This was, to their complete surprise, jaw-droppingly astonishing. And just \$154 a night, too, located right in the middle of the city.

‘There’s no television,’ Claire said, standing up straight as she regained her breath more quickly than her husband.

‘We’re... not here... to watch TV,’ Robert said, still doubled over.

‘I know,’ Claire gave him a slight eye-roll. ‘I just mean — you know. People live here, don’t they? They rent it out when they’re not here, but they live here otherwise. And there’s no TV.’

‘Maybe there’s a TV in the bedroom.’

Robert thinking, maybe the owners of this place sit around all day on chaise longues, sipping Italian coffee while reading from leather-bound books and swapping mildly witty conversation about high art and culture. Maybe the people who lived here were simply not Americans who got home every night and immediately flipped on the TV so they could zone out from ordinary life.

As Robert recovered enough from the climb to stand fully upright, Claire wandered through to the bedroom and let out a high-pitch shriek.

‘Oh... uh... hello?’ he heard his wife saying.

What?

Robert rushed over to the bedroom, which was just as extravagantly furnished as the rest of the apartment. Upon arriving at his wife’s side, he found a man lying on the bed. The guy was dressed in a ridiculously tight t-shirt and striped Adidas sweatpants and didn’t look like a local.

‘Are you... the owners?’ Claire said.

‘No, we’re not.’ Another voice came from over by the windows, making Robert just about jump out of his skin. ‘Are you?’

A blonde woman, wearing a bright scarlet top that looked expensive, and what looked like black leggings, stepped in from the ensuite bathroom. Her expression seemed like she’d caught a waiter spitting in her salad.

‘It looks to me as though we’ve been double-booked,’ she said with a melodramatic sigh.

‘Oh, *Jesus*,’ Claire said, looking at Robert, horror on her face.

The guy on the bed just moaned and lay back on the mattress, arms and legs outstretched like he was trying to make snow angels in the white bedsheets.

Robert waited for a heartbeat or three, and when no one else volunteered to actually do anything about the situation they were in, he said, ‘Well, should I call the guy Lorenzo, or whatever his name was?’

‘Somebody should,’ the blonde woman said. She was very attractive but struck Robert immediately as the princess type.

‘Thank you, Rob,’ Claire said quietly, giving him a sweet smile.

His phone seemed to be working, at least, although the network was 'TIM' rather than AT&T. He found the number on the print-out he had folded up in his jeans back pocket and wandered back into the living room to make the call. Claire drifted along in his wake.

The phone rang three times, and then Robert heard a stream of Italian that just seemed like noise, or perhaps someone with an extremely loud television on in the background. 'Uh... hello? Hello? Is this Lorenzo?'

'Si. This is Lorenzo,' came a deep, masculine voice that made Robert think of a walrus.

'Uh... hi. It's Robert here — we've rented the apartment from you. Through Airbnb.'

'Ah, si, Airbnb,' came the reply.

Claire watched her husband contending with the man on the phone and shivered at the thought that some kind of error with their booking might mean they would have nowhere to stay. That all the hotels in the area would be booked up, and they'd be forced to spend the week in some slum on the outside of town, where it would take them three hours just to get back into the city each day to take in the sights.

Robert was talking in circles. His face was going red, the blood vessels on his temple becoming prominent, as they did when he was angry or stressed. He even tried dropping in a little rudimentary Italian, to no apparent success.

The blonde woman stepped out of the bedroom to see what was happening. Even if he wouldn't like to admit it, he was quite taken with her beauty. She looked like one of those people who travel around the world and do little other than put impossibly glamorous photographs onto Instagram and somehow earn a living.

'They've double-booked us,' Robert said, at last, steam practically coming out of his ears.

'Well, duh,' the blonde woman said.

'He says it's not his fault, but he knows somebody he can call at AirBnB...' Robert said, sighing and running a hand through his prematurely graying hair. 'He says something about waiting for a text message. I think... we're supposed to wait for a text message.'

'God,' the blonde woman said and returned to the bedroom.

Robert sighed again, and Claire took his hand before leading him to the windows. They could part the billowing white linen curtains and gaze out of the tall windows into the courtyard below. There were no other signs of life in the building except in their apartment.

'What do you think will happen?' Claire said.

‘I don’t know. Maybe they’ll be able to find us another apartment somewhere.’

‘Do you think we’ll get to keep this one?’ she offered a hopeful smile.

Robert laughed. ‘Things never work out like that, do they?’

She thought he was too cynical, but it was undoubtedly the case that this apartment did seem a touch too good to be true.

‘I suppose we can complain, maybe get some money back,’ she said.

Robert shrugged. ‘We’ll see what happens. I guess if we haven’t received this text message, or whatever it is, in half an hour, I’ll have to call Lorenzo back.’

It was so frustrating. They were so tired and just wanted to flop down on that enormous bed — except that an obnoxious man was lying on it already, and his waspish partner haunting the rest of the bedroom.

They waited.

They only had a week in Rome. It seemed pretty poor that they would have to spend their first afternoon sorting out this accommodation screw-up.

Robert sat there on a couch that was too ornamental to be comfortable, stewing. Claire quietly wandered around the room, examining all the pictures, the furniture, the fixtures, and fittings, as though this really was some world-renowned museum.

Twenty minutes after Robert hung up on Lorenzo, he did, indeed, receive a text message. The strange thing was, they all did. Claire felt her own phone vibrate in her shorts pocket at the exact moment that Robert’s phone bleeped. And Claire didn’t remember switching her phone back on since they’d taken off from JFK.

‘Oh *Jesus*,’ Robert said, reacting first because his phone had been already in his hand. His tone of voice dampened Claire’s spirits before she even had the chance to look at her own phone.

Then, when she did look at her own phone, she was confused.

‘What the fuck — ?’ Robert said.

The message didn’t come from some random European number she didn’t recognize. It didn’t come from an unknown US number, either. It came from a named contact — *Marriage 2.0*.

Claire's heart seemed to stop the moment she saw the name on her phone.

No. Surely, it couldn't be?

She read the message:

Marriage 2.0: *You may unpack your bags. You will be staying in this apartment for the entire duration of your stay in Rome.*

She scratched her head. She felt uplifted about being able to stay here if that was true — but why was Marriage 2.0 sending them a message about all this? Was AirBnB part of the same company? Weird. And they hadn't even heard back from Marriage 2.0 since registration day.

Perhaps her phone had gotten its contacts mixed up.

Claire was also confused about Robert's frustrated reaction to the text message, given that they were being allowed to stay in this lovely apartment just a stone's throw away from the Piazza Navona, right in the heart of the city.

Robert said, 'Well, I guess we'd better book another taxi.'

Claire furrowed her brow as she looked at him. 'What are you talking about?'

He sighed, 'Well, I'm pretty sure it's just over the other side of the river, but I sure as hell don't have the energy to walk right now.'

'What do you mean? What's just over the other side of the river?'

Robert showed her his phone. 'The apartment they want us to move to,' he said.

Claire gasped. Robert hadn't received the same message she had — but his text message had also come from Marriage 2.0.

Marriage 2.0: *You'll be moving to an apartment near the Basilica di Santa Maria in Trastevere. Address details will follow.*

Now Claire showed him the message she had received.

Robert gave a big eye roll and heaved a huge sigh.

'Jesus,' he said. 'You just wish they'd get something sorted out. So there's another apartment across the river. Let's just get our things and head back out to find a taxi.'

He was on the phone to Lorenzo again, only this time the phone was ringing and ringing and ringing, and there was no sign of the deep-voiced Italian on the other end.

After a few minutes, the blonde woman came out of the bedroom, trailing a dainty-looking pink suitcase behind her.

She said to them, 'I think I'm supposed to go to another apartment across the river.'

Robert and Claire froze, completely confused.

‘You got messages like this, right?’ The blonde stepped over to them and showed them her phone — it was huge, Claire would have said it was nearly a tablet, but it made it easy to read the screen.

Marriage 2.0: *You’ll be moving to an apartment near the Basilica di Santa Maria in Trastevere. Address details will follow.*

Gillian: *I’m sorry, do you mean I’ll be moving there with Mason? Only, you seem to have sent a different message to my husband by mistake.*

Marriage 2.0: *There has been no mistake. Address details for your apartment will follow.*

Claire could just about figure out that this blonde woman, presumably named Gillian, had texted Marriage 2.0 back instead of trying to call Lorenzo. But what did it mean when it replied to say there had been no mistake?

Robert said, ‘I don’t understand... what does it mean, ‘there has been no mistake’?’

‘Mason’s message told him he’s staying here in this apartment,’ the blonde, Gillian, said. ‘What did your messages say?’

Claire and Robert showed her their phone screens. Gillian gave a little laugh. ‘I thought they might have given us an apartment each,’ she said and then looked at Robert. ‘But I guess you get to come with me to the other place, huh?’

Robert said, ‘What — ?’

Claire felt suddenly cold and vaguely sick. ‘What are you talking about?’

Gillian smiled as though her cool exterior had thawed a little out of empathy for their confusion. She said, ‘Don’t you understand? This is *Marriage 2.0*. Did they never tell you what would happen after you signed up?’

‘*What — ?*’ Claire stammered.

Robert insisted, ‘Of course they did,’ as though Gillian was making him feel stupid. ‘We just didn’t expect them to get in touch *now. Here.*’

Gillian nodded and shrugged, silently saying, ‘So there you go, right? *So we do what they say.*’

He looked toward the bedroom, from where Gillian’s husband, Mason, now emerged to see what was going on out here. Robert wondered if there was another bedroom in this apartment, because there didn’t seem to be any kind of a sofa bed out here in the living room. And yet where would a second bedroom be located? There was the little

kitchenette off this living room, but no other doorways save for the front door.

How would sleeping arrangements work in here?

There was another beeping-and-buzzing sound as they all received another message. Claire looked at hers:

Marriage 2.0: *Say goodbye to your husband. His taxi is waiting outside. You'll see him again at the airport next Saturday.*

Claire felt her head spinning. What the hell was going on? She was being left on her own in this apartment with a complete stranger? Robert was going across town with a pretty blonde he had no reason to be going anywhere with?

Robert gave Claire a funny kind of look that seemed to suggest that they ought to go along with this, whatever it was. They had signed up with Marriage 2.0, after all. They'd paid good money for it, too.

'You think it'll be okay?' she said.

He gave her an attempt at a reassuring smile. 'They told us it might seem strange at first, didn't they?'

'I suppose so,' she nodded.

'We'll just be seeing the sights with other people this week,' he said. 'I suppose it'll give us the chance to focus on the city, rather than... you know...'

...Rather than the tension in our relationship, Claire silently finished his sentence.

'I guess so,' she said, glancing at Mason, whose smile seemed genuine enough. However, she still wondered what it was going to be like touring the great classical city of Rome with a guy who looked like he spent most of his time in the gym.

So weird. So, so weird.

But they were supposed to do what the text messages told them to. That was the whole point of Marriage 2.0.

And so, Claire went down to the street with Robert and kissed him goodbye — before watching him climb into the awaiting taxi, along with the pretty blonde woman.

Then, the taxi drove away, leaving Claire alone with Mason.

‘Have you done this before?’ Robert asked Gillian as they sat in the back of a sweltering taxi that reeked of stale cigarette smoke, heading toward the river.

‘You mean *Rome*... or...?’ her tone alluded to their latest quandary.

‘Touring a foreign city with someone who isn’t your husband,’ he said and attempted a relaxed smile while subtly wiping sweat from his brow.

‘No,’ she said, with a slight shake of her head that seemed oddly flirtatious. ‘We just signed up for... we just signed up last week, you know?’ She smiled, trying to hide mild embarrassment.

‘Oh, right.’

‘Saw the advertising, you know? Thought it might be fun. Try something different,’ she said, trying not to blush since it was so evident with her complexion. She looked down at the guidebook open on her lap as though studying it, but it seemed to Robert she was using it as a prop to cope with this whole awkward tension.

‘You guys... been married long?’ he asked her and suddenly felt he was going beyond polite friendliness and into intrusiveness. He gave her an apologetic look.

She shrugged off his silent apology. ‘Three years,’ she said, opening a window, although the taxi was traveling too slowly for it to really offer much air, and the street outside smelled vaguely worse than the taxi interior. ‘God, do they have any air-conditioning in this city?’

Robert chuckled. ‘I think they did in that apartment back there.’

‘You think they’ll give us something similar?’

He tilted his head. ‘Knowing my luck, probably not.’

‘Your luck?’ she grinned.

‘I guess I’m a bit of a pessimist,’ he said, somewhat sheepishly.

‘Oh, you shouldn’t be,’ she said. ‘Be an optimist. It’s much better. We’ll be staying in the Trastevere area, it’s quite well-located, I think. Even if the apartment’s a slum.’

‘Well, that’s something.’

‘We could do the Vatican tomorrow — it’s only a walk away, I think.’

Robert smiled. ‘Sounds good.’

Perhaps it would be nice to tour the city with someone different, for a change. Take a break from Claire, and then at the end of the week, well, absence makes the heart grow fonder and all that. He was pleased that Gillian seemed interested in actually getting out and seeing the city. Sometimes Claire could be so passive, preferring not to do too much, even if they were traveling to a place as historically saturated as Rome.

Across the river, the taxi squeezed itself into ever smaller cobbled streets until they reached a tiny little lane flanked on either side by apartment buildings painted shades of terra-cotta pink, yellow, and orange. Most of the windows had brown shutters to block the afternoon sun. Here, the taxi stopped, and the driver got out to pull their suitcases out of the trunk.

‘This is it?’ Robert asked him while trying to surreptitiously resolve a mild, sweat-induced wedgie situation with his chinos.

‘Si, si,’ the driver said, nodding while pulling out a cigarette.

‘Uh... how much do we owe you?’

‘Uh, no, no,’ the man shook his head as he looked at Robert flicking through the unfamiliar bills in his wallet. ‘Uh... e fatto... gli altri hanno pagato...’

Robert nodded and put his wallet away.

‘Well, thank you.’

The man nodded and stepped back to his vehicle to light up his cigarette. Robert turned to find Gillian already opening the front door of the building before them.

‘It’s open,’ she said, squinting at her phone screen. ‘This is the address they’ve given us. Apartment 4.’

‘I guess we should just go in, then.’

It wasn’t nearly as grand as the place they’d left their respective spouses in. Inside the front door was nothing much more than a concrete stairway, with white-washed walls on either side. Clean, at least.

Robert offered to carry Gillian's case along with his own, and she seemed mildly surprised by his courtesy.

'Italians don't have elevators, huh?' she said as they began the climb up to the fourth apartment, which turned out to be on the third floor.

The door to Apartment 4 was open, too, with a set of keys protruding from the lock. 'Do you suppose we take these?' Gillian said, promptly taking them anyway.

'Well, if we're here for the week, presumably.'

Inside, the apartment seemed small and surprisingly modern compared to the exterior of the building — but it was definitely not the jaw-dropping interior that they had left Claire and Mason in.

'Oh,' Gillian said as they poked their noses around the place. 'Well, it's clean, at least. A little small.'

'Yeah, fairly small,' Robert nodded, silently thinking that it was probably twice the size of the place he and Claire rented in Brooklyn. There was a relatively large living room and a decent-sized bedroom, even if the kitchen and bathroom were like shoeboxes.

'Can we last a week in here?' Gillian said, dropping her suitcase by the wardrobe in the bedroom. Robert couldn't quite tell if she was joking or not. He didn't know her well enough.

'Well, you said yourself we'll be mostly out of here, won't we?' he said. 'We only need to come back here to sleep.'

Gillian dropped onto the bed, saying, 'I hope the mattress isn't too soft.'

Robert stood back awkwardly, running a hand through his hair. 'I can... probably sleep in the living room.'

'It's not too bad; it'll do,' she said, rolling onto her back. Robert wasn't sure she'd heard him. But then she said, 'Will you be all right in there?'

'I'm sure we'll figure it out,' he said, stepping back out to look at the possibilities in the living room. The couch looked okay to sit on, but it didn't look like much for sleeping on — far too narrow, with wooden arms.

As he was checking out what kind of floor space there might be if you moved the coffee table out of the way between the couch and the TV, Robert heard his phone bleep.

Another message.

There was a loud squeal from the bedroom, and he knew Gillian must have received a message as well. He pulled out his phone, feeling a

certain trepidation about seeing what it was, though he knew exactly who it was from.

Marriage 2.0: *Welcome to your adventure in Rome. There is only one rule: treat Gillian exactly as though she is your wife. Respond 'stop' to cancel this adventure any time.*

He wandered back into the bedroom. Gillian was kneeling on the floor by her open suitcase, unpacking and putting items onto the bed.

'You got it as well?' she asked him, turning her phone toward him so that he could see she'd received the identical message he had, except hers told her to treat Robert as though he was her husband.

'What does it mean, 'respond 'stop' to cancel this adventure'?'

She said, 'I guess it means we can stop all this if we text back the word 'stop'.'

'Oh,' Robert nodded.

'But you know it's all over if you do that?'

'It's *all* over?'

She nodded and smiled up at him. 'You've paid all that money to them and for basically nothing.'

'You can't get them to... start things up again?'

She shook her head. 'Not without signing up with them again. Paying another fee, I'll bet. Do you mind... if I ask you *why* you guys signed up for it?' she asked him, her playful tone making light of her question's effrontery.

Robert sighed and leaned back against the bedroom doorway. 'Claire and I... we love each other, but, you know... there's no... *excitement* anymore.'

'You mind me asking... do you still find her attractive?'

He shrugged. 'Yes. No. I don't know. Sometimes.'

He felt terrible about saying that. Guilty.

He shrugged and said, 'I guess we both figure... if we really *wanted* sex, we could have it. Whenever. We don't need to make an effort to... you know... look nice, or whatever. And then we figure... we *know* what sex is like with each other. Why not just skip it until we're really desperate? Save the bother. Only... we're *never* really desperate.'

Robert felt himself flushing, his cheeks hot. *Oops, perhaps I revealed too much.*

But Gillian didn't look as though he'd overshared. She simply nodded, then smirked. 'Mason and I get desperate all the time,' she said.

'Then why did you guys do it?' Robert asked and then added, politely, 'if you don't mind me asking?'

She laughed. 'We're always arguing. Over stupid things, really. I know usually it's all going to blow over, but sometimes... you know, you wonder if you're with the right person. You look at other married couples, and they're so... into each other... and you wonder if you're doing it wrong...'

'I think *everybody* wonders if they're doing it wrong,' he said and made her laugh.

She brushed her shoulder-length blonde hair back behind her, offering him a better view as she sat down there on her haunches to unpack some disturbingly high-heeled black shoes.

'How long have you two been together?' she asked him, and it seemed all right to ask personal questions now. The tension seemed to have lessened.

'Ooo... eleven, twelve years?' he said. 'We were together a few years before we married, though.'

'Impressive. You're a little older than us?'

'I'm 40. She's 36,' he said.

'31,' Gillian grinned. 'Sometimes even 29 if I need to be. Mason's 31, too.'

'Makes me feel like a dinosaur,' Robert chuckled.

'No, not a dinosaur,' she said, offering a nice smile. 'You're my husband now.'

Robert left his things in his suitcase, which wasn't unusual if he and Claire were only traveling for a week or so.

While Gillian took a shower, he flicked on the television. It was an ancient thing that still used a cathode ray tube — and nothing was showing but Italian talk shows and game shows that seemed to have absolutely no rules.

Ignoring the TV, instead he found himself exploring the cupboards in the kitchen. The place was well-stocked. There was probably enough food to get them through the week if they didn't feel like going out.

When Gillian emerged from the shower, towel wrapped around her body, she said: 'I'm sorry, I think I used up all the hot water. I didn't realize there was, you know, *a limit*.'

Robert nodded. 'I'll just take one later,' he said, trying not to think of what she might look like under that towel.

‘Hey, you want to head out, get a bite to eat somewhere?’ she asked him.

‘Uh... sure, that would be nice. Hey, do you think we should phone the others? You know — let them know we’re okay, and so on.’

‘If you want,’ Gillian said, on her way back to the bedroom. ‘I think Mason will just assume I’m okay!’

Robert pulled out his phone. It didn’t switch on. He groaned and went over to his suitcase to dig out his charger and an adaptor so that he could plug it into a European wall socket. Once it was all plugged in, he waited for a few moments, expecting it to switch back on once the battery had the minimum charge needed. It usually only took a minute or two.

But the phone still didn’t switch on.

He waited longer. Five minutes. Still nothing. Was it the European wall sockets? Perhaps they were a lower voltage. Frustrated, he said, ‘My phone battery died — could I use your phone?’ Walking to the bedroom, he wasn’t sure he could even remember Claire’s full number. God, modern technology has really made us stupid. Back in college, he’d have been able to remember Claire’s number and those of all his closest relatives.

He stepped around the bedroom doorway and found Gillian standing in front of the dressing table and mirror. She was wearing nothing but a pair of black thong panties — and scrabbled to cover her breasts with a matching bra when he suddenly appeared there.

‘Oh, sorry,’ he said, averting his gaze, although the sight of her in just her underwear was seared onto his retinas.

‘Are you spying on me?’ she said, and there was a distinct smile in her voice.

‘Uh... no, no, I was wondering if I could use your — ’

‘It’s okay,’ she said, interrupting him. ‘I am supposed to be treated as your wife this week, huh?’

He looked back in her direction, but she seemed to be doing up her bra incredibly slowly, perhaps hoping he’d catch sight of her like that again.

‘My phone’s not working,’ he said, trying to look her in the eye, via the mirror.

‘Oh, okay,’ she said, reaching for her phone, which lay on the bed beside her. ‘Here. You remember her number? You could call Mason, otherwise...’

He gave her an appreciative smile and took the phone from her. He switched it on. The blank screen did not respond. He pressed the power button again — and again, nothing.

‘Has yours run out of power too?’ he asked her.

‘No, it was at, like 84%,’ she said, stooping to pull on a pair of chic black skinny jeans. ‘I had it plugged in most of the way over from the States.’

Robert showed her the blank screen and demonstrated the art of pressing the power button a few times. She frowned. ‘I didn’t think my phone was out of battery, either,’ he said. ‘But it’s not working. Just like this.’

Gillian seemed to dance a little to get her tight jeans in place over her hips, and it made her breasts shake just enough to catch Robert’s interest again. She wasn’t being particularly shy in front of him. In fact, she could have easily closed the bedroom door while she changed but hadn’t.

‘So they don’t want us to call our spouses,’ she said, fastening her fly button, sounding as though she wasn’t particularly surprised.

‘You think they’ve purposefully messed with our phones?’

She looked at him and gave a wry smile. ‘You remember that long list of terms and conditions you agreed to when you registered with them?’ she said. ‘Twenty thousand words in six-point font.’

‘Still,’ Robert said. ‘It seems a bit much. I mean... what if there’s an emergency, and we need to call for help?’

‘They’re probably monitoring us, anyway,’ she said, putting on a bright scarlet tank top. ‘Don’t you think?’

‘Oh God, do you think so?’

He glanced up into the corners of the bedroom, looking for anything that might signal that there were hidden cameras placed around somewhere. Bugs in the walls. He probably wouldn’t be able to see them even if they were there.

‘Oh, hey, that is what we signed up to,’ she said, a smile spreading across her pretty face. When she noticed him looking in her direction, she stretched her top in place over her chest in such a way to emphasize her cleavage.

‘I suppose...’

‘Lighten up, buddy!’ she giggled. ‘Come on, we should just try and have some fun this week, don’t you think?’

Robert changed clothes, and then they went for a short preamble around the neighborhood, before discovering a little restaurant on the quiet Via Garibaldi, just opposite a police station. They were given a

lovely table in the courtyard at the rear and enjoyed some truly wonderful pasta over a few glasses of wine.

Over dinner, Robert learned that Gillian was a mid-level marketing executive for a Chicago-based insurance firm and that hubby Mason ran an expanding gym empire. And, before the meal was done, Gillian had boldly suggested that Robert's job as a high school English teacher and Gillian's job as an events planner had probably led to their mid-life crisis.

'Mid-life crisis? *What* Mid-life crisis?'

'You know, the one that made you sign up with Marriage 2.0.'

He laughed at that.

'I'd just like to point out that you and Mason signed up to the same service.'

'For *totally* different reasons,' Gillian grinned and took another huge swig of her chilled white wine. Robert took one himself. This was good stuff. Gavi. He didn't know much about Italian vino, but this was very drinkable.

'So you guys have loads of sex,' he said, realizing that all the wine had loosened his tongue. 'And all you do is argue every now and then.'

'*Loads* of sex,' Gillian confirmed, as though taunting him. The wine might have got to her, a little, too.

'But you're looking for something... a little different,' Robert furrowed his brow and raised an eyebrow as though to question Gillian and Mason's sanity.

'If you and Claire had the arguments that me and Mason have, you'd understand why,' she said.

'If Claire and I had the kind of *sex* that you and Mason have, then never mind the damn arguments,' Robert joked, and raised a glass as though toasting the other couple's sexual success.

'But you and Claire don't have arguments.'

'Claire and I don't have *sex*.'

Gillian smiled and pointed at him with the outer edge of her glass. 'So maybe,' she said, 'you need to learn to argue just a little bit... at least enough so that you'll have good sex.'

Robert took his final bite of pasta. 'And maybe you and Mason need to learn how to have a little *less* sex. And then you won't argue quite so much.'

'Sounds logical,' she said, but then after a bottle and a half of wine between them, logic was becoming relatively flexible.

‘This week,’ Robert pointed out, ‘will give you a perfect reason to cut down on sex. In fact, unless you can remember your way back to your husband’s apartment — and *I* can’t — I’m guessing you’ll get the opportunity to have no sex at all for the whole week.’

Then the blonde said, ‘Oh no, no, no,’ shaking her head. ‘There’s no way I’m going without sex for a whole week.’

‘You’re going to go find your husband?’

She shook her head and smiled, then pointed at him. ‘You’re my husband, remember? This whole week. *You* have to treat me like your wife.’

Robert chuckled, but his semi-drunken cock rather woke up within his chinos. ‘Would Mason be happy for you to do that sort of thing?’

‘Mason’s not my husband,’ she said. ‘Not this week. You read the message.’

‘I’m not sure that’s what it meant,’ he said, but his heart was hammering away. ‘You know, you could interpret it to mean that I’m supposed to treat you like *my wife* — I’m supposed to treat you like I’d treat Claire. That would mean no sex. Or at least, no sex unless she decides to have one last attempt at having kids.’

Gillian shook her head. ‘No, it doesn’t mean that. Because that would mean I would have to treat you the way I treat Mason.’

‘Oh, right?’ He had to admit, her wine-logic was sound again.

‘And that would mean I get sex this week. *Loads* of sex.’

They were a little unsteady on their feet when they walked home, stumbling on the cobbles, tripping on curbs, and even managing to miss steps when the terrain was perfectly flat. They would pitch forward suddenly, in torrents of giggles, sometimes caught by the other, sometimes falling onto all fours on the street.

The climb up all those stairs to the apartment felt as though it sobered them up a little, but they were still in a jovial mood.

Inside the apartment, Gillian went into the bedroom and collapsed face-forward onto the bed. Robert went to the little kitchenette to find a glass of water. He then headed into the bathroom for his long-delayed shower.

Thankfully, there was hot water by now, although apparently no shower curtain, so he had to be careful to keep the water in the shower.

Facing the white-tiled wall, Robert was washing off the soap when he heard another fit of giggles from behind him. He turned to find Gillian there, and she didn't have a stitch of clothing on. Wow. She was quite a sight.

'You're here,' she said, laughing. 'I just woke up and assumed it was Mason in here taking a shower.'

'Uh... yeah, it's me,' Robert said, holding his hands in front of his crotch in an attempt at modesty.

'Well, this is me,' the blonde said, not attempting to cover up. 'So I guess *that's* out of the way.'

Robert tried not to look as though he was checking her out, although she was very easy on the eye. God, did she shave her pussy? Did real people actually do that? When his gaze returned to her blue eyes, she smiled, and he blushed.

'Sorry,' he said, 'I'll turn around.'

‘Don’t be silly,’ she said, taking a step forward. ‘You’re my husband, right? This week? You’re going to see me naked.’

‘Oh.’

‘And I’m going to see you naked.’

She reached forward to pull his hands away from his cock. He felt drunk enough to let her.

‘Jesus, is that *real*?’ she blurted out and then giggled.

‘Huh?’

She was apparently staring at his cock.

‘Of course it’s real,’ he said, turning away from her, feeling seriously awkward.

‘Can I see it?’

‘I don’t think we should...’

‘Oh, go on. You’re my *husband*. The thing said we’re supposed to treat each other like husband and wife this week.’

‘I’ve told you,’ Robert chuckled, thinking that this situation was getting ridiculous, ‘if I treated you like *my* wife, there wouldn’t be any sex, maybe ever.’

‘But you *paid* the clever people at Marriage 2.0 to *change all that*, Robert.’

The pretty blonde now had her hand on his rapidly hardening cock. For God’s sake. She wasn’t even a bottle blonde.

‘Fuck me, it’s *huge*,’ she said, her voice trailing off into an awed whisper as she gripped his stiff shaft with one, then two hands.

‘I can’t cheat on my wife,’ he said in a quiet voice, as the beautiful 31-year-old started slowly stroking his cock, peeling down his foreskin, then pushing it back up.

‘It’s *beautiful*,’ she breathed. Then to him, she said softly, ‘This is your adventure, Robert. Didn’t you read that part of the text message?’

‘I did, but...’

Gillian grinned wickedly. ‘Don’t you think your wife...Caroline?’

‘Claire,’ he corrected her.

‘Claire — don’t you think Claire will be fucking Mason right about now?’ the blonde asked him.

Robert felt a jolt of surprise at that. He hadn’t really thought too much about Claire since dinner had started, since they’d started drinking. It was a bit of a shock to imagine that she might ever be tempted to sleep with another man. And yet logic would suggest that she would have the opportunity this week. If she and Mason were to interpret the text message from Marriage 2.0 in a similar way to Gillian...

‘Claire would never — ’

‘My Mason’s very persuasive when he’s horny,’ Gillian squeezed his cock to underline her point. ‘And you know what? He’s horny *most of the time*.’

‘Claire’s too...’ he didn’t want to say ‘boring’. God, was that what he thought of his loyal wife? ‘She’s too *proper* to do that. Too scrupulous.’

‘She got tested too, didn’t she?’ Gillian said, ducking down to kneel in front of him, as though she desperately needed to examine Robert’s cock close-up. ‘You *both* had your responses to certain sexual stimuli assessed extensively during your registration day, am I right?’

Robert had to give her a nod. All that had seemed bizarre at the time, yet they *had* bought into it — because Marriage 2.0 was supposed to be based on state-of-the-art technology.

‘And they used all that information to engineer this *adventure*, don’t you think?’

He felt her hot breath on his cock, and looked down to see her putting her mouth right up to it while avoiding actually touching it. Pretending to lick him, pretending to take him in her mouth, without yet doing so. It was an insane tease. It made him desperate for her to go down on him for real.

But Gillian had him thinking. Was this what their adventure was supposed to be? Was this kind of thing a secret fantasy for Claire? What if she had cheated on Robert already? Taking a firm interpretation of that text message, that she and Mason could do whatever they liked with each other this week because *they were husband and wife*.

‘Would you be angry at Claire for sleeping with Mason when she’s been told she’s his wife for this week?’ Gillian asked him, her eyes flashing up at him. ‘I mean... she’s not cheating on you, right? You’re not her husband this week.’

Robert thought of Claire with that guy Mason, that buff, gym-bunny-turned-owner, and the picture formed in his mind of the two of them going at it.

And thinking about that had a funny effect on Robert.

Gillian giggled, and Robert felt his cock accidentally nudge against her soft, warm cheek.

‘Sorry,’ she said, as though she had crossed a line of decency, even though she had the base of his cock gripped firmly in her hands. ‘I wasn’t expecting it to jump like that!’

‘It’s okay,’ he said quietly, confused about his feelings. He thought about Claire *cheating* on him — except that she wouldn’t really be

cheating because she'd been told she was Mason's wife this week. And because both she and Robert had consented to this Marriage 2.0 service. Apparently, this experience was shaped around their own sexual preferences and tastes, secret or otherwise.

'So you'd be okay, Claire figuring that she's all right to sleep with Mason this week?' Gillian prompted him, and Robert felt his cock throbbing in response — and no doubt it was that throbbing that made the naked blonde giggle again.

The funny thing was if he did as Gillian wanted and thought of Claire *fucking* some other guy, it made Claire seem so much more interesting. More than that, in fact. It made her seem so much more fucking *desirable*. He couldn't explain it.

He *wished* she would take advantage of this week and fuck Mason for all he was worth.

'You like it, don't you?' Gillian laughed, sounding triumphant. 'You like the idea of Claire being naughty with another guy.'

He felt her hot breath on the tip of his cock again and moaned quietly.

'So you have to figure that she'd be okay with you... treating me as a wife ought to be treated...'

Suddenly her lips were touching the tip of his cock, and stretching over the glans, and then she was taking him in her hot mouth, and it felt irresistible.

'Oh, God...'

But it felt so wrong.

'Wait, wait, wait, wait!'

Gillian pulled back and gazed up at him, somewhat surprised he could still resist her.

'What if my adventure... *our* adventure... is to try and *resist* temptation?' Robert said.

'How is *that* an adventure?'

He stifled a moan — she was still stroking his cock. 'Well... the whole point of the service is to strengthen your marriage, right?' he said. 'So maybe this time, it gets stronger because we've resisted the temptation... and when we get back together with our spouses... Well, you know, absence makes the heart grow fonder.'

Gillian kissed the tip of his cock. 'Okay...' she said. As the shower water fell pitter-patter all over them, Robert thought the pretty blonde seemed decidedly sober again. Her voice wasn't even slurring. 'Don't think about the reasons *why*, but right now, gut feeling, do you like the

idea of meeting up with a Claire next Saturday who spent the week having *naughty*, sexy, secret, *wild sex* with Mason...'

"Sexy' sex?" Robert grinned.

'Or, do you prefer the idea of meeting up with a Claire who has been good all week, resisted every ounce of temptation Mason has thrown her way. She's clean, she's wholesome, she's *boring*, she's exactly the same Claire you flew out of JFK with...'

'Well, okay, but are you saying she's...'

Gillian shook her head suddenly. 'No, no. Don't think about the context, the *why*, the *how*. Don't think. *Feel*.'

'Okay, Yoda.'

'Which Claire turns you on?'

'Well, clearly the naughty, *sexy* Claire... but...'

'No 'but', the blonde stood up and stepped up to him in the shower booth, putting her hands up behind his neck and then dropping them down so that her arms were around him. 'Don't you think she feels the same about you?' she said.

Robert felt awkward. He didn't know where to put his hands. Gillian took them for him and slid them down over her butt. She had a fantastic butt. God. It was so round, so pert, so perfectly shaped. In fact, her whole body seemed designed to fit against him and turn him on.

'Women aren't like men, though, are they?' he said.

'Not entirely...' Gillian smiled and then took one of his hands and brought it around the front of her body, guiding him to touch her between the legs.

Oh, Jesus. She was so smooth down there, completely hairless. Women weren't really like that outside of pornography, were they? Except that, apparently, some were.

She was wet, too, and not just from the shower. He felt the oily slipperiness of her wetness as she pressed his fingers against her sex.

'No,' he said, looking back into her mischievous eyes. 'I mean... women don't fantasize about having sex with lots of people, or their husband's having sex with lots of people...'

'Are you *kidding* me?'

'They want one person, don't they? One person they can love and trust...'

'Where did you read this?' Gillian said dryly. 'The 1950s?'

'Okay, but *Claire* would want to feel she can trust me, that I'm hers and no one else's, that I'm *loyal*. She wouldn't fantasize about me sleeping with you.'

‘I bet she’s not as boring as that in real life,’ the blonde said, grinding against his hand — almost using it to masturbate. ‘Maybe if the idea of you fucking me is connected to the idea of her being able to screw someone else for a change, maybe that *would* appeal to her. Maybe she can accept the fact that this week only, you’re not her husband. Mason is.’

‘Yeah... I don’t know.’

Gillian squeezed his cock one more time, but Robert pulled his hands away from her.

‘Grrr!’ she growled, then rolled her eyes. ‘Suit yourself.’

She turned on her heels and sashayed out of the bathroom, walking as though she knew his eyes were on her butt as she went — well, they were — and she wanted one last little attempt to tempt him.

He stood there, his cock softening almost instantly and his stomach lurching downward as he sensed how disappointed she was. Did she hate him now? Was he going to have to tour Rome with a woman who hated him? Or perhaps they’d just do their own thing each day, touring separately, returning home to sleep, without really talking to each other. He wasn’t sure which was the worse option.

He heard the bedroom door close. After grabbing a towel to dry off and hang around his waist, he headed out of the bathroom to find that Gillian had sealed herself off from the rest of the world.

Wearing a fresh pair of boxer shorts, he was searching the rest of the apartment for any kind of spare bedding when he heard a quiet buzzing sound from inside the bedroom. It was soon accompanied by the soft soprano sighs and moans from a pretty blonde using a vibrating toy to find release.

God. His manhood thickened up, of course. Had he been totally stupid, turning her down like that?

There was an airing cupboard opposite the bathroom, in which, to his joy, he found some spare blankets and even a pillow. Clearing space between the couch and the TV in the living room to lie down, however, it wasn’t exactly a comfortable place to sleep.

And now, as he tried to ignore how hard the floor was underneath him, he lay on his back, and his cock was rock hard. Well, that wasn’t going to let him fall asleep. There was no way he could just make his mind go blank and wait for his erection to go away. How could you rid yourself of all thoughts when there was a gorgeous blonde gasping and moaning just a few yards away, fucking a fake dick?

He stroked himself — but at least tried to think about Claire while he did so. And thinking about Claire, the only thing he could imagine was the two alternatives Gillian had suggested for when they would all meet up at the airport again the following Saturday.

...Do you like the idea of meeting up with a Claire next Saturday who spent the week having naughty, sexy, secret, wild sex with Mason... or a Claire who has been good all week, resisted every ounce of temptation...

Robert slowly pumped his shaft and tried to think of Claire rejecting Mason's attempts at flirting with her. Claire giving him the cold shoulder because she was a good, loyal wife.

She's clean, she's wholesome, she's boring, she's exactly the same Claire you flew out of JFK with...

Robert pumped his shaft more quickly and started imagining Claire standing in the shower, trying to wash after a long, hot, sticky day, as a naked Mason approached her. The other man, all buff and gym-toned, offering to kneel down before her and make her come with his mouth until she was screaming the house down.

Robert jacked his hard dick and imagined Claire blushing and telling Mason she couldn't possibly cheat on her husband. Mason reminding her that this week, *he* was her husband. And that since Claire and Robert had signed up to Marriage 2.0, Robert had basically consented to all this.

Claire getting flustered as Mason knelt down in front of her and started stroking the soft, dark hair between her legs.

Mason telling her that this was their Rome adventure. That she should treat him as her husband.

Claire moaning as she let the man lick her pussy, long and slow. Claire turning her back to him as he stood up, to let him slide his hard cock deep into her soaking pussy.

Claire on all fours on that enormous bed, as the muscle-bound Mason mounted her and *mated with her*.

Robert thought of Claire riding another man like a cowgirl, whooping and yelling as she gyrated on top of him, liberated and free and overwhelmed by sexual feelings she hadn't experienced for years.

Robert thought of Claire cheating on him, except that it wasn't really cheating, was it? Because they'd both signed up for this, they'd both signed up for Marriage 2.0.

Robert thought of Claire coming hard as another man spurted his thick cream inside her — and Robert came harder than he had for a long time.

He was so turned on he'd entirely forgotten about the mess he'd make when his orgasm hit. Afterward, as he quietly cleaned up, he pondered, amazed, why it might be that he apparently found it so arousing to imagine Claire *cheating* on him.

Why did he wish — so strongly now — that when they met up at the airport on Saturday, Claire would have something *awful* to confess to him?

In the morning, he awoke to the smell of bacon frying in a pan. It smelled incredible.

‘Morning!’

He opened his eyes to find Gillian at the stove in the little kitchenette, presumably cooking bacon. She was wearing a neon pink sports bra and a tiny pair of black shorts and nothing else.

‘Did I wake you?’ she said, turning to him with a big cheerful smile.

‘Uh...’ he said, still gripped by sleep.

‘I just got in from my morning run, and I *always* need serious protein when I’ve just had a run...’

Jesus, she looked good. He was surprised she was here, in the room with him, talking to him. And sounding cheerful, too. As though last night’s little bust-up had never happened.

‘You want some?’

‘Uh... sure,’ he said, and his stomach grumbled as though to show approval.

‘Bacon... some eggs. This kitchen’s quite well-stocked, actually. Some people seem to think it’s a big deal having a cooked breakfast in the morning, but really, how hard is it to heat up some bacon, some eggs...’

She talked a lot. He kind of liked that, though. Claire wasn’t much of a talker. He propped himself up on his elbows and watched her cooking. Had she really gone out running looking like that? Her shorts were almost so short they were like underwear. Maybe she had a little wedgie going on, but it showed almost the entire shape of her delectable buttocks.

Was this going to be her strategy for the week? Wander around the apartment in next to nothing until he was just about begging for sexual

release?

He tried to distract himself by tidying away his blankets and bedding. But then he was sitting at the table, and she was serving him bacon and eggs, and even pancakes, and sitting across from him wearing a sports bra that covered very little.

‘What do you want to do today?’ she asked. ‘Are we going to go to the Vatican?’

Robert smiled. ‘Sure, that could be good. You know they probably have a dress code up there, right?’

Gillian grinned. ‘You don’t think they’d let me in wearing this kind of thing?’ she joked.

‘You’d probably get arrested.’

‘I’ll put something nice on after I shower,’ she said with a mock eye-roll as though to say, *God, you’re nagging worse than my mother.*

They talked about what they wanted to see in the Vatican. Robert got to make use of all that time he’d spent on the plane reading the guidebooks, but Gillian also surprised him with her knowledge.

Afterward, he did the washing up. As he was halfway through it, Gillian wandered into the kitchenette, wearing nothing but a tiny pair of white panties. She was carrying an armful of clothes, including her running gear, before crouching to put them in the little washing machine that Robert hadn’t even noticed they had.

‘Thanks for cleaning up,’ she said, stooping to slip off her panties and add them into the laundry before closing the washing machine door.

‘Thanks for cooking me breakfast,’ he said, flushing a little, trying desperately not to look at her.

She really was trying to flaunt herself in front of him.

She paused there just a moment too long — until he was psychologically compelled to look at her, to see why she wasn’t saying or doing anything. So he looked at her naked body, and she smiled brightly, having forced him to look at her.

When she wandered back out, he tried to count to ten, to calm down. He willed his erection to go back down.

What was Claire doing right now? He thought. *Has she already fucked Mason?*

His hardness was never going away thinking like that.

Now he was thinking, what if Claire spent all week in bed with Mason while he spent all week resisting Gillian? When they got back together, Claire would feel awful for what she’d done, having expected that they were both supposed to ‘cheat’ that week.

Or maybe Claire would be mad at Robert because he'd wasted the week — because he hadn't done what he was supposed to on the Marriage 2.0 program.

He would have missed the chance to take a little break from monogamy so that they could both return to it refreshed.

Robert thought, *and if I spend all week fucking Gillian, maybe Claire holds out and resists Mason. Then Claire will be mad at me for cheating on her.*

He smiled.

But at least I'll have spent the week fucking Gillian.

Robert groaned and put his dishcloth down.

Gillian was in the shower. She'd left the bathroom door wide open, predictably. Robert found her holding the showerhead, stooping as she held it toward the plug, away from her body while the water heated up.

He took off his t-shirt and then his boxer shorts.

Gillian looked up and jumped, startled by him. But then, laying her eyes on his naked body, she smiled and giggled.

'Hi,' she said seductively, directing water over her body while standing almost as though posing for a photographer.

'If we do this,' Robert said, 'and we get to the airport on Saturday, and it's obvious that Claire hasn't done anything with Mason all week...'

'Of course,' she said, looking serious but still flaunting herself in front of him, 'I won't say a thing.'

'I just don't want to hurt her,' he said, but he felt awful.

Was he really about to cheat on Claire?

But this wasn't cheating. This was Marriage 2.0.

'It'll be our little secret,' Gillian said, and Robert walked toward her.

He reached out and touched her bare behind, marveling at how soft her skin was, yet how firm and shapely her derriere was. Toned. She stood and just let him touch her while she continued to pour water all over her front.

She said, 'You don't think it would have been front-and-center on Claire's mind when she watched you walking out of that apartment with some strange blonde, that you might be tempted to do something like this?'

Robert nodded. 'I guess so.'

'And when she got that message saying she's supposed to treat Mason like her husband? She *must* have assumed you got the same message.'

'What if she didn't get a message like that?' he asked.

Gillian laughed, 'They're not *evil*,' she said. 'You paid them to help improve your marriage, right? Not fuck it up.'

'I suppose so.'

Gillian sank down to sit on her haunches as if she really was going to wash herself and have a normal shower. But then she was holding the shower head as though contemplating using it to simulate oral sex.

'Your wife saw you going away with a beautiful blonde,' she said. 'You don't think, if she was *really* worried you'd cheat on her, she wouldn't have texted 'STOP' to Marriage 2.0 already?'

Robert paused. He hadn't thought of that. Claire could, at any point, have canceled this whole thing.

'What if she felt pressure not to stop the whole thing — because we paid so much money for it?' he asked.

Gillian grinned and shook her head. 'What's more important, your marriage, or the money you spent on Marriage 2.0?'

Robert reached down to gently cup one of her small but pert breasts. Her nipples were like little pebbles. Gillian quietly took his hard cock in one of her hands, gazing at it longingly.

She looked up and gave him an encouraging, it'll-be-okay-trust-me smile and lodged the showerhead between her legs. Then she leaned forward and took his cock in her mouth.

She closed her eyes and sucked on his glans, squeezing the base of his shaft in her hands gently as she swirled her tongue around his tip and worked her way toward getting more and more of his length inside her mouth.

He moaned. God, it felt good.

When had Claire last done this for him?

Had she done it after they'd gotten married? He couldn't remember. But then, he couldn't remember when he'd last gone down on Claire, either.

Gillian really seemed to like his cock. She stroked it as though it was the most valuable thing in the world; she gazed at it as though she'd never seen anything more beautiful. She licked it as though it was the most delicious thing she'd ever experienced.

After a while, she said quietly, 'I need to clean off.'

She had him sit on the toilet, the lid closed, as she soaped herself. She didn't just wash, though. She performed. She moved like an exotic dancer. He sat there and stroked his hard cock as he watched her — and she seemed to like him doing that.

Then she stepped out of the shower and grabbed a towel, saying, 'You know there's a bed next door, right?'

He followed her into the bedroom, where she jumped onto the bed and covered herself with the towel.

He knelt on the mattress beside her, and her hand found its way back to his cock, just as his found its way between her legs. He stroked her while she stroked him, exploring her incredible shaven pussy.

'Our secret,' she said softly, as though she needed to remind him.

'If it has to be,' he agreed, two fingers gently probing her entrance.

He knelt between her thighs as she pulled her legs wide apart. She was stroking her pussy with one hand as he lined up to touch the tip of his cock to her entrance. She looked amazing. He could see everything as his manhood nudged up against her pussy lips — there wasn't a single hair down there to hide anything.

And then he was inside her, a little at a time, slowly filling her, slowly stretching her tight pussy. Damn, it felt good. So tight around him, so wet.

'Oh my *God*...' she breathed, looking surprised as he inched his way into her.

She was wet as he moved into her but not used to his size — that was clear enough. It took a little time for her to adjust for him, to be entirely comfortable with him.

'*Jesus*,' she gasped. 'How is it that Claire doesn't spend all day, every day, on her back demanding *this* inside her?'

Robert smiled, 'I guess she got used to it.'

She held the cast iron bars of the bedstead as he thrust into her again and again, gradually upping his pace. He massaged her beautiful breasts, ran his hands down to her hips, taking in her sensational toned form.

She came within minutes.

They toured the Vatican. Gillian smirked as they walked up the steps to St Peter's Basilica. When he asked her what she was smirking about, she asked him if he was worried about catching fire when they entered such a holy place.

'Catching fire?'

'Because we're such *sinner*s,' she whispered.

He laughed but shook his head. 'I don't think Catholics believe in that kind of thing. They're all about forgiveness, aren't they? There'd be no need for confession if everyone burned up when entering the church.'

'Let's hope so, huh?'

As they entered the great Renaissance church, however, they seemed to temporarily forget about their sinfulness, to concentrate on what they were seeing. This was supposedly the burial place of the chief Apostle. It was full of beautiful marble, reliefs, sculptures, and ornate gilding, soaring to the heavens thanks to its breathtakingly high ceilings.

They didn't mention their morning's sexual exploration for the rest of the day. However, Robert occasionally found himself glancing over at Gillian, thinking to himself: *did I really have sex with her this morning?*

Sometimes, he caught her looking at him in prolonged moments, and he got the sense that she was also thinking about how strange it was that they'd actually had sex that morning. They were married to other people.

Gillian and Mason might have been a highly sexual couple, but Robert got the impression that they had at least been faithful to each other before this week.

Robert was the first guy she'd been with, other than Mason, for a long while. It must have been just as weird for her. She probably wasn't as stunned at how attractive he was, in the way he was of her.

Was she regretting it? He didn't get the feeling she was — not from the little smiles she gave him through the day, the occasional gentle touches that almost made it feel like they really were a couple.

Despite that constant undercurrent of strangeness between them, they spent the day happily touring the Vatican, traipsing through the basilica and the Vatican Museums, including the Sistine Chapel. Then, in the afternoon, there was the 13th-century fortress, Castel Sant'Angelo.

They both, surprisingly, seemed to appreciate what they were seeing. Robert found it a breath of fresh air to be with someone who was apparently as interested in what they were looking at as he was. Claire would have been complaining for much of the day about how much walking they were doing.

But he felt terrible, thinking ill of Claire while they were apart. Sure, she was never as impressed by cultural stuff as he was. That was just who she was. Was she having a good time with Mason? He genuinely hoped so, whatever it was they were doing.

He did miss her, perhaps surprising himself by how much he did.

Later, after a superb dinner at a restaurant in the Piazza Risorgimento, a small square just outside the Vatican City walls, it was a

30-minute walk back to their apartment. It felt like a delightful way to burn off the calories.

By the time they returned to the apartment, Robert had started wondering if he'd imagined the whole thing about the two of them having sex. It seemed so unlikely that a woman like Gillian would go for a guy like him.

Yet when they got back, and Gillian reminded him that there was probably only enough hot water for one shower — and Robert graciously suggested she ought to have it, if she wanted one — the pretty blonde cracked a broad smile and said, 'We could share it, if you'd like.'

And then there he was, standing with her under the running water, both of them naked, and she was letting him gently rub soap all over her body — her breasts, her stiff nipples, her stomach, between her legs, her shapely behind.

She washed him very deliberately, paying particular attention to his hard cock, which she could hardly take her eyes off at any point.

‘I’ve been thinking about this all day,’ she said, pumping him slowly.

He laughed. ‘We’ve been seeing some of the most incredible art ever produced, and you’ve been thinking about this all day?’

‘I can think about more than one thing at a time, you know,’ she smirked. ‘Don’t tell me you haven’t given a single thought, all day, to what happened this morning.’

He shrugged. ‘Maybe one. Or two.’

‘Or three or four?’ she grinned.

He laughed again. ‘Come on,’ he said. ‘Look at you — you’re gorgeous. I can’t believe someone who looks like you...’

He realized he was being a little more honest than he had intended. But she blushed as he complimented her, and he figured he wasn’t saying anything that would offend her.

‘...You know... would even go for somebody like me,’ he finished, a little sheepishly.

‘You’re sweet,’ she said, as though explaining herself. ‘And... you have the biggest cock I’ve ever seen. Any woman would go for you if they saw what you were stowing.’

At that point, the temperature of the water suddenly plummeted, and Gillian was squealing, and Robert was gasping, and the two of them stepped away from the flow of the shower.

‘I was getting out anyway,’ she giggled.

But since her hands had been focused so much on Robert's cock, he still had soap all over the rest of him. 'That's not fair,' he gave a mock-grumpy expression.

'Rinse off,' Gillian laughed at him as she stepped away and wrapped a towel around herself. 'I'll be waiting for you in the bedroom...'

He howled a little as he stepped under the cold water, but only a little. Actually, after the heat of the Roman summer, it was pretty refreshing. After a minute or two, he stepped out, invigorated and feeling somehow cleaner than he had in a while.

Wrapping the towel around his waist after drying off, he walked out of the bathroom, not quite knowing what to expect. She wanted to sleep with him, right? Wasn't that basically what she'd said? It seemed unreal. But he glanced through that open door and saw her sitting there in the armchair by the window, wearing something too sexy to be innocent.

'Hey,' she said, beckoning him in with her eyes as she stood up.

She was wearing a lacy babydoll the color of pinot noir up top and black and sheer over her toned stomach. Her panties were also black and sheer. Her legs were clad in black lace-topped thigh-high stockings.

Wow.

'You look incredible,' he said as he stepped into the room and she approached him.

'Thank you,' she smiled, 'you don't look so bad yourself.'

Her eyes dipped down, and he could see she was checking out the bulge in his towel.

Claire had never dressed in lingerie for the express purpose of having sex. She didn't even own any underwear as fancy as this. He remembered a few lacy items she'd worn while they were dating, but that had been a long time ago. Gillian looked incredible. He was stunned by how exciting it was that she would wear something naughty purely to turn him on.

'You like it?' the pretty blonde giggled and touched his cheek gently.

'Can't you tell?' he grinned, indicating the hardness hidden by his towel.

He put two hands up to her face and kissed her. She smelled of a light, floral perfume and tasted vaguely of cinnamon. Her lips were a touch waxy from lipstick she must have applied in a rush, but otherwise, she was makeup-free, fresh from the shower. She closed her eyes and moaned quietly as he sucked on her mouth.

'Claire never — ' he started to say as they broke apart, somewhat breathless. He stopped himself, figuring it was inappropriate to bring up

another woman in the bedroom like that. And yet he wasn't bringing up an ex. Claire was still his wife — outside of this adventure, at least.

Gillian smiled, her expression telling him it was okay to bring up Claire. That she wasn't offended by it; it didn't make her feel insecure.

'Claire doesn't wear things like these?' she prompted him, her tone confirming that, in her view, it was only natural to be thinking of his spouse at a time like this. After all, they hadn't swapped merely for a quick week of red-hot sex. This was also about considering and re-considering their respective marriages. Re-kindling the passion.

'Never,' he said, guiding her back to sit down on the bed, going down onto his knees as she did so. 'Nothing like this.'

Gillian grinned. 'It's such an easy way to get Mason going,' she said. 'I love shopping for things like this, picking things off the shelf and knowing how hard it's going to make him...'

Kneeling before her, he put his hands on her stocking-clad thighs and spread her legs to expose her sweet pussy, which was already visible through her sheer panties.

'Claire thinks it's too much bother,' he said, making her smile by picking up one of her feet and kissing it like some devoted slave.

'She's insane,' the blonde said, her breathing deepening as he kissed his way up over the bridge of her foot to her ankle.

'I suppose sex as a whole is too much bother for Claire and me these days,' Robert chuckled.

'You think it'll still be like that after this week is done?'

He shrugged. 'I don't know...'

He thought about Claire being with Mason, with another man. It gave him a funny little fluttering feeling inside his chest — what was that? He wasn't angry about the idea of Claire sleeping with Mason. They'd both signed up for Marriage 2.0, they'd both agreed to the terms. They had agreed that any adventure would be consensual on both sides because they'd both been so rigorously assessed.

But how would he feel, seeing her again at the airport, knowing she'd been with someone else? He didn't know the answer to that.

'How do you think you'll feel about Mason... after, you know... this week...?' he asked Gillian while kissing his way up her slender calf, past her knee, along her thigh.

'I don't know,' she grinned. 'But that's what all this is about, isn't it? Finding out how we feel about each other after this adventure is done.'

'I suppose so.'

He could smell her arousal as he pressed his lips against the bare flesh above the lace top of her stockings. She lay back, and her tiny panties were revealed to be pretty much a g-string, with strings tied together at the waist by her hips. The string between her legs was partially swallowed up by her glistening pussy lips.

He traced his fingers alongside her sex, breathing her in, desperate to taste her but distracted by the question of why he hadn't done this kind of thing with Claire in so long. Marveling at how strange and hot it was that this pretty blonde would let him do this with her, and they hadn't even known each other much longer than 24 hours.

Now he swept his tongue along her slippery groove, enjoying her delicate, savory flavor and the thrill of making her moan with his mouth. Thinking it so wicked and wrong to be wedging his face against this sopping pussy, when it wasn't even his wife's.

'Oh, that's good,' she whispered, panting now, as he sucked on her pussy lips and nudged her clit with his nose.

She fondled her own breasts through the lace of her babydoll as she gazed down on him, and he wondered if she was getting off on this being someone else, not her husband.

He loved how she gasped when he covered her clit with his hot mouth and gently sucked on her little sensitive button. How she groaned as he thrust his tongue as deep as it would go into her sex.

How she whimpered softly when he slid his fingers inside her.

But then she was wriggling out from under him and coaxing him up onto his feet, slipping down onto the floor where he had been to pull the towel off his waist, to take his granite-hard cock in her hands.

'Claire's going to be horny as a bunny rabbit when you get her back on Saturday,' she said, pressing his cock against her soft cheek, taking in its size before stretching her lips around its crown.

'You think so?' Robert chuckled.

'Mmm-hmm.'

She gazed up at him as she took more of his cock inside her mouth.

'Well, I'm not sure about that,' he said. 'I mean... I assume she's having a good time with Mason... but then... maybe that'll be enough for her for a while...'

'Na-uh,' Gillian shook her head, jacking his shaft in her hands as she said, 'he's going to remind her what she's been missing... and then she'll get you back... and this enormous cock...'

She bobbed down on it and seemed to be trying to squeeze as much of it into her mouth as she could. It was too large for her throat, however.

‘She’s going to want you to whip this out every night, right after you get home from work,’ Gillian giggled. ‘And she’s going to get sore from having so much sex...’

‘I hope so,’ he said, stooping, crouching so that he could kiss her lips again, her mouth with a slight hint of cock about it, a subtle flavor, a subtle scent. Thinking, though, that he and Claire had been locked in a kind of friend zone for so long. What if there simply wasn’t any chemistry anymore? What if there was no fizz like there was with this incredible blonde?

He knelt over her, now, as she sat on her haunches. Kissed her, sucking on her lips, somehow fascinated and surprised by the fact that she had just gone down on him, this pretty blonde, this stranger, this woman who was not his wife. Was that the future of his marriage? An occasional rumble with other women? Was that really the secret to lifelong happiness? How could Claire possibly countenance that kind of arrangement?

He slipped the straps of her babydoll off her shoulders to reveal those perfect little breasts and her sweet, stiff nipples. Crouching down to take them in his mouth, one of his hands found its way back between her legs to seek out her flower. He slipped a finger or two inside her, finding her sensationally wet.

Her hands reached for his cock, but then he urged her up on the bed again, and she was very willing to be led.

He lay back on the mattress and guided her over him, to straddle him, to find her place over his rock-hard shaft, to press her searing-hot pussy against it, to press down, grind herself over it. She pulled off her babydoll and then unfastened the ties above her hips to remove her panties. Keeping on her stockings, she rose to guide the tip of his cock to her sopping entrance. She then very slowly sank down on it, inch-by-inch, letting it fill and stretch her, moaning softly as she went, as her body adjusted to the sheer size of what was moving into her petite body.

‘Oh God...’ she gasped and began to move herself on him, slowly, cautiously, but steadily gaining confidence.

Robert let her take the lead, leaving her to ride him only as fast as she was comfortable doing so. Had it ever been like this with Claire? He wasn’t sure she’d ever been quite as tight as this. But he did remember having to go fairly slow with her to begin with, back when they’d been dating. She’d gotten more used to it later on.

But it struck him now — had he stopped being so careful with Claire? After a while, he’d stopped remembering to treat her cautiously

because of his size. She was, in his mind, used to it. But was that one reason she wasn't as interested in sex with him these days?

'That feels so incredible,' Gillian said now and kissed him. It felt as though she was okay for Robert to take some control now, to move his hips, to fuck her.

'You're so tight,' he said, making her smile.

'I'm not used to this... I feel so full... you're stretching me...'

'But it feels okay?' he said, with a note of concern.

'Oh, yeah. Like, you're touching every single inch inside of me at once...'

She started riding him again, her body writhing and rocking over him, her breasts brushing over his face, her hair flowing all over him like rivers of molten gold as she pumped his cock with that vice-like, tight pussy.

They tumbled on the mattress, and he fucked her while she was lying on her back, the way it always was with Claire, or at least the way it had been for a long while. Except that Gillian was wearing stockings, and her legs gripped him as he fucked her, and he felt her nylon-clad thighs clamped against him, feet pressed to his back.

He fucked her from behind, and it made him feel like a beast, a big alpha beast, king of the beasts. Taking this female as though it was his right, she took his pounding, showing him her respect, moaning appreciatively. Was this how Claire was with Mason? He felt a ripple of strange desire for his real wife now, as though as King of Beasts he shouldn't be losing his woman to another man. As though he needed to get back and show her he really was King of Beasts.

And now, weirdly thinking that Claire was being taken by an impudent pretender to his throne, Robert came forcefully inside Gillian's tight pussy. His orgasm exploded like some colossal special-effect fireball, his cock bucking and jolting as he shot spurt after spurt of his thick cream inside her.

There was even an odd moment of surprise when he opened his eyes after firing his last jet of come, and the woman beneath him was blonde, her skin faintly tanned rather than pale, her legs clad in sexy stockings.

He almost had to remind himself he'd just been fucking Gillian, not Claire.

Claire was with Mason. Were they fucking right now? Jesus. What a weird thought, what a weird feeling. His orgasm was done, he was pulling out of Gillian now — and yet somehow, he was left in a strange state of mild arousal.

They lay together, without bothering to cover up with bed sheets because of the heat of the night, vaguely spooning but not quite touching, because what they didn't need more of in Rome, with no air conditioning, was heat.

'What if Claire and Mason really aren't sleeping together this week?' Robert said. 'I mean... if they take that message to mean they're just supposed to be touring Rome together all week, having dinner, chatting. Nothing else.'

Gillian said, 'If that's how they interpreted the message, then Mason's not going to get through two days without texting 'STOP' back to Marriage 2.0, in big, capital letters.'

He wasn't entirely sure if he was woken by the text message or whether he woke up anyway. Perhaps he woke because it was just too warm in the middle of the night, with no air conditioning available.

Either way, it was 2am, and he was awake, and his phone had just received another message from Marriage 2.0.

It took him a moment or two to remember that his phone had died; he'd been unable to even switch it on. But now, it was definitely on again — and bearing a fresh missive from their friendly marriage counseling program.

Robert's heart was suddenly beating heavily, so heavily he could feel each beat like a hammer being struck against the wall of his chest cavity.

And yet the text message said only:

Marriage 2.0: Wakey, wakey

He was confused. What did it mean? He was supposed to wake up, sure. But then what? Was something about to happen?

Gillian was beside him on the bed, still asleep. She was wearing a skin-tight tank-top that didn't quite cover her midriff and a pair of tiny gym shorts after her second shower of the evening. Lying curled up in the fetal position, the roundness of her behind seemed just delightful to his eye — as though she couldn't stop trying to tempt him into something, even when asleep.

Pulling himself off the bed, Robert went to pick up Gillian's phone — but though she'd had it on to charge since it had died, it still wouldn't switch on. He had to assume she hadn't received a message from Marriage 2.0, or her phone would also be on right now.

So what next, Marriage 2.0?

His phone was on... and he was awake. So was he supposed to try to call Claire? They could have some kind of conversation, an update about how it was going. Was he supposed to confess to his sins? Tell her about Gillian? Or keep it secret?

He quickly saw that the question was moot, anyway: there was no reception for this phone. He walked out of the bedroom and wandered around the living room to see if there was any reception anywhere else in the apartment, to no avail. The phone was on, but useless. He tried calling Claire anyway but couldn't.

He sighed. Marriage 2.0 must have activated his phone long enough for their text message to get through — and then had rendered it useless again. He wasn't going to get to talk to Claire.

So what now?

He wondered if he was supposed to wake up Gillian for another round of adulterous sex. What would that achieve? He'd probably make her mad by waking her in the middle of the night. Then they'd both be tired in the morning, and it would probably spoil a day enjoying the sights of Rome.

He stared out of the window, through one of the cracks in the shutter, out into the street. All was quiet.

Was he supposed to go somewhere? Was he supposed to find his way back to the other apartment? Hammer on the door to get through to Claire?

Suddenly, a pale light materialized behind him. It was powerful enough to be seen reflecting from the white-washed walls around the window as he gazed out into the street.

He turned to find that the television had switched on — apparently by itself. It was showing only the snowy pattern that indicated there was no signal.

Robert walked over to the TV to switch it off. The thing was so old; perhaps it was simply malfunctioning. And yet, because of the text message from Marriage 2.0, he found himself on edge as he stooped to touch the power button.

The TV did not switch off.

He tried some of the other buttons. Switched channels, turned the volume up and then down. The thing did not respond to anything he did — there was just the same snowy pattern showing on all the channels. He glanced around the living room as though he might spot a remote control, even though they hadn't found one anywhere. The TV was old enough that it might never have had a remote control.

He was about to reach behind the set to pull the plug out of the wall socket when suddenly the picture changed of its own accord.

Robert gasped.

The TV screen now showed the other apartment — it was unmistakable, the size of the place, all that antique furniture. He was looking at the living room, towards the antique sofa facing that magnificent fireplace and the regal-looking mirror above it.

Jesus.

Was this a live picture? But the place was too light. Daylight. This was a recorded feed; it had to be.

For a moment, nothing happened. Robert started thinking this was only a still picture. But then he saw movement, and the familiar sight of Claire wandered past.

A few seconds later, Mason went by. Robert recognized the tight t-shirt and striped Adidas sweatpants as the clothes he'd been wearing that first afternoon when they'd first arrived in Rome. Claire, too, was wearing what she had been wearing then, a relatively ordinary-looking black top and jeans, comfortable attire for the flight over from JFK.

'This is from the other day,' he whispered to himself.

When Claire and Mason emerged into the picture again, it was clear that they were looking around the apartment, exploring.

There was no sound, but Robert still found himself fascinated. Watching them, working out that this must have been filmed just after he and Gillian had left the apartment.

His heart was thumping, thumping hard. Suddenly, the picture changed again, and after a brief moment, Robert saw that he was looking at the bedroom. Claire and Mason were checking out the closet space, and then apparently the en-suite, and then the view from the window.

They seemed to be perfectly comfortable in each other's company already.

Was this before or after Claire had been told that this was her 'adventure in Rome'? That she should 'treat Mason just as though he was her husband'? As Robert watched, he was willing to bet that it was after.

She was smiling at Mason a lot. Was she happy to be rid of her real husband?

Robert felt the sharpness of acid in his stomach, and it wasn't helped by the fluttering queasiness of his anxiety.

He watched Claire and Mason talking for a while, and then they moved back to the living room. The picture switched back to the first camera so that Robert could continue watching them.

Were they aware of the cameras?

Robert remembered looking around the apartment well enough — he certainly hadn't spotted any cameras at the time. Claire and Mason weren't acting as though they knew they were being filmed.

Was Claire blushing a little? At one point, she tilted her head, and adjusted the strap of her black tank top in a way that didn't seem right, didn't seem like her. God — she didn't walk that way. She didn't move that way. This wasn't an entirely familiar Claire that he was watching.

She was flirting with Mason.

Robert was sure of it. Jesus. *Already?*

She looked kind of giddy — like she was on a first date and she'd had a few drinks already.

The picture changed again — it jumped, like a badly-done edit. It now showed the living room, facing away from the fireplace, toward the sofa and the armchair opposite it. The lighting was different — the lamps were on around the room. This was later, nighttime.

Claire was sitting cross-legged on the end of the sofa, wearing a too-small white t-shirt that nicely highlighted her shape, along with a pair of pale gray, skin-tight leggings. Mason sat in the armchair, leaning back in a black t-shirt and red shorts, his legs parted in the way many men like to relax, but in a way that showed a distinct bulge in his crotch.

They were both drinking rosé wine, the bottle on the coffee table in front.

Claire's hair was down, but she played with it in front of Mason. Brushing it back in her hands, forming a ponytail without tying it back, flicking it over her shoulders — it struck Robert as seriously flirtatious.

And the way she moved her legs in front of him, sitting back, lifting her knees, changing position now and again — *she was showing herself off for him.*

Robert felt like it was increasingly difficult to breathe, watching her. And yet, strangely, though he was somewhat shocked by what he saw, there was also an undeniably heart-thumping sense of excitement. For him. For her.

Claire looked totally relaxed, perfectly safe, perfectly happy with Mason. And it was clear she kind of wanted something to happen with him, even though Robert couldn't hear their conversation.

Robert found himself torn — between the intense fear that Claire would be tempted to cheat on him and the growing buzz, deep down, of *wanting* this other man to seduce her. To give her the joy of being

desired, of being wanted, without the obligation of marriage compelling the man to want her.

God. It was the weirdest feeling.

Mason seemed relaxed with her, too. The way Gillian had spoken of him, Robert half expected the guy to be on his knees, begging Claire for sex. Telling her desperately that he couldn't live a whole week without burying his cock inside her. But the guy was chilled out, sipping his wine, chatting with her with a calm smile.

He made her laugh. Robert felt the sharp stab of jealousy. This other guy could make her laugh, but Robert couldn't remember the last time he had made her laugh like that.

She hung on his every word. She couldn't look away from him. *Jesus.*

And yet Robert felt his manhood thickening up from watching them.

He couldn't be angry if anything happened between them, could he? *This was their Rome adventure.*

And Robert had already slept with Gillian.

This was Marriage 2.0. The agency was telling them what was best for them. They shouldn't question it.

Claire sat up on the edge of the sofa. She seemed to be thinking about doing something but wasn't entirely sure about doing it. Mason didn't really move. Then Claire stood up and slowly sauntered away, out of the camera shot, leaving Mason chilling out in that armchair, still sipping his wine quietly.

Robert waited. What was she up to?

The camera cut to a wider angle of the living room, facing the door to the bedroom.

Robert gasped as he watched Claire step out of the bedroom nervously, wearing red and black lingerie — a complete set: basque, panties, stockings, and suspender belt. He'd never seen her in anything like it.

When was this? How had Mason persuaded her to don red-hot sexy lingerie in the course of only a day or so?

God, Robert was rock-hard. This was the Claire he'd dated, not the Claire he'd been married to for so long. But even more so.

Jesus, she looked good.

As Robert watched the TV screen, he saw Claire stop and show herself off for Mason, who was presumably there out of shot. She twirled for him, smiling bashfully but still clearly thrilled at the attention. God, she wasn't wearing regular panties. It was a thong. She played with her

hair and ran her hand down over her breasts as though guiding his eyes over her body.

She was wearing sexy underwear for another man. She was going to cheat on him.

Except that it wasn't cheating was it? It was Marriage 2.0. They had consented to this. Robert *had* felt a little foolish signing up and agreeing to something without knowing entirely what he was signing up to. It was a little like giving a blank check to a car salesman before watching as he delivered a Ferrari to your door instead of a Ford.

But he had to believe there wasn't any malice on the part of Claire. She wasn't doing this to spite him. She was doing this *because it was their Rome adventure*. And she had to assume that, somehow, if she did this, it would be agreeable to Robert.

Perhaps a weird secret fantasy.

Robert looked down between his legs, and his cock was so hard he couldn't believe it. It *was* a turn-on, seeing Claire this way. It was just a *confusing* turn-on. Was this lingerie something Mason had brought along for Gillian to wear or had he and Claire been underwear shopping out in Rome somewhere?

'That's some outfit.'

Gillian's voice came from behind him. He turned to find her leaning against the doorway into the living room, watching the TV. How long had she been watching?

'Is it one of yours?' he asked her.

She shook her head and took a couple of steps into the room. 'Not one of mine.'

Gillian was still wearing her tiny gym shorts and her crop top. Robert didn't think she seemed at all angry to see Claire on the TV screen like that, in the company of her husband in the other apartment.

'So did they go shopping for it, or did Mason bring it here for you as a present?'

Gillian smiled. 'I don't think she's my size.'

'No...'

'A little fuller in the chest, I'd say.'

Gillian came to sit on her haunches beside him in front of the TV. He asked her, 'Did I wake you?'

She shook her head. 'They texted me.'

'So your phone does work, only you can't call anyone with it?' he asked her.

She nodded. They were on the same page.

‘So you think we’ll get to watch them... doing it?’ she asked him. The way she was looking at him, he knew she was assessing him, trying to figure out how he felt watching Claire seducing another man. Was he going to get jealous, insane with anger?

‘Maybe.’

Her hand slipped across, over his lap, and quickly found its way to his erection.

‘My, my,’ she said, teasing him a little. ‘So the clever people at Marriage 2.0 *were* right, weren’t they?’

‘I don’t know,’ he said, somewhat embarrassed. ‘I never saw her act like this. Or look like this.’

The camera flicked back to the angle showing the sofa and the armchair, looking at the living room from the fireplace. Mason was standing up now. They could see him only from the waist down and above the shins, though his shorts had a definite tent pole in them.

And now Claire stepped into view — they saw her from behind, again from the waist down to her ankles.

The suspender belt covered more of her behind than her panties did.

Robert caught his breath as he saw Mason grasp his hardness, squeezing it through his shorts. He wasn’t subtle. Claire sat down on the couch where she had been before, and now they could see all of her. She was grinning, laughing, covering her mouth with her hand as though she was scandalized that he should be fondling his cock like that, right in front of her, even though she was dressed up like a Playboy Playmate.

‘You’re okay with this?’ Robert asked Gillian.

In the silence of the room, he could hear her breathing fairly deeply beside him.

‘It’s what we signed up for, isn’t it?’ she said. She was nervous too. He hadn’t expected that.

‘But are we okay with it because it was secretly our fantasy anyway, or because Marriage 2.0 is telling us it is?’ he asked her.

On screen, Claire sat up, her face just two feet away from the bulge in Mason’s red beach shorts. Again, she was giggling and laughing, nervously covering her mouth with her hand.

‘It’s kind of sweet, isn’t it?’ Gillian said. ‘I want them to do it. It’ll be fun for them.’

Robert watched Mason lean forward and tentatively place a hand on one of Claire’s breasts. But then he took it away again.

‘You’re not threatened by her, are you?’ he said. ‘You know he might want her because she’s different, but when he sees you again... she won’t

compare.'

'Why do you say that?'

Robert smiled. 'You know you're a knock-out, right?'

'You're sweet,' she said, and her hand snaked across his lap to press against his hardness again. 'But you don't feel that way about Claire?'

Robert chuckled. 'Oh, I *love* Claire. I recognize she's more of the girl-next-door type than you are, though. It's different.'

'You still find her attractive?'

On screen, Mason reached forward again, this time to stroke Claire's chin and then brush her hair back out of her face. Leaning a little closer toward her, that bulge oh-so-noticeable. Making it look obvious that he was gunning for a blowjob and that he would likely get one, even though Claire was doing the shy, bashful innocent act, blushing away fiercely.

'Oh yes,' Robert said. 'But it's different... and... seeing her like this...'

'It turns you on because it's forbidden,' Gillian said. 'Because she's your wife. And society says she shouldn't be with another man.'

'Mm-hmm.'

Robert didn't see the point in lying to Gillian. She was helping him figure out this tangled collection of feelings he was experiencing in watching Claire like this.

Mason stroked Claire's hair again. They talked. Claire blushed. Mason's hard cock was jutting right out in front of him now, the shorts straining to contain him. Claire sat back a little, her hands held coyly between her legs, staring straight at the man's bulge.

Then Mason yanked down his shorts, and Claire sat right back against the couch cushion as the man's bare cock sprang free.

Robert gasped.

Claire blushed and giggled nervously, again covering her mouth with her hands. Mason reached forward to grab one of her hands and brought it to his cock. The man had absolutely no pubic hair. Kind of went with the gym-bunny image, Robert supposed.

Robert felt his own cock throb as he watched Claire tentatively cup the man's balls and then delicately brush her fingers against his stiff shaft. She stroked it but then shook her head and withdrew her hand.

'Playing hard to get,' Gillian said quietly.

'Still not jealous?' Robert asked her.

'I think it's nice. She's like a sex toy for him.'

Mason and Claire were talking. She was letting him stroke her upper chest, but she was both excited and horrified at that hard cock wagging

in the air right there in front of her. She was reluctant but also amused. She was sitting up again, gently stroking his thigh, and yet looking up at him with a pleading expression as though asking him if they could not do this right now, if they could think about it a little first.

She sat back on the couch again, hands over her face in that defensive manner, and Mason took a step back, even looking as though he was about to pull up his shorts again.

Then Claire stopped him, leaned in, and draped her hands over his bare cock. Stroked him again, looked up at him, smiling bashfully. He brushed her hair out of her face again unnecessarily. Now she picked up her glass of wine and noticed that Mason was stroking her nearest breast; he'd slipped it out of the basque. It clearly made her feel nice. She rubbed his wrist approvingly, and he stooped so that he could touch her other breast with his other hand.

Claire signaled for Mason to wait while she took another drink, and Robert caught his breath to see her sitting there, her breasts exposed in front of this other man. She drank a huge gulp of wine and then sat back again on the couch, giggling and laughing.

'She's *going for it*,' Gillian said in barely more than a whisper.

Robert felt his heart pounding, his cock throbbing, his breathing so deep he was almost gasping for oxygen.

Claire sat up again, and now Mason was brushing her hair back behind her head with both hands, and he was standing so close to her so that he could do that, his cock was inches away from her face. Claire put her hand around it, her other one sliding up his toned stomach, pushing up his shirt. She leaned into him, craning her neck to reach the tip of his cock.

She touched the man's erection against her bottom lip.

She licked it.

She slipped the tip into her mouth.

She sank down on it.

Robert was stunned. Claire was sucking another man's cock. Quiet, shy, loyal, traditional, *conventional* Claire had her lips stretched around the hard penis of a *complete stranger*.

The man had his hands on her head and was gently encouraging her as she took the whole thing in her mouth. As she treated the thing like the most delicious treat.

'She's loving that,' he heard Gillian say, but it was as though a voice was talking in his head because Robert's entire focus was on the television screen. He just gaped at the image of his wife sitting on a couch wearing expensive lingerie, one hand cupping a stranger's balls while the other gripped the base of his cock and guided the rest of that thing into her mouth.

'You're *loving* that,' the blonde said, and Robert now felt Gillian's hands on his own cock, which was harder than ever.

'It's just so... *unlike her*,' he whispered.

Gillian's hands were fumbling to free his hardness from his boxers.

'Claire wouldn't...'

'I hate to break it to you, buddy. She *is*...'

This was Claire, wasn't it? Not some elaborate deepfake concocted by Marriage 2.0? She was holding onto the guy's buttocks and devouring his cock. Licking it, stroking it against her face, gazing up at Mason with a big grin, giggling at him, flirting with him. Loving the feeling of this stranger's cock in her hands, in her mouth.

Looking up at him to tell him: 'Fuck me. Fuck my mouth.'

Claire wouldn't say something like that.

Now she took him in her mouth again, gripping his butt and encouraging the guy to thrust into her. To fuck her mouth. Her dirty, cheating mouth.

‘You still love her?’ Gillian said with a sly grin.

‘Of course,’ he said and realized that what he said was automatic, instinctive. When he actually thought about it, he was *proud* of Claire. She was really embracing this whole adventure, trying new things.

Cheating on her husband.

She was *so sexy*.

‘If you could see her right now, what would you want to do with her?’ Gillian asked, her hand wrapped tightly around Robert’s cock. She slowly pumped him as they watched Claire on-screen, leaning away from Mason now, her face red from the effort of blowing him, giggling.

Claire having a wild, sexy adventure.

‘I’d want to kiss her,’ Robert said, realizing instantly how weird it was, what he was saying, but seeing no point hiding the truth from Gillian.

‘Kiss her? Where?’

‘On the mouth,’ he said, and again it struck him as weird, plainly weird — because Claire had just had another guy’s dick in her mouth.

But it was true. Robert wanted to *kiss* his adulterous wife — as though it would prove, beyond a shadow of a doubt, that what he was watching on screen was true. That Marriage 2.0 had not faked it, digitally inserting Claire’s face on another person’s body.

He wanted to suck on her mouth and taste her cheating lips.

‘You’re not jealous?’ Gillian asked him.

‘No. Not at all.’

‘She *loves* his cock,’ she said, trying to taunt him and get him jealous if he wasn’t jealous already. ‘You can tell. I bet she loves it so much because it fits so well in her mouth.’

‘Uh-huh,’ he said. On-screen, Claire and Mason were talking about something, but he couldn’t tell what they were saying.

He felt Gillian sink down on his own cock, enveloping it in the heat of her mouth, and he didn’t stop her from doing it. But his attention was on the television screen and how that other man held his hard cock up in front of Claire to tempt her further.

‘I love your cock, but I bet it’s tiring to go down on you a lot,’ Gillian said, smiling as she came up for air. ‘And I can’t get nearly as much of you in my mouth...’

She tried again, forcing herself down on him as far as she could go. But she was right: he was too big for a genuinely fantastic blowjob. Had Claire hated going down on him? He liked the idea that another man — a

smaller man — might give her the excitement of sucking cock, and be able to fit inside her mouth more easily.

On-screen, Mason was fucking Claire's mouth some more. Off-screen, Gillian sat up and took hold of Robert's head in her hand. She kissed him deeply. He tasted a hint of his own cock on her mouth — it was subtle but unmistakable.

When she broke their kiss, she said, 'You'd want to kiss your wife right now, even though she's just been sucking another guy's dick?'

He thought about how it would be to kiss Claire right now. To taste that hint of another man's cock on her mouth. Weird. Subtle, but weird. Her cheating mouth. It wasn't that he was drawn to the idea of sucking the man's cock himself. It was the idea that Claire was so *dirty*, so sexy because she had just been sucking on another man's cock. And he was kissing that dirty, cheating mouth.

'Yes,' he said without beating around the bush.

Gillian laughed, and he knew it was because she was stroking his cock, and feeling how it was throbbing at the erotic images in his head and on the TV screen.

On-screen, Claire leaned back, looking up at Mason with a flirty smile. Was he saying something to her? She was stroking his cock, but now reluctantly let go of it, and then the next thing was, she was pulling herself up to her feet.

She was looking gorgeous in those thigh-high stockings, turning slowly around in front of him, in front of the camera, giving them a superb view of her cute behind, framed by the suspender belt and those garter strings, the thong panties almost an after-thought.

Robert gasped as he saw his wife face away from Mason, bending over, her hands touching down on the back of the couch to support herself as she presented her behind for Mason's approval.

The man tugged on the waistband of her panties with one hand and cupped her pussy with his other.

Robert was holding his breath as another man touched his wife's pussy.

Gillian whispered, 'Is he going to *fuck* her?'

The blonde's own hand was tight, so tight, around his cock. Squeezing him to tease Robert about what he was seeing.

'I think so,' he said.

On-screen, Mason crouched behind Claire and removed her panties completely. The man held his hard cock up to her behind and patted it against her buttocks. Rested it between her cheeks. On the screen, they

could no longer see Claire's face. But she was gently waggling her hips to encourage the man to slide his cock inside her.

Pushing back toward him as though to force his cock inside her.

Robert forced himself to breathe. Mason guided the tip of his cock to Claire's pussy, and held it there for a beat or two.

Gillian whispered, '*He's going to fuck her...*'

And then the man eased forward, and his dick was inside Claire's pussy. He was *inside her*. He was fucking her. Thrusting into her. She had another man's cock buried in her cheating sex.

Robert had never wanted his wife more.

On-screen, Claire dropped her head a little, and now they could see her face again, and she looked to be in heaven. Eyes closed, mouth open, she was clearly moaning in pure pleasure.

'You're okay with this?' Gillian asked him, her hand seeming to hesitate around his cock.

'It's *amazing*. *She's* amazing.'

'God, you're so *into* this.'

Despite his sensory overload, it suddenly occurred to Robert that Gillian was watching her own husband having sex with another woman. Yet, she had been making this experience all about him.

'What about you?' he asked her. 'Are you okay about Mason... having sex with Claire?'

Gillian smiled and pumped his cock slowly. 'I don't mind if that's what you mean. It doesn't bother me. I wouldn't say it particularly turns me on, watching him doing it. Not like it seems to get you going, watching Claire.'

They watched as Mason and Claire detached themselves from each other. Robert wondered if Mason had come inside her, if they were done. *God, they weren't even using a condom.*

But Claire turned around and perched on the edge of the couch, and it appeared that they weren't done. Robert watched his wife carefully take the other man in her hands again, and guide the tip of his cock to her mouth. She bobbed her head as she sucked it, as though she couldn't get enough of going down on the guy. She had to be tasting her own wetness on him.

'But would you prefer it if Mason *wasn't* having sex with somebody else?' he asked Gillian.

'I really don't care one way or the other,' Gillian said, toying with his cock with both of her hands.

‘But... isn’t this all supposed to be your fantasy? I mean... they tested you and your husband... and this adventure was supposed to come out of your fantasies.’

Gillian giggled, and briefly ducked down to kiss his hard cock at the tip. ‘Oh, but it *is* my fantasy, don’t you get it?’ she said brightly. ‘Getting to play with an *enormous dick* like this all week?’

Now she was licking and kissing his throbbing manhood while Robert watched his wife on television doing similar things to someone else.

‘So you’d be happy... if Mason slept with other women after this?’ he asked her.

‘If I get to play with other guys... sure,’ the blonde giggled again.

Well, it made some kind of sense. Not everyone felt the same way about sex. About relationships. About monogamy. And everyone had different turn-ons, didn’t they?

Robert wondered if Claire was thinking about the possibility that he and Gillian were having sex. Did she like the idea that he was being naughty with the pretty blonde, in the same way that he liked the idea of Claire being naughty with Mason? Or was she more like Gillian, mainly excited about being free to enjoy another guy, another cock — oblivious to the fact that Robert was with another woman?

As they watched, Mason withdrew from Claire again. Now she sat back on the couch, spreading her legs, offering Mason a view of her exposed pussy. Then she shuffled closer to the edge of the cushion so that this near-stranger could slide his cock back inside her, this time from in front of her.

‘Would you let Claire... see other guys... after this?’ Gillian asked Robert before ducking down again to take him in her mouth.

‘Yeah...’ Robert said, moaning as he watched his wife pulling her breasts out from the confining basque, fondling herself while Mason continued to thrust into her again and again. ‘I really think I *would*...’

Then the image on the television turned to snow again. It was so sudden, Robert thought for a moment that someone had cut the feed in response to him confirming that he’d be okay with Claire being unfaithful in the future.

‘What happened?’ he said when it seemed clear the picture wasn’t coming back.

Gillian sat up, brushing her long, golden hair back over her shoulders again. ‘I guess they feel we’ve seen enough of Claire and Mason for now.’

Robert got the feeling she was right that Marriage 2.0 had decided to limit their viewing time, rather than this being some kind of technology fail. Even if the television looked to be at least as old as Gillian.

Nevertheless, he still picked himself up and went to fiddle with the TV, trying different channels, checking the connection of the wires at the back. Nothing brought back the video of Claire and Mason.

Giving up on it, Robert glanced over to see Gillian stripping out of her gym shorts. Her crop top was already cast aside.

‘Didn’t I tell you? It’s not going to work unless they want it to.’

‘No,’ he nodded.

‘Come on,’ she said, the flames of lust in her eyes. ‘You got to enjoy your fantasy. Now *I* get to enjoy mine.’

Well, fair’s fair.

She took his hand and led him out of the room. It was funny — this woman was gorgeous. Pert as a button and sprightly as a pixie, her long golden hair flowing down her back as she dragged him to the bedroom, her every curve straight out of a teenage sex fantasy. And yet Robert found himself wishing he could have Claire instead.

But he did feel obligated to give Gillian what she desired.

‘Lie down,’ she said, in no uncertain terms.

He did as she wanted, clambering onto the bed, collapsing onto his back, taking his cock in his hands in case it softened. Thinking about Claire cheating on him while he stroked his rigid shaft.

Gillian hopped up onto the bed, standing on the mattress. Robert was impressed at her athleticism. Had she been a gymnast once? A dancer? She stepped over him and immediately squatted over his lap.

‘Hey, are you — ?’ he said, remembering how tight she was — knowing how it was to try entering someone like her before she was ready.

‘I’m soaking wet,’ she said with a smirk, reading his mind. ‘Come on, just do it.’

He held his cock up, and she touched down against its tip, her pussy searing-hot. He stroked his tip against her and felt the slickness of her juices. She wasn’t lying about being soaking wet.

Nevertheless, he held his cock by its base and left her to push herself onto it, to take it inside her at her own preferred speed. Stretching that tight pussy to get his cock inside her.

She moaned as he filled her. ‘Oh my God...’

She slowly moved down on his shaft, coating it with her personal oils.

‘You have the most *amazing* cock... *Jesus Christ*...’

‘Feels okay?’

‘Oh, you have no *idea*...’

He was close to coming. After watching Claire with another man, it had already gotten him right to the edge. Now he was worried he was going to rob Gillian of her orgasm.

He tried to think of something other than Claire. He tried to concentrate on Gillian, on fucking her, on her perfect body. Focusing on how it felt as he swept his hands all over her, her straw-colored hair draped all over him, so soft, so different from Claire.

Was he weird, fantasizing about his wife while a stunning blonde writhed naked on top of him, his cock buried inside her vice-tight, shaved pussy up to the hilt?

‘God... Oh my *God*...’

He said, ‘Are you thinking about your husband right now?’

She giggled. ‘God, no.’

The blonde pulled herself up and off his cock, and dismounted from his body. Kneeling beside him, she took his shaft in her hands and ducked down to take his tip in her mouth. She moaned as though *she* was the one getting the physical pleasure from her oral attention.

She didn’t seem bothered that his cock had been wet with her own juices. She was thrilled at getting to experience another man, at breaking out of monogamy. And none of it was hindered by guilt because she was doing it knowing that her husband was okay with it, too.

She didn’t go down on him for long, however. Just a refresher. Soon enough, she was straddling him again, facing away from him. Reverse cowgirl. She slid onto him more quickly now, used to his size. Pre-stretched.

‘Uh...’

He held her by the waist as she moved cautiously on his full length. But as she fucked him like that, Claire kept infiltrating his mind again. He felt himself getting closer to the edge once more.

‘Hey — do you think Mason’s like me?’ he asked Gillian. ‘Or... you know... more like you.’

‘What?’ Gillian said, breathless, slowing her riding of him.

‘Well... you know... do you think he’s turned on more by... fucking a different woman for once... or because he knows his wife is fucking somebody different?’

‘Oh... uh... I don’t know... oh Jesus... I can’t believe it... it’s so *huge*...’

He kept quiet after that, realizing that the main thing for Gillian was how large his dick was. As she fucked him, and then later, as she went down on all fours and he fucked her from behind, she kept stating how big he was in amongst all her moaning and gasping.

Robert let her do the talking. He let her pontificate on the size of the cock filling her. The words tumbling out of her mouth seemed to get her more and more revved up.

But Robert was thinking about Mason — theorizing that Mason was like him, that the idea of another man bedding Gillian would be a thrill for him.

How could a man not be excited by someone else's big cock stretching his wife's pussy? How could a husband not be turned on by the thought of another guy making his wife gasp and yell while he fucked her?

When Gillian turned over, and he entered her missionary style, her legs spread so wide for him.

He asked her, 'You gonna come?'

And he was surprised when she said, 'Already did. Twice. You missed it?'

He had missed it, in amongst all her moans and cries.

She looked up at him and told him, 'Come inside me. Come inside me...'

His mind switched instantly to the thought of Claire being pounded by a stranger's hard cock, spreading her legs for him, just like this. Sexy, wicked, gorgeous Claire, entirely giving herself up to someone else. *Cheating on her husband.*

Except that, of course, with Marriage 2.0, it wasn't really cheating. It was all consensual.

God, he couldn't wait to see her again.

FRANK AND JENNI

Frank Dixon was just about to duck into Gaines's office — to grab his business partner for a lunchtime round of racquetball at the Club — when a group of interns went by on one of their Induction Week orientation tours.

Usually, Dixon tended to ignore most interns — although, during Induction Week, he might give tour groups a polite nod and a smile if he happened to run into them.

Today, he accidentally glanced at a young brunette, only to find himself helplessly locked in eye contact with her. She was both devastatingly attractive and apparently well aware of how best to use that fact to get ahead in life. As his gaze fixed on her sharp green eyes, the corner of her pert mouth crept up into the beginnings of a mischievous — and flirtatious — smile.

She knew how she was affecting Dixon and enjoyed the knowledge immensely.

'Oh my goodness, we are *so blessed*,' the tour guide exclaimed. 'People, say a quick 'hello' to our esteemed founders, Mr. Martin Gaines and Mr. Frank Dixon.'

Alerted to the presence of his business partner by the guide, Dixon nearly jumped out of his skin. He twisted around and winced at being caught staring at a young woman who looked as though she was barely out of her teens.

Sure enough, Gaines was emerging from his office, and of course, he had noticed Dixon being trapped by the remarkable vision of beauty in their midst.

Gaines uttered some brief words of welcome to the interns and then gave Dixon a hearty pat on the back to prompt him to do likewise. He

just about managed to blurt out a few platitudes while trying to escape from the brunette's soul-stealing emerald eyes.

Then — thankfully — the guide was moving his group on for more of their whistle-stop tour of the corporation while reciting the usual mythology of Bradley, Dixon, and Gaines. Dixon breathed a little sigh of relief as the brunette finally released him from her spell.

But the damage had been done.

As the young law students departed, Gaines leaned into Dixon and said, under his breath, 'You *sly* dog.'

Dixon felt his cheeks flush with embarrassment.

Gaines looked smug with the self-righteousness of a devil who had caught an angel being devilish.

'I can get her for you if you like.'

Dixon glanced at his business partner with a jolt of panic. 'Huh?'

'Have her assigned to your office... *you know...*'

Cue the hidden eye roll. Gaines really didn't get how things had moved on in this era of #MeToo. This was the man who led the teasing of Dixon at the Club because he was *only* on his first wife.

'No, better not,' Dixon said and started walking with Gaines toward the elevator, hoping they could get past this whole thing.

But moments later, as the elevator doors were closing on them, Dixon glanced out and was startled to find his gaze again connecting with the sharp eyes of the stunning brunette.

The tour group had shuffled back to cluster around the cabinets displaying all Gaines's various industry awards.

As the tour guide discussed The Great Man's achievements. The brunette glanced over at Dixon and offered him an unmistakably seductive smile — one that said, *I know you've noticed me, I know you want me, but even though you're the Big Boss and I'm a lowly intern, you're going to have to work for it if you want to have me.*

She wore a charcoal-gray jacket and matching skirt that almost reached her knees and a pristine white shirt and tan hose on her shapely legs. Most of the female interns seemed to be wearing similar apparel. A number of them were almost as attractive, but the brunette was something else.

The elevator doors seemed to take an absolute age to close.

Dixon allowed himself a moment to lust after her. He imagined her standing over him, looking sternly down at him as he complied with her orders to kiss his way slowly up her legs from her feet.

Jesus, where did that come from? He was no quivering submissive.

Only the elevator doors finally closing allowed Dixon to break away from the brunette's strangely dominant gaze.

'So Marshall says they're likely to take a dive in the fourth quarter because the numbers are all stacking up like you wouldn't believe, and something is going on there...'

As the elevator began to descend, Dixon saw to his relief that Gaines hadn't noticed him catching another glimpse of the stunning brunette.

Gaines was too preoccupied with his reflection in the mirrored walls of the elevator.

But Dixon realized that he had missed half of his business partner's current conversation — about some company or other that their investment firm had in its eye for an acquisition.

'What d'you think?'

Dixon flushed again as Gaines suddenly put him on the spot, and he didn't even know which company they were talking about here. 'I think we should wait,' he said vaguely, trying to act relaxed and confident and not at all distracted.

Jesus. How could a lowly intern take his focus off the ball like that? He wasn't some hot-blooded horn-dog.

'You always say 'wait', ' Gaines chuckled, but thankfully seemed to have bought it that Dixon had been listening. 'You're like whatever the opposite is of the Boy Who Cried Wolf.'

'That would make *you* the Boy Who Cried Wolf,' Dixon grinned.

'That's why we've always worked well together, buddy.'

The limo was waiting for them on the street outside. As it pulled away from the curb, Gaines had already moved on to gossip about some of their old college buddies. Rob Thornton was currently divorcing his fifth wife, Dennis Glade had sent his youngest daughter to rehab over some kind of Xanax issue, and Michael Grady had lost his house in the Hamptons in some dumb game of poker.

Dixon could get away with nodding and smiling at most of it.

It gave him time to think about why that brunette had left him feeling so troubled.

It wasn't that he felt guilty about looking at an attractive woman who was not his wife. What had hit him so hard was the sense that he'd been missing out on something. It wasn't a feeling he had very often — he'd been very successful in business, he'd become a very wealthy man. There wasn't a lot he couldn't get himself if he wanted it.

Jenni had once made him feel the way that brunette had today. She'd had that kind of crazy power over him when they'd first met. But that

raw, almost mystical power over him had faded over the years.

Had they even *had* sex since the twins were conceived?

He'd always been happy with Jenni. She was kind, gentle, and thoughtful. She was the perfect mother for their three-year-old twins. She was also bright, funny, and easy on the eye, with her silky blonde hair, pretty blue eyes, and a trim figure she maintained in their personal gym.

But parenthood had sapped Jenni's libido, and Dixon had been fine about waiting for her to find it again. And then Jenni complained that his snoring was too loud, so they'd started sleeping in separate rooms.

Of course, he had his work — something he could bury himself in and distract himself from things like sex.

But now, that brunette had reminded him of what he'd been missing.

The truly terrifying thing was that, if he really wanted, there probably was a way for him to run into that brunette again. To engineer some kind of meeting. To turn it into some sort of secret date. To start an affair. And among Dixon's social circle, an affair like that would be seen as practically *de rigueur*.

Gaines even called him 'Virgin' sometimes, away from the office, to tease him because he was still on only his first marriage.

But what if he did have an affair, and then his marriage broke down as it inevitably would? Jenni would take the kids and go live somewhere else. *That* was truly terrifying.

Oh, Jesus, he really couldn't handle losing the kids. And Jenni... she was such a massive part of his life. Sex wasn't *vital* for life, was it?

‘What’s up with you?’ Gaines said during their racquetball match at the Club, bringing Dixon sharply back out of his thoughts.

He didn’t want Gaines knowing he was having even the mildest doubts about his marriage.

‘Nothing, nothing. Just thinking about this EFH deal,’ he said, referring to one of the projects currently on his slate.

‘Bullshit,’ Gaines laughed and hit the ball hard at the wall so that it bounced back and nearly took out Dixon’s eye. ‘You never get hung up on a deal like this,’ he said. ‘You work like a fucking dog until the small hours to get every detail on any deal you ever get near. There’s no fucking *room* for doubt in your mind.’

‘I suppose...’

Dixon wracked his brain to quickly come up with some alternative story.

But Gaines said, 'You're thinking about that cute-as-a-button intern, huh, buddy?'

They'd worked together for so long that he could read Dixon like a book.

'Hey, it's all right, my friend,' Gaines insisted, his voice oddly reassuring rather than teasing. 'It's only natural. You've been with Jenni, what, eight years now?'

'Ten.'

'*Ten? Fuckballs.*'

Gaines served again, and he nearly took himself out with the ball this time. He'd never been good at racquetball. It was why he tended to play Dixon at the Club — since Dixon often let him win because that was usually good for business.

'I know you. You're terrified about taking a risk. But you've got to live a little, buddy, as well. You know? Enjoy your success.'

'And enjoying my success means cheating on my wife?'

Gaines shook his head and smiled. 'Look. You don't *understand* because... well, you're a *virgin*.'

'I don't need four ex-wives to understand women.'

'It's our *biological imperative*,' Gaines said, letting the point go so that he could step up to his friend and emphasize his view. 'Men are designed to spread our seed far and wide — not settle down with a single female. It's *biology*. *Science*. It's not our fault. We stay with a woman a certain length of time, of course we're itching for something new.'

'Well, you're itching because you don't wear condoms...'

Gaines laughed. 'Look, I get it. I get it. Most men marry the first woman who comes along and gives them the kind of emotional support their mom used to. Then, if he's got an ounce of sense, his *second* wife is the woman who comes along and shows him what sex can really be.'

Dixon just sighed and shook his head. But maybe Gaines *did* know more about life than he did, because Gaines had been through more than one marriage?

'But hey, even that sex will eventually fizzle. Because we're designed to move on, right? And she's designed to nest.'

When they were showering, Gaines continued to lay out his life philosophy.

'Wife number three comes along, and she's a good blend of supportive *and* sexy, right? She's dignified when you need her for a

polite business dinner, but she's also stunning to look at. The *trophy wife*.'

Dixon said, 'And what happened to your wife #3? What happened to Penelope?'

Gaines grinned. 'Well, if you're successful enough like us — I mean, when a guy's got *one* trophy in his cabinet, what more could he want, other than *another* trophy? And another.'

'And you lose more and more of your money with every divorce.'

Gaines laughed. 'But you, buddy, you married *late*. You spent your twenties and thirties hooked on the damn stock market. You're still stuck on wife number one.'

Dixon sighed and switched off the shower before grabbing his towel.

Gaines said, 'I mean... you know I *love* Jenni. She's *pretty*, right?' Well, *that* sounded like damning her by faint praise. 'But is she still hot between the sheets? Was she ever?'

'Hey, watch what you're saying about my wife.'

Gaines stepped out of his shower stall, towel wrapped around his waist. 'Okay, okay. But *you* know, and *I* know I'm telling the truth. Jenni's your emotional support now. And that's hard to give up.'

'She's the mother of my children.'

'And your best friend, right?' Gaines grinned. 'Apart from... well, *yours truly*, of course. But that goes without saying...'

Then they were dressing, and Gaines sounded like he was reeling in a fish, telling Dixon, 'The hardest goddamn wife to leave is your first one. Always the first.'

Dixon could feel the ghosts of feminists past turning over and over in their graves.

'You just need to know it's *okay*, buddy,' Gaines said, patting him on the back to say he could provide support, too. 'Maybe you just need... you know... a few test drives.'

'*What?*'

'Have a little fun. Jenni never needs to find out. See what sex can *really* be like.'

Dixon concealed a sigh.

Gaines continued, 'And even if she does find out... there's plenty of other fish in the sea. And you need to know, it's your biological *imperative*...'

Then they were heading back out to the limo, and just before they climbed in, Gaines stopped and told him earnestly, 'You just need to get *laid*, man.'

And it felt like they were still at Dartmouth and weren't 53-year-old men with silver flecks in their hair.

The worst thing was feeling that Gaines had it right. It made Dixon feel somehow tainted. But this time, he did have it right: Dixon *did* need to get laid.

The obvious answer would be to try to get Jenni in the mood for something when he went home.

But what the hell was he supposed to say to her after all this time since they'd last had sex?

Hey, honey, how about one for old time's sake?

Uh... say, sweetie, I was just feeling a little... horny...

You know what, you're looking mighty fine today, sweetheart! How about a little roll in the hay?

It was funny how marriage made it so weirdly difficult to seduce your partner.

He spent the whole journey back to the office thinking about how to broach the subject of sex to his wife. He regretted the fact that they had let their sex lives fizzle — and yet, what choice did he have?

Ever since that awful morning sickness she'd suffered during that second trimester with the twins, she hadn't shown any interest in sex. What was he supposed to do, demand it from her even though she wasn't interested?

And yet, as a married man, shouldn't he have the right to have sex?

Back in the office, he immersed himself in the fine detail of an imminent acquisition in the pharmaceutical sector. For a couple of blessed hours, he managed to forget about the whole issue of his marriage and that damn brunette.

Then it was four o'clock, and Mrs. Hawkes, his secretary, politely knocked on his door to inform him that his new intern had arrived. And Dixon was quietly shocked to open his office doors to find the *damn brunette* waiting patiently outside for him.

Jesus *wept*.

'Uh... hi there... I'm... Frank. Frank Dixon.'

'Yes, I know.'

She was too confident. She was too beautiful. She stepped up to him and offered her hand, and her hand was too soft. Her perfume was too

sweet. Her shirt had too many buttons unfastened. She was just too damn tempting.

And if he wanted her, he could probably have her.

‘Look,’ he said, an apology suddenly imprinting itself in the lines on his face. ‘I think there’s been some kind of mistake.’

‘Mistake?’ for the first time, a note of uncertainty flickered across the brunette’s perfect features.

He really didn’t like to reject her. God. He couldn’t face destroying her confidence — not when she was only an intern, not even out of law school yet.

‘I’m sorry,’ he said, fumbling for something to get him out of this. He finally said, ‘This isn’t a good time... I’ve got to go out...’

‘Oh, okay,’ said the brunette.

‘Why don’t you... brush up on the paperwork sitting on my desk... or something,’ he suggested while backing away.

‘Sure,’ she said, and her general sense of dominance was spiked by a sudden look of gratitude. That he was honoring her with the chance to glean something of what he was currently working on, even though she was an intern.

He gave her a nod and a silly little thumbs-up, which was one of those things he’d feel quietly embarrassed about for months afterward. He then turned away to stride with attempted confidence toward the elevator.

He went straight down to the parking levels.

Usually, he’d have Villiers drive him home in the limo — why waste so much time driving when you could spend the journey working? But Dixon didn’t want to walk through the building lobby to the street so early in the afternoon.

He didn’t want word to get back to Gaines that he’d gone home before it was even 4pm.

The 488 was parked down on the lowest level.

Naturally, it had been kept in perfect condition, but no one except the occasional mechanic had driven it in years. Dixon himself hadn’t been behind the wheel much since taking ownership of it back in 2015. But here it was. Magnificent.

Sure, the suspension was pretty hard when you weren't driving it at the track, but it was so *responsive* and so damn quick. And the sound of the V8 Berlinetta engine...

Then he was stuck in traffic on the FDR all the way up to Harlem, sitting behind a bus that belched out so much smoke it was a wonder the 488's beautiful rosso corsa paint didn't start to warp.

His thoughts turned to Jenni, of course.

Did she ever have sexual desires these days? It had been a long time since she'd had the twins. And these days, they had a competent nanny to help reduce the stress.

What if he was caught boinking the brunette intern, and Jenni decided to leave him? Would she remain asexual for the rest of her life, even if she was single again?

Dixon laughed at his weird train of thought.

When you thought about ending your marriage because you weren't getting enough sex, you weren't supposed to think about whether your wife would sleep with other guys after you walked out on her.

Was he trying to frighten himself out of accepting Gaines's view?

It gave him an odd, fluttering feeling inside his stomach to think of Jenni being free to see other guys.

He sighed. The bus moved ten yards forward. The lane beside him was moving fractionally more quickly, but there really wasn't any point in changing lanes. You get in the next lane, and the first lane starts moving.

There was an ad on the back of the bus that looked like one for a dating app. Two beautiful, nicely diverse people hugged each other and smiled brightly, undoubtedly happily living the perfect mediocre life in their perfectly mediocre GAP clothing. Dixon sighed.

Wait until you're married ten years, and then see how you feel about each other, he thought.

At the bottom of the advert was the logo, 'Marriage 2.0'. That caught his eye.

The tagline read: "Upgrade Your Relationship".

Huh?

There wasn't any other information on the ad. God. That was the way it was going these days, wasn't it? In this era of digital excellence, you didn't need to put a phone number on your advert; that was almost as outdated as putting an address there. You were supposed to go Google it.

He spent the whole way across the RFK Bridge wondering what the hell Marriage 2.0 was. He didn't want to use his cell phone while

driving; it was becoming as socially unacceptable as driving under the influence.

If it was a dating agency, why was it called Marriage 2.0?

He noticed that the models in the ad were both wearing wedding rings. Was it an Ashley Madison thing — a website to help married people have affairs? He'd nearly invested in that site. And then it got hacked spectacularly, its customer data leaked.

Driving onto the 278 northbound, Dixon found himself purposefully keeping behind the bus so that he could ponder the advert some more.

The models in the advert for Marriage 2.0 were in their forties, it seemed to Dixon. A little older than people you'd target for a dating app. So was this a dating app for divorced people? Or widows and widowers?

'Upgrade your relationship'. What did that mean?

Dixon felt he and Jenni needed to upgrade their relationship.

Past where the 278 merged with I-95, Dixon got sick of thinking about Marriage 2.0 and its advert. The traffic opened up a little, and he threaded his way through it, and it wasn't so long before he was crossing the Byram River, entering Connecticut, then sweeping down Exit 3.

When he got close to home, he drove past his own driveway and continued toward the Point and the Golden Cove Yacht Club.

He was too early to arrive home. He didn't want to face questions from Jenni. It wasn't like him to be early from work like this.

He parked in front of the Clubhouse, feeling overwhelmed by anxiety and all his racing thoughts. He tried to focus on breathing, on calming down. Maybe it was time to go back to that therapist. Find out what over-priced supplements would be suitable for anxiety.

He took a deep breath and clambered out of the car, nodding to a couple of staff members who had stopped to admire the Ferrari.

The concierge took his jacket and then showed him to a quiet table with an ocean view within the VIP Lounge. He requested a Hennessy on the rocks. Drinking on his own: *that* was never a good sign. But he needed space to breathe.

He picked up a magazine someone had left on the table — Town and Country. He wasn't really paying attention to it, flicking through pages full of glossy pictures of well-designed interiors, profiles of extremely wealthy people he hadn't actually heard of, and property listings for estates in Connecticut or the Hamptons that he had no genuine interest in.

However, toward the back of the magazine, there was a half-page ad featuring a familiar brand. *Marriage 2.0*.

God, he just kept coming back to it, didn't he?

This time, however, the image in the ad showed a less-than-happy couple, smartly dressed, seated on a sofa facing the camera, while off to the side was the blurred form of someone who could only be a marriage counselor.

Again, there was a tagline at the top, but this one read: "It doesn't have to come to this".

So was it some kind of marriage counseling service?

Dixon scratched his head, pulled out his phone, and flicked it out of airplane mode. He then ignored the 17 missed calls and 14 voicemails and Googled 'Marriage 2.0'.

Here it was.

Google described it as a "New Approach to Modern Relationships", which didn't help much. Still, Dixon clicked through to a glossy website that showed more images of happy couples enjoying life and moody couples clearly talking through their problems.

With Marriage 2.0, you don't have to sit on the couch and hope your spouse is telling the whole truth about what's going on in your relationship. And you don't have to untangle your own complicated feelings, either. Let science do all the hard work. Our proprietary technology will give you all the answers. Definitively.

Dixon thought: *if only.*

There was a page in the website's menu entitled 'Our Process'. He clicked on it.

With Marriage 2.0, we use technology to assess you and your partner to determine how you feel about each other, what is missing in your relationship, and how you can both strive to rebuild friendship and intimacy in a way that doesn't seem like too much hard work.

Well, that seemed too good to be true. Could you really assess someone scientifically and discover precisely what was causing problems in a relationship?

Once we have assessed you, the real magic happens. Using state-of-the-art Artificial Intelligence, we develop Experiences that will enhance your life together — and strengthen the bond between you in the most perfect way. Our Experiences are based on the specific needs and desires determined by our assessment of you. They are tailored to your exact preferences so that you will enjoy your new life as much as you enjoy your perfect relationship.

Dixon found himself scratching his head at all this. Was this real?

He stayed at the Yacht Club for a while, but for once, he wasn't working. He had his phone out, but he wasn't taking calls. He had his laptop open on the table, but he wasn't scouring the usual spreadsheets.

He was looking into marriage counseling. Couples therapy. Psychotherapists.

And while he did his due diligence, he was hiding in the corner of the VIP lounge, where other members he knew might not find him. He'd tipped the Maitre D' to help keep people away from that part of the room, wheeling out a story about not feeling so good, about needing some time away from people.

His research wasn't going so well. He didn't like anything that he saw. He kept coming back to that damn website for Marriage 2.0.

Meanwhile, Jenni kept texting him with updates about how the kids were doing after she'd collected them from kindergarten. About cute things they did at dinner time or later in the bath. The messages made him feel normal, that life could just roll on as it had been. That Jenni was happy with her lot.

But they also made him feel guilty for staying away. For always staying late at the office in the evenings.

He was missing out on watching the kids grow up.

He was missing out on Jenni.

But he just didn't feel right, going home, acting as though everything was fine. The workaholic in him needed to buckle down and plug away at this until he had a satisfactory solution.

Later, the Maitre D' sent over a waitress to see if he felt like some dinner.

'There's a delicious beef bourguignon on the menu tonight,' she said, with more than a hint of flirtation.

Dixon found himself looking her over and imagining how she might look beneath that neat white shirt and dark pencil skirt. How she might look on the bed of a cheap motel, wearing nothing but a come-hither look.

With that, the guilt set right back in.

'Uh... no, I think I'm going to head off in a moment or two,' he replied to her, hiding his lecherous feelings with a polite smile.

'That's a shame,' she said, with a look that suggested she really might be available to him if he changed his mind about leaving.

She was blonde, like Jenni. He watched her walk away from his table, checking out the delicious shape of her behind in that tight skirt. He tried to imagine Jenni wearing something like that but couldn't engineer nearly as much lust.

Had *he* lost interest in *Jenni*?

He remembered Gaines talking about her earlier. The way he'd called Jenni 'pretty'. The tone he'd used had suggested Dixon could do so much better.

Was he losing his peers' respect by clinging to a fading marriage?

But then Jenni texted him again, sharing a picture of the kids settling down for a bedtime story, and it made Dixon feel like a monster for thinking ill of his wife.

Before leaving the Yacht Club, he wondered what 'state-of-the-art Artificial Intelligence' would make of his relationship woes and what kind of 'Experience' would it devise to solve them?

And Frank Dixon very nearly signed up to Marriage 2.0 there and then.

When Frank Dixon finally returned home that evening, it seemed very late — but a glance at his Rolex Submariner said it was still only 7.30pm. It was relatively early for him to be back from the office. He might even be in time to read the kids a bedtime story.

But as he brought the Ferrari to a halt in front of the grand portico of their Greenwich mansion, Dixon felt a pang of sadness. He was usually home too late to even see the kids before they went to sleep. Had he become a lousy father, like his own dad?

Inside the house, he jogged up the main staircase toward the second-floor landing, and as he reached the top nearly ran right into the nanny.

‘Evening, Mr. Dixon.’

Ophelia was all dressed up, ready to go out and enjoy her own social time now that Mrs. Dixon was getting the kids in bed.

‘Hey, Ophelia. How’s it going?’

‘Great, thanks.’

He caught himself admiring the way she looked in her evening attire. Usually, she wore jeans and t-shirts and very little makeup or perfume. Tonight, however, she looked glamorous in a cream dress and dark nylons, a bright scarlet jacket over the top. She had a touch of cleavage on view, plenty of makeup, and an exotic fragrance.

‘Everything okay, Mr. Dixon?’

He stopped himself from staring, but a fraction too late. He brought his eyes up to hers and felt embarrassed that she’d caught him checking her out.

‘Uh... yeah,’ he smiled apologetically. ‘I just realized I left my glasses at the office.’

Ophelia smiled, seeming somewhat delighted that he’d noticed her. She even pushed out her chest a little more as though to reward his

attention.

He said, 'Well... have a good night.'

She flashed her eyes, daring to flirt with him, almost seductive as she said, 'You too, Mr. Dixon.'

For a moment, he could imagine Gaines, like a little devil on his shoulder, whispering into his ear: *'I can get her for you if you like.'*

He turned to watch her scamper down the stairs, leaving him with a chestful of her perfume, wondering if he needed to book himself into a sex addiction clinic. Was this a full-blown mid-life crisis? He was lusting after almost every woman he saw.

God. He could imagine Gaines chuckling smugly at his predicament.

'Go away,' he said aloud, as though the Gaines in his head might actually comply.

'Did you say something, darling?'

It was Jenni, appearing from around the corner, overhearing him talking to his imaginary business partner.

'Oh, not really. I just hung up on Gaines, that's all.'

'Can't that man leave you alone when you're at home?'

His wife looked tired but somehow still upbeat, smiling ear-to-ear to see him home.

'Are they...?' he asked her.

Her smile broadened. 'Still awake. They'd *love* you to read them something.'

Then he was straight into the kids' room, and the way their faces lit up with pure delight as they saw him filled him with absolute joy. He read them *The Pout-Pout Fish* and got them all nicely tucked in and settled down, ready for sleep.

On his way out, he was thinking, *how could I possibly give all this up, merely for the chance to sleep with a beautiful young thing who meant nothing to me?*

With the kids falling asleep, he went downstairs to the kitchen to find Mrs. Habscomb, the housekeeper, and retrieve some of that evening's dinner before she left for the night.

As he picked over a plate of Linguine Alla Puttanesca, he saw Jenni, now changed into her workout gear, heading off to the gym.

Then, later, after Mrs. Habscomb had wished him a good night and retired to her little apartment in the Summerhouse, he strolled up to his study to make a few work calls.

Through the kitchen window, he could see Jenni — now changed into an elegant black one-piece swimsuit — dive gracefully into the pool out on the terrace. Cooling off after her workout.

When they were both at home together, the two of them seemed to spend much of an evening doing their own thing, independently of each other. Often, they might not even bump into each other after dinner until it was time for bed.

Tonight, Frank wasn't in the mood to do much work. He checked on a few numbers, he monitored a few deals. But then he purposefully downed tools and left the study to check on the kids, before quietly descending to the first floor and the family room. Jenni was there, freshly showered and changed into some comfortable nightwear, watching late-night talk shows on TV.

'Hey,' Jenni said, surprised but delighted that he was joining her.

'Hey yourself.'

'Finished work already?'

'Uh-huh.'

'*Wonderful*,' she smiled.

While they sat together, Dixon kept looking over at his wife, subtly, out of the corner of his eye.

She was still attractive. Wasn't she? So why didn't he want to just drag her upstairs and tear her clothes off? Was it really just familiarity that took the thrill out of the possibility of sex for them?

She rarely wore makeup these days; she rarely wore glamorous clothes, but she rarely did anything unless it involved the kids. That meant her clothes would often gain food and paint and all the usual parenting stains. She didn't put effort into dressing up to impress her husband these days, but perhaps she felt she shouldn't have to. It was his job to be impressed with her anyway — he was her husband.

But because he was expected to believe she was beautiful purely because he was her husband, it was no longer special if he told her she looked good. Therefore, she had no motivation to wear something sexy or put on makeup.

And, if he ever dared to ask her to wear something sexy or put on a little lipstick now and again, she would take that as personal criticism. He'd learned to avoid that long ago. It wasn't his place to tell her how to dress, how to behave.

Of course, she was attractive without wearing lingerie or putting on makeup. She *was* a beautiful woman. It was just that because she didn't, it made him feel she wasn't interested in anything sexual with him.

He should dress up nicely, get some new cologne, take her out to dinner and romance her. But he'd tried that before and had been shot down. He didn't want her to feel she was being forced to do something she didn't want to do.

'Everything okay, sweetie?' Jenni asked him, and he knew she'd caught him staring.

He suppressed a little jolt of panic.

'Can you believe we've been married ten years?' he said, coming up with an explanation on the fly.

Jenni smiled. 'Crazy, isn't it? Time flies.'

'Seems like only yesterday we were *dating*.'

She laughed. 'I sold you this house, and next thing I know, you're picking me up at work so we can have dinner together out on the patio, surrounded by incredible ocean views.'

'I told you,' he grinned. 'You made more of an impression on me than the house.'

'But you still love the house.'

'I *adore* the house.'

They smiled at each other and were silent. They didn't need to talk at length these days. They didn't need to impress each other; they didn't need to fill the silences. They could just be with each other.

But we never want to ravish each other anymore, he was thinking. We never want to kiss and stroke each other and slip into sexual bliss together. We never want to jump each other's bones and just go at it until we're both gasping for oxygen.

'Are you feeling okay?' she asked him, and he guessed that she'd noticed him gazing out of the window.

'I'm a little tired,' he said, scratching for some excuse.

'You need more sleep.'

'Yes,' he nodded, feeling the fatigue in his joints and muscles.

He felt suddenly gloomy. He wanted to try and make something happen with Jenni, but he genuinely did not know how. He didn't know how to seduce his own wife anymore.

And if he tried, suddenly, out of the blue, would she think he'd gone crazy?

Have you been drinking, honey?

Maybe she'd even suspect he'd been having an affair. Wasn't one of the signs of being unfaithful a renewed effort to be romantic with your spouse? It was a way to stave off the guilt from your adultery.

Perhaps there was no point in even trying.

He sighed quietly and said, 'I should head up to bed.'

Jenni smiled, 'I'll be up a little later. After Game of Thrones.'

'Right.'

And that was that. He was walking away, and there had been no sex. And it seemed like there would be no sex any time in the near future. Maybe, in the future, at all.

He shuffled away and headed upstairs.

He took one last little glance at the kids, sleeping peacefully in their beds in the west wing. They were just beautiful. Perfect little combinations of himself and Jenni. He was so lucky just to have them in his life.

And yet, as soon as he stepped away from their room, his thoughts turned to his wife again. To sex.

Jenni seemed peaceful, happy with life, he thought. Was she completely content? Did she ever think about the fact that they didn't really have sex anymore? She was living the perfect life; otherwise, perhaps it didn't matter to her.

Did sex matter?

Maybe he could just get by on masturbation for the rest of his life.

'*God, that's pathetic,*' he heard Gaines's voice in his head.

Walking out of the west wing, back toward the main bedroom, he passed Ophelia's bedroom. The door was slightly ajar, and he paused as he went by. He caught a whiff of her sweet, enticing perfume.

Now he peeked through the doorway. Her room was fairly untidy, with clothes all over her bed as though she'd been trying on various outfits before deciding on what to wear to go out. The clothes she'd been wearing that day were heaped on the floor — jeans, a tank top, panties.

God. Apparently, she wore thongs even while she was working as a nanny to take care of the kids.

He started picturing her wearing them and nothing else. Imagining himself pinning her down on the bed, dragging those panties down her long, slender legs with his teeth while she giggled under him, excitedly waiting for him to have his wicked way with her.

Dirty old man.

And then came Gaines's voice in his head again: *'I can get her for you if you like.'*

He felt suddenly embarrassed. He wasn't going to lust after the nanny. Perhaps he did need to just go out and have sex with someone — an escort, whoever — and be done with it, and maybe that would stop him from thinking these awful thoughts about the future of his marriage. But he wasn't going to seduce Ophelia.

He closed Ophelia's door and padded quietly along the second-floor landing to the east wing, and around the corner toward the main bedroom.

In recent months — years? — he'd been sleeping in the guest room opposite the main bedroom since his snoring had disrupted Jenni's sleep. But tonight, he went into the main bedroom. He wanted to be with her. He missed sleeping with her, even if it didn't involve sex.

He had half a thought that she might slide into bed with him later, after she was done watching *Game of Thrones*, and a little cuddle could gently turn into something mildly sexual between them. Probably wouldn't happen, but he could fantasize.

He saw Jenni's black swimsuit hanging up on the towel rail beside the shower in the en suite bathroom. She looked good in a swimsuit. She'd always been a swimmer. He remembered a time when seeing her in her swimsuit — or out of it — would have gotten his hormones raging and led to something raunchy between them.

Now, he gazed down at her swimsuit and felt nothing much.

He sighed.

Over by the door, her gym clothes were sitting on top of the laundry basket. The lycra had been skin-tight on her as she had flexed and pumped and sweated. Her underwear — certainly not a thong — dropped on top.

Yet he felt no sexual desire from such a sight, as he might have done once.

Was it just familiarity that made him respond sexually to the sight of the nanny's underwear while feeling nothing for his wife's?

Another sigh.

Later, he awoke as Jenni came to bed. She was surprised to see him there, wanting to share her bed for the first time in a while, but she wasn't unhappy about it.

'Night-night,' Jenni said, smiling as she put her earplugs in.

They kissed on the lips, briefly, and then the lights went out.

He breathed in her scent and admired the shape of the back of her neck, her shoulders as she lay facing away from him. But he felt nothing sexual anymore.

Was this the kind of problem that should end an otherwise perfectly good marriage?

He couldn't sleep. That wasn't particularly unusual, but this was one of the few times it was caused by something other than work issues crowding his head.

It was 1am, and Jenni was sound asleep.

Dixon donned a bathrobe and his leather slippers and headed downstairs, back to the family room and the TV. Usually when he couldn't sleep, he would simply head to his office and get some work done. This time, however, he was in no mood for work.

He lounged on the oversized couch in front of the TV and flicked through the various streaming services. They had pretty much everything available, a whole world of entertainment, but Dixon couldn't choose. Maybe there was even *too much* choice.

He wanted something familiar to watch, something comforting. He found the first episode of the first season of *Lost* on Disney+.

At the end of the second episode of *Lost*, he started thinking he ought to at least try to get some sleep. He reached for the remote and accidentally touched the button that switched the television over to the local TV station coming in through the antenna.

A middle-aged woman who looked like she'd been plucked from the 1970s stood in front of a blank green background, talking about how she'd lost her job and became angry, frustrated, and depressed.

'*Pretty soon, my husband and I weren't getting along,*' she said. '*He was getting the brunt of my anger, and I knew we needed help.*'

The woman went on to say that a company called Family Counseling Services had given her and her husband the support they needed. That it had helped them get back to a life they enjoyed.

‘And now I’m moving forward in life — with a renewed spirit,’ she said brightly, walking across the screen for some unapparent reason.

Dixon groaned. Maybe he *did* need therapy.

Or maybe he and Jenni needed marriage counseling. But how would she feel if he suddenly suggested it? They hadn’t been fighting. They didn’t dislike each other. They certainly weren’t having money problems; they weren’t unemployed, angry, depressed.

Would she be angry that he felt they needed counseling?

God. He had to get some sleep.

As he emerged into the entrance hall, he nearly jumped out of his skin as the front door opened — but it was only Ophelia, coming back from her night out. Wow, she’d been out late.

‘Oh, hi, Mr. Dixon,’ she grinned, and he could tell from her eyes and the way she walked to the bottom of the stairs that she was somewhat inebriated.

‘Hey, Ophelia,’ he said, approaching her since it would have looked odd to suddenly shrink back and change the direction he’d been going. ‘You have a good night?’

‘Oh, yes, thank you. Lot of fun.’

She wasn’t wearing her scarlet jacket anymore. As he approached her, he saw that her nipples were faintly visible, pushing against her cream dress.

‘You’re up late again, Mr. Dixon. Everything okay?’ she said, touching her hand to the bottom of the banister and lifting one foot onto the bottom step before pausing to look over at him. Her position made her arch her back and push out her chest, almost as though she was posing for him.

‘Oh, you know. Can’t sleep.’

‘Anything I can do to help?’ she said. He didn’t think he imagined it that she was being mildly suggestive, that she was subtly opening the door for something to happen between them.

He approached her — he could hardly avoid it — and drew in a chestful of her perfume and the scent of alcohol.

‘Ah... no, thank you,’ he said, thinking that Gaines probably would have taken her up on her offer. ‘I really should try to get some shut-eye.’

‘Well, okay,’ Ophelia smiled, with a hint of seduction in her eyes, ‘but if there’s anything at all I can do...’

‘I know where you are,’ Dixon finished her sentence — and then felt mildly embarrassed at suggesting he would know she would be up in her bedroom.

‘I *do* have the day off tomorrow.’

Did she really mean to suggest that something might happen between them? It was rather shocking if so. Dixon liked to think his paranoia and libido were merely leading him astray — she probably meant they could have a drink together or shoot some pool or something. He preferred to give her the benefit of the doubt.

‘Well, you’d probably better get some sleep anyway,’ he said.

She nodded, with a note of disappointment in her dark eyes.

He said, ‘Night, Ophelia.’

‘Good night, Mr. Dixon,’ she said, walking up the stairs in front of him.

He tried not to gaze up at her while she went on ahead of him up the stairs, though he could see a whole lot since her dress was so short.

He woke late the following day, or at least late for him. It was 8am, and he had only managed about two or three hours of sleep in the end.

He went down to the kitchen to greet the kids as they ate their second breakfast, and kissed Jenni on the cheek before assuring her he was feeling all right, despite this disruption to the usual routine.

Then he was out the door, thankful that there was no sign of Ophelia on his way out.

Climbing back into the Ferrari, he headed back toward the city, groaning as he realized he was now facing rush-hour traffic because he’d gotten out so late.

On the less-than-excellent car radio, which wasn’t exactly a perk of spending all that money to own a Ferrari, he found nothing worth listening to except NPR. He half-listened to the news as the traffic stopped and started pretty much all the way down to the Bronx and then zoned out as a piece about the staggering number of cars that hit deer each year.

But after switching from I-95 to I-278, a woman came on the radio talking about the harm that marriage counseling could do to modern relationships.

‘My advice to any couple is, don’t,’ she said. ‘When my husband and I went to marriage counseling, we just ended up trading insults each

week. And even though the counselor took my side most of the time, it didn't do anything to repair our relationship.'

He listened as the woman explained that she and her husband had been encouraged to open up to each other about the bad things happening in their relationship.

'I wasn't encouraged to look at the good things about my husband at all. I wasn't reminded why I was with him in the first place, why he's just so *brilliant*. All the little things about him I overlooked when I got tired and cranky, and we got into fights.'

The woman revealed that her marriage counselor had ultimately decided the best thing for her and her husband was to split up.

Dixon sighed. There were probably good and bad marriage counselors out there, and this woman had picked a stinker. But what if he went to try counseling and ran into the same problem as the woman on NPR?

His new intern was waiting for him in his office, of course, looking fresh as a daisy and tempting as sin.

‘I’ve taken a look at the Retsina numbers,’ she said, rising from Dixon’s own desk chair as he approached. ‘I think there might be room to...’

‘Let’s have a look,’ he said, noticing the top two buttons of her white shirt were unfastened, offering him a view of her upper chest bordering on the inappropriate.

As he stepped passed her, he inhaled a lungful of her overstrong perfume. He tried not to gaze at her chest, though it was as impressively presented as the numbers on his desk, which she must have spent all night analyzing.

She’d written an entire report on the Retsina deal Dixon had been lining up.

‘Very impressive,’ he said and saw her demeanor brighten as she stood there primly in front of his desk.

She was a bright one. Made him wonder why she felt the need to use her feminine wiles to try to get ahead as well. He figured she was attempting to use every possible weapon in her arsenal to climb the corporate ladder.

But as Dixon read her report further, he found himself imagining what Gaines might say to all this. Gaines would suggest he take her for lunch somewhere — somewhere impressive — to talk about her insights into this deal. Wow her with a rooftop restaurant like Manhatta.

Maybe lunch would turn into afternoon drinks, and afternoon drinks would turn into dinner. And then, eventually, a hotel room with an equally breathtaking view of the city.

Mrs. Hawkes would rearrange all his calls and his meetings for an afternoon.

Then, imagine what it would really be like, fucking a young woman like *this*? It would have to be *out of this world* good sex.

And what about afterward? He'd find his way back home to Greenwich and feel genuinely awful about what he'd done.

'Look,' he said now, looking up and trying not to notice Samantha's wincingly trim figure that her business attire only seemed to accentuate. 'Why don't we get you a nice little office downstairs, and you can spend a little more time looking into these deals.'

'Oh,' she said, sounding unsure whether to be excited by the opportunity or spurned by his failure to go down the whole *Gaines route* with her.

'We'll get you a senior exec to support...' From the top of her report, he saw that her name was Samantha — Samantha Bryant.

'This is good work, Samantha.'

'Thank you... sir. Mr. Dixon.'

Then he was on his feet, escorting her toward the door. 'I've got a few meetings to attend to today, but I'll get Mrs. Hawkes to sort something out for you... and we'll take it from there, okay?'

'Great. Thank you, Mr. Dixon.'

On the way into the first meeting of the day, Gaines patted him on the back and asked him, 'How's that sweet intern working out for you, buddy?'

He seemed almost offended when Dixon told him he'd had her moved downstairs, that he didn't have any real need for interns just now.

'One of these days, you are going to get *blue balls*, my friend,' Gaines warned him. 'And I'm warning you... that is not something you want to have. Not in this game.'

He had lunch with a client at the Club, and then when the client had to rush off for an auction preview over in Hell's Kitchen somewhere, Dixon didn't feel like going straight back to the office.

He felt a trifle bloated from lunch, perhaps. Or perhaps he just needed more of a break from things.

He had a couple of calls to make, but then he decided a swim in the Club pool might let him stretch his limbs, while at the same time

encouraging him to relax. The water was wonderfully cool, and after swimming lengths for 45 minutes, the burn in his muscles and his lungs felt good. Yet it didn't do much to take his mind off things.

After his swim, he sat in the sauna for 20 minutes but didn't manage to relax there, either.

He showered, and was at his locker in the changing room, changing back into his suit, when he overheard a conversation between two men in the next row of lockers.

'...No, it's not counseling. Not at all. I mean, I thought that's what it was when Janine came to me with the brochure.'

'You've tried counseling?'

'We did. It's really only effective at making us argue *more*. I don't know anybody who's done it and then didn't head straight for the divorce courts.'

'It's, like, something you have to tick off your list before you get to divorce, isn't it? I didn't bother, my last two divorces.'

'But you know, we thought there was still hope for us, me and Janine. I mean, we've always clashed heads. Even before we got married. Nothing's changed about that.'

Dixon didn't want to eavesdrop, but this seemed like too much of a coincidence, overhearing a conversation like this, considering the thoughts he'd been having recently. So he found himself sitting on the bench between the lockers, frozen mid-way into buttoning up the shirt, listening intently.

'So, what was the answer for you guys?'

'Sex. Damn good *sex*. Can you believe it? We've always argued, Janine and I, but when we first got together, it always ended up with us in bed, so none of the arguments really mattered.'

'I remember you saying she was shit-hot in bed before you married her. So how did it work, this new place?'

'It's hard to explain. We went to this place, and... well, we didn't have to *talk* about our problems — they hooked us up to this machine.'

'Modern technology, eh?'

'And then... well, a few weeks later, we started getting text messages from this place, instructing us on what to do... some of them were... well, a little *unusual*, you might say.'

'What did you have to do?'

'Well... this and that. But the upshot was, now Janine and I can't keep our hands off each other...'

Dixon sighed. He was totally intrigued by what the two men were talking about — of course he was. But what he needed to know was the name of the marriage counseling firm the one guy had used. And he could hardly walk over there and admit to eavesdropping their entire conversation before asking the firm's name.

‘And it wasn't prohibitive?’

‘Not for us. It all depends on your circumstances, of course. How much... intervention... is necessary to repair the marriage.’

‘Right, right.’

‘But you have to ask yourself — what is your marriage worth?’

‘And, how much would another divorce end up costing you?’

Dixon started rehearsing possible lines he might say to them while he finished getting dressed. He didn't know them. He'd never seen either of them at the Club before. Perhaps he'd never see them again — he didn't know all the Club members, of course he didn't. He decided that just walking up to them and apologizing for overhearing their conversation would be worth the bother for knowing what place they were talking about.

But then, as he rounded the corner of the next bank of lockers and saw them there in front of him, Dixon spotted one of them giving the other a leaflet. On the leaflet was a very recognizable brand.

Marriage 2.0.

As Villiers drove him back to the office, Dixon was once again trawling the Marriage 2.0 website on his phone.

He had to admit, it was all intriguing.

It appeared that whatever solution it came up with, the program was tailored toward the specific, individual problems in your marriage. It wasn't based on what worked for other people; it was designed for you.

Hearing another Club member providing an unsolicited testimonial about the service was powerful persuasion.

He looked up the office address on the Marriage 2.0 website. The HQ was on Lexington — it had to be a fair-size operation to afford rents around there. Perhaps he could slip away one afternoon and take a look.

The main concern he had was what Jenni might do if she found out he was toying with bringing in the professionals to help with his concerns about their relationship. She might interpret his move as

indicating he wasn't happy being married to her, that *there was something that needed fixing in their relationship*. What if she didn't feel the same way?

Jenni might not feel the need for sexual intimacy in their marriage. She might be upset at what he was thinking about doing. She might even suspect it was all some way for him to pressure her into sex she didn't want.

On the way back up to his office, the elevator slowed unexpectedly. It came to a halt on floor 57, where the boardroom and associated meeting rooms could be found.

Dixon waited for the elevator doors to open, and when they did, Gaines stepped into the elevator. But he was not alone.

The brunette intern, Samantha, was with him.

'Hey, Buddy,' Gaines said, with the kind of smirk you might expect to find on a crocodile.

'Mr. Dixon,' Samantha greeted him curtly.

'How's it going?'

'Good, thank you.'

'Never better,' Gaines added.

As the elevator got moving again, Dixon noticed that the beautiful brunette was standing noticeably close to Gaines in that small space. As though she was insinuating that she was now attached to Gaines rather than having more to do with Dixon.

Then Gaines said, 'Hey, Sam, you think you could track down that Trent-Ross guy we talked about? It would be interesting to hear his take on things.'

And Gaines touched a hand to her lower back, hinting that something was going on between them. Asserting some kind of territorial rights to her.

'Of course, Mr. Gaines. I'll get on it straight away.'

Via the mirrored wall, Gaines gave Dixon the kind of grin that said, without words, *well, you had your chance, buddy. Can you blame me for having a crack at her?*

Dixon gave a little shrug as though to say, *whatever, she's nothing to me.*

And yet it did hurt him a little that Gaines would go for her. Perhaps ‘hurt’ was too strong. Annoy. It didn’t surprise Dixon that Gaines would attempt to move in on Samantha. What *was* surprising was the faint feeling of regret that Dixon felt — he still found the young woman devastatingly attractive.

‘Perhaps try and arrange dinner for us all — tonight,’ Gaines said to the intern. ‘We could try Manhatta. You ever been to that place?’

‘No, Mr. Gaines.’

‘You should see the views. Food’s not bad, either.’

Then the elevator stopped again, and the two of them gave polite salutary glances at Dixon before disappearing off together toward Gaines’s office.

Dixon sighed as the elevator doors closed.

Mrs. Hawkes had seen everything in all her years of service — but apparently, she hadn’t seen Dixon looking like this.

‘Is everything okay, sir?’

Dixon was puzzled at her response to him simply walking out of the elevator toward his office.

‘Uh... yeah, just feeling a little under the weather today,’ he said, wondering what signs she was picking up that he was feeling troubled at this point.

‘I can move this afternoon’s meetings, Mr. Dixon, easily enough.’

‘Oh, no, Mrs. Hawkes. That’s very kind, but — ’

‘You should get Villiers to take you home early, get some rest.’

She could seem like your kindly old mother, sometimes, Mrs. Hawkes.

‘No, I’ll be... I’ll be fine,’ he insisted.

‘Well, you certainly shouldn’t overdo things today, Mr. Dixon. ERG were asking for a conference call later today, but I think I’ll just put them off until tomorrow.’

‘Thanks, Mrs. Hawkes, that would be fine.’

In the quiet sanctuary of his office, Dixon went to the small bathroom hidden by one of the walnut panels lining the walls. Inside, he glanced at the mirror. His face was looking a little pale. The bags under his eyes were a little on the dark side. His eyes were somewhat bloodshot.

He splashed water on his face and found his thoughts shifting back to Gaines and the intern, Samantha. Dixon knew Gaines well enough, knew his methods well enough. Whether or not they had dinner with the Trent-Ross guy that evening, Gaines would take Samantha to Manhatta.

She would be impressed by the meal, the restaurant, Gaines. And later, her clothes would be strewn around his hotel room, and Gaines would be lying between her coltish thighs.

Dixon sighed. He felt a fluttering in his chest, a deep anxiety all of a sudden. Such a weird feeling.

The first thing that sprang to mind as some kind of explanation for the feeling was that he wanted to go back down to Gaines's office and rescue young Samantha Bryant. Tell her, straight up, *you don't need to do this to secure your career*. Warn her, perhaps, that after Gaines had chewed her up and spat her out again, he probably wouldn't want her sticking around the company much longer.

Part of him wanted to try to win Samantha back for himself. He felt a huge pang of regret, of *miss it, miss out*.

Gaines would make way if he went down there and claimed her for himself, wouldn't he?

But what if Jenni found out?

Outside in the office, the intercom was ringing. Mrs. Hawkes had someone on the line for his first call of the afternoon. Dixon stepped out behind his desk and felt suddenly weak, the energy draining from his body.

Oh, Jesus. What was happening to him?

There wasn't any kind of pain where his heart should be inside his body. He wasn't having a heart attack, was he? Weren't you supposed to have a piercing pain in your chest, just to the left of center?

But he felt undeniably awful. Cold, feverish, and so weak. He felt the sweat breaking out over his pallid forehead. Every step forward felt as though his shoes were made of lead. He struggled just to get to his desk. He lunged for the intercom.

'Yes?' he said, breathless.

'Mr. Dixon, I have Surefire on the line, from Chicago...'

'Okay, thanks, Mrs...' he said, forcing the words out of his mouth. Every syllable seemed to take the kind of effort it would take an Olympic powerlifter to raise a record-high weight.

And then, finally, it all seemed too much.

The next moment, he was sitting on the floor, his back against the panel that was the secret door to his personal bathroom, and Mrs.

Hawkes was holding a cold, damp cloth against his forehead while a young man he'd never met was attempting to fan air onto his face with a stack of papers.

'Doctor Ryan is on his way,' Mrs. Hawkes said.

But Dixon shook his head gently. '*No*, no. I don't need any of that.'

He did feel a little better now. Warmth was returning to his body, and it was no longer hard work to speak. He still felt a little strange — with the headache, a certain looseness to his balance, and queasiness in his stomach, he would have said it was a hangover, except that he hadn't had alcohol for a while. He made it a rule not to drink before 6pm.

'You *collapsed*, sir,' Mrs. Hawkes said.

'It was just a little turn...' he said, not wanting to cause any kind of commotion.

'Frank.'

Mrs. Hawkes seemed to shock the universe with her first-ever use of his first name.

'Look, I'm feeling much better, thanks, Mrs. Hawkes.'

'At least get checked out?'

He took a deep breath and did his best to pull himself up to his feet as though nothing was amiss. 'Look,' he said, 'I'll get Villiers to take me home. I can get Dr. Swann to come out and give me a check-up while I'm at home.'

Mrs. Hawkes nodded.

'But call off the paramedics, okay? There's people far more in need than me.'

Then he was in the limo again, Villiers at the wheel. Only for some reason, they didn't shoot straight out and onto the FDR to drive north. Villiers took them up Church Street and 6th Avenue.

Dixon didn't feel like questioning the route.

Perhaps the driver had been told to take a deliberately long time to get him home, to encourage him to relax and see that there was no rush in this.

But by the time they eventually drew close to Central Park, an idea leaped into Dixon's head, and he was asking Villiers to take them via Lexington Avenue.

And here, as bold as day, was Marriage 2.0.

If the logo hadn't been above the entrance there on the street, Dixon might have glanced at the main headquarters of Marriage 2.0 and thought it nothing more than a fairly large Apple Store.

Sitting there on Lexington Avenue, a block down from Bloomingdale's, it certainly didn't look like the offices of a marriage counseling service.

The grand glass facade gave it an open and airy appearance. Inside, there was nothing more than tables laid out with tablets placed around them. It looked like they were selling tablets rather than marital therapy services.

Plenty of people were milling in and out, so Dixon didn't feel too self-conscious wandering in.

Inside, the few advertising displays around the store showed only more of the kind of happy people living fulfilled lives that could be found on their website.

The tablets around the store seemed to form the focus of discussions between customers and staff. Dixon noticed people picking them up, touching the screens to find out more about various aspects of the Marriage 2.0 service — and then available staff members would approach.

Dixon found himself moving to an empty table and picking up one of the tablets himself. The screen offered him a single question in big, bold white font on a blue background:

- Are you ready to upgrade your relationship?

He was quite taken aback by all this. There were a lot of people in here. A lot of customers. Sure, when you looked at them, they were generally a little older than the people who would frequent an Apple

Store — very few people in their 20s, quite a few in their 40s and 50s. But the point was, demand for this service was surprising.

But, sure. How many people in this country are in a relationship? How many people are married? Dixon happened to remember from research on a potential investment project that there were more than 61 million married couples in the US alone.

And he was willing to bet that if you asked them, the vast majority would admit that there were ways in which their relationships could be ‘upgraded’.

This agency was simply normalizing the whole process of marital therapy, surely. Bringing it into the 21st century.

And prime retail space on Lexington Avenue, for God’s sake.

Dixon felt strangely encouraged. So many other people were doing this; there *couldn’t* be anything wrong with it.

‘Can I help you, sir?’

A staff member approached — a young man wearing black jeans and a button-down shirt that was the shade of blue that always seemed to surround the Marriage 2.0 logo on all of its branding materials.

‘Uh... yeah,’ he said, scratching his head, glancing around to check no one was watching or laughing at him. ‘How... does this whole thing work, exactly?’

‘I take it you’re a first-timer, sir?’

‘Uh-huh. Yeah.’

The young man nodded. ‘Okay. You’re in a relationship?’

Dixon held up his hand to reveal his narrow, gold wedding band. He smiled in response to the young man’s smile.

‘Okay. So you know how people say you really have to *work at it* to make a relationship successful over a long period?’

‘Right.’

‘Well,’ the guy smiled again. ‘We’re here to take away some of that *burden*.’

The sales patter wasn’t far removed from what he’d already gleaned from the Marriage 2.0 website, advertising materials — and that overheard conversation in the Club. It did all sound intriguing. Dixon was, in many respects, already sold. The main thing Dixon didn’t understand was the technology behind the service.

‘How does it work?’ he asked the guy. ‘I mean, I get it that you design and operate experiences for couples — to help them strengthen their relationships. But how? You’re Expedia, but for romantic vacations?’

‘It’s different for each couple,’ the guy explained. ‘Sure, some might find themselves traveling, enjoying a fun Experience together in some exotic or historic location abroad. But some couples just find their normal day-to-day lives tweaked here and there, and that is enough to relight the fire — if you know what I mean?’

Dixon nodded. ‘I think I get it.’

The staffer said, ‘We use a lot of proprietary technology — to assess couples, to determine what they need, to provide them Experiences and gather feedback on how they’re responding to those Experiences...’

And Dixon was sold by everything he heard. But when the guy’s performance was over, Dixon said, ‘Here’s the thing. I would kind of like to see what all this is about — from what you say, from what I understand, I would want to use your service. But I don’t really feel comfortable *persuading my wife* that we need to use a service like this.’

The staffer paused then said gravely, ‘You know a good marriage is all about *communication*, don’t you?’

Dixon pressed his lips together and gave a mildly embarrassed little nod.

Then the guy broke out into a big, broad smile as if to say he’d been joking by acting so serious. ‘Hey, it’s okay,’ he said. ‘I mean, I wouldn’t say it’s the most *common* way to do it, but we can take on individual clients, sure. I’ll just have to check with my boss...’

Dixon nodded and calmly waited for the guy to scurry away and consult a superior. Thankfully, he wasn’t away for too long.

‘Okay. There shouldn’t be a problem,’ he said, nodded, rubbing his hands together. ‘My line manager said you might find your Experience... is slightly *different* than it might have been if you’d brought your wife in with you. But we are beginning to see more and more demand for this kind of approach. So — ’

‘So I can do this, and you won’t... I mean, she won’t find out...?’

‘It’ll be okay. Your situation will be analyzed by our AI...’

Dixon nodded.

So Marriage 2.0 used AI to provide experiences for married couples? That just seemed insane. But then, some of the best ideas started out seeming insane.

‘...And then you will find yourself and your wife undertaking an Experience that should improve your relationship. But you’ll find it will be only yourself that gets direct instructions from Marriage 2.0 as your Experience unfolds.’

Dixon nodded. ‘That makes sense, I guess.’

He signed up, of course. While the shop assistant entered his basic details into the Marriage 2.0 registration system, Dixon called Villiers to tell the driver not to stick around that afternoon, that he'd make his way back home by his own steam.

'You can come back any time for your assessment,' the Marriage 2.0 assistant explained once he was done with Villiers.

'I have some time this afternoon. Can I do it now?'

The guy nodded. 'Of course. It can take... a while to complete.'

'I have nowhere else to be today.'

'Great. You have some kind of ID on you?' Dixon nodded curtly at the guy's question, making him smile. 'In that case, just go on upstairs, and they'll be able to check you in.'

Then he was on his way up a fairly lengthy escalator to an upper floor.

Dixon got the feeling he was leaving an Apple Store and entering an airport terminal. There were no travelers with suitcases around, but otherwise, it was just like checking in at a modern airport, aside from the abundance of Marriage 2.0 branding everywhere.

It took a while to check in — he had to have his driver's license scanned, and he had to surrender his cell phone for collection on his way out.

Then he passed through security — again, just like an airport — before he found a seat in a large waiting area that was just like the gate at an airport terminal. There were even banks of TV monitors on which appointment times were listed by surname. For appointments within the next 10 minutes, there was a little note on the screens telling customers to go to a particular room. For others, including himself, the instructions simply read 'on time' for now. Just like an airport.

Even the architecture seemed to nod to airport design. The large, floor-to-ceiling windows at one end of the waiting room looked as though they should have gazed out over a view of parked aircraft, rather than out onto Lexington Avenue.

Around the central waiting area, there were small cafes and restaurants, even a little store offering newspapers, magazines, books,

and candy. Signs directed visitors to hallways that supposedly led to rooms 0–20, 20–49, 50–79, and 80–124.

As Dixon took a seat with a view over the street, he marveled at the sheer scale of this whole operation.

So many people were here, supposedly getting their marriages improved. Jesus. How had he only recently heard of this place? It was a bona fide *phenomenon*.

He wondered why the high security was needed. Surely there was no terrorist threat to this place? Was it simply about keeping the company's IP secure? After all, they supposedly had some serious technology at the heart of their service.

After a few seated minutes taking in his surroundings, the other thing that struck him was just how normal everyone else around him seemed to be. Even merely a cursory examination suggested there was quite a cross-section of society here — in terms of apparent wealth, age, race, and so on.

It was clear most of the people here were here as couples, of course. However, there were some individuals dotted around the place, suggesting to Dixon that couples could have their assessments done separately, perhaps since their marriages were in such trouble, or simply because of scheduling availability.

With an hour to wait, he found himself getting up to pick up a newspaper, a snack, and a drink at one of the stores around the edge of the terminal, before returning to his seat. But he used the newspaper more as cover to observe the people around him than to read the actual news.

The people here didn't seem particularly miserable. Sure, there were a few, here and there, who weren't what you'd call especially positive-looking. A few couples, here and there, seemed to be sitting in stony silence, perhaps facing slightly away from each other, mouths curved downward. Dixon almost awarded himself points for spotting two couples he believed were actively engaged in arguments. However, they were being subtle about it, trying to keep things from getting too public. Yet many people seemed cheerful, even happy and optimistic.

Perhaps some couples were acting to strengthen their relationships before things spiraled into problem territory, he thought.

Perhaps some couples were happy *because* they had decided to do this.

There was more of an air of excitement about the place than you might find at an airport; that was tangible. People seemed to have that

edgy, nervous look from not knowing what would happen to them, as though they were lined up waiting for a scary rollercoaster. But there was clearly a certain level of hope that life would be improved somehow, now that they were doing this.

Opposite him, an interracial couple in their late 20s or early thirties were cheerfully holding hands and looking at each other as though still profoundly in love. Dixon could see the Asian woman's hand, and she had a conspicuous engagement ring but no wedding band. Were they here before they'd even gotten married?

He overheard the Asian woman saying, 'I'm not marrying you if they make you wear some kind of gimp suit to the wedding. You know that, don't you?'

Her fiancé was chuckling. 'What if I sit through my assessment trying to constantly imagine *you* wearing a gimp suit at our wedding? You think they'll make you?'

The fiancée rolled her eyes and pouted good-naturedly before declaring: 'If that happens, I am telling you right now I'm hitting the 'STOP' button on all this, buddy.'

Dixon almost got caught staring at the couple and smiling at their conversation, so he tried to avoid it.

A little further along the row, a single woman sat alone, her attention buried in a Kindle. Perhaps she was reading a romance novel in which she could immerse herself in a more prosperous, or more enjoyable, relationship. She was smartly dressed in a business-looking suit, successful-looking, around 40ish.

What was her story?

Ten minutes before his allotted time, the status against his name changed from 'Please Wait' to 'Please Go to Room 244'.

As he made his way, following the overhead signs, he had the strangest feeling he'd forgotten his carry-on suitcase. But he wasn't heading for the gate, he wasn't boarding a plane.

He passed a cafe and ventured down a wide hallway until he came to a large elevator, which was already waiting for him, although he had to rush to get on before the doors closed. A woman wearing horn-rimmed glasses, who had long Swedish-looking blonde hair tied back in a ponytail, held the doors open for him as he approached.

‘Thanks,’ he nodded.

‘You’re most welcome,’ she smiled. ‘Floor, please?’

He glanced at the floor listings beside the elevator controls and saw where rooms 231 to 249 were located. ‘Uh... 20, thanks.’

‘No problem.’

They shared another smile after she pressed his floor 20 button and then stood silently as the elevator got moving. He could see her reflected in the elevator doors — surely someone who looked like that couldn’t be having marital problems? But then, he figured, how would Jenni look if she was here, waiting to be assessed by Marriage 2.0? If he was some other man, he might wonder how someone like her could have marital problems.

God, the people in here seemed so normal. All the people waiting for their appointments downstairs, too. They didn’t seem like life’s losers, they didn’t seem like they were on day release from some nearby asylum or other. They weren’t even like the kind of publicity-hungry types who line up all day to audition for X-Factor or American Idol. What did he expect, though?

He was the only one stepping out on the 20th floor. He glanced back inside the elevator as the doors closed, and the blonde woman gave him a little smile that seemed to be wishing him luck. He attempted to return it before the doors closed.

Then he was on his own, heading down a walkway that circled around the waiting room ‘terminal’ as though this was the Globe Theatre, and he was looking down on a production of Shakespeare.

The door to room 244 was open. A man with white hair, who seemed way too young for his white hair to be age-related, stood waiting for him.

‘Mr. Dixon,’ he said, smiling as Dixon approached.

‘Yes?’

‘Patrick Clayton.’ The man held out his hand for Dixon to shake. ‘Welcome to Marriage 2.0.’

Clayton showed him into the room, indicating that he should take a seat in an oversized chair on the other end of the room. The chair looked like the kind of thing you’d sit in to have your eyes tested at an optician’s. In fact, as Dixon took in the whole room, it struck him how similar it was to an optometrist’s room at the optician’s. There was a desk beside the chair in which Dixon sat, on which was a computer and a small shelving unit containing tiny bottles of clear liquid. The white-haired man sat here, facing Dixon as he tapped in a little preliminary information.

‘So... I’m sorry for the wait,’ Clayton said with a smile. ‘As you can see, we’re swamped at the moment.’

‘It’s incredible,’ Dixon said. He couldn’t quite contain his amazement at it all. ‘The number of people out there waiting for appointments...’

The other man nodded. ‘There’s a lot of demand. You know there are 62m married couples in the United States? And the divorce rate is currently running at around 50%.’

‘You have offices in other cities? Other countries?’

‘An office in Los Angeles, of course. Chicago. One in Houston, actually. We’re not yet international, at least in terms of client recruitment.’

‘But it’s *phenomenal*. Even just this...’

Clayton grinned. ‘We’re not quite a Netflix — or an Apple. But there certainly seems demand for what we’re offering.’

‘You have competition, anyone else doing this?’ Dixon felt himself slipping into investor mode, *work mode*. Hell, maybe this crazy company was an investment opportunity.

‘Well, not really. Not yet,’ Clayton said. ‘Actually, we see divorce lawyers as our natural competition at the moment! Anyway. Mr. Dixon. We’re here to talk about you. Or, actually, if you know anything about our process, not so much *talk* about you...’

‘I’m not quite sure how this process goes,’ Dixon said. He wasn’t used to being this earnest, but somehow this whole weird place encouraged him to get his feelings out there in front.

‘No, okay. We’ll be doing a series of tests on you this afternoon. Nothing too strenuous, I can assure you. And the tests will culminate in a mental examination using our proprietary technology.’

‘What are we talking about here? You’re not going to drill into my skull...’

‘No,’ the white-haired man grinned. ‘It’s non-invasive. We simply measure your brain’s electrical responses to certain stimuli.’

‘Oh, okay.’

‘And because we know *exactly* what to look for, we can tell all kinds of things about your personal preferences, feelings, tastes, and attitudes — even those you didn’t know you had yourself.’

‘You can tell what my secret fantasies are, that it?’ Dixon raised an eyebrow.

‘Uh-huh. Basically. But what I’m saying is, they might be so secret that even *you* don’t know about them. Yet.’

Dixon scratched his head. Did he *have* any secret fantasies? Nothing much sprang to mind. His wife's lack of interest in sex after the twins came along had somewhat dulled his libido. When he looked at pornography occasionally, what did he go for? On the whole, he would have to say high production values. He liked looking at beautiful women, filmed beautifully. Films from Erika Lust, Marc Dorcel, Lucie Blush, Anna Richards.

'Okay. So, are you ready to begin the testing?'

Dixon took a deep breath. 'Sure,' he said.

By the time the testing was over, Dixon was exhausted. He stumbled through the front doors of the Marriage 2.0 store onto Lexington Avenue, and it was starting to get dark outside. It must have taken a few hours. He could hardly believe it — he'd thought it might take an hour, max.

He was going to be home late — too late for bedtime.

Villiers was outside, without Dixon having to even call him, standing at attention in front of the limo.

'You haven't been waiting long?' he asked the chauffeur as he approached the car, and Villiers opened the door for him.

'No, sir. The company called me thirty minutes ago to let me know when you would be ready to go home.'

'The company?' Dixon's head was spinning a little. Who at the firm knew where he was, let alone when his appointment would be done?

'A Mr. Clayton, sir.'

'Oh, right.' Dixon nodded. Villiers hadn't meant his company; he'd meant Marriage 2.0. The chauffeur was being his usual unobtrusive self by not even uttering the company's name.

He almost fell asleep in the back of the car on the way home, he was so tired. The testing process had seemed so rigorous that Dixon felt as though every cell of his body had been individually torn from his body, inspected, and then returned to the whole before it was all done. He'd gone through written tests, screen-based tests, fitness tests, and medical assessments, and that was before the evaluation of his actual brainwaves had taken place.

That final stage, though, had been the most exhausting of the lot. On the surface, he had only needed to sit there, wearing a special cap that

measured his brainwaves and wirelessly connected to the Marriage 2.0 supercomputer system. It had measured his response to various stimuli, and the stimuli had gradually gotten more and more intense — and more and more sexual.

By the end of it, he was a sweaty mess, and he felt as though every muscle in his body was on fire.

Five floors down from his appointment room, Dixon was able to take a shower and change into some fresh clothes. Strangely, his rock-hard erection hadn't faded until he'd stepped out of that changing room in a brand new suit and tie, ready to be escorted downstairs again and out onto the street where his driver was waiting.

What a bizarre day.

When he arrived home, he had, indeed, missed the kids' bedtime. He apologized to Jenni, who didn't seem the least bit put out, nodding with understanding as he made up some white lies about a late-running meeting.

'You're feeling okay?' Jenni asked him, wiping a hint of perspiration from his brow with a handkerchief.

'Uh... yeah. Why?'

'Marty called this afternoon and left a message. Said something about you feeling under the weather, overdoing it at work?'

'Oh,' Dixon smiled, thankful that Gaines hadn't elaborated too much in what he'd said on his voicemail to Jenni. 'No... I'm okay. I think I have a cold coming on. I had to duck out of a meeting early at one point today...'

Jenni nodded.

'Well, I think I'm going to go up to bed,' she said. 'I'm pretty tired myself.'

'Okay.'

'Don't stay up too late, sweetie,' she said as she took the first step up the staircase.

'No, I won't.'

'You know Gaines is right — you do overdo it at work. You don't need to work that hard. Not now. You've earned more rest.'

'I know,' he nodded and smiled, then quietly watched her walking up the stairs, having made the assumption that he would go straight into the

kitchen to track down something to eat before swinging by his little first-floor office to get into some more work. In fact, he didn't do that. He stayed and watched her climb to the first-floor landing. She was effortlessly graceful. She was very easy on the eye, even wearing her usual sweatpants and baggy t-shirt combo, which was hardly flattering.

Was Marriage 2.0 going to work for them? He wondered. Was it going to help them reconnect? To restart their fire?

But for a long time, life just seemed to get back to normal. Dixon almost forgot he'd even been to Marriage 2.0. Almost forgot the \$100,000 payment he'd made to them.

For a while, nothing happened.

Dixon had expected it to take a while for the agency to digest the results of his assessment before designing an ‘Experience’ for him and Jenni. But really, nothing much happened for a *long* while.

One thing that did happen after going to Marriage 2.0 was that Dixon found himself noticing his wife more than he had for some years.

Had he been taking her for granted before signing up for the program? Possibly. But now, each evening he came home from work, he made more effort to pay her more attention. He greeted her properly and spent time with her instead of slinking away to his office.

And he slept in the same bed as her — trying various methods to reduce his snoring rather than simply abandoning their bedroom.

He even attempted little steps toward restarting some kind of physical connection — a kiss on the cheek here, a touch on the shoulder there, a stroke of her thigh while they watched TV together.

Jenni gave him little affectionate smiles, but it didn’t lead to a sudden desire, on either of their parts, to strip off and start banging like porn stars.

What was Marriage 2.0 going to do for them?

At home, he made more effort to think about Jenni in a sexual way, too. He stole glances at her when she was dressed for the gym — trim in leggings and a crop top, or even occasionally in a sports bra.

At the weekends, he’d gaze out of the window, and she’d be playing in the pool with the kids, and he’d catch a few glimpses of her in her swimsuit.

On rare occasions, he’d be lying in bed when she needed to get dressed to take the kids to their soccer practice, and he might catch sight of her in her panties and a t-shirt as she decided what to wear.

She did inspire some arousal in him, though familiarity had taken the edge off things and had left them in the Friend Zone. When he masturbated — needs must when there was no sex in his marriage — he did everything he could to think of Jenni, rather than resorting to the easy route via pornography.

At the same time, during those early days and weeks, he consciously avoided their nanny, Ophelia. He avoided Gaines as well — at least socially.

Gaines could inspire bad thoughts in him.

Gaines had some strange agenda to actively spike his marriage.

While he waited for his adventure, he couldn't stop thinking about Marriage 2.0. Even for a few days.

He checked the company's website and the mobile app every day. He religiously watched his text messages, social media accounts, and email — including his spam folder — in case there was something from the agency.

In the middle of meetings, he found his attention drifting back to what he'd signed up for, pondering what would happen.

He just about managed to get his work done.

As with any project he was involved in, Dixon did research. He researched the hell out of it, in fact.

There certainly seemed to be plenty of information about it. Articles in newspapers, online magazines.

People weren't supposed to talk about their own personal adventures — Dixon remembered signing a Non-Disclosure Agreement in the early stages of his assessment. He'd joked with Clayton about why anyone would want to publicize their own personal marital adventures.

But here online, there were plenty of people apparently breaking their NDAs, albeit anonymously or through fake names.

He read about other people's experiences, and he found YouTube videos about what happened to some people. However, it was rare to find direct testimony from those who had used the service.

There was some negative coverage — people saying that Marriage 2.0 made couples do unnatural or immoral acts. Religious people say the service went against God's teachings, or whatever. But none of the

negative coverage seemed to come from couples that had used the program.

As for the Experiences: well, the ones he read about seemed very varied, helping couples in various different ways to rekindle their passion.

One couple was signed up to an amateur dramatic group and ended up having to seduce each other as part of a production — to the point where they had to strip off on stage and have simulated sex. This drove them wild for each other when they got home after each performance.

Another couple revealed that the husband was instructed to dress up and behave as a woman for a whole week, while his wife was supposed to pose as a man. Treating each other as different genders, the couple apparently learned about how they'd treated each other in everyday life. It made them realize how they needed to treat each other with more respect. They also had fun in the bedroom trying opposite roles to their usual ones.

Sex seemed to be a central part of the Marriage 2.0 experience, which was partly why religious groups seemed so offended by the whole thing. However, it seemed confusing to Dixon, since weren't religious types supposed to support the concept of marital sex?

Every minute he spent researching Marriage 2.0 seemed to ramp up Dixon's own curiosity about what would happen for him.

It also made him worry that his own Experience might not turn out as favorable as the ones he'd read about.

The main thing, though, was wondering when his adventure would begin.

I paid a six-figure sum, for heaven's sake!

Then it was their anniversary coming up. His personal calendar system had shot him a little warning message to say that he would have to get something for Jenni.

Their official tenth wedding anniversary — what was he supposed to get her?

The tenth anniversary was traditionally marked with tin or with aluminum. Well, that was hardly very romantic.

Apparently, the 'modern alternative' was to buy diamond jewelry. But these days, Jenni had a ton of jewelry. She had everything money

could buy, as far as Dixon knew.

What could he get her that would be truly special?

He'd book them a nice table somewhere, of course, some kind of 'romantic' dinner, even though there wasn't an awful lot of romance going on between them these days. A table at the Club, perhaps? But that might not seem particularly special by now.

Somewhere special in the city, perhaps with an overnight stay at the Peninsula. Would a night in the city force some kind of sexual reawakening? He couldn't see it.

While Dixon contemplated what to do about his anniversary, Gaines suddenly stormed into his office. He informed Dixon that Gilderoy Suffolk, a prominent property developer based in Seattle, Washington, was about to go belly-up.

Gilderoy Suffolk was a client that Dixon had brought in.

'Marty, Marty, keep your hair on,' Dixon said. 'There's nothing wrong with Gilderoy.'

'The Days Creek project — heard of it?'

'Of course.'

'If that thing loses its permit because of some lone weirdo digging through the dirt...'

'It's just a contaminated soil issue,' Dixon said. 'We're getting it sorted out.'

But Gaines wasn't persuaded. 'We're exposed on this one, Frank. *Badly* exposed. I have a new fund I'm desperately trying to bed in...'

'We're getting it sorted.'

'That's not what I'm hearing on the ground.'

'Will it make you feel better if I go down there?' Dixon said.

The last thing Dixon wanted was to have to go to Seattle — particularly with his damn anniversary approaching. But it was the only thing that would calm Gaines down.

Once his business partner was out the door, Dixon asked Mrs. Hawkes to set up a visit to Gilderoy Suffolk and a few nights' stay in a Seattle hotel.

His secretary said, 'Of course, sir.' And then she added, 'Oh, Mr. Dixon?'

'Yes?'

'This envelope came for you while you were in with Mr. Gaines.'

She handed him a fancy-looking, plum-colored envelope.

'A motorcycle courier brought it,' she said before handing it to him and scurrying back out of his office.

The envelope was made of a velvety kind of paper, sealed with an old-fashioned gold-colored wax seal, while its plum color and the black lacy decor framing it gave it the look of a boudoir.

Was it some kind of marketing from a luxury lingerie firm or something? Perhaps designed to catch his attention close to his anniversary — marketing people were clever these days.

Dixon wondered why someone would courier over a piece of junk mail — and why Mrs. Hawkes would bother to give it to him.

But then, when he turned it over, he saw that it was addressed to Ms. Jennifer Dixon, not to himself.

His cell phone buzzed and bleated shrilly — louder than he ever had the ringer set, forcing him to pull it out of his pocket to tend to it.

The alarm came from the Marriage 2.0 app.

There was a notification message:

Marriage 2.0: *Please be careful with the envelope. This is your adventure starting.*

Dixon felt his heart start beating twice as fast — and so hard that it was almost painful.

Jesus. So it was actually starting, at last.

When he opened the Marriage 2.0 app, it presented Dixon with a series of instructions:

- 1. This envelope is your wedding anniversary gift to your wife. Do not open it yourself. Give it to her when you next see her but tell her not to open it until the day of your anniversary.*

- 2. When you give her the envelope, warn her that she might be surprised by the nature of your gift. But ask her to give it a chance, and say you've thought long and hard about giving her this gift.*

- 3. You can tell her just to have some fun with it, and you'll enjoy hearing all about it when you see her next.*

It was a little frustrating not knowing exactly what he was giving to Jenni as his gift. But he had to have faith that Marriage 2.0 knew what it was doing. It had told him explicitly not to open the envelope and for her to open it on their anniversary.

What kind of a gift could you put inside an envelope?

Vouchers for some kind of store? Or for one of those experience days — flying lessons, race-car driving, sky-diving, wine tasting, cookery

courses with celebrity chefs, spa days?

Perhaps he was giving her some kind of pampering thing; he'd done that for her before.

But how could that kind of solitary experience help with their marriage?

Perhaps Marriage 2.0 had given Jenni something for couples to enjoy. And yet, the message clearly told him to tell her to have fun with whatever was in the envelope, and *he would enjoy hearing all about it when he saw her next*.

That part of the message seemed to infer that he wouldn't be with her when she opened the envelope on their anniversary.

How could Marriage 2.0 know that he would be away from home on their anniversary?

Dixon pulled his phone out of his pocket. He *had* consented to them having access to his personal communications devices. Were they really monitoring his life that closely?

Clayton had said anything like that was done by the company's artificial intelligence systems. Could they really have followed his conversation with Gaines and then written these instructions to him?

Dixon figured the envelope would have been already on its way to the office by the time Gaines stormed into his office and totally changed his plans for his anniversary week. But perhaps it had been a gift he would have otherwise given to Jenni in person?

Well, it was clever. Slightly creepy, he might have said — if he hadn't given Marriage 2.0 permission to hack his life as much as it needed to set up his Experience — but there you go.

On the way home that evening, he found himself trying to figure out what he would most want to be in that envelope he was giving to Jenni.

Tickets for some kind of travel adventure they would do as a couple?

How would sex fit in if that was central to the usual Marriage 2.0 adventure?

As the limo crossed the New York/Connecticut boundary, he had half a thought that the envelope might simply contain vouchers for an expensive lingerie store. He might return home from his Seattle trip to

find her in the bedroom, dressed in the sexiest outfit imaginable — stockings, a thong, maybe?

Well, if it got Jenni in the mood... but why would an experience like that set him back \$100,000?

And would some fancy lingerie be enough to overcome the familiarity between them?

As they reached Old Greenwich, he was getting nervous. Despite the gift he held in his hands, he still had to face telling Jenni that he wouldn't even be there for their anniversary. Ten years, and he couldn't make the day.

What if she got all upset?

He glanced at his Rolex as Villiers drew the limo up in front of the house, and Dixon realized he'd also missed the kids' bedtime again.

Groan.

Jenni must secretly hate me, he thought. No wonder she's given up on our sex life.

'Good night, sir,' the chauffeur said, holding the door open for him to exit the vehicle.

'Night, Villiers,' he smiled and felt a pang of guilt that the chauffeur had to do late nights almost all the time. That couldn't have been great for his social life.

Stepping inside the front hall, Dixon looked up to see his wife descending the main staircase. She looked mighty fine in her skin-tight workout clothes, her long, sandy hair tied up in a ponytail.

'Hey,' she said with an easy smile as she came down from putting the kids to bed, apparently on her way to the gym.

'Hey,' he said. 'I'm *so* sorry for missing bedtime again.'

'Oh, it's okay. They weren't any trouble.'

He ogled her as she came down — he was allowed to, wasn't he? He was her husband. He tried not to make it obvious, though. If they weren't married and trapped in the Friend Zone, if she was just a random blonde he'd only just met — he'd want to sleep with her, wouldn't he?

God, he was terrible.

'I have bad news,' he said as she reached the last few steps before joining him.

'Oh, no, really?'

'I'm going to have to miss our anniversary this year,' he said.

'Oh,' Jenni said, surprised by what he said, but only a little.

Actually, she seemed somewhat relieved — and he realized she'd probably been bracing herself for worse news than that. *Oh, honey, I'm*

so sorry; we have to file for bankruptcy, we'll be losing the house.

Yeah, there were worse things to worry about than missing an anniversary. But with Jenni, he wasn't sure if she'd be offended.

She said, 'It's our anniversary again? Oh, it *is*, isn't it? Doesn't the time fly. What's this one — the ninth?'

'Tenth. Gaines needs me to fly to Seattle to sort out this company we've invested in — '

'Okay.' She kissed him — on the lips for once, though it was only a brief peck. It nevertheless caught him by surprise, and made him imagine that perhaps his efforts to slowly increase the number of affectionate touches he gave her were beginning to work.

'It's okay,' she said calmly. 'I know there's nothing you can do if it's work.'

He sighed. 'I had a nice table booked for us at Fabric, as well. And a room at the Peninsula.'

'Ah well, perhaps we could take a rain check,' she said, 'we could do it another time.'

'Sure,' he nodded, feeling a trifle relieved.

She stepped away from him — facing him, but stepping back toward the gym. She was assuming he would go find something to eat and then dive inside his office for most of the evening. However, lately, he'd been trying to make sure he joined her when she watched TV before bed.

He remembered the envelope — well, how could he forget that? He was holding it behind his back.

'Oh — I have this for you.'

It caught her by surprise. 'What is it?'

He smiled, remembering the odd instructions he'd been given by Marriage 2.0. 'You'll find out on our anniversary,' he said, since he didn't want to tell her he had no idea what was in the envelope. 'Don't open it until then, okay? Then perhaps the day won't feel like a washout.'

'Oh, okay,' she said, bemused, turning it over and over in her hands, admiring how elaborate it was.

'I have to tell you...' he said, trying to remember the wording of his instructions from Marriage 2.0, 'You might be... *surprised*... when you open it.'

'Okay...'

'Yeah. But... you know... give it a chance. I've thought long and hard about giving you this...' he said.

In attempting to remember his 'lines' from the Marriage 2.0 instructions, he actually came across as rather earnest, even rather

humble. As though he'd searched the world for some worthy gift, and this was honestly the best he could do.

She smiled appreciatively, tilting her head to give him the expression that said, *aww, you're so sweet*.

Then she walked up to him to plant a kiss on his lips again — and this was a little more lingering than the last kiss. He was able to appreciate the softness of her lips, even taste the sweetness of her mouth, breathe in the clean, delicate scent of her perfume-free body.

'I'm sure I will love it,' she grinned, stepping back from him again, waving the envelope as though to fan her face.

'Well... you just have some fun with it,' he said, hoping she wasn't going to ask him anything else about it, since he had no clue what was now in her hand. 'I'll... you know... look forward to finding out all about it when I get back from my travels.'

'Okay, sweetie,' she smiled sweetly, then turned to walk cheerfully away to the gym, leaving him gazing at her ass in those tight leggings as she went.

While Jenni was in the gym, he ate chicken and potatoes given to him by Mrs. Habscomb and then went upstairs to his office to prepare for the Gilderoy-Suffolk trip.

Later, when he spotted Jenni wandering past the open door of his little office after her workout, it reminded him of the envelope.

This is your adventure starting.

His heart was pounding again. He felt perspiration on his brow. It was undeniably exciting that this was happening. He had no idea where it was going to go, what was going to happen, but for now, the anticipation was quite something.

Was he really going to end up rekindling his passion with Jenni?

He rose from his chair and drifted to the doorway of his office to watch Jenni heading up the stairs to shower and change. She was holding the envelope, carrying it upstairs.

It was a little exciting just to watch her, and think that something would happen between them, something to stir up the libido again.

It was a shame he couldn't tell her all about Marriage 2.0 — but then again, how would he even bring it up? He knew it would probably get all awkward. He'd put his foot in it, or something. She'd be upset with him.

Clayton had assured him that Jenni would not find out that he was using the Marriage 2.0 service. That the service was 100% confidential.

Would Jenni really wait until their anniversary to open the envelope?

Dixon waited until she disappeared from view and followed her up the stairs. He was itching to take a look at the contents of that envelope before her. Could there be any way to get into that envelope without disrupting the wax seal? Or break the seal and somehow... glue it back together?

Upstairs, he ducked his head in the kids' room to check on them and then walked cautiously toward the main bedroom.

He was still thinking of ways to open that envelope when he came to the doorway to their bedroom.

He stopped in his tracks when he realized Jenni was in there, undressing.

His usual response, drawn from years of marriage, would have been to turn on his heels and tiptoe out of there to give her some privacy. But tonight, he felt his blood stirred by the whole Marriage 2.0 thing. He froze in the darkness of the hallway and watched Jenni peeling off her gym clothes.

She pulled off her top and then her sports bra.

With her pale complexion, her chest was still flushed a faint pink from her exercise, but her breasts were perky, her nipples stiff in the cool, air-conditioned air. He watched her tuck her fingers into the waistband of her leggings and peel them down over her behind, revealing little white panties beneath.

She was stunning to look at. He felt his manhood thickening at the sight of her removing her panties. How long had it been since he'd seen her *completely* naked?

And yet, he wasn't going to race in there and jump her. It didn't feel right. She'd be shocked at his sudden entrance; she'd feel embarrassed at being naked in front of him. It would feel weird, trying to get something physical going with her after so many years.

She would think him strange. She would think something odd was going on.

Maybe she'd even be suspicious that he might be having an affair.

'Everything okay, Mr. Dixon?'

He nearly jumped out of his skin at the sound of Ophelia's voice behind him.

He turned to find the young nanny standing in her bedroom doorway, dressed in a black leather skirt and a silky purple top with a very low

neckline. Her top looked almost as though it was originally designed to be lingerie.

She also had plenty of makeup on, which made her look different than she did during her work hours — more glamorous, more seductive.

‘Uh... fine, yes,’ he said, smiling. Trying to act casual as he wandered toward her, away from the main bedroom, but flushing at being caught effectively spying on his wife.

‘On your way out, are you?’

She nodded. ‘Day off tomorrow,’ she said, giving him a slightly funny look that he couldn’t quite interpret.

It was almost as though Ophelia thought it sweet that he would want to hide out in the shadows to watch his wife undress. But at the same time, that made the nanny more interested in him herself.

‘Well, have a good night,’ he said with a grin and headed into the bedroom as though he’d been on his way there anyway. He figured the sound of his conversation with Ophelia would let Jenni know he was approaching.

‘You too, Mr. Dixon.’

In the bedroom, Jenni had disappeared, and he heard the sound of the shower starting up in their en suite.

He noticed the envelope lying there on Jenni’s bedside table.

Hearing his wife stepping under the water flow, Dixon found some casual clothes in their walk-in closet and changed out of his suit. It would give him an excuse for being there in the bedroom right now, in case Jenni wondered why he was there.

Then he moved to her side of the bed to quietly examine the envelope.

The gold wax seal was really bonded onto the envelope. It was so elegantly done, so thinly applied, that any effort to open the envelope would damage the seal.

Dixon sighed with frustration as he touched a fingernail to the edge — even if he had a sharp knife, he wouldn’t be able to slip off the wax seal without ruining it.

He put the envelope back on Jenni’s bedside table in precisely the position he had found it, and then he quietly left the bedroom, somewhat frustrated.

It felt uncomfortable not having control over what was going on in his life. Also, he didn’t like the feeling that he had no idea what Jenni’s present was when he had supposedly bought it for her. It meant he could

be tripped up at some point — she might get the impression he'd simply asked Mrs. Hawkes to go buy his wife an anniversary present.

He was already watching TV in the family room when she came downstairs again. But while they were watching Game of Thrones together and then in bed later, Jenni didn't mention the envelope once.

She didn't get its significance — but how could she?

On the day of their wedding anniversary, Dixon woke early in a huge hotel bed after a long day traveling cross-country to Seattle, Washington.

He'd never been entirely comfortable flying, and on this trip, the company jet had been taken out of service by some kind of plumbing issue, leaving him to grab a commercial flight last-minute.

The hotel was comfortable enough, however. He called out '*curtains!*' and as he sat up in bed, the curtains drew back automagically to offer a superlative view across the bay.

It wasn't long before the peace and tranquility was pierced by the sound of the FaceTime ringtone, however.

Dixon groaned and reached across the mattress to pluck his iPad from the bedside table, assuming it was Gaines failing to appreciate the time difference. But it was Jenni calling.

He tapped the accept button, his heart rate already picking up.

There she was, wearing a dark blue, short-sleeved dress, her golden hair flowing down over her shoulders — and for once, she had makeup on. She looked pretty stunning, and it wasn't even breakfast time.

'Hey, sleepyhead!' she said with a beaming smile.

'Hey...' he said, glancing at the clock on the bedside table. 'You know I'm three hours behind you, right?'

'Right, I forgot that,' she giggled, making Dixon smile. He hadn't known Jenni to really *giggle* for... ages. Then she said, 'Happy Anniversary!'

He nodded and replied, 'Happy Anniversary yourself. You're looking very... *nice* today. Going somewhere this morning?'

'Oh no,' she grinned broadly at his compliment. 'Not really. Thank you for my present.'

Here was the awkwardness. He had to hide his shame at not knowing what her present was, even though he had given it to her.

He leaned back from the camera and said calmly, ‘Oh, that’s okay...’

Jenni said, ‘You were right — it *was* a little... *surprising*.’

She held up that strange, plum-colored envelope to obscure the lower part of her face as though to hide her blush from him.

Dixon felt his nerves tingling — *what was in that envelope?*

He couldn’t *ask* her what her present was. All he could do was say vague things, play it safe, and hope she dropped enough hints about it.

‘Well, I just thought... you’d like it, you know?’ he said after a pause, trying not to sound too ill at ease.

Jenni lowered the envelope again, revealing a big smile she could not quite control.

‘You’re *sure* about this?’ she said, making his nerves jangle even worse, and frustrating him with her lack of clues.

‘Of *course*.’

He concealed a sigh. Whatever it was, he had to have faith in Marriage 2.0, that the agency had chosen something for Jenni that would launch their adventure together. He’d paid for it well enough. He’d given them as many details as he could about himself and his wife.

‘I thought about it a lot,’ he said, ‘and... you know... I thought you’d really like it.’

‘Well, it’s just... it’s just... so completely *out there*,’ she said, still beaming, ear-to-ear, but apparently quite taken aback by what he had given her.

What was it — something kinky?

Some kind of sex dungeon thing? She had read those 50 Shades of Grey books, now that he recalled...

Now he could feel himself blushing. What must she think of him if he would just come out and give her something like *that*?

‘I think you’ll enjoy it,’ he said, still scratching for vague things to say, slightly embarrassed that he couldn’t be more specific. ‘You deserve it. It’ll be fun.’

He tried to reduce his awkwardness by believing that the gift was probably just something like a sky-diving experience. She’d always wanted to do that, right? And he had never let her do it — he’d always been too afraid of heights.

‘And you’re *really*... okay with me doing this?’ she said, one of her eyebrows rising up to denote that not only was she somewhat perplexed by all this, but that she really thought it was a little crazy of him to get it for her.

‘Of course,’ he smiled, relaxing a little, thinking that it *had* to be a sky-diving thing.

That was totally unlike him.

Maybe the extreme nature of the experience would get her juices flowing and lead her to jump him the next time they were in bed together.

Now that he thought about it, he had even mentioned the sky-diving thing to Clayton when he told the guy all about his fear of heights and fear of flying.

Jenni was still puzzled by her gift, however. ‘But *why*...?’

‘I think you just need to do it, honey,’ he said, relaxing as he felt confident the gift had to be sky-diving.

‘Okay...’

‘Try it. I mean, I never thought I’d *want* you to... you know... but I’ve done a lot of thinking. I think it’ll be good for you. You need to enjoy life more, take more of a break from the kids every now and then — we’ve got Ophelia there to take care of them.’

‘Sure...’ the doubt imprinted on her face softened a little.

Dixon tried to think of the instructions he’d received from Marriage 2.0 and remembered something he’d not said to her yet.

‘You just have some fun with it,’ he said, ‘And I’ll enjoy hearing all about it when I’m back with you.’

‘Oh, you would, would you?’ she said and then raised her eyebrow again — though this time, making it seem as though he’d just asked her for a blowjob in the middle of a crowded subway train.

But then she was smiling and laughing, her face so pretty when it was filled with unbridled joy.

‘You know, I didn’t get *you* anything for our anniversary,’ she giggled. ‘I’m so embarrassed — I completely forgot about it this year. And it’s our tenth.’

‘It’s okay, honey, I really don’t need anything,’ he said and meant it.

All he wanted right now was some way to rekindle their passion — and he was beginning to think that changing his attitude on things sky-diving really *could* change their attitude toward sex.

What if Jenni had such a rush from her sky-diving experience that she came home feeling horny as a teenager again?

His first full day of business in Seattle was just exhausting — an intensive series of meetings and site inspections to make sure he knew exactly what was going on at the Days Creek construction project.

And it was all made more difficult because he couldn't stop thinking about the anniversary present he'd just given to his wife.

What the hell was it?

Jenni had been quite surprised by it, he could tell. Very surprised. But she had been pleased, right? Or at least intrigued.

She hadn't been angry, had she?

What the hell had been in that envelope that Marriage 2.0 had had him give her?

He dined with senior partners at Gilderoy-Suffolk that evening, discussing the firm and its development projects while feasting on nouveau cuisine and fine wines.

It wasn't the best way to troubleshoot in Dixon's book, but these West Coast guys seemed to like to keep things informal.

Then he was finally back at the hotel, feeling like he was running on empty despite the heavy meal. Part of him wanted to just curl up and sleep as soon as he got up to his suite.

Part of him was desperate to call Jenni and try to glean clues as to what he had got her for their anniversary.

'Hey, honey. How's it going?'

'*Good*. The kids have been missing you.'

‘Well, tell them I’m missing them, too,’ he said and peered a little closer at his phone screen. Was Jenni wearing lipstick again? What was that about? In fact, she had some eyeliner on, too.

It made her look *great*.

But why was she wearing makeup to call him coast-to-coast?

She asked him, ‘You had a good day today?’

He shrugged. ‘Yeah... I think we’re making progress. I’m finding out what’s really going on here. I think there’s a way through.’

‘Wonderful.’

She was wearing a gray tank top that wasn’t too different from what she might sometimes wear to use the gym — but it was a touch surprising to see her wearing it to call him on FaceTime.

The straps on her top were thin, and it showed a lot of skin — a fair amount of cleavage, and a lovely display of the shape of her breasts, even if they were covered. Maybe he was just noticing it more this time.

‘You had a good day, honey?’ he asked her.

Jenni grinned broadly. ‘You know... same as usual. But you know, after the kids were asleep, I’ve started... Well... *finding out what my present’s all about*.’

Dixon felt a jolt of surprise and fear that his wife had suddenly brought up the subject. He tried to hide his anxiety by casually chuckling, saying, ‘That’s wonderful, honey.’

Was she blushing again? Her tone of voice, the way her eyes darted off to the side when she said it... now he was thinking the gift wasn’t sky-diving. Maybe it really was some kind of sex dungeon thing.

Fearful of an awkward silence, he found himself repeating one of the lines he’d been instructed to say to her about the gift: ‘You know, I really do want to hear all about it...after it happens...’

She said, ‘*Okay...*’ She glanced coyly off-screen again, and now she was blushing furiously. It was a strangely attractive look for her. All bashful and mildly embarrassed, as though he’d asked her out on a first date to some kind of erotic movie at the theater.

God. His heart was hammering in his chest now.

Maybe the gift really was something... *sexual*. Like all those other Marriage 2.0 couples he’d read about online.

Dixon felt a slight stirring within his pants. He was getting a little excited, even if he had no idea what he was getting excited about.

What if they’d been given tickets to one of those hedonistic resorts they had in the Caribbean? Where people stripped off and had sex in public.

Jesus. That would be pretty shocking for someone like Jenni.

For someone like him, for that matter.

‘You know...’ he said, trying to be reassuring despite being clueless. ‘...You don’t *have* to do it if you really don’t want to. I just think it would be *good* for you. And maybe... you know... good for *us*.’

She nodded and took a deep breath.

He could tell she was trying to be calm. She said, ‘You know I have a couple of friends who... well... do it already?’

‘Oh, yeah?’ he smiled, trying to conceal his emotions and not seem overly curious, since he was supposed to know what her gift was.

Then she said, ‘Of course, *they* don’t tell their husbands about it...’

And that completely threw him.

What on Earth did she mean, her friends didn’t tell their husbands about it?

The idea that immediately sprang to mind was that it must have been some kind of spa day or pampering experience. Jenni’s friend’s probably did it all the time, and didn’t tell their husbands about it because they might think it a frivolous expense.

He felt suddenly let down, thinking that he’d merely given Jenni a day at the spa.

He said flatly, ‘Oh, okay.’ Then, trying to hide his disappointment, ‘So you’ll be able to discuss it all with them, huh?’

She shrugged. ‘Maybe. I mean, I *suppose* so.’

What was Marriage 2.0 thinking — that manicures and pedicures would help improve their marriage? Surely it couldn’t be just that. Why had his instructions been so cryptic then, so *weird*?

Why had he been told to tell her he wanted to hear all about it when she was done with whatever-it-was?

There was something odd going on.

He said, trying one more time to get the nature of her gift out of her, ‘So you think you’ll want to give it a try?’

She laughed. ‘You really *do* want me to do this, don’t you?’

‘I’m just... trying to be encouraging, honey. *Supportive*.’

A moment of doubt seemed to take hold of her. ‘Is it because you secretly want to... *you* want to do it as well? I mean, so *both* of us are...?’

Well, now he was totally confused.

Was she talking about a spa day?

Perhaps she was talking about a cookery course, or an art class, or something like that, something couples did together. That kind of thing

really didn't appeal. Not at all. He was good at his job, but Dixon didn't have an artistic bone in his body. He could barely paint a wall.

If it was something like learning to sail at the Yacht Club — they'd talked about that before — well, Dixon didn't need to learn. And he would probably find it frustrating being with Jenni as she learned the basics.

Hedging his bets, he said, 'Oh no... it's not for me, honey. I don't need to do that kind of thing...'

He was still digging for clues.

'...But you know, I'm out all the time, meeting clients, talking business, traveling to sort out companies that go kaput. I'd never have time for any of that, even if I *wanted* to.'

'Oh, okay,' she nodded, a slightly uncertain smile returning to her pretty face. 'Because I don't think I'd like it *at all* if — '

He smiled. It sounded as though she was giving him a Get Out Of Jail Free Card, knowing that he would hate whatever it was.

She did that sometimes. Saving his blushes.

Now he was thinking it was some kind of art class. But how on Earth would *that* help their marriage? Perhaps it would make Jenni feel relaxed, good about herself. It would bring her distraction from the usual day-to-day. Could it be enough to get her interested in rekindling the heat in their relationship? Who could say?

Trying to be encouraging while also counting himself out of whatever activity Jenni's present happened to be, he said, 'It's okay, honey, this is just for you. You know, I heard it can be empowering, it can do the world of good for your self-confidence...'

He was *still* digging for clues. So frustrating.

Jenni's smile returned to full, dazzling brightness. 'Well, I know what my friends say about it, but their husbands aren't... you know... I mean, *they* probably wouldn't...'

God, she looked good when she was happy. When she was genuinely excited about something.

Perhaps Marriage 2.0 had some insight into what Jenni lacked in her life. Even if she had a nice house, wonderful kids, and theoretically anything money could buy, they had figured out *something* she still wanted.

Maybe fulfillment, however it came, would lead her back toward a renewed desire for sex.

Her creativity might fire up her passion.

'And your friends enjoy it?' he asked her, unable to stop his curiosity.

‘Uh... *sure*,’ she nodded awkwardly. Swallowed. Her smile leveled out — she was showing some nerves.

Well, when you took up some new kind of activity, it *could* be a little nerve-wracking.

Dixon managed to conceal a sigh of frustration. He’d had enough of digging for clues. He was going to call up Marriage 2.0 and demand to know what gift they had given to his wife.

He had to know.

But right now, he was so drained.

‘Look, honey, I’m really sorry,’ he said. ‘I’ve got to get out of here at 8am sharp tomorrow, and I am so *unbelievably* tired after today...’

Jenni looked concerned but understanding. ‘Oh, of course, sweetie. It’s so late already. Even later, here. I should go to bed, too.’

‘Okay, look, I love you, okay? I’ll try to call tomorrow night.’

He always said he’d *try* to call her when he went on these trips, because it felt more honest. She knew if he was kept late on a site visit, if something unexpected came up and he had to work through the night, he didn’t like to break promises to her.

‘Okay, sweetie. I love you too. With all my heart.’

‘And if all goes well, I can fly back the day after tomorrow,’ he said, prompting another of her world-class smiles.

‘I hope so,’ she said.

‘Well, good night, honey.’

‘Good night, sweetie.’

Of course, as soon as he ended the call with his wife, he suddenly felt any form of sleepiness disappear from his body. That was the way with insomnia, wasn’t it?

Of course, he was still tired — every muscle in his body seemed to be aching — but when he lay his head down on his pillow, sleep was not forthcoming.

He had too many questions whirling around his head to sleep.

He sighed and rolled over onto his back, grabbing the remote control from the bedside table, to switch on the TV.

The first thing he saw was a reality TV show — Big Brother, or something like that. He switched to CNN. There wasn’t much on the

news, but occasionally, he could watch CNN and relax and then drift off to sleep.

Then, five minutes into an update on what the candidates for the upcoming Presidential election were saying, the television seemed to flip back to the reality TV show all by itself.

Annoyed, Dixon reached for the remote again and switched it back to CNN.

When it switched back to the reality TV show yet again, Dixon groaned and was about to call room service to come to give him a working TV.

But then he looked at the screen and recognized the empty room that was being shown.

This was no reality TV show at all.

Dixon was looking at a view of his own darkened living room. He took a close look — he recognized it as their house in Connecticut.

What was this doing on TV?

His heart skipped a beat, his head spun. He quickly reached for the remote and turned up the volume in case it was some awful news update about some kind of home intrusion at a Greenwich mansion.

But how could something terrible have happened at home if Jenni hadn't said a thing about it? He'd only just been talking to her, not so long ago.

Even with the volume turned up, there was no sound to go with the picture of their living room. Nothing was happening on screen at all. Was it merely a still picture?

Was this some kind of weird joke?

Dixon sighed and switched to another TV channel. To his astonishment, the picture now changed to a view of their kitchen and breakfast area. Again, it was unmistakably *their house* in Greenwich.

The room was completely empty, there was nobody there. All the lights were off.

Why was he looking at this?

Dixon switched the channel again. Here was a view of their dining room. Another change of channel, and here was the library. Again, all the lights were off, and nobody was to be seen. Another channel, the family room. Another channel, the sunroom. Another channel, the downstairs office. Another channel, the swimming pool and surrounding terrace.

What was going on? Was this some kind of crazy prank?

Dixon was tempted to call room service to complain — or at least to ask what the hell was happening. Had somebody signed him up for some

kind of new home security system? Like Amazon's Ring service, where you could put little cameras up everywhere and access video of your home from your mobile phone.

But right now, he was watching it *on the hotel television screen*, not on his mobile phone.

He changed the channels again and was surprised once more as it switched back to CNN. It made him laugh out loud — maybe he was going a little crazy and imagining things.

The CNN anchor, Christiane Amanpour, came to the end of a segment on Joe Biden's position on trade with China and paused, looking straight at the camera.

She said, 'You don't need to worry, Frank. Everything is okay. This is just part of your *Experience*.'

Dixon was stunned.

Uh... what the hell?

He rubbed his eyes and looked again.

Christiane Amanpour, CNN's chief international anchor, was looking at him — or seemed to be, through the TV screen.

In fact, it seemed so much like she was talking directly to him that he found himself answering her, saying, 'Oh... uh... it is?'

He even felt mildly embarrassed that she might see him there in bed wearing only a pair of boxer shorts.

On-screen, Amanpour smiled and said, 'Just relax, Frank. Enjoy the ride. Don't overthink things.'

He jumped, startled. She was talking to him. How the hell had Marriage 2.0 swung this? How had they gotten *Christiane Amanpour* to talk to him through this TV?

Then there was a slight click, and the TV changed channel by itself again, and now he was looking at a view of the entrance hall of their house in Connecticut.

Again, there were no signs of life.

He switched channels again, and then again, and then again, flicking between views of the first-floor landing, the laundry room, the two empty guest bedrooms, the upstairs office, and the upstairs sitting room.

He was amazed. The whole house seemed to be carpeted by cameras. The only rooms that had been spared from this invasion of privacy were the kids' rooms and Ophelia's bedroom.

This was his Marriage 2.0 adventure?

How did it all tie in with the gift he'd given to Jenni?

At first, scanning through the various cameras mounted throughout their home via the channel buttons on the TV remote, Dixon couldn't understand why this was his Marriage 2.0 adventure.

It was late. Everyone was asleep.

Why was he watching this?

Then, one more click on the remote, and he was watching their main bedroom. He'd learned recently that you couldn't call it the 'master' bedroom these days. Here it was.

Dixon caught his breath.

Jenni, wearing her tight tank top and a pair of black leggings, walked into plain view of the camera from the bedroom door.

Well, somebody was awake in the house.

She looked gorgeous. Why was he watching her from his hotel room? Were the good people at Marriage 2.0 simply getting him interested in his wife again by turning him into some kind of voyeur?

But he did watch her. There was something instantly captivating about it as Jenni wandered over to her dressing table and rearranged a few of the bottles sitting on it in front of her mirror. Then as she moved to the side of the bed, and fluffed some of the pillows.

The quality of the camera was impressive. Where had they hidden the device? Jenni seemed so close, and yet she certainly didn't notice there was a camera filming her.

Should he call her and warn her that their house had been bugged?

But this was Marriage 2.0. This was for his benefit. If they wanted him to tell her she was on camera, he would have received a message from them, some instructions.

He could watch her and quietly side-step his guilt by placing the blame on Marriage 2.0.

He watched his wife stoop and then peel down her leggings, revealing a pair of black panties underneath. Okay, so they were fairly normal-looking panties, but she was in good shape, and it was so sexy being able to watch her when he really shouldn't have been able to. She had a cute ass.

What was she doing now? Just standing up, facing away from the camera.

It was crazy late. She'd stayed up crazy late just to talk to him when he returned from his night out with the Gilderoy guys. Usually, she wouldn't stay up that late at all. She'd record him a little video message

wishing him well in his work, adding that she missed him, the kids missed him, and hopefully, they'd get to talk the next day sometime. This time, though, she'd waited up into the small hours.

She'd stayed awake to ask him about the gift he'd given her. So she could confirm how he really felt about it.

'You really do want me to do this, don't you?' she'd said.

And he'd told her he thought it would be good for her — *I heard it can be empowering, it can do the world of good for your self-confidence* — even though he had no idea what it was.

Well. Now she was awake and turning around to face in the direction of the camera. She looked *amazing*, and Dixon was getting excited watching her. He was getting hard.

This was Marriage 2.0's strategy for them? To let him spy on his wife while traveling on business, and he'd get home and want to pounce on her, fuck her silly?

Jenni picked up her leggings and folded them. Scratched her belly. Peeled off her tank top, and now she was wearing only her panties. But she was facing away from him. Ah... now she was turning again. He could see bare breasts, so gorgeous.

She was folding up her top, throwing it over to the laundry basket. Turning away again to drag her panties down her thighs, down her legs.

He watched her walk away, out of the camera shot, and his hard cock was in his hand; he was stroking it.

Okay... so this was quite arousing. He didn't often get to enjoy the sight of his wife like this.

Then she put on a bathrobe. She walked out of shot.

Boo, he could hear his inner voice say, reacting to Jenni's covering up, her leaving the bedroom.

He sighed and continued to watch. She was using the bathroom, probably. She'd be back — she had to be back. She had to sleep in that bed, didn't she?

Sure enough, here she was again. Why did she have to wear that bathrobe? There wasn't anyone around to see her naked. Now she was in front of her dressing table again, picking up the bottles, examining them. Pouring something onto her hands, rubbing it over her face, her neck.

She turned around again, facing the camera. Unfastened the belt around the robe. Pulled it open.

Alleluia.

Oh wow.

Jenni was naked, facing the camera. Slipping off her bathrobe entirely. This was more like it.

She turned to the dressing table again. Grabbed something from a bottle and then turned back to the camera. She lifted a foot onto the bed, giving him a superlative view of her bare body. Now she was rubbing something all over her leg, something like sun cream. Then the other leg. Moisturizer?

She rubbed it into her buttocks, over her stomach, hips, thighs, chest. Over her breasts.

Then, her arms. It seemed like hard work compared to what men did when they got out of the shower. But the way she did it... it was sensual. Erotic.

He sighed as she walked off-screen again. What was she up to?

This time, she was only gone a moment or two. Back she came, holding something white. More panties. White, this time. Next up: a white bra, fairly plain. She picked up a bottle and walked off-screen again.

Dixon was riveted. He smiled, chuckled at his own pathetic excitement. Most other guys wouldn't probably give a shit about watching this kind of scene. It wasn't exactly pornographic. Jenni was attractive enough, but it wasn't like there was anything really sexual going on.

But Dixon hadn't been this hard in ages.

It was Jenni. Looking *so* good. And he could pay attention to her, watch her, lust over her, and she wasn't hiding away from him. Why didn't she ever wear just a bra and panties in bed when he was around?

He watched her turn out the lights, and then she wandered to the bed. He could still see into the bedroom easily enough, even with the lights switched out. The camera had some kind of infrared capability — night vision.

Jenni got into bed, covered herself with the sheets, and was still.

Oh. Was she going to just sleep?

Dixon watched for a while longer and couldn't help but stroke himself to orgasm, to release that pent-up arousal inside him.

Jenni, however, really was asleep on screen.

And now, after the most sexual satisfaction he'd had for ages, Dixon found himself drifting off, too.

Wondering whether he would be allowed to watch more of Jenni on this hotel TV while he was staying here.

Wondering if this was the Marriage 2.0 strategy for him: turning him into a voyeur.

Frank Dixon slept well, better than he had in a long time. He could hardly believe it when the hotel phone woke him, and it was his emergency backup morning call. It was something he'd never actually had to use in his life, although he'd always been careful to arrange on business trips.

He felt wonderfully refreshed, getting all that uninterrupted sleep — even if it had started relatively late.

He was up, showered and dressed, out the door quickly, and firing on all cylinders from the very first meeting of the day.

Even if he did spend most of the day thinking about Jenni. Hoping that when he got back to the hotel that evening, he'd be able to spend some more time checking in on his beautiful wife, enjoying the sight of her.

Was he some kind of voyeur now?

Marriage 2.0 had turned him into a peeping tom.

However, the question still remained: what had been in that purple envelope he'd given her for their anniversary?

As it turned out, he needed that restful sleep to get through the second day of going over the whole Gilderoy-Suffolk thing.

The development company finally revealed that it had sunk a ton of money into a project to build a 'garden suburb' in Spokane. When Dixon demanded to see the figures, the numbers did not add up.

One awkward meeting led to another, and then to another. There simply was no demand for this project. The housing market was not

buoyant enough, particularly in this part of Spokane — no matter how much the execs insisted that the project itself would transform the local realty market.

It got to the point where he could do little other than threaten to withdraw their financial backing from Bradley, Dixon, and Gaines unless Gilderoy-Suffolk could find a way to pull out of the Spokane project. The execs insisted there was no way to pull out now. They were in too deep. They would lose everything.

Finally, they pulled in old Mr. Gilderoy, who was virtually retired, to plead with Dixon to just turn a blind eye and let his firm continue with this project.

They all called it a day, without apparent resolution, at about 3pm. An early close to business, but there was no progress to be made. On the way back to the hotel, Dixon had an angry Gaines on the phone, demanding to know why he'd been persuaded to put his clients into anything as risky as Gilderoy-Suffolk.

You win some, you lose some.

The first thing he did on returning to the hotel was book an early flight home. The private jet was still out of action, and you never knew what availability would be for commercial flights.

Then he took a long, hot shower and ordered room service. It was early for an evening meal in Seattle, but he was already turning his mind back to the East Coast, where it was now just past 7.30pm.

He thought about calling home, but felt vaguely embarrassed about the imminent collapse of the Gilderoy-Suffolk investment. If he called Jenni this early in the evening, it would feel like real failure.

He felt a pang of regret that he wasn't calling the kids before they went to sleep — but he'd see them the next day anyway.

Instead, he settled in bed and switched on the TV. He watched CNN while he ate his evening meal, disappointed that all the channels on the hotel TV were back to normal tonight.

Watching the various goings-on in Washington, he even started wondering if he'd imagined the strange adventure of the previous night. Had *Christiane Amanpour* really spoken to him through the TV screen to remind him that this was his Marriage 2.0 adventure?

Maybe the stress had really gotten to him.

Maybe he was going crazy.

Then he put his plate back on the little room service cart and wheeled it back out to the hallway to park it beside his door. When he returned, the CNN broadcast seemed to have frozen. It looked like there had been some kind of glitch in transmission.

Dixon sighed and searched for the TV remote. It was there on the bed, under one of the pillows. He aimed it at the TV and hit the channel up button.

And once again, he was presented with a view of their house in Connecticut.

Dixon smiled broadly — even after such an awful day at work.

How had Marriage 2.0 done this? Not only bugging the house, but rigging it up to the TV in this hotel room. It was clever. He wasn't sure it was \$100,000 worth of clever, but it was clever.

He flicked through the channels, and once again, they all offered different views of the house. The kids seemed to be in bed already — of course they were, at this time in the evening — though there was no camera in the kids' room.

He could see Ophelia was watching TV in the family room.

He found Jenni in their bedroom, changing into her workout gear, and his heart leaped as he laid eyes on her.

She seemed to be in a cheerful mood, a smile spread across her face — impressive after the exhausting feat of finally getting the kids to sleep. Kids who had their father's insomnia gene.

He watched her step to the side of the bed and peel off her gray tank top, and then her fairly plain white bra to expose her gorgeous breasts.

His heart rate was picking up. His manhood was thickening. Surely there was nothing wrong with watching your wife undressing, from getting pleasure from a sight like that?

Jenni sat on the edge of the bed to remove her dark blue pants, and then pulled on a pair of black-and-white striped lycra shorts over her purple panties. She faced the camera to stretch them over her hips and get them in exactly the right position. Damn, she looked good.

Next, he watched her pull on a sports bra that matched the shorts.

After donning white socks and sneakers, she left the bedroom, pulling her long, sandy hair into a long ponytail as she went. Dixon found he could switch between cameras and follow her down to the gym, marveling at how good she looked in those tiny, skin-tight shorts and sports bra, which looked almost painted on.

He'd never seen her wearing quite *this* little for a workout — was this how she was when he wasn't at home? Like wearing a bra and panties to sleep, she behaved differently when her husband wasn't around. She was less shy about her body.

He watched her walk into the gym, he watched her stretch her limbs and warm up her muscles, and he even watched her workout routine.

He watched her, and he quietly stroked his hard cock.

Well, Marriage 2.0 was working wonders at getting him to notice Jenni again.

But even if he was horny as a teenager when he got home, how would he break that Friend Zone barrier, that wall of awkwardness that now existed between them as far as sex was concerned?

Her workout lasted 90 minutes, which seemed excessive for Jenni. Dixon sat riveted to the screen, sitting on the edge of the mattress, gently stroking himself as he watched her.

It wasn't a glamorous look, but hey. He enjoyed watching her; it turned him on, so he was making the most of it.

After her workout, he watched her walk back upstairs to their bedroom, strip off her gym clothes and drop them in the laundry basket before venturing into the ensuite to turn on the shower.

He flicked between channels, following her all the way into the bathroom — and then into the shower. He couldn't believe there was even a camera in the shower. How had they got all this equipment rigged up throughout the house without anyone knowing?

He enjoyed the sight of Jenni standing naked under the flow of the water in ultra-high definition. He took in the sight of her washing her body, shaving her legs, washing her long, golden hair.

It did seem wrong that he could watch her like this. It crossed all kinds of ethical boundaries. But he was doing this for them, right? To renew the passion between them.

Better *this* than some secret affair with an intern.

And somehow, the fact that it felt wrong made it feel all the more erotic.

After her shower, Jenni toweled off and blasted her hair with a hairdryer, before slipping on a simple pair of pink cotton panties with a white bra that didn't even match. Hey, who did she need to impress?

He watched her hop onto the bed, pulling something off the bedside table that he soon saw was her tablet, her iPad.

Was she going to call him? FaceTime him? Surely she wouldn't call him while wearing nothing but a mismatched bra and panties? And she hadn't even covered herself with the bedsheet; she was lying on top of the bed in her underwear.

Plus, she tended to wait for him to call her when he was on a business trip because she never knew his schedule. He assumed she was simply reading the news, or an ebook, overly warm from her shower.

For a moment, Dixon thought about calling her to let her know the business arrangement with Gilderoy-Suffolk had turned sour. That he would be returning home earlier than planned. Perhaps he'd surprise her in her current state of undress — would she get all self-conscious and cover herself up? Something was amusing about that.

At the same time, he didn't really want to spoil this nice view he had of her sitting on the bed, leaning back against the pillows, peering at her iPad. She had her legs apart, one knee raised, and he had a nice view of her panties.

Watching like this was far better than calling to share the somewhat embarrassing news about Gilderoy-Suffolk. That could wait.

Jenni was looking at her iPad quite seriously. Flicking the screen with her fingers, apparently typing a few things here and there. What was she doing, Facebooking her friends?

She was really focused on it, whatever it was she was doing. Almost as though it was work.

Surely it wasn't *actually* work? She didn't need to work.

But the thought triggered an idea in Dixon's head: What if Jenni had felt under-used since she'd given up work? She might feel her natural talents and intellect were not being fully stretched by being a full-time stay-at-home mom. She had a nanny to help her take care of the kids, and there were plenty of people around to take care of the house.

Did she need employment to feel fully satisfied with life?

Dixon caught his breath — did the purple envelope contain some way for her to get back into the real estate business? Perhaps some kind of refresher course? It would turn her back into a working woman, giving her that confidence boost from earning her own money again.

Of course, that made sense.

Was that really how Marriage 2.0 was rekindling the spark in their marriage?

But now he felt vaguely put out by the idea — not that she would want to go back to work, but that she hadn't said anything to him about wanting to do so.

Maybe she hadn't realized before he'd given her the purple envelope.

He watched her tapping away at the iPad for nearly an hour, her facial expression serious, as though she was trying to have a passport photo taken.

There were a few smiles along the way, as though she'd gotten something right in a quiz, or if somebody had sent her an amusing email. Perhaps she was Facebooking with one of her friends while looking into this real estate thing, whatever it was.

While watching her work, Dixon was distracted by an email himself, which led him to do a little work on his laptop computer, sketching out a few ideas on moving forward with Gilderoy-Suffolk.

When he next returned his gaze to the sight of his beautiful wife on the TV screen, he gasped.

She was still lying there on the bed in her underwear, holding her tablet in one hand — but now her other hand was placed lightly over her crotch. Her legs were spread wide apart as she sat on the bed, leaning back against the pillows.

Was she gently *stroking* herself?

Dixon felt his heart skip a beat, and his cock rapidly return to full hardness. Wow. What was she looking at on that tablet? Porn? It was a shame Marriage 2.0 hadn't given him the ability to see what was on her screen.

He watched as she stopped touching herself and adjusted her position on the bed. She reached over to the bedside table for a glass of water. Was she done?

More, he thought. *I want more*.

Then she returned to gazing at the tablet, and Dixon took in every detail of her. Was she breathing more deeply than usual?

Both her hands were on the tablet now. She was typing something. It was almost like she was teasing him. What was she writing?

But then her hand dropped to her crotch again, the other still clutching her iPad. Dixon dropped everything and moved to sit at the edge of the bed again to watch her intently. She was properly touching

herself now, that hand between her legs coaxing her pussy through her panties.

God.

Dixon couldn't remember seeing anything as beautiful, anything as sexy. He pulled his cock out of his boxer shorts and stroked while watching her.

Was there a slight smile on her face now? What was she watching?

It was surprising to think of quiet, serene, steady Jenni doing something as filthy as watching pornography. What kind of porn did she like watching? What was her preference? What were her fantasies?

Now, as he watched her, he saw her pull her hand away from her crotch, only to dip it down inside her panties, to begin stroking her sex without the barrier of her underwear getting in the way.

He'd never seen Jenni masturbate before.

He hadn't even fully believed she did masturbate until now. But here she was, really going at it. The motion of her hand became more vigorous, drawing imaginary circles on her pussy with an accelerated motion.

Was this something she often did when he was away from home?

She stopped for a moment to type something on the iPad screen, and Dixon thought she might be looking for a new porn clip — but then she smiled as though someone had said something funny. Was she Facebooking *while continuing to masturbate*? Crazy.

Women were supposed to be good at multi-tasking, weren't they?

He watched her pull off her panties with one hand while holding the iPad with the other. Now he could see her pussy — so pink and glistening wet, surrounded by the golden fuzz of her pubic hair. She was back to touching herself, this time sinking in the pillows, pushing up her hips so she had easy access to slide two fingers inside herself, still clutching that iPad.

Another smile, a biting of the lips. Was she watching pornographic *comedy*?

But then, after a little while longer, she seemed to get more into the masturbation, and her face became serious again. She was still looking at the iPad, but leaning back, her eyes sometimes closing, her mouth opening as she moaned at the sexual sensations sweeping over her.

God, he was watching her *orgasm*.

It seemed like an absolute age since he had seen such a thing. It was so incredibly hot that he found himself reaching orgasm even before she

did. He accidentally shot come all over the TV screen and the floor in front of him.

Wow. What a ride.

And yet, before he cleaned up his own mess, he watched Jenni on-screen, recovering from her own climax, sitting up to look at the iPad almost as though she was feeling guilty about whatever it was she had been watching on there.

She wouldn't be the first woman to feel guilt when she masturbated. She wouldn't be the first wife.

He watched her reach for her panties, then pull herself off the bed in order to put them back on. Now she reached into the drawer in her bedside table and put on a pair of loose floral shorts and a dark green tank top. Was she feeling bad about getting off using pornography? Dixon hoped not.

He was taking it as a good sign that Jenni's libido was apparently firing on all cylinders.

It was 9pm in Seattle and midnight on the East Coast when he decided to call Jenni.

He texted her first — which he would do if he didn't have the capability of watching her on the hotel TV — to ensure she was still awake to take a call.

Only when she replied 'yes', with a smiley face, did he suddenly remember to turn off the TV so that she wouldn't notice he'd been watching her on the screen.

'Hey, sweetie!'

'Hey, how're things?'

'Good, good.'

Jenni was wearing the same tank top and floral shorts that she had put on straight after he'd watched her touching herself. The recognition brought back that vivid image of her making herself come, and brought with it a semi for Dixon.

Wow. Had he really seen her doing that? It almost seemed like a wet dream — and yet the clothes she now wore were tantamount to proof that he had not dreamed it.

'Everything okay, sweetie?' Jenni asked him, and he supposed she knew full well it was still relatively early in Seattle, so this wasn't the

end of a big night out for Dixon and his clients.

‘Yeah, fine,’ he nodded and tried a reassuring smile. ‘Things are just wrapping up here a little early. I’ll be flying back in the morning.’

‘That’s wonderful!’ she said and meant it. Had she always been that happy about the prospect of him coming home? Or was she looking at him with fresh enthusiasm? Had Marriage 2.0 already made her more fond of him? Would that translate to something sexual?

‘So you had a good day?’ he asked her.

‘Yeah,’ she grinned. ‘We took the kids to the trampoline park, and they just had a total blast!’

They talked about the kids for a while, and Dixon even forgot about his unsuccessful attempts to get Jenni to reveal what had been in that purple envelope.

That was until she mentioned that she’d had coffee with her friend Phoebe that afternoon and that they had discussed her ‘anniversary present’.

‘Oh, you *did*?’ he asked, remembering that Jenni had said a couple of her friends were doing it too, whatever ‘it’ was.

Was Phoebe going back to work? Was she taking some courses to go back into real estate, or something similar? He couldn’t remember, offhand, what Phoebe had done for a career before her kids had come along.

Jenni smiled and nodded, excited but trying hard not to show it too much. ‘Yeah... I mean, she’s been doing it a while, so we talked about the best way for me to get going, you know? The kinds of things to say... the things you have to be careful of...’

Hmm. Was it some kind of self-starter thing?

Had the envelope contained some kind of huge check to help her start up her own real estate business, or some other kind of small business? It sounded like she was preparing to get into the selling of something.

‘Well, you certainly have to be *careful*, honey,’ he said, again keeping things vague so that he didn’t demonstrate ignorance about what he had given her for their anniversary.

‘I’ll be okay,’ she said with a broad grin. ‘I can stand up for myself.’

He nodded and tried another probing question, ‘So it’s going okay so far?’

Her grin widened if that was possible. ‘Uh-huh,’ she blushed. Why so self-conscious? She said, ‘I’ve... chatted with a few people online, so far... it’s... been kinda fun...’

He smiled and very nearly launched into a story about how terrifying it had been when he and Bradley and Gaines had come out of Lehman Brothers all those years ago.

But he stopped himself as he realized his story would fall flat if he'd got it wrong, and she wouldn't be starting her own business.

'So you think you're really going to give it a go?' he asked her, another prompt of a question, but he was beginning to get a little frustrated again.

She looked serious. 'I think... I mean, you *want* me to, don't you?'

'Of course,' he grinned, trying to be as reassuring as possible. 'I think it would be *great* for you.'

'And... you want me to do it... *properly*, don't you?' she said. 'I mean, you're not just... wanting me to... you know... do it online.'

He nodded, sensing from what she said that it was some kind of college course, or real estate school, or training program they were talking about. 'I want you to do it properly,' he said. 'In person. You know? I really think that would be better all-round, right?'

She nodded and gave him a strangely nervous little smile. Well, she was going back to school. Of course she was a little nervous about that.

She said, 'I was talking about it with Phoebe, and naturally enough, she wanted to know if you *really* wanted me to... you know... *get out there*. Or if I was going to just... talk about it online without really doing it for real.'

Jesus. He couldn't even ask her which college she would attend, or which training school, or whatever. Because what if he'd given her a specific course at a specific venue?

He really did not want to make it seem like he'd simply asked Mrs. Hawkes to pick out an anniversary gift for his wife.

He nodded, feeling a little confident that doing some kind of training thing and actually getting back into the business world would be good for Jenni.

'You've got so much going for yourself,' he told her. 'You need to get out there and do it properly, sure. You know, you'll feel more fulfilled if you do it properly, I bet.'

Her smile broadened again, so pretty, so dazzling. 'You're the best husband in the world, you know that?' she said. 'Phoebe was saying how much she wished she had a husband like you.'

'And her husband really doesn't know she's doing it?'

'Lenny? Not a clue.'

Dixon nodded his head and scratched the back of his scalp, thinking, *I haven't got much of a clue, either.*

'Well,' he said, deciding to bring the conversation to an end before he revealed the limits of his knowledge concerning her present, 'I'm glad you're having fun already. I'm sure when it gets going... properly... It's really going to improve life. For both of us.'

After that, he had to concede defeat, and after a little small talk and confirmation of when his flight would get in and what time he'd be home, he signed off and ended the call.

He was tired, anyway.

He switched on the TV again and saw that Jenni had switched out the lights and appeared to be going to sleep. A touch disappointing after the erotic display she'd put on earlier that evening. But Dixon figured he should be happy with what he'd got.

Perhaps when he got home, he'd find a more empowered woman ready to get frisky with her husband again.

Not for the first time, he had to trust that Marriage 2.0 knew what it was doing in working to improve his relationship.

When Dixon finally got back to New York, he was burning to get back home and see Jenni in the flesh.

But there was to be no easy way home, it seemed.

Villiers, the company chauffeur, was there at the airport to collect him. Gaines had called an emergency board meeting.

All Dixon could do was go along with it. Gaines was livid about the Gilderoy-Suffolk developments and would not let it go. When Dixon arrived for the meeting, the board was determined to resolve the problem here and now.

It meant they would be locked in the meeting until a satisfactory resolution was reached — even if that took days and days to achieve.

They were working all through the night for three days. On the second night, Gaines allowed them to retire to nearby hotels for a few hours of sleep, but that was about it.

Dixon retired to the apartment he and Jenni kept on Dutch Street, not far away from the office, in the Financial District. He often used it when working so late it wasn't worth the drive up to Connecticut afterward.

All he could do was keep in touch with Jenni and the kids, and apologize for being kept away.

It felt more than a little frustrating. He didn't get much time to talk with Jenni, and it seemed to Dixon that being kept away from her at that point risked undoing the progress being made by Marriage 2.0.

'It'll be okay,' Jenni said when he tried to tell her he was missing her on the third day and ended up tripping on his tongue.

She said, 'You've always had unexpected things come up at work. Unexpected trips. Isn't that part of the reason why I've got *this* now?'

She held up the purple envelope in front of the camera. It sent a jolt of heat through Dixon's heart.

What *was* in that envelope?

But there wasn't time to discuss that on this occasion. Gaines was calling them back in for another meeting.

'Look, honey, I'm sorry, I've got to go back in.'

'Of course. I hope everything works out, sweetie.'

And that, basically, was the only time either of them remembered to even bring up the anniversary gift before he got home after those long, tiring three days.

Then, at last, Villiers was driving him home, and he felt like he'd been away for a month.

When he got in, the kids were in bed already, and there was Jenni, waiting for him at the front door, looking sweet and gorgeous, her hair down and nicely brushed, her face touched up with makeup, and she was even wearing a dress, as though she was trying to impress him.

He kissed her on the lips, thinking it might be just a peck in greeting. But then it lingered a little so that he could taste the sweetness of her mouth, feel the waxiness of the lipstick on her lips, and breathe in her perfume.

It seemed to happen because she wanted it, too. The awkwardness between them melted away.

Dixon felt warm all over, and a little shivery at the same time, his manhood even beginning to thicken. If only he wasn't so tired.

'Hey, I've missed you,' he said, finally pulling back from their slow, soft kiss.

'I missed you too,' she said, her pretty mouth stretching into a bright smile.

'You look so nice,' he said, not even thinking what he was saying, the words just seeming to fall out of his mouth. Judging by her smile, he wasn't doing so badly. 'I wish I wasn't so god-damn *tired* right now...'

'It's okay,' she said, and there was a flicker of disappointment in her eyes as well as something else, something a little more... exciting. Was that *lust*, for the first time in a long, long while? 'Come on, let's get you to bed, sweetie.'

They went hand-in-hand up the stairs as though they'd just gotten married, and she led him into the bedroom. He could feel the fatigue aching in every muscle in his body. God, such a bad time to be this tired.

Was he getting old or something? His younger self would have shrugged off the exhaustion if he'd had a long night of partying and ended up with a pretty girl.

But he took it as a positive sign that he felt this way about her, and she clearly felt something for him, too.

Marriage 2.0 was doing something.

And in the morning, when he wasn't so tired... well, perhaps something nice might happen.

She helped him pull off his clothes, leaving him in his underwear to climb into their large bed, slipping beneath cool sheets.

Then she said, 'Sleep well, sweetie,' and there was another one of those phenomenal kisses.

But then sleep consumed him.

He woke the next morning to find the house empty and quiet.

He climbed out of bed, threw on a bathrobe, and staggered out of the room, still groggy from sleep.

He slowly descended the main stairs into the entrance hall, feeling almost like a stranger in his own home. He was so rarely here during daylight hours.

Jenni was out with the kids. Had to be. The house was too quiet, too still. It was Ophelia's day off, Jenni's day to take care of them herself, and with the fine weather, she would undoubtedly take them to the playground at the nearby park.

Dixon went through into the kitchen and retrieved a glass of orange juice from the large, stainless steel fridge. It was when he wandered into the living room with his drink that he remembered looking into this place from the comfort of his own hotel room in Seattle.

Where was the hidden camera?

He looked up, and there was a ventilation grille in just about the place a camera would have to be to get the kind of view he'd had of this room. But you really couldn't see the camera.

He pulled out his phone and switched on the flashlight. He held it up closer to the ventilation grille, and, there in one of the slots, he saw the characteristic glint of glass reflecting light back at him.

There *was* a camera in there.

It gave him a mild shock to confirm it, even though he knew it had to be there. It was so well hidden and so well installed. The ventilation grille didn't seem to have been moved in years.

So how did he access the feed from these cameras now that he was no longer in his hotel room?

He wandered through the living room and pushed through the double doors leading to his small ground floor office.

Here, he found the remote on his large, mahogany desk and switched on the TV screen in the back wall, which was filled with bookshelves. CNN appeared and seemed normal. He switched the channel and groaned as he found himself flicking through the usual array of cable channels — mostly commercials for drugs, accident lawyers, and life insurance, at that time of day.

So how did he access the hidden cameras throughout his home?

He was slightly nervous about being monitored himself, now that he was here in person. But hadn't he been monitored by Marriage 2.0 non-stop since his assessment?

He had granted them access to all his devices and personal communications technology. Clayton had explained that only the company's Artificial Intelligence systems would access them — unless he himself called the company to report some kind of problems. He shouldn't be nervous about AI checking up on him.

'AI's going to replace a lot of jobs in the security industry,' Dixon remembered saying to Clayton.

'I bet you're right,' Clayton had smiled, and Dixon had found himself wondering if his firm had any investments in that particular sector.

After that, he went back upstairs to shower and dress.

When he was getting out of the shower, his eyes fell on their laundry basket. Something green was hanging out of it, and he recognized the shade from the top Jenni had been wearing the other night when he had called her from the hotel room.

It was the top she had put on immediately after he'd watched her bring herself to orgasm.

He wasn't usually interested in Jenni's clothes, or indeed, her laundry. But seeing her green top evoked such memories in him — and, perhaps more importantly, it seemed to provide tangible evidence that what he had seen on that hotel TV had actually happened.

He opened the laundry basket, and here were those floral shorts she'd worn that night. And the bra she'd been wearing. And those pink panties.

He picked them up.

He was rock hard as he touched them to his nose. It felt so wrong, so dirty, so embarrassing, so perverted, so *shameful*. And yet she *was* his wife. There was nothing illegal in it.

He breathed in the remaining scent from the soft cotton and caught a chestful of her personal smell, the smell of her arousal.

Musky, spicy, it made his erection throb. It made his heart pump twice as fast.

It was indisputable evidence of what he'd watched. It assured him that he wasn't going crazy — he *had* watched Jenni touching herself. It had been one of the most thrilling experiences of his life up to that point.

He resisted the urge to jack off to the smell of his wife's pussy. It wasn't the easiest temptation to beat, surprisingly. Yet, he was able to do so by fixing a more interesting thought in his head: that this whole project was working. Weirdly, he *was* becoming sexually interested in Jenni again — and she was becoming interested in sex again — and these panties of hers were proof enough of both.

Perhaps that evening, when the kids were in bed, he could make some move on her, see if she wanted to take things up a notch.

Jenni returned home about lunchtime — she'd taken the kids to the park, managing to get at least some of their endless energy out.

Dixon joined them in a nice, light lunch provided by the ever-capable Mrs. Habscomb. It was a lot of fun to be with the kids for once, during the day when he would typically have been at work.

After getting through sandwiches and sliced fruit, they all changed into swimwear and headed out to the pool for a few hours. Though Dixon's head was certainly turned by the sight of Jenni in her tight one-piece swimsuit, his attention was so caught up in playing with the twins that he couldn't afford to dwell on his growing sexual desire for her.

And, he didn't even think about work once.

When they went back inside, it was mid-afternoon, and Jenni had to get the kids changed again and ready to go to a party — the birthday party of one of their neighbors' kids. Dixon had been having so much fun — and had been enjoying not thinking about work — that he suggested that he could take them to the party.

'Sure, that would be great,' Jenni said.

Then, with a slightly strange expression, she added, ‘Hey. You think you could take care of them this evening, as well?’

‘Uh... sure,’ he said cautiously.

Jenni smiled broadly. ‘I was hoping to go out for the evening... I was going to ask Mrs. Habscomb to watch them since Ophelia’s off for the day...’

‘Oh, no. That would be fine,’ he said. He was about to ask if she was going out with Phoebe, or her other ex-college friends, when the twins launched themselves at him. They were thrilled to have overheard that their dad would be taking care of them instead of Mrs. Habscomb.

And that killed any possible conversation about Jenni’s evening plans.

Later, as he shepherded the twins to their neighbors’ large house and the party that was already going on in the extensive grounds, Dixon tried to think how long it had been since Jenni had gone out for a Girls’ Night Out.

It had been a long while.

Had she even been on a full night out with her friends since the kids had come along?

He took it as a good sign. She was building her self-confidence. Going back into the workforce, or whatever she was actually doing, was paying off.

Bringing the kids back from a party filled with snacks and candy was a little like shaking up a can of soda and then opening it.

They ran wild around the house as they got home, and then a little later came the sugar crash, the grumpiness and tantrums when bedtime came along, and there was no more time to play.

Dixon tried not to trouble Jenni with any of it — let her have some time to get ready for her night out.

He simply knuckled down, took the kids upstairs, and began the bedtime routine — getting them undressed while the bath filled, bathing them, and then getting them into PJs before reading stories.

He was in the middle of reading about the exploits of *The Little Blue Truck* — and marveling at the overt socialist subtext of the kids’ favorite story — when he looked up to see Jenni come in to wish the kids a good night before she went out.

She looked drop-dead gorgeous in a turquoise dress that hugged every curve, all the way down to just below her knees.

Dixon was just stunned by the sight of her.

‘Do I look okay?’ she asked him, and she seemed nervous.

‘Okay? You look *amazing*,’ he said, pulling himself out of the armchair in the kids’ room to wish her a proper farewell.

‘You know... first date and all that,’ she said with an anxious smile.

Wait, what?

Dixon felt his heart stop.

‘First *date*?’

‘I know. I haven’t even had the chance to tell you anything about him,’ she said with a nervous laugh.

If he’d had a drink in his hand, now would be the moment to spit out a mouthful all over the place, in complete and utter surprise.

Jenni was going on a *date* with someone?

Another guy?

What the hell?

And she wasn’t hiding it from him. She was telling him plain as day.

Dixon was in a daze as he heard her saying, ‘But you know... he just suggested a little first meeting, you know... a drink or two, nothing *significant*... and I thought you seemed quite keen for me to do this... you know... *properly*...’

God.

He was too stunned to really think straight or to really say anything. What was she talking about, a *date*? Was she really having a drink or two with a *guy*?

But the trouble was, Dixon didn’t feel as though he could ask her too much about it all. The way she was acting made it seem that he should know all this was happening. That she was going on a date with another man.

He still felt restricted by the possible shame of admitting he had no idea what had been in that purple envelope.

Jenni leaned in to kiss his cheek by way of a goodbye, and he breathed in her sweet, exotic perfume. God, she was really dressing to impress.

But she wasn’t trying to impress him. She was trying to win over some other guy.

What the hell was this?

What had Marriage 2.0 done?

Her golden hair was brushed and flowing in waves down her back. She looked *devastating*. Any guy would pounce on her if given half a chance. Let alone someone out on a *first date* with her.

Dixon felt his heart racing, felt his blood fizzing with shock. He felt like he had just before he'd collapsed at work.

He had to calm down.

Maybe he'd gotten the wrong end of the stick. Maybe people used the word 'date' differently these days? God knew it had been years since he and Jenni had dated.

Maybe she was going out to meet a course professor or some real estate guy with whom she wanted to go into business.

Right now, the kids were here anyway. So, all in all, he had to smile and try to hide his shock and surprise.

And to his overwhelmed, bewildered, astonished chagrin, he had to just let Jenni walk out of there looking like a goddess in human form. He had to let her walk downstairs, out of the house, and into the car waiting to take her somewhere where. And unless he had imagined it all, she was going on a *date*.

A *first date*.

He felt a crazy lack of control.

Stuck in their house trying to get the kids to sleep while Jenni was out on a date with another man.

It took an entire hour for him to persuade their two three-year-olds to get to sleep. He ended up reading them stories, stories, and more stories until they eventually passed out.

Meanwhile, Jenni would be arriving at a restaurant somewhere, looking gorgeous and all dressed up, and would be meeting *whoever*, for her *first date*.

Would you call it a 'first date' if you were simply meeting someone to talk about restarting your career in real estate? Or if you were doing something like sky-diving?

Dixon felt ultimately foolish that he still didn't know what the gift was he'd given to Jenni.

While waiting for the kids to finally get to sleep, his brain had been working on overtime, trying to devise possible scenarios that didn't

involve Jenni getting entangled in some kind of weirdly open, adulterous affair.

Had she been *joking* by calling it a first date?

She hadn't seemed to be joking. She'd been nervous about it. She wouldn't be that nervous if she was simply meeting up with someone to talk about her career.

She'd been anxious like she'd been about to go on a proper first date, hoping it would lead to something... *romantic*.

What on Earth had Marriage 2.0 gotten her into?

When the kids were finally asleep, and Dixon could creep out of their room without them rousing, he decided his first imperative had to be to find out exactly what was in that purple envelope he'd given her.

He launched a full search of the property.

Jesus. It was nowhere to be found. He tried Jenni's bedside table, he searched through the whole of her office, then flicked through Jenni's walk-in closet beside the main bedroom.

No sign of it.

He went downstairs to check the kitchen, the family room, the living room to see if she'd casually left it around somewhere. But apparently not.

The library — nothing. His office — well, there wasn't much chance of anything in there. Nothing in the sunroom. Nothing in the playroom down in the basement.

He even checked the sauna and the utility room in the basement.

Had she hidden it deliberately? Back in the main bedroom, he looked through her drawers, including her underwear drawer. There was nothing there, either.

God, God, God. He *had* to find out what was going on.

After another search of the office upstairs, he found Jenni's tablet. For a moment, he paused as it reminded him of how she'd been holding it while he'd watched her touching herself.

He didn't like to intrude on her privacy, but this felt like an emergency.

He knew her passcode to get into her tablet — the two of them didn't usually have secrets from each other. But what if she came home from her date and discovered he'd been looking at her tablet?

He couldn't afford Jenni to be angry with him at a moment like *this* — when she was toying with *cheating* on him.

Dixon sighed and went back into his own office downstairs. He drew up Facebook on his computer, wondering if there might be some clues on Jenni's profile. There wasn't anything particularly enlightening — though he noticed a familiar face among the friends pictured by the side of Jenni's profile.

Phoebe Breslaw.

Hadn't Jenni been talking to her and other friends about whatever this was all about?

Jenni had said Phoebe had been doing this herself, without her husband's knowledge. Had she meant Phoebe had been seeing other men? Going on dates behind her husband's back?

Dixon dug Phoebe's numbers out of the family contacts file and called her from the phone on his desk.

Phoebe picked up almost immediately, but mistook his call as coming from Jenni — chirping, 'Hey, girl! Are you *still* getting ready?'

Dixon said, 'Uh... *Phoebe*?'

'*Frank*?'

'Uh... yeah...'

There was a pause as she seemed to regroup, surprised that she was talking to Dixon and not Jenni.

Then she said, 'You getting cold feet *already*?'

She sounded almost *amused*.

'Cold feet about what?' Dixon felt himself trembling. He felt a slight nausea in his stomach. A little cold sweat breaking out on his forehead. He felt the truth might be approaching — and that he might not be able to handle it.

Phoebe said, in a very relaxed tone, 'About Jenni. You know. *The big date*...'

Date.

There was that word again. Dixon felt his heart seize up for a few moments after hearing her say it. He was really shaking now as he sat at the desk clutching that telephone handset.

'Look, you have to help me,' he said seriously. He saw no two ways about it. He needed her help. This was humiliating, but he saw no way out.

'Hey, buddy, I get it, I get it,' she said, too relaxed, though the amusement had somewhat leached from her voice.

She felt for him. Something, at least.

She said, ‘Hey, you want me to call her? Persuade her to... you know... *bail*, or whatever...?’

God. How embarrassing would it be for Jenni to get a call from her friend telling her to stop what she was doing because her husband wanted to back out?

It would come out that he hadn’t known what he was giving her as an anniversary present.

‘Wait, wait,’ he said, trying to slow things down — and stop his head from spinning. ‘Look, start from the beginning. I know... she told me... this is something you’re doing, too. I know your husband doesn’t know...’

‘*Hey, hey, what are you saying?*’ Phoebe said in a low, quiet voice as if she did not want to be overheard.

‘No, no, it’s okay,’ he said quickly, trying to reassure her. ‘You have my word. I won’t tell anybody. But you have to promise not to tell Jenni I’m calling you now. Or what we’re talking about.’

‘Okay...’

‘I just want to know... what this *is*. What it involves. What Jenni’s *doing*.’

There was a long pause as Phoebe got her head around what Dixon was saying to her. He wondered if he’d offended her, whether she’d taken his demand for her confidentiality in this matter as some kind of threat: that he would tell her husband what she’d been up to if she revealed all to Jenni.

But then she said carefully, ‘Are you saying you didn’t know what it was all about when you got it for her?’

He felt stupid. Embarrassed. But there was no way of avoiding this now.

‘I’m saying...’ he said, blushing even though he was talking on the phone, feeling so weird, so awkward, so physically ill. ‘Look... what service is it... you’re using?’

And Phoebe said, ‘Ashley Madison. Same as Jenni.’

Dixon bent over and threw up all over the floor.

Frank Dixon just about managed to apologize to Phoebe before he hung up on her, but only just.

He was in shock.

His wife had been using Ashley Madison. For God's sake, she was on a first date with somebody she — presumably — had met through Ashley Madison.

Dixon had heard of Ashley Madison.

Back in 2015, the company's database was hacked, and all its customers' personal details were posted online. The world had discovered what Ashley Madison did — it encouraged married people to have affairs.

Ashley Madison was basically a dating website for married people.

And somehow, Marriage 2.0 had tricked him into gifting his wife a god damn *membership* for it.

Dixon was stunned. What must Jenni have thought of him, giving her a gift like that? That he wanted her to cheat on him? That he hoped she'd have an affair?

The first thing he had to do after hanging up on Phoebe was to clean up the mess he'd made in his study. He certainly wasn't going to call out Mrs. Habscomb to deal with it. She'd gone home for the night, anyway.

He found the cleaning supplies and dutifully mopped up the vomit, before disinfecting the whole area.

God.

While he cleaned up, he found himself replaying in his head how Jenni had reacted when he'd given her that damn purple envelope. When she'd opened it to discover she was now a member of Ashley Madison, paid for by Dixon himself.

When he'd given her the envelope, he'd been instructed to warn her she might be surprised by the gift. He'd been told to say he'd thought long and hard about giving it to her. He'd told her not to worry about it, to just have fun with it, and he'd enjoy hearing about it afterward.

Marriage 2.0 had set him up.

They'd made it seem like he was entirely on board with Jenni dating other men. How could he have been so *stupid*?

On their anniversary, after Jenni had opened the envelope and discovered what her present was, she'd been delighted. Well, of course she was — she must have thought her husband wanted her to start dating other guys on the side.

He'd been too proud to ask her what exactly her gift was.

So stupid.

And he'd foolishly said countless more reassuring things to her as he'd tried to work out what the gift was. Jenni had even pressed him to make sure he was really okay with her doing it. And he'd said of course he was.

That he thought she'd really enjoy it.

That it would give her confidence a boost.

That he didn't need to do it himself — he just wanted her to try it.

God. He'd walked into a monumental trap.

He'd told his beautiful wife to *commit adultery*.

Once he'd cleaned up the mess, Dixon went to his computer to look up Ashley Madison.

After all that brouhaha surrounding the leak of its confidential data, he'd assumed Ashley Madison would have gone bust. And yet, here it was online, dominated by an image of a woman wearing a wedding ring holding a finger up to her mouth to demand secrecy.

And under its brand name, its no-nonsense tagline: 'Life is short. Have an affair'.

Jesus.

Dixon felt hurt. He felt weak. He felt vulnerable. Was he going to lose his wife? He had gone to Marriage 2.0 specifically to ‘upgrade’ their relationship. How had it led to her being pushed into the arms of another man?

Dixon felt his heart beating a thousand times a minute; the air seemed *cold* to breathe all of a sudden — he was hyperventilating, gasping for oxygen.

Was he going to lose everything? His wife would run off with another man, take the kids with her, and then demand half of his wealth.

A court would hardly say she’d been at fault *when her husband had signed her up to Ashley Madison*, the world-famous dating site for cheaters.

What could he do about this?

He sat at his desk in his office, brainstorming the options. Clearly, he could give Jenni a call right now and tell her there had been a horrific misunderstanding — and that he didn’t want her to date other men.

But he felt such horrible shame about all this. About going to Marriage 2.0 in the first place.

And hadn’t Jenni said she wasn’t expecting this first date to lead to anything? She’d said it was just a first meeting to see if they liked each other. Surely Dixon was safe for now?

Perhaps before he humiliated himself in front of Jenni, he could get Marriage 2.0 to fix their mistake.

He had paid them \$100,000, for crying out loud! They were supposed to be *fixing* his marriage.

Dixon pulled out his cell phone and found the Marriage 2.0 app he had secreted in a folder on the fifth page of apps on his home screen.

He was welcomed to the app, and then when the thing loaded up, there was a message wishing him a good evening and stating that his adventure was currently underway.

A button at the top of the screen allowed him to log out of his account or submit any changes to his profile. When he tried that button, it brought up a screen allowing him to type in any pertinent new information about himself that might update Marriage 2.0 as it continued to manage his adventures.

He thought about submitting some kind of complaint.

But before that, his eye was drawn to the menu options at the bottom of the screen. One of them was ‘bills and pay’, which, when he pressed it, said simply that he was all up-to-date on his payments. Of course he was. *He’d paid the bastards \$100,000.*

However, another option was ‘tips and advice’, which drew up a page offering suggestions to ‘help him cope with a demanding adventure’.

There were also menu options for ‘help’, and in the bottom right-hand corner of the app, the word ‘STOP’ in capital letters.

Trembling, he pressed the ‘Stop’ button.

A warning box came up asking if he was sure about wanting to stop his adventure, and that if he did so, he would lose his current membership package and be required to be re-assessed by Marriage 2.0 if he wished to try the service again.

He sighed, feeling a heavy pressure on his shoulders.

It was only \$100,000, right? But Jenni wouldn’t be happy that he was throwing that kind of money away. As she would remind him, any money wasted, even a low six-figure sum, was money ultimately taken away from the Foundation.

The Foundation had been one of Jenni’s big projects ever since she’d stepped away from real estate — the point of it being that once the financial needs of their normal lifestyle were accounted for, and the savings needed to guarantee their lifestyle in the future, any additional income would go to charitable causes.

Dixon could not bring himself to confirm his request to stop the Marriage 2.0 adventure.

How would he feel if everything returned to the way it had been? He and Jenni leading entirely passion-free lives, treating each other platonically, as friends and nothing but?

How exciting had it been recently, when he’d watched her from afar, when he’d seen her getting interested in sex again.

She must have been looking through the Ashley Madison website when he’d watched her touching herself. Had she been matched with someone? It had made her happy, it had given her a real thrill, it had stirred her to lie in bed after her workout and touch herself.

Well, now Dixon was sitting there at his desk with a hard-on as he thought about Jenni masturbating. He was a voyeur, wasn’t he? *That* had been a real thrill.

What if he lost all of that?

Dixon sighed.

He looked through the advice section on the Marriage 2.0 app. There was a Frequently Asked Question there that seemed relevant: ‘What if my adventure is of no interest to me?’

The app advised: *‘Sometimes, your adventure can seem like quite a surprise — even a shock — because it can be based on fantasies and*

preferences that you do not know you had. Before taking a knee-jerk reaction to quickly stop your Experience, it is a good idea to consider the positive aspects of your adventure, and whether any negative aspects come simply because you are not yet accustomed to the nature of your Experience.'

It was one of those circular arguments. You should be thrilled by your adventure because it is your adventure. You don't know this is your fantasy, so it shocks you. But you should just relax and enjoy it, it's your fantasy.

He could understand why it would be Jenni's fantasy — she would get to date, and perhaps sleep with, other men.

But how could this possibly be *his* fantasy?

He breathed. In. Out. Tried to relax.

He thought about what Jenni might be up to at that very moment — having dinner with some guy. Her *date*. Were they having a good time together? Did she *like* him?

Could she imagine sleeping with the guy?

The thought of it made Dixon's stomach churn.

This was so stupid. The Marriage 2.0 advice went on to urge him to wait, to see if the negative feelings toward his Experience resolved as the adventure progressed. *'Sometimes, it takes time for the full impact of your adventure to become clear.'*

Buzz. Buzz. Buzz.

Dixon was shaken from his contemplation by the sound of the gate buzzer on his home security app. His instant first assumption — or perhaps *hope* was a better word — was that Jenni was back from her 'date' already and that she'd decided it was all a bad idea.

But why would she need to buzz at the gate?

He leaned over and flipped on the intercom system. It was *Phoebe* staring up at the video camera.

'Frank, Frank, are you all right? It's me, let me in!'

He groaned. And now he had to deal with Phoebe's questions, too? He wished he hadn't called her in the first place — but then again, he wouldn't have found out about the Ashley Madison thing if he hadn't.

He pressed the button to let her in through the gate and now headed to the front door to let her in before the doorbell woke the kids.

Heck, perhaps Phoebe could help figure out some way to stop Jenni from going on any more ridiculous dates without the whole thing turning into total humiliation for him.

‘Hey,’ said the sharp-featured brunette said as he let her in and quietly closed the front door behind her. ‘You okay, Frank?’

‘I *think* so.’

‘You look pale as all hell.’

Phoebe was breathing hard, as though she’d been running.

‘You know she’s only going for a drink with the guy, don’t you?’ she said as Dixon took her coat and hung it in the closet inside the front door. ‘She’s not intending to... you know... *do anything* tonight...’

‘You’re *sure*?’

Phoebe nodded.

‘You want something to drink?’ he asked her, and when she answered in the affirmative, he led her through to the library.

He asked Phoebe her drinks preference as she made herself comfortable in one of the green leather armchairs in front of the fireplace, which ignited at the touch of a button. Then he poured a gin and tonic for her and a single malt for himself.

He felt a little calmer with some alcohol inside him.

And because of Phoebe’s assurance that Jenni wasn’t going to do anything with her date tonight.

As he sat in the armchair across from her, Phoebe asked him, ‘So what happened? Your secretary accidentally bought Jenni the wrong gift?’

‘No, it wasn’t quite like *that*,’ he insisted.

‘Maybe if you treated your staff better, they wouldn’t get your wife inappropriate presents on your behalf, huh?’

Dixon shook his head and heaved a huge sigh before swigging down his drink.

As he got up to pour himself another, Phoebe said, ‘You *can* tell me, Frank. I know I’m *Jenni’s* friend, but I like to think I’m *your* friend, too, these days.’

He took a sip of the Scotch and then topped up his glass again.

Phoebe tried another approach. ‘Look, you know *I’ve* been using it too, right? Since Jenni obviously told you...’

‘Uh-huh.’

‘So I’m trusting you not to tell Lenny...’

Lenny, being her husband. She was inferring that since he was keeping her secret, she could keep his.

It worked for Dixon.

‘Ever since the twins came along,’ he explained, ‘Things with Jenni have gone a little... you know... *cold*. Well, I mean, not ‘cold’ in terms of... I mean, *in the bedroom*...’

He sighed again. It wasn’t easy to open up. He took another sip of his drink, the fire of the alcohol searing the back of his throat. His hand, holding the glass, was still shaking.

‘Sure, I know,’ Phoebe said, her tone reassuring, understanding. ‘Jenni felt awful for a long while after the twins came along... and after that... she thought you’d lost interest, you know that?’

‘*She* thought *I’d* lost interest?’ he said, nearly spitting out a mouthful of single malt.

‘Even went to therapy for a while. ‘She did research on how to get you in the mood.’

‘You’re kidding?’

‘You didn’t notice? For a while she was dressing up in *ridiculously* short skirts... wearing sexy underwear...’

‘Seriously?’ Dixon was astounded. When was this? He genuinely could not remember seeing her in short skirts or sexy underwear.

‘Oh yeah. She did loads of research. Tried talking to you, teasing you... you were always *working*. Always too busy.’

‘Jesus.’

‘And you know, she’s never given up hope... she always thought once you got through this phase of stressful work... or you completed such-and-such an acquisition... you’d be able to take more time to relax, and feel like you wanted sex again...’

‘My God.’

Dixon felt cold. He felt like that moment at the end of the movie *The Sixth Sense* when you realize you’ve been missing the whole point of what’s been going on for the entire movie.

Poor Jenni.

It was a wonder she hadn’t divorced him already. It was true that when he was snowed under with work, he tended to focus on it, to the detriment of everything else.

‘You know that’s why she’s always kept herself in such good shape,’ Phoebe said. ‘I mean, *God*, if I had her figure, I’d be out there banging every tennis instructor, pool boy, yoga teacher, interior decorator, and landscape gardener from here to Bridgeport.’

‘You *are*, aren’t you?’ Dixon said.

Phoebe rolled her eyes. ‘I only use Ashley Mad *occasionally*, I’ll have you know. When I get desperate.’

The front door banged as it was opened and closed, and both Dixon and Phoebe rushed to the library door believing that Jenni must have come home from her date early.

But it was Ophelia, returning from her day off.

‘Hey, Mr. Dixon,’ the young nanny said, glancing across the entrance hall at them, then turning away as though she thought it would be easier to pretend she hadn’t seen her boss in the company of a woman who was not Mrs. Dixon. Ophelia scampered upstairs toward her room.

‘The nanny,’ Dixon explained to Phoebe.

‘You’ll have to tell her I’m the kids’ auntie or something.’

Dixon nodded and took another long drink of whisky.

As the two of them returned to their places in front of the roaring fire, he said, ‘Look, I know I’ve got it wrong... with Jenni... with the whole work-life balance thing. I accept that. I thought about marriage counseling — but I didn’t want to tell Jenni we needed help like that. I didn’t want it to seem like I was placing any blame on her.’

Phoebe grinned. ‘Funny, she said just about the same thing about marriage counseling when we talked about it.’

Then Jenni’s friend added dryly, ‘Of course she was totally wrong. It was your fault. *All* your fault.’

Dixon sighed. ‘I found out about this new program in the city. Marriage 2.0. It said it could ‘upgrade’ people’s relationships. I thought I might go in there, and they’d fix things. Without dragging Jenni through some counseling thing.’

‘Wow. Okay.’

‘I don’t know... these guys examine you. Test you. Figure out all your secret desires, I guess. Stuff maybe even you didn’t know about yourself. Then they’re supposed to organize... some kind of *experience*... to bring you and your partner closer together.’

‘And *they* sent her the envelope?’ Phoebe asked him.

‘They had me give it to her. But I wasn’t supposed to find out what was in it.’

Phoebe’s jaw dropped at that.

‘And inside was a fancy invitation to join Ashley Madison?’

‘Uh-huh.’

She raised an eyebrow. ‘So they tested you and figured out your secret desire was for your wife to *cheat* on you?’

He said dryly, ‘I guess if she started sleeping with someone else, at least *she* would have her passion rekindled...’

Phoebe directed her glass toward him as though raising a toast. 'But they told *you* to tell her *you wanted to know all about it*,' she said.

He was a little taken aback that she knew this detail.

She smiled. 'You know she tells me everything?'

He gave a sheepish shrug. 'So... okay, I did what they told me to.'

'They figure you're into *cuckolding*, then?'

'*What?*' he felt stupid, not really knowing what the word meant. He'd seen it before, maybe. He'd never known what it was.

Phoebe smiled, 'Jenni and I did some research on Google. You know, she called me over virtually the moment she opened that envelope, she was so confused about why you'd given that to her. She knew you wouldn't give something like that to her for *malicious* reasons. You weren't trying to *trick* her.'

'No, I'd never — '

Phoebe smiled again. 'I thought she was being naive, you know? You were trying to entrap her, get out of a huge divorce settlement...'

'*Never* — '

She nodded. 'But why would you want her to tell you what happened on her dates if you were just trying to set her up, to persuade a judge she'd been cheating on you?'

'Exactly,' Dixon agreed. 'I wouldn't need to know about it if I was trying to trap her.'

'That's what we figured.'

'You guys figure anything else?'

Phoebe shrugged. 'Two logical reasons why you would want Jenni to have an affair.'

'Which are?'

'One: you can't physically have sex with her anymore yourself, maybe on medical grounds... And you want to make her happy, even though you can't *perform*.'

Dixon gently shook his head. 'But if I couldn't have sex with her myself, and I wanted some other guy to do it... why would I want her to tell me all about it afterward?'

Phoebe's eyes flashed as though he had just confirmed something. 'Which leaves us with the second possible reason.'

'Which is?'

'That it turns you on to think of your wife sleeping with another guy.'

Dixon felt breathless with shock.

He could only stammer, '*What* — ?'

Phoebe finished her drink and said, 'It's the *only* other logical explanation.'

'But... I...'

She smiled. 'You know, there's a lot of guys out there who fantasize about their wife sleeping with other guys? It's really common. Apparently, it's, like, one of the top search terms on porn websites these days.'

Dixon felt nauseated. His skin crawled with a burning sense of injustice. Phoebe and Jenni had gotten the wrong end of the stick. He didn't get off on the thought of his wife cheating on him...

'I'm not a *cuckold*,' he insisted.

'Well, *no*,' Phoebe said, getting up from her chair, wandering over to the little bar to fix herself another G&T. Then she said, 'Guys who are into... *sharing* their wives... well, they don't necessarily think of themselves as *cuckolds* if they're the ones persuading their wives to sleep around.'

'I don't understand.'

'The ones who call themselves 'cuckolds' tend to be guys who enjoy their wives actually *cheating* on them — you know, the humiliation of it. They might even want their wives to know they like her cheating, and for their wives to tease them about it... belittle them and everything...'

'But I'm not — '

'Well, *sure*,' Phoebe smiled and sipped her fresh drink to check its quality. 'You were the one who gave Jenni the Ashley Madison membership. *You* asked her...'

'I *didn't*...'

'Well, she doesn't know that.' Phoebe sat back down in her armchair, carefully clutching her drink. 'She thought it was so sweet you'd been hiding this secret fantasy all these years... and now you finally pluck up the courage to share it with her on your anniversary...'

'It was those guys at Marriage 2.0...'

Phoebe laughed, 'You said they work out what your secret fantasy is, right? *Stuff maybe even you didn't know about yourself?* Are you sure it doesn't... turn you on even a little? The thought of Jenni being *naughty* with some other guy?'

Dixon was about to flat-out deny it, but he suddenly realized he was sitting in that armchair with a monumental erection.

Phoebe chuckled at his hesitation. 'You know it's nothing to be ashamed of?' she said. 'What people do in the privacy of their own home...'

‘I don’t want my wife to *cheat* on me.’

‘Guys don’t consider it *cheating* if their wife shares all the details with them afterward.’

‘You seem to know a lot about this,’ he said flatly.

‘I told you: we did our research. You know, according to Cosmopolitan Magazine, it’s one of the top five male fantasies?’

Dixon was shaking again. He tensed the muscles in his jaw and said, ‘Yeah, well, it’s not one of *my* fantasies.’

He felt that he was being encouraged to come out of the closet, but he wasn’t sure if he was gay, straight, transgender, vegan, or just some confused, bleeding-heart liberal.

Was the alcohol making him feel this way? It did reduce your inhibitions, right? He was a *little* excited about the thought of Jenni having sex with another guy... but wasn’t that just the fact that he was thinking about sex in general, and he hadn’t had it in so long?

‘You want to call Jenni, tell her to come home?’ Phoebe suggested.

‘I don’t want to *embarrass* her...’

His damn erection wouldn’t go down. He tried to come up with the worst thing he could think of — the terrifying idea that Jenni was on a first date with another guy, hoping it would turn into a second date, presumably, and then a third. And then sex?

And his erection still wasn’t going away.

If anything, he was getting more turned on.

It’s just because you’re thinking of Jenni having sex, he told himself. Jenni taking off her clothes. Jenni looking sexy as hell, inviting a guy to take her.

Phoebe’s voice snapped him out of his thoughts. She said, ‘This is them?’

She held up her phone to him, and on the screen, he could see the Marriage 2.0 website.

‘Yeah, that’s them,’ he confirmed.

He said nothing as she gazed at her phone, examining the website. Gave her the space to see what it was he’d gotten them involved in.

He glanced at his watch, trying to determine how long Jenni had been out on her first date. She’d be back soon, wouldn’t she? She’d be back, saying the guy turned out to be a disappointment. That she was having second thoughts about the whole Ashley Madison thing...

Phoebe said, ‘It says here that the number one piece of advice for someone having doubts about their Marriage 2.0 adventure is to trust in Marriage 2.0.’

‘Well, of course they do,’ he sighed.

He felt a sudden burst of shame that he’d been persuaded to give them \$100,000. He wasn’t going to tell Phoebe that.

She read from the website: ‘The process is based on extensive, intricate tests of your personal feelings, responses and desires, even some of which you may not have known you had.’

Dixon merely shook his head at that.

Phoebe looked sympathetically at him. ‘Maybe you just have to wait it out a while. Figure out how you really feel about it after you’ve had time to think about it.’

‘Easy for you to say. Jenni’s already on her first date. How long before she’s on her *second*?’

‘Okay, okay, but you know for sure she’s not going to do anything drastic *tonight*...’

‘But if she comes home, and she’s had a great time, and she has all her hopes up... and in a couple of days she’s planning on going out with the guy again... and I turn around and say ‘no’...’

Phoebe sighed. ‘She would have to *understand*... that maybe you could get cold feet...’

‘To say that I have ‘cold feet’ suggests I’ve changed my mind,’ Dixon said, slightly annoyed. ‘Whereas, really, I wasn’t in support of this in the first place, because I didn’t know it was happening...’

‘She could come back from her date, figure the guy’s not her type...’

‘I’d *hope* so...’

Phoebe cast him a wicked grin. ‘Or she could come home so hot for the idea that you’d want her to sleep with that guy... she just wants to drag you to the bedroom and *fuck the living shit out of you*.’

Dixon felt his hard-on throbbing at that, and it made him feel distinctly confused.

‘Shut *up*,’ he said.

Phoebe imitated the sound of a mattress creaking rhythmically as two people presumably had sex on it. Then offered him a semi-apologetic smile that also expressed the hope that she was at least amusing him.

He glanced away toward the front door, but only felt his fear building again, from the fact that Jenni wasn’t home yet.

Phoebe said, ‘Hey, you know which restaurant he’s taking her to? Le Fat Poodle. You know, the French restaurant?’

‘She loves that place,’ Dixon sighed.

Jesus. He could picture Jenni sitting there laughing, smiling as she took a bite of grilled asparagus.

‘Romantic, huh?’ Phoebe teased, before realizing that teasing him about his wife being out on a date might not be a good idea just now.

After he said nothing, she said, ‘Look, maybe I could go over there... subtly talk to her... in the bathroom or something. You know, tell her you’re not feeling so good about her being out on a date after all.’

He felt a strange little throb in his hard-on when she uttered the word ‘date’, and the nervous butterflies fluttered in his stomach. It was an odd mixture of feelings.

Almost enjoyable.

‘No,’ he said, ‘I don’t think we should... I mean, there’s no point in ruining her dinner.’

How weird it was that the thought that he might be embarrassed by having to have Phoebe go in there and pull Jenni away for him. Telling her he was changing his mind, or some such little white lie?

Weird that he would prefer to let them finish their date than humiliate himself by begging Jenni to come home early?

But humiliation could be a powerful motivator. A lot of people were more afraid of public speaking than death.

Phoebe nodded, not quite knowing what to suggest.

‘We could... go up there... and, you know... check on her,’ he said. ‘You know, make sure she’s safe.’

‘She said she’d text me, or call me, if she was in any trouble,’ the brunette said instantly, reassuring him. But then she gave him a brief, silent Oh-face, realizing that perhaps this wasn’t about making sure she was *safe*. She changed her tone, saying suddenly, ‘We could go take a look. Make sure she’s safe.’

Dixon felt himself blushing again. Did she think him ridiculous? Because he was getting confused about how he felt about his wife being out on a date?

Maybe he wanted to just go over there and catch a glimpse, from afar, of Jenni enjoying a meal with a man he’d never met. To see how she was responding to it. To him.

Maybe to see if the guy was good-looking.

Did Phoebe think him pathetic because he was curious to test exactly how he felt *seeing* Jenni on a date?

To see if Marriage 2.0 had it right.

‘Come on,’ the brunette said, coaxing him, cajoling him, drawing him up onto his feet. ‘We can take my car.’

She was too excited by this.

And so was he.

Frank Dixon had to apologize to Ophelia, and ask if she wouldn't mind just keeping an eye on the children while he dashed out to help 'Auntie Phoebe' sort out something to do with her car.

He didn't like the somewhat suspicious look she gave him, but that couldn't be helped for now.

Then he and Phoebe were clambering into her silver Mercedes convertible and driving to downtown Old Greenwich.

They pulled up quietly, opposite the restaurant on Arcadia Road.

The brick building looked faintly as though it ought to be a bank, perhaps the kind of bank that Bonnie and Clyde might rob if this was the Midwest, except that there were potted palm trees outside the front door and a large French flag hanging over the entrance.

There was a seating area outside the restaurant, with the tables visible from the road. Phoebe leaned over to open the glove box, from which she retrieved a compact but apparently powerful pair of binoculars.

'What?' she grinned sheepishly, handing them to him. 'Lenny goes birdwatching sometimes. Don't *ask*.'

'I'm not saying anything,' he said, taking the binoculars and peering toward the restaurant. He fiddled with the settings a little and managed to get them in focus.

Then he caught his breath.

There was Jenni, unmistakable in that bright, turquoise dress, her long, sandy hair seeming to shimmer in the candlelight. He felt his stomach churn to catch sight of her, sitting there so full of smiles, holding her fork as she talked animatedly to a dark-haired man who made Dixon shiver, he was so classically good-looking.

Jesus.

She looked so happy, so excited. So damn hot.

Did she really meet that guy on Ashley Madison? Were they really there at the restaurant together under the pretext that they would start an affair if they got on well?

Dixon took a deep breath, feeling his heart fluttering, his stomach quietly turning over, the butterflies stirred up.

He felt oddly giddy. Fearful, sure, but also strangely excited. Was it just because of how Jenni seemed to be? He *did* like that Jenni seemed so cheerful, so fired up.

Was that so wrong for a husband to feel about his wife?

Was it wrong to enjoy this just a little?

But the feelings he was experiencing as he watched her so obviously flirting with another man were just too intense. He was shaking as he watched her through those binoculars.

‘There are really guys who would *choose* this?’ he said.

Phoebe hesitated a moment as though surprised at his question.

Surprised that he wasn’t simply straight-out furious to see Jenni having a good time on a date with another man.

Then she said, ‘Sure. A lot of guys.’

Reassuring him. Encouraging him.

She wanted him to be okay with Jenni dating this guy. Was that because it might give some tenuous justification to her own use of Ashley Madison behind her husband’s back? Or because she genuinely wanted her friend to have a good experience?

Dixon breathed and tried to keep calm.

He asked Phoebe, ‘But why would a guy want his wife to sleep with someone else?’

Phoebe said, ‘There’s a few theories out there, actually.’

‘A *few*?’

She chuckled. ‘There are psychology papers about this stuff.’

‘Okay...’

‘Some guys find it exciting to give their wives the thrill of a new sexual relationship, even if it’s with someone else. They just *enjoy* her happiness.’

Dixon was silent. Thinking, *okay, I can understand guys wanting their wives to be happy...*

‘There’s the obvious sexual motivation — if his wife comes back all horny from fucking some other guy, the husband gets to enjoy her being all worked up and craving sex.’

Strangely enough, Dixon felt a little tickle of arousal at that thought. Was he going crazy?

Jenni had seemed so chirpy and excited since he'd given her that damn envelope. It *was* nice that she was being that way. Wearing makeup. Making herself look nice.

Masturbating in secret as she thought about the possibilities of dating other men.

Phoebe cut into his thoughts, saying, 'Some guys are just voyeurs, right? They get off on watching people having sex. And if one of those people is their wife, who they love... well, that's even better, right?'

She gave him a knowing look that made him feel the warmth of shame flushing his cheeks. *She couldn't know about him watching Jenni on the hotel TV, could she?*

She couldn't know *he* was a voyeur, could she?

'It's only sex, right?' she said, 'this isn't about their wives *falling in love* with other guys.'

He breathed. 'It isn't?'

He put the binoculars down for a moment. Phoebe said earnestly, 'You know she loves you, don't you? She's excited about this whole thing — but she's only doing it because she thinks you really want her to.'

Dixon's heart was thumping so hard, he could feel his whole chest move with the beat.

It's only sex, right?

Why was it suddenly so thrilling, thinking about Jenni being with another man? Jenni touching someone else, kissing him, *going down on him*. Letting him *fuck* her.

Dixon shifted in his seat. He was getting hard again. Seriously hard. How weird was that?

Thinking about Jenni coming back from a date with someone else. Jenni, all rosy-cheeked with her hair mussed up, makeup smudged, dazzling smile stretched across her pretty face.

Jenni glowing with sexual satisfaction.

'I'm not a cuckold,' he said quietly.

'No,' Phoebe agreed, and it was oddly reassuring. 'But maybe you like the idea of Jenni being a hotwife.'

'A 'hotwife'?'

'A wife who is *allowed* to sleep with other men, not just her husband.'

Dixon shivered — but his hard-on throbbed.

Why did it feel arousing to think of *allowing* Jenni to sleep with other men?

‘Can I?’ Phoebe asked, holding her hand out to request the binoculars.

‘Sure,’ he said, unhooking the strap from around his neck.

It was a small car, and when she leaned over again to peer out of the window with the binoculars, he felt Phoebe’s elbow brush lightly against the erection pushing up against his pants.

‘*Woah, there*, buddy,’ she said, jumping a little as she realized what she had accidentally touched. She sat up. ‘Is there a gun in your pocket? Or are you pleased to see... *her*...?’

He was somewhat horrified at her discovery. ‘It’s just... I’m just...’

But she wasn’t laughing at him. That made him feel a little less humiliated. She said, ‘You know, there’s *another* theory about why guys...’ she nearly added ‘like you’, but then censored herself, ‘...might be turned on by the thought of their wives being unfaithful.’

‘What’s that?’

‘It’s called sperm competition. Deep down, men just react to the sight of other guys fucking their woman by getting hard — so they can move straight in on her afterward, and... you know... *dislodge* the other guy’s sperm.’

‘Seriously?’

‘It’s just instinct. Your body gets itself ready, so it can immediately perform. And to you... uh... *to some guys*... it feels like they’re turned on by the act of their woman being unfaithful.’

‘That’s quite a theory.’

Phoebe handed back the binoculars.

‘He’s a good-looking guy,’ she said. ‘She seems to like him...’

She wasn’t teasing him; that was apparent. She was trying to work him out, untangle his feelings about all this.

Dixon picked up the binoculars again and gazed over at Jenni. She was laughing again. Had he seen her laugh quite that much with him? Ever? Well, not for a while. She was having such a good time, it made Dixon feel all warm inside. Happy *for* her.

Was his dick hard because his body was getting him ready to move in on her if she happened to mate with that dark-haired lothario sitting opposite her, chewing on steak frites?

‘You know,’ Phoebe said, ‘The human penis is even *shaped* to scrape out another guy’s...’

‘*Okay*,’ he interrupted her. ‘I am going to note that down under the “good to know” column...’

‘I’m just saying it isn’t your fault,’ Phoebe laughed. ‘It’s biology, right? Primal instinct. Your instinct is to get ready to reclaim your wife, so you’re *sexually aroused by her adultery...*’

Fuck.

And he *was* hard, watching Jenni laughing and smiling *and flirting* with another man. Toying with her hair in front of him, tilting her head slightly while she listened to him, flashing her eyes at him to attract his attention. Would he really continue to be aroused if things went further?

What if he knew Jenni was taking her date to some hotel room somewhere to start an *actual* affair?

‘*It’s not your fault at all...*’

Phoebe was almost whispering it, as though trying to get through to him subliminally. Trying to hypnotize him into accepting his strange new feelings.

‘No, look...’ he said, panicking at the thought that he wanted his wife to sleep with other men. ‘... It’s *nothing* like that.’

‘So, what is it like?’

He paused. Thought. Scratched his head.

‘You know... when you’re afraid you’ve *lost* something, you want it more...’

Dixon sounded almost as though he was trying to persuade himself that it was true, more than simply explaining himself to Phoebe.

‘Of course, buddy,’ Phoebe said, nodded, smiling, her tone sounding as though she bought his explanation, but only just. ‘Like... absence makes the heart fonder, right? You don’t know you’ve got it until it’s gone.’

Dixon sighed. ‘I’ll admit, seeing her... with that other guy... makes me realize what I’ve got...’

‘Of course it does. So... d’you want me to go in there and get her? Tell her to come home?’

Another sigh.

‘I suppose... if you’re *certain* she’s not intending that this go anywhere tonight...’

‘That’s what she told me. She said she wanted to make sure you were definitely all right with all of this before she took the next step...’

‘So, then,’ he said, feeling slightly reassured.

There was another slight pause.

Then Phoebe said, ‘And you *are* definitely all right with all this, aren’t you?’

She was giving him another of those knowing looks.

He felt the panic rising inside him again. But also, he couldn't deny the sexual arousal.

Had Marriage 2.0 got it right? Was he turned on by the thought of *sharing* his wife?

He said, 'It'll be okay, right? I mean... she'll come home tonight and... well, *hopefully* she'll be in the mood for something...'

'And we know *you're* already in the mood for *something*,' Phoebe gave him a mischievous grin.

'And that will be that,' he said, feeling a certain easing of the jealousy that had been burning a hole in his stomach. 'I mean... that might even be what my whole adventure was supposed to achieve, right?'

'Of *course*,' the brunette giggled.

'She goes out on one date and reminds us both how we feel about each other.'

'Trust in the service, right? Trust in Marriage 2.0...'

'Exactly.'

'And when things settle down again for you two,' Phoebe said, her words startling to Dixon. 'You'll let her go on another date?'

He stared at her.

But he knew she was right. Things would probably return to normal for them, wouldn't they? And then what? Would he let her go on another date to get the juices flowing again? And if he did that, would she feel she had the green light to take things with her date further than just dinner?

Why was he so curious to know how it felt for his wife to actually sleep with another man?

He sighed again, for the umpteenth time.

'Come on,' he said. 'Take me back. I don't need to see any more.'

On the way back, he felt a little better.

He was still nervous that Jenni was on a date with some other guy. He was still massively weirded out by his own sexual arousal, thinking about the possibility of her sleeping with another man.

But the pure terror he'd felt on discovering that he had gifted her a membership to Ashley Madison and merrily encouraged her to start dating other people — that had simmered down a little.

She wasn't intending on doing anything tonight — Phoebe had assured him.

They'd be able to talk this out, wouldn't they? When she got back? Perhaps they'd be able to ask Marriage 2.0 for help.

Was there a way to stir these feelings of arousal without resorting to the whole *cuckolding* thing?

Thinking aloud, Dixon said, 'Can a person date... without ever intending on having sex?'

Phoebe, who was driving, slowed for a moment as they trundled along the lanes back to the Dixon house, so she could turn her head to look at him.

'Plenty of people date without intending on having sex,' she said. Then she added, 'Of course, that's usually because they need more time with a person to build up to a full relationship in which they would likely start *having* sex...'

'But there are people who don't believe in sex before marriage...'

Phoebe shook her head. 'When they date, it's usually to find the right person to *marry*.'

'But they might not be ready to marry. They might feel they're too young... not in the right place in their career... but they could still want to *date*, right?'

Phoebe nodded slowly and offered him a smile that was almost pitying.

'You want her to date other guys... but not sleep with them?'

It sounded stupid coming from her mouth.

His tone implied that he agreed with her that it probably wouldn't work: 'She just looked so *happy* having dinner with that guy...'

'She *did*...'

The way her eyes seemed to be all lit up with excitement... but now that Dixon thought about it, it was likely that Jenni had been excited by the prospect of sleeping with the guy.

If he told her she could date other guys, but not sleep with them, would that be as thrilling for her? Probably not.

Phoebe said, 'You know plenty of guys only fantasize about their wife sleeping with other guys...?'

'They do?'

'Very common. I've read about some couples doing nothing more than talking about the fantasy during sex... maybe role-playing...'

'Hmm...'

It was a thought.

There was a long silence between them as Phoebe drove them in through the gates and slowly along the driveway to the main house.

Then Dixon asked her, 'So how long have *you* been using Ashley Madison?'

Phoebe shrugged. 'A few years. You know, ever since it was on the news for a while.'

That made him laugh. 'You heard they got hacked, and their customers' details were all leaked onto the Internet, and you *wanted to use it*?'

She smiled. 'That was the best advertising the site ever had, I'd bet. I never knew anything like that even existed. And then there it was, the answer to all my problems. Confidential, immediate, *sex on tap*.'

'Christ.'

'I signed up using fake details and a discreet payment service,' she said. 'The hack probably made me take more care to sign up without giving out any of my real details.'

'And then did it take a while before you first... you know... went on a date with somebody?'

'As soon as you sign up, you get a *flood* of messages. At least, as a woman you do. I'm guessing there are many more men on there, looking to cheat.'

'How long would you say... it takes to get into something... you know... *serious*?'

'You mean before sex happens?' Phoebe glanced at him and smiled as she gently brought the car to a halt in front of the house. 'I don't know. Could be a few days. Could be six months. Depends on the guys you find.'

'Okay.'

'You know, it's not about finding *The One*. Not with Ashley Madison. You're not trying to sift through the world's male population to find the most incredible person out there.'

'No.'

'You're just looking for someone to make you come.'

'Wow.' He felt cold again, embarrassed, frightened. He was trembling. And yet he was also rock hard again.

'At least I was.'

He thought about Jenni gazing at her tablet as he'd watched her from that hotel room in Seattle. Had she been looking at men on Ashley Madison? Checking out their profiles?

Had she been chatting with men on there?

Surely. He should have figured that out. But it was still a little surprising. He'd watched her touching herself while she did it.

'This isn't Match-dot-com we're talking about,' Phoebe said. 'It's not e-Harmony. People aren't trying to find someone to settle down with.'

'Right.'

'You know, some people go on there without even intending on meeting anyone else in person.'

'They do?'

She smiled. 'Maybe you'd be okay with Jenni talking to guys on Ashley Madison without meeting them... you know... a little online flirting... a little online sex...'

'Online sex?'

She laughed. 'Is it cheating if she never meets the guy? If she never touches the guy...?'

He opened the door.

Climbed out of the car.

'Frank?' Phoebe called out after him.

'Yeah?' he leaned back into the car to hear her out.

'You're going to be okay, you know that?' she said. He nodded again, but said nothing more than a brief word of thanks for her help. Then he was standing there in the cool night air, watching her drive away.

His anxiety returned in a big way once Phoebe was gone, and he was left to his own devices.

He went upstairs to let Ophelia know he was back home again, and that she no longer had to watch over the kids. The young nanny was lying on her bed listening to music through her headphones as he ducked his head into her room. When he relieved her of duty, she lifted up her headphones and said, 'Oh, yeah?' as though she'd forgotten she was ever asked to look after the twins.

Regardless, the twins were sleeping soundly.

Then he was on his own, watching TV, trying not to think about Jenni staying out late with her date.

What had Jenni been talking about with that guy over dinner? Were they drinking wine with their meal? Would the alcohol lower their inhibitions?

Would Jenni stick to her plan not to do anything *significant* on her first date with him?

Damn it — he couldn't stop the questions rattling around inside his head. And he couldn't make his erection subside. What would Jenni think if she came home and saw him like this?

She would imagine he was supportive of her dating other men.

And he wasn't. Was he?

Could Jenni be back from her date?

He wanted her to think he hadn't been completely freaked out about her actually going out on a date, that he had meant it all along, that it was all part of his plan. And that required him to be relaxed and calm when she returned home. He opted to hang out in the Family Room, slumped on the couch in front of Netflix — even tried a few different positions to determine which might make him appear the most relaxed, the most untroubled by everything that was going on.

Marriage 2.0 had other ideas, though.

About an hour after Phoebe left, Dixon's phone buzzed. On the screen, there was a notification message letting him know that the Marriage 2.0 app had been updated to offer him 'better access to your adventure'.

Puzzled, he opened up the app to find a 'What's New' page indicating with a small graphic that a new 'Watch now' option had been added to the app's main menu.

Sure enough, there it was at the bottom of the screen.

Dixon tapped it.

Most of the phone screen was now taken up by a black-and-white image that Dixon recognized as a view of the road just outside their front gates.

He saw one of the tree branches nearby wave in the breeze, proving that it was a video feed, not a still picture. There were small arrows on either side of the image. Dixon found that by pressing them, he could scroll through the other views available throughout the household — the camera views he had been able to watch on his TV in the hotel room in Seattle.

'Jesus,' he whispered as he scrolled through all of the cameras and returned to the view from the one above the front gates.

So presumably, Marriage 2.0 intended him to continue spying on his wife?

Did that mean the adventure *wouldn't* end tonight when Jenni got home from her first date?

Dixon caught his breath as he saw a black Lincoln now pull up in front of the gates.

He peered at his phone, at the image of the man Jenni had just taken out for a first date climbing out of the car to walk around and open the door for Jenni to get out.

And there she was, looking so beautiful, so smiley.

The two of them stood there by the car and just talked, smiling at each other, giving little nods now and then, gazing into each other's eyes.

What were they saying to each other?

It didn't look as though the date had gone badly. Not at all.

Dixon felt a can of jealousy open up in his stomach, the acid spilling over to singe his stomach walls.

There was too much smiling going on.

Then Dixon noticed a strange, serious expression suddenly come upon the two of them, and he openly groaned.

The man moved forward, brushing Jenni's fair hair back out of her face before grabbing the back of her head, tilting his own head, and moving in for a kiss.

Oh God, oh God.

Dixon felt his heart stop, his whole body freeze.

Jenni was just closing her eyes and letting the guy kiss her. Oh God, why wouldn't she push him back? Slap him around the face, *something*?

At last, they broke apart. Jenni looked surprised, but not in a bad way. Oh, God. The guy still had his hands cradling her head. He kissed her again. She still wasn't obviously objecting. Now she had her hand on his cheek, and *she was kissing him*. She was smiling as she kissed him — was that even possible? It seemed so tender, so affectionate, so sweet.

Dixon wasn't angry — how could he be when he had been the one, it had appeared, who had encouraged her to go on this date, to use Ashley Madison in the first place, *to have an affair*.

He wasn't angry, but he was feverish with terror, shaking with fear, rock hard with...

Well, that was only his body getting ready to prove his worth as her husband, right? Preparing itself to give her the best sex of her life. Marriage-saving sex.

I'm not a cuckold.

He was only hard because of that weird instinct thing Phoebe had mentioned. Because his body wanted him ready to immediately make love to his wife. To reclaim her. It just *felt* as though he was turned on by

the sight of this stranger kissing Jenni *because* he was erect watching the two of them together.

Any man would be this hard watching his wife enjoying an intimate embrace with another man. It was only natural. She had her arms around him, for God's sake.

Were they using tongues? *Oh, Jesus...*

Now they were parting, at last. A few nervous smiles for each other. Had they discussed the possibility of a second date?

Was Jenni thinking she might sleep with this guy?

Dixon felt his whole body throbbing now, centering around the pulsating hardness making the most almighty bulge in his pants. Jesus, he felt like he might come soon if he wasn't careful.

He looked back at the app on his phone, and the view out over the front gates was empty — Jenni had gone, and so had the car. He tried to keep calm and focus on breathing. He couldn't seem to do anything about this god-damn erection. He really didn't want her to come in here and find him with an erection. She might get the wrong idea about how he felt about her date.

But nothing was working. It was as though he'd consumed too many Viagra pills or something. He thought about chopped liver. Swimming in a sewer. That guy from *CSI: Miami*. Nothing was getting that thing to subside.

Then he heard the front door opening, and it was too late. All he could do was take up his relaxed position, keep breathing, and hope things in the pants department softened in time. There was the sound of her heels on the hard marble of the entrance hall. She was walking toward him, closer and closer.

At the last moment, he suddenly wondered about letting her 'catch' him watching porn or whatever was the closest to it available on Netflix. Anything to explain away his erection. But when he flicked through Netflix, his profile was full of financial documentaries and gangster movies. Hardly anything remotely like pornography.

'Hey,' Jenni said in a sing-song soprano that instantly suggested she'd had a few glasses of wine.

'Hey honey,' he said, trying to act uber-calm. 'You have a good time?'

'I *did*...'

He looked up to see her there, and his jaw nearly dropped to the floor. She looked stunning. Her dress was so tight, dropping down to

show plenty of thigh... wait, hadn't that gone down below her knees before? He stood up as she walked around the couch to him.

'The question *is*,' she said, 'did *you* have a good time?'

He didn't quite know what to say. It was an odd question to ask of a partner who had stayed home all night. Or, who had *in theory* stayed home all night instead of being the one going out on a date.

She pulled him against her, and he groaned as he felt her crush his hard cock — there was no way she wouldn't be able to feel it, considering how thin her dress was.

'Mmm...' she purred, leaning in to kiss him now, her body wiggling up against his erection. Her lips were sweet, soft, warm. He breathed in, trying to keep calm, and inhaled a blend of her perfume, the wine she'd drunk, and the unmistakable tang of cologne — the scent her date had been wearing.

That scent smelled all wrong on her. And yet it only seemed to turn him on more, made him desire her more. He told himself it was only his body getting ready to reclaim her, to show her who her true love was.

'Phoebe told me she dropped round to check up on you,' she said, making him wonder when the brunette had found time to call Jenni with an update after she'd left his company.

'Uh-huh.'

Jenni smiled and kissed him again before saying, 'She said the whole time you two talked about me being out on a date, you had the biggest erection.'

Dixon silently cursed Phoebe for purposefully making trouble for him.

'I just... you know... because you were talking to another guy about...'

'About having an affair?' she grinned.

Dixon felt his cock throb — and so, incidentally, did Jenni. He said, 'It's just because... you know... subconsciously my body wants to...'

‘Reclaim me?’

She pushed him back down onto the couch.

Staring up at her in that dress, she did look amazing. A goddess. True, he had needed a little prodding to really *notice* her again, but his arousal, now, had nothing to do with the fact she’d just had dinner with someone else. Did it?

‘So... you want to know how my date went?’ she asked him, her voice low, sultry. She seemed to think he was turned on by her dating another man. But Dixon felt a pressure not to tell her she was wrong. Because to tell her she was wrong might suggest... somehow... that he hadn’t meant to get her that gift — or, instead, that he didn’t personally choose that gift for her.

Never mind. The important thing now, he felt, was that if she was going to have this idea about him, that he make it clear he only wanted things to stay as a fantasy, not as a reality.

‘H-how did it go?’ he asked her, still trying to sound casual, relaxed.

She pushed up her dress even further on her thighs and climbed onto the couch, straddling his lap.

‘It went *very* well,’ she said, smiling so beautifully. She leaned down and kissed his mouth. There was that scent of another man again — subtle but unmistakable. It made him a little crazy. He kissed her back, his hands spreading over her shapely behind, then sweeping around to explore the topography of her trim body in that tight dress.

‘You want... to know... his name?’ she asked him in between more kisses.

‘Mmm-hmm,’ he moaned, feeling her grinding her body against his hardness.

‘Tom,’ she said. ‘He works on Madison Ave.’

‘Uh-huh.’

She sat up, a mischievous grin plastered across her pretty face. ‘He’s *very* good-looking,’ she said.

‘Married?’ Dixon managed to say, his throat dry and scratchy, almost as though he was trying to talk her out of a second date with Tom.

‘He is,’ she nodded. ‘But he’s been using Ashley Madison for a year-and-a-half already. It’s nothing to do with me.’

She slipped off his lap, and then she was kneeling on the floor in front of him, her hands spreading over his thighs.

‘Did you tell him... that you’re married?’ he asked her.

‘He knows I’m married,’ she said, stroking his bulge through his pants before fumbling to open his belt. ‘But we didn’t talk about much

more than that. He doesn't need to know anything about you. Or about us.'

Dixon felt a little shiver of fear at how current she made it sound, that he *doesn't need to know*. It made it sound like she believed a second date would happen. But she distracted him from that fear by pulling open his fly, dragging his pants down to his ankles. She stroked his hard cock through his underpants, grinning like a woman possessed, and then she was dragging the underpants down his legs, too, his bare cock bobbing free.

'What did you talk about with him?' he asked her, since it was a question that had been on his mind. As soon as he asked it, though, he regretted it. It sounded too much like what a cuckold might ask.

'What it's like to live in Old Greenwich,' she said. 'Where I went to college. *What turns me on.*'

She said it while stroking his thighs, and seemed to know that uttering that last bit would make him catch his breath, his cock bobbing up with his increased heart rate. She smiled and took hold of it in both hands, bringing it to her lips, licking it along the underside.

'And what does turn you on?' he asked.

She smiled. 'Well, I didn't tell him that *you* turn me on,' she said, gazing at his cock like it was a long-lost treasure she'd recently rediscovered. 'Or the fact that you want me to date other guys... and *tell you all about it...* and that is the biggest turn-on I've ever known...'

Well, how about that for pressure? Now he felt awful about telling her it could only ever be a fantasy.

She took him into her mouth, exploring the shape of his cock with her tongue, her lips.

Curious, he said, 'What did you tell *him* turns you on?'

She smiled broadly, even though her mouth was full. Withdrew his cock so she could speak. 'A big cock?' she said. 'And a man who knows how to use it?'

She bobbed up and down on his shaft, and he felt that strange element of pride, that he had this beautiful wife, and she'd flirted with another guy — a good-looking guy — even going as far as to tell him of her sexual preferences, but she had ultimately come home to Frank Dixon.

'You talked dirty with him?' he asked her.

'*Very* dirty,' she said, pulling off his cock, wrapping her hand around the tip and its upper third, squeezing it while she kissed her way down his shaft. 'I told him how much I like sucking cock,' she said.

Dixon moaned as she seemed to try to prove herself, squeezing and pumping his ridiculously hard shaft with both hands while she sucked on him.

‘And I said how much I love a good, *hard* fucking,’ she said, in almost a whisper.

She pushed herself up from the floor so that she could reach up to kiss him on the lips. He tasted his own cock on her lips, a light, subtle flavor. Would this be what it would be like kissing her after she’d slept with someone else? Why would he start thinking about that?

But naughty Jenni was awfully desirable. He couldn’t believe the dirty words coming out of her pretty mouth. And she’d said such things to a *stranger*?

‘What did he say to you?’ Dixon asked, feeling helpless against the urge to find out what had happened on her date.

‘That he wanted to suck on my tits,’ she said, smiling as she kissed him, one hand still gripping his cock, pumping him, while she kissed him with that dirty mouth. ‘That he wanted to *eat my pussy...*’

Dixon felt a slight shudder of what he believed was jealousy, but it only seemed to spice up his arousal at this stage. He urged Jenni up onto her feet, where he could more easily push up her dress to reveal the rest of her thighs and hips. The simple white panties that were apparently soaking already.

He peeled her panties down, and she did a little twirl as though to flaunt herself for him. He pulled her back toward him, his butt slipping off the edge of the sofa so that he slumped down to sit on the floor, and now he was pulling her back to him, only she was still facing away from him.

No matter. He was too hungry for her now. He urged her to bend a little, and parted her buttocks, and now he could push in there to run his tongue over her glistening pussy. She tasted divine, and she was unbelievably wet. She moaned as he jiggled his tongue against her slick groove, then leaned forward — making it easier for him to lick her pussy, and allowing her to take hold of his hard cock again while he did.

After a while, when it seemed to be too much for her, she pulled away. But then she turned slowly around, still holding up her dress, offering him a gorgeous view of her pussy, and the triangle of golden curls above it, before parting her thighs slightly and easing her sex back into place over his mouth.

‘You like that?’ she asked him, and he moaned in reply, nodding his head slightly, eager to let her know how much he was into it. ‘God, that

feels wonderful, my love.'

'Mmm...' he moaned, lapping at her deliciously tangy sex while inhaling the strong scent of her arousal.

She said, 'You think you'll still want to do this... when I start sleeping with other guys... and you know... I'm *going all the way*...'

What was she saying?

'Are you... going to see... Tom again?' he asked her, between kisses on her clit.

'Oh yes,' she said, holding his head with one affectionate hand, while she held up her dress with the other. Now she gently stirred her hips, pressed her pussy down against his mouth, and rubbed herself against him. He shivered a little as he ate her, his hard cock twitching at how certain she was about seeing her date again.

'You know... I've been talking to other guys too... on Ashley Madison...'

She moaned and tilted her head back for a moment or two, closing her eyes, but after a while looked down at her husband, tucking her hair behind an ear, out of her face, as she peered down at him.

'Phoebe says I should probably meet a few in person, and then decide which one I really want to... have an affair with...'

It was so strange that his wife openly talked about communicating with other men and arranging to have an affair. He knew it was that stupid thing Phoebe had described — sperm competition — making him hunger for her more and more as she spoke about other guys wanting her. About the possibility of sleeping with someone else. He somehow saw her as more valuable because she was getting attention from others. It was simply biology, he told himself. His body acting to protect its interests from outside threats by demonstrating his own sexual prowess by girding him up, ready to mate with her instead of the other men.

And mentally, of course, his poor brain registered the powerful new sexual desire as an erotic craving to see his wife sleeping with other men.

Jenni moaned again, her eyes closing, head tilting back as he feasted on her with new vigor, responding to his body's overwhelming desire to consume her, to have his way with her, to restart their sexual reawakening with a real bang. Soon, both her hands were gripping his head, and she was gyrating her hips over him, grazing her sex against his mouth. He let her take the lead, providing her his mouth, his tongue, for her to rub herself against. Snatching breaths where he could.

She came like that, judging by the uncontrolled shuddering of her body, pressing his head down against the edge of the couch as she did so,

letting out an anguished howl as she pressed her soaking pussy to his mouth, which she only just managed to stifle in time to prevent waking the entire house.

But after that, she grinned wickedly and suggested they should go upstairs to the privacy of their own bedroom. He nodded, and she led him up there, almost dragging him by the hand. As they passed the bottom of the stairs, he noticed a lone white earbud, one of those Apple headphones that doesn't have wires, lying forlorn on the bottom step. Ophelia's. Had she been standing there? Had she watched him with Jenni? But she was gone, now.

Jenni dragged him to the bedroom and then stripped off his remaining clothes.

'Look at you,' she breathed, kneeling down on the carpet before him, taking his stiff cock in her hands. 'You're so *hard*, sweetie. I *love* it...'

She took him in her mouth, squeezing the base of his shaft in her eager hands, and all he could do was moan. She took him in her mouth, and all he could think was that she wanted to do the same to her date, Tom. And maybe she would meet other men and want to do the same with them. Stretching her pretty lips around their big, hard cocks. Enveloping their throbbing dicks with her hot, wet, soft mouth, gazing up at them with those beautiful, blue eyes as she pleased them.

'You want me to see Tom again, don't you?' she said, and he could only moan, even if it meant she interpreted it as agreement.

'Did you enjoy thinking about me dating him tonight?' she said, her words making his manhood throb as she kissed it, licked it, and pumped it in her hands. 'Did you enjoy thinking about me flirting with him? Talking with him about having an affair?'

Damn that sperm competition. She'd done research on it. She and Phoebe had. She knew exactly what kind of things to say to him to stir up this response. It was only natural, Phoebe had said, hadn't she?

He wasn't a cuckold.

Jenni was just making him respond as though he was a cuckold.

'You know, we talked about meeting in the city the next time,' she said, pausing to suck on him some more before continuing, 'I'd meet him after work, have a few drinks with him... he said we could go to a hotel...'

'Oh, God...' Dixon managed to groan, horrified yet still so stupidly aroused by her words.

But she smiled and took his reaction to be positive, to be approval, to be his uncontrolled sexual desire.

Well, it was sexual desire, and it was currently uncontrolled. She stood up, peeled off her dress and then her little white panties, and sat on the edge of the bed, opening her legs wide to invite him to her.

‘I told him we have an apartment in the city,’ she said, but Dixon was too distracted by her naked body, by the apparent fact that she had gone out on a date with another man without wearing a bra. Had Tom seen her nipples pushing, stiff, against her dress while they had talked about what they liked to do in bed?

‘I thought maybe I could take him there after we’d had a few drinks, don’t you think, sweetie?’ she said, but he was too focused on stroking his cock up against her wide open sex, feeling the brush of her soft, golden pubic hair against his sensitive glans, then the heat and the slick wetness of her pussy lips.

‘You think it would be all right to take Tom to our apartment?’ she asked him. ‘You know... get a little better acquainted with him...’

Dixon groaned as he pressed his hardness against her pussy. She looked so incredible, the fire in her eyes, the lust brightening her pretty face. Was she thinking about taking her date to the apartment on Dutch Street? Sneaking in the back way, perhaps, to avoid the concierge seeing her taking a strange man up to their plush little pied-à-terre.

Was she thinking about him placing his big, hard dick up against her eager pussy? Or was she responding, now, to her husband?

Dixon felt the burn of jealousy in his chest again — and yet, somehow, it only spurred on his own lust for his gorgeous wife. That whole competition thing again. It made him want her so badly. It made him so desperate to fuck her that all other considerations fell by the wayside.

So she said, ‘I could let him fuck me all night... and then come home to you, my darling.’

And all he could do was grunt and thrust his throbbing cock deep inside her hot, dripping wet pussy, filling her with a single powerful thrust. She was so very wet from all this talk of sleeping with another man.

‘Oh Frank... fuck me, Frank... fuck me...’ she moaned, though he didn’t need any encouragement. The mere thought of her lying like this, on the bed in their apartment on Dutch Street, letting a dark-haired stranger fuck her just like this... It made Dixon want to fuck her for all he was worth, with every ounce of his remaining energy — to show her how superior he was. To let her know, before she went off looking for comparison with other men, that he was worth coming back to afterward.

Sure, he also found himself wondering what Tom, or whoever she decided on, would think as he was squeezing his fat cock inside Jenni. Would he be as impressed with her trim figure as he was? Admiring the lines of her legs, the flatness of her stomach, the firmness of her thighs as he fucked her, delighting in the shape of her pert breasts, the hardness of her pink nipples, all that golden hair splashing down over her shoulders.

Would Tom wish he could have her all to himself?

And yet she belonged to Frank Dixon, unswervingly.

Dixon fucked her now and thought how wickedly intriguing it would be for Jenni to take a lover. They were no longer a dull, conventional married couple. She was going to take a lover. She was so hot, so sexy, she would sneak away to their Downtown apartment and embark on an affair. She would take one cock inside her and then drive home to her waiting husband for another.

How would it really be to welcome her home after she'd come straight from sleeping with another man? Would she still look all flushed, like she was now?

Would her pussy be soaking wet already, like it was now?

Dixon pulled out from his wife and ducked down to cover her open pussy with his mouth, tasting her pussy again, enjoying her flavor, but this time imagining how it might be to do this after another man had fucked her. Would he be able to tell? Would he detect the characteristic smell of the condom they used? The scent of the man's cologne lingering on her body?

He was so fired up that he pulled on his own cock while he lapped at her pussy again. Was he really going to let Jenni see Tom again? Would he really allow them to go on a hot date in the city and sneak off to the apartment for some red-hot, illicit sex?

Would he really let this go beyond the fantasy, as far as actual, unabashed adultery by his wife?

'Oh, sweetie...' Jenni moaned, tousling his hair as he sucked on her clit and thrust his fingers into her pussy. 'You know Tom has a big cock, too?'

He stood up again and plunged his hardness back inside her, making her whole body shake with the force of his thrust. She smiled wickedly, like some dangerous nymph trying to steal his soul.

'You know when he dropped me off tonight? He kissed me.'

He groaned. She took encouragement from it.

'He did. He kissed me, long... and hard... and I liked it.'

She pulled him up onto the bed, and he wordlessly complied with her demands. He lay on his back, and she straddled him, sliding his big cock inside her again as she sat astride him, so he could gaze upon her exquisite body and reach up to cup her jiggling breasts.

‘You know...’ she said, bouncing on him, ‘...when he kissed me... he pressed himself against me... and I could *feel* how big his cock is...?’

Oh, Jesus. His poor, simple brain might be all confused by this sperm competition thing, but he couldn’t deny how hot it was to hear her talk like this. To see her being so sexual, so fired up, so excited by sex and the prospect of more sex in the future. Even if it took another man to get her like this. Perhaps *because* it took another man to get her like this.

Jesus. Sweet, pretty, quiet Jenni was riding him hard, squeezing his big dick inside her tight, ravenous pussy, shaking her hips as she rode him. Her pretty face filled with light and utter joy as he satisfied her like never before. And she was talking about Tom fucking her like this, about riding Tom like this, about stretching herself with his huge cock before coming home to tell her husband all about it.

What had Phoebe said?

It isn’t your fault. It’s biology, right? Instinct.

What else had she said?

You know it’s really nothing to be ashamed of.

And.

I mean, it’s only sex, right?

Dixon was staring up at Jenni, and imagining that he was somebody else, that she was riding a new lover, a stranger, a dark-haired man called Tom. Would she look like this? Would she look as excited, as joyous as this? He had to believe so. But she would come back to him, wouldn’t she? Because what could Tom offer her that she wasn’t already getting from her husband? How could Tom possibly compete in what Frank was giving her? The lifestyle, the children, the stability, the love?

Tom wasn’t in it to steal her from him. Tom was already married. Tom didn’t want anyone to even know he was seeing Jenni.

Tom was no threat. None of them were.

Jenni could see whoever she liked and then come back to her husband to share the details while she fucked him, too. Where was the harm in that?

No one else needed to know.

Dixon manhandled his wife, lifting her, rolling her over. She went only too willing onto the mattress, onto her front, raising up her shapely derriere to tempt him again.

He said, 'You can't wait to fuck him, can you?'

And he was smiling.

And she was smiling, ear-to-ear.

One more time, he shoved his face between her thighs and drew his tongue along her glistening, slippery groove, saturating his senses with her flavor. Then he was up on his knees, thrusting his cock back inside her, this time from behind, mating with her like a beast, the alpha of the pack reclaiming what was rightfully his.

'Oh yes...' she moaned.

And he said, 'I bet he can't wait to fuck you, too.'

'Oh yes... oh yes... I'm gonna let him... fuck me... honey...'

Dixon heard himself saying, 'You're going to fuck him... and then you're going to come straight back to me afterward, right?'

'Oh yes, honey... oh yes... and then... you'll fuck me so hard...'

And just like that, to hell with it, he thought, I'm a cuckold. I'm a god damn cuckold. But who the hell needs to know?

Just me and my sweet, sexy, unfaithful wife.

He came inside her, and it was like the force of a thousand tons of TNT detonating between his loins.

Jesus.

And his last thought before collapsing next to her in a tired, unbelievably happy and satisfied heap, was:

They got it right, damn it. How the hell did they get it right?

Trust in Marriage 2.0...

He came home from dropping the twins off at yet another birthday party one Saturday afternoon to find that Jenni had company. Male company.

They were in the kitchen, and one of the first things Frank Dixon heard, along with their voices, was the click-click-click of an expensive-sounding camera. He'd been planning on changing clothes and heading out to the boat — since Ophelia was due to collect the twins from the party when it was done in a few hours. But, naturally, he was curious about Jenni.

When he entered the kitchen, he found Jenni wearing a very businesslike white, short-sleeved, button-down shirt, along with a charcoal-gray skirt that dropped to her knees, dark nylon hose, and chic black leather shoes. She was standing somewhat stiffly by the stove, holding a brochure of some kind, and some sort of leather-bound folder, while a casually-dressed dark-haired man was taking pictures of her using a professional-looking Nikon camera.

'Oh, hey, honey!' she chirped, smiling as he walked in.

'Hey,' he said, his tone distinctly questioning.

'Oh, this is Jeff. He's getting some shots for my new website,' Jenni explained. Jeff flashed Frank a courteous grin and briefly held up a hand in greeting.

'How you doing?' Dixon gave the photographer a welcoming nod.

'Good, good,' Jeff said. 'The camera *loves* her, man.'

Jenni turned around, and the photographer continued to fire off shot after shot, murmuring at her while he did so, 'This is good... yeah, just like that. Turn a little more... great, great...'

Dixon stood back, quietly amused but concealing his emotions for fear that Jenni would be in any way discouraged. Anyone could be a

professional photographer these days, right? The technology did it all for you. And with digital photography, you could get so many thousands of pictures during a photo shoot that a few of them would have to come out good, just by pure luck.

But it was great that Jenni was doing this. That she had taken his suggestion seriously and embraced the idea of launching her own realty business. It might not have been the Marriage 2.0 strategy for ‘upgrading’ their relationship, but working on the whole thing seemed to give Jenni a buzz, a glow, a golden self-confidence boost in a similar way that the Ashley Madison dating thing had done.

And all this was providing her some good distraction from the actual dating thing while Dixon got his head around it. And, perhaps, it might provide an alternative to the dating thing that would prove less complicated, with less potential for his public humiliation.

‘We’re having trouble getting shots that make it look like I’m in a normal house,’ Jenni laughed as Jeff guided her over toward the kitchen table for some more shots.

‘Normal house?’

She smiled. ‘I’m thinking that to start with, I might be working with clients who can’t exactly afford a Greenwich mansion.’

‘Oh, right.’

Jeff glanced around the kitchen, and there was a note of concern on his face. ‘What about the library?’ he suggested.

Jenni laughed. ‘You think most people have a library in their homes?’

The photographer smiled. ‘No, but we can make the pictures look as though you’re at work, and all the books will signify that you’re well-qualified and intelligent.’

‘Uh... she is well-qualified and intelligent,’ Dixon pointed out.

‘But this will suggest that to the website visitor before they’ve even had time to read her resume.’

Dixon casually followed them through to the library, watching as the photographer took some more pictures with Jenni standing in front of bookshelves, by the desk, and so on. He enjoyed how happy Jenni looked. She was getting on with this project — her project. It was empowering, and she was confident of achieving success.

‘Okay, this is more like it,’ the photographer said as he whirled around her trying to capture all the angles.

Strangely, Dixon found he enjoyed watching Jenni in this photoshoot for more than the reason that it showed she was getting on with her real estate business idea. Sitting in one of the armchairs by the fireplace, he

felt a familiar warm feeling blooming inside him, watching Jenni smiling at the camera and responding to the ongoing stream of comments from Jeff. God. He was getting aroused.

‘Oh, lovely, lovely... Just like that. These pictures are looking so good...’

It was all boosting her self-confidence, and she was so sexy when she was full of confidence. At the same time, the way she was posing in front of that camera — occasionally toying with her hair or fiddling with the buttons on her shirt, turning this way or that and arching her back to present the most elegant profile — it was like she was flirting with the photographer.

Dixon sighed quietly to himself. He couldn’t seem to get away from the bizarre fact that he responded sexually to the thought of other men paying attention to Jenni. Why couldn’t there be something else that made him respond as strongly to spice up their relationship?

Here, the photographer had her sitting in a chair by the bookshelves, making her look all bookish and erudite, to give clients confidence that she knew what she was doing in the real estate business. But all Frank could focus on was her skirt, as it rode up on her thighs whenever she crossed or uncrossed her legs while Jeff was kneeling in front of her. She was giving him a full view up there.

As his silky voice continued to purr, ‘Oh yes, very nice... beautiful... great, Jenni...’

Dixon felt his manhood thickening further.

He thought to himself, this isn’t part of the Marriage 2.0 adventure, is it? It’s nothing to do with any of that. So what did it matter if he enjoyed this whole photoshoot thing a little?

‘Honey? Honey? Are you okay?’ Jenni’s voice pulled him out of his daze.

‘Uh... yeah, yeah.’

‘You were miles away.’ She smiled. Then she added, ‘Jeff says he probably has enough now...’

Dixon felt an unexpectedly heavy sense of disappointment. The photoshoot was over.

‘Uh... yeah, we’ll have plenty to choose from,’ Jeff confirmed as he squatted over his bag to begin dismantling his enormous camera.

‘Can I see some of the shots you got?’ Dixon said, trying to keep the disappointment out of his voice. If only he’d gotten home earlier, if he’d driven more quickly, if he’d taken I-95 instead of the backroads, he would have caught more of the show.

‘Uh... sure,’ Jeff said, standing up to approach Dixon before handing him the main body of his camera, which no longer had any of the cumbersome lenses or flash attachments. ‘Here, just flick through the pictures with these buttons.’

Dixon flicked through the images of his wife on the 4-inch view screen. Every shot was perfectly professional and presentable. Jeff was, after all, a good photographer. But even though each image was clean and innocent, it was so hot seeing the sight of Jenni captured by this camera. The way she looked on screen... the way she looked at the photographer. It was flirtatious in many of the shots.

Frank Dixon was hard as a rock.

He said, ‘Can you take some more?’

Both Jenni and the photographer did something of a double-take at him.

‘Uh... *more?*’ Jeff said, glancing at Jenni as though for guidance.

Jenni looked at Dixon and raised a questioning eyebrow.

Dixon felt the flush of embarrassment flaring up all over his face, but at the same time, he’d said it now, he could hardly take it back, tell them he’d made a mistake, he’d said something he hadn’t meant. He had blurted out what he wanted, and now he had to own it.

‘Would you take some more pictures?’ he asked the photographer, handing the camera back. ‘But not for her website. For *me*.’

Jenni looked somewhat startled, and yet the corners of her mouth crept up into a smile that suggested she was at the very least flattered by her husband’s desire for more pictures.

‘Oh, like for the family album?’ Jeff inquired. ‘For Instagram? We could get some nice pictures outside...’

Dixon shook his head. ‘Not for the family. For *me*,’ he said. ‘For me, personally. *Privately*.’

‘Oh — ’ the photographer understood, and glanced at Jenni to see if she might be on board with such an answer. He said, ‘Sure... I mean... I do boudoir shoots sometimes...’

Jenni was silent, still a little shocked, and perhaps a little nervous, and yet there was more than a hint of excitement on her face.

‘I’ll double your fee,’ Dixon said.

‘Of *course*...’ Jeff was hurriedly fixing a lens to his camera, reassembling the flash.

‘Honey...’ Jenni said, at last breaking her silence to confirm her own surprise about this, and register her quiet excitement.

‘Where do you want to take this?’ the photographer asked.

Dixon said, 'Here is just fine.' He didn't want them all to relocate. He didn't want to make a big thing out of all this. He didn't want to lose the strange, thrilling tension in the air just now.

'What do you want me to do?' Jenni asked quietly, standing in front of him rather primly, all straight and proper, with her arms at her side, as though she was on military parade.

The photographer had just put in a new memory chip into his camera, and now he pointed it at Jenni and began taking fresh shots. Dixon felt his pulse quicken and his hardness throb.

'Why don't you unfasten a couple of buttons on that shirt,' he told Jenni, smiling at her with affection, hoping to reassure her.

She gave a pretty little half-smile that suggested she couldn't quite believe they were doing this, but that it was kind of exciting. Then, after a nervous pause, she did as her husband asked, slipping two of the buttons on her shirt free, to let it fall a little more open, exposing more of her skin.

'Very nice...' the photographer was murmuring again as he took more pictures.

'Pull your skirt up a little,' Dixon asked her. It seemed almost amusing that she did exactly as he asked, revealing more of her dark hose, which had a diamond criss-cross pattern that made her legs look stunning, but weren't quite as slutty as fishnets.

'A little more...'

She was almost showing her underwear. The tension in the air was palpable. This wasn't just a wealthy husband getting a professional photographer to take erotic pictures of his wife, and Jenni knew it. This was Frank Dixon showing off his wife to another man. This was almost Frank Dixon *sharing* his wife with another man. She raised her skirt a little more, and now she was flashing the photographer, exposing her elegant lace-trimmed black panties.

'Wow...' the photographer breathed as he took more pictures. 'So beautiful...'

Dixon smiled up at her, in love and in lust, impressed at her bravery, and so obsessed with her and the fact that there was another guy here while he asked her to do this.

'Turn,' he told her. And she did — revealing some of her shapely rear, covered by the sheer nylon of her pantyhose and also indicating that her panties were thongs.

Then she turned back to face her husband again. She did look a trifle awkward, not entirely natural, posing like this in front of a camera. But

this wasn't for display on a website. It wasn't even the most crucial thing for Dixon to have these pictures at all. It seemed that the experience of the photoshoot — of having Jeff here — had as much to do with the erotic nature of what was going on as the fact that they were creating erotic images.

'Take off the skirt, honey,' Dixon said.

There was a glint of surprise and excitement in her eyes as she registered what he was asking of her. And then she slipped her thumbs into the waistband of her skirt. She managed to turn while she pushed the skirt down off her hips, offering her husband and the photographer a view all the way around as she took off the garment.

Now there was more fire in her eyes. She was almost challenging her husband to go further.

'Pull your shirt up a little,' he said, and she did so, exposing her gym-toned stomach and navel.

'Very nice... very nice...' the photographer continued his murmuring while he took the pictures, though he seemed happy enough to defer to Dixon when it came to directing her.

'Unfasten the rest of the buttons,' Dixon told Jenni. His voice was getting croaky, his throat drying up.

Jenni crouched down as though she felt too conspicuous standing, but then she began unfastening the buttons on her shirt, slowly so that her shirt gradually opened more and more. She offered a little glimpse of her cleavage and black bra, which, like her panties, was fairly plain since she hadn't expected this kind of photoshoot, although its lacy trim gave it an elegant, feminine look.

Buttons unfastened, she slipped the shirt off one shoulder, teasing her husband and the camera with full sight of one of her breasts, albeit confined by her bra. And then, encouraged by her husband's eyes, she took the shirt off her other shoulder, offering full view of her chest. Jeff whirled around her like a satellite in orbit.

Jenni stood again, a slightly defiant expression on her face as she left the shirt on but entirely open at the front. She was complying with her husband's orders, but not removing the shirt entirely as he might have wanted.

Dixon let his eyes wander all over her graceful lines, her elegant curves, breathing deeply at the tension between him and Jenni while another man, a virtual stranger, examined her and recorded her with his camera.

Then he said, 'Lose the hose.'

She didn't hesitate, slipping her thumbs under the thin material of her hose at her hips — but then she peeled them down so incredibly slowly. Teasing her husband. Teasing the man her husband had asked to take more pictures of her. Was the photographer hard while he took these shots of her? She turned once again to tease the men by rolling the black nylon off her behind, exposing the narrow band of black that was her thong underwear?

She stepped out of her shoes, and then she was peeling her hose completely off her long, slender legs. And eventually, she was standing there in just bra and panties, her shirt still on but so open that it might as well have been off.

Dixon loved to look at her. He was a voyeur, there was no doubting that. And she seemed to be considerably fired up by this display of herself in front of the photographer. Could he and Jenni limit their marital adventure to simply her exhibitionism and his voyeurism? Without involving other men?

And yet having Jeff, the photographer, here seemed like much of the point.

'Take it off,' Dixon said, the frog in his throat making it difficult to speak.

He didn't think that she might interpret his words some other way than the removal of her shirt. But Jenni turned again, facing away from the two men, and facing away from her husband. She tucked her fingers in the waistband of her thong panties and slowly — oh, so slowly — began to ease the tiny scrap of material over her behind and down her thighs.

Dixon caught his breath in sheer shock as he watched her panties drop to her ankles — that his wife might stand so naked in front of another man.

'My *God...*' the photographer breathed, and Dixon could not believe the guy could be anything except hard while watching this. But what did he think of Dixon? What did the guy make of a man who would want his wife to strip off in front of him? It made Dixon feel uncomfortable, embarrassed even.

Jenni smirked, and as she turned toward them again, she grabbed hold of her black leather-bound folder from the mantelpiece beside her. Then she held the folder in front of her bare pussy, hiding the front view from her husband and the camera.

So sexy. But Dixon was hard, and he wanted nothing more than to jack off while the photographer took more filthy pictures of Jenni, but he

worried the guy would think he was *weird*.

‘Uh... that’s enough,’ Dixon said hastily, and to Jenni’s amusement, now he was standing up, grabbing the photographer’s camera bag and ushering the guy out of the library.

Jeff seemed very understanding.

‘Of course, of course, no problem, no problem...’ he said as he took control of his camera bag and hastily disassembled the camera again, while they were on the move through the entrance lobby of the house, approaching the front door.

‘How does this work?’ Dixon asked the man as they arrived at the front door. ‘You’ll send me the pictures by email?’

Jeff nodded. ‘I can, sir, of course. Or I can FedEx a memory stick — might be more convenient, you know? Email’s so hit-and-miss, especially with a lot of large files...’

‘Fine,’ Dixon said, feeling a little bad at practically shoving the guy out of the front door. ‘And of course, your fee will be doubled, as I said.’

‘Thank you *so much*, sir. Really — ’

‘Goodbye.’

‘Uh... right — ’

And then the front door was shut, and Dixon was alone in the house with his beautiful wife.

‘Are you okay, honey?’ she said, padding slowly across the lobby toward him, still wearing only her bra under the open white shirt — the rest of her so brazenly naked it made his mouth water.

‘Of course,’ he said, trying to act calm.

‘You’re not angry with me?’

‘Why would I be angry with you?’ he said as she approached, and suddenly grabbed her, pulled her to him, kissed her mouth hungrily, making her squeak in surprise and delight.

Her squeak soon turned into a low moan, however, as his mouth melted into hers, and he moved her back, pressing her up against the wall at the bottom of the staircase. She raised her knee, rubbing his leg with hers, and soon felt the hardness jutting out from between his legs.

‘You’re so hard...’ she whispered, her leg dropping back down so that her hand could find its way to his crotch.

‘You were so... hot...’ he murmured, groaning as her fingers closed around his erection, pinching it, squeezing it, exploring its sheer size.

‘I’ve been neglecting you, huh?’ she smiled as he kissed her neck, breathing in her sweet scent, the light notes of her perfume. ‘I suppose I

haven't had any more dates while I've been sorting out all this real estate stuff...'

Dixon groaned. That she would interpret his desire to have her photographed in a striptease as his need for her to get back into the dating game.

But he could hardly correct her. He could hardly tell her he still suspected it was all a mistake, that Marriage 2.0 had got it wrong. She didn't even know about Marriage 2.0.

He slipped her breasts out of her bra and began sucking on them, feeling an enormous sense of pride in her beauty and an enormous sense of superiority that the poor photographer had to go home and tend to his erection alone while Dixon had this gorgeous blonde wife to relieve his sexual tension.

'You know there are a couple of guys I've been talking to online who suggested a nice night out in the city...' Jenni purred, and Dixon nearly melted at the sheer eroticism of what she was suggesting.

He sank to his knees in front of her, his mouth still clamped to one of her breasts, and though he was still massively confused by his own sexuality — was he gay, or bisexual, perhaps, because he was sexually aroused by the thought of his wife dating other men? He was so turned on by Jenni, right now, right here, that the hard thinking could wait.

He swept his hands over her shapely figure as he sucked on her hard nipple, and finally brought one hand between her legs, where she was so wet already, her soft patch of golden pubic hair soaking.

'You're so *wet*...' he said, stroking her slippery folds with his middle finger, making her gasp.

'Well, I wasn't expecting you to test out... you know... how you feel about me being naked with another man... I mean, not just then...'

She stroked his hair affectionately as he sucked on her other breast. Then they were kissing again, mouth-to-mouth. Dixon felt that if they were to find something else to strengthen their relationship more than this bizarre adventure run by Marriage 2.0, it would have to be quite remarkable to reach this level.

What if he just stopped thinking about it so much? Let everything run its course. Let Jenni date other guys. Let her sleep with other guys. Nobody would have to find out. It would be hot, right?

Jenni said, 'You know, you could have let him stay longer.'

'Him?'

She grinned. 'The photographer. I could have taken off the rest of my clothes,' she said, pulling off her shirt and then reaching behind to

release herself from the bra. 'You think he'd have liked seeing me without that folder in the way?'

'Of course he would,' Dixon said, detecting the irresistible scent of her arousal in the air now, confirming how crazily turned on she was.

'I would have done anything you wanted, you know that?' she said softly as he kissed her neck, and her fingers teased the bulge in his pants.

'Anything?'

'You could have asked him to take the dirtiest pictures...'

He groaned, almost overcome with his lust for her.

'I could have done something naughty while he took pictures... touched myself or something...'

He was trembling with desire as he kissed his way down her body and now ran his face over the slight roughness of her pubic hair and eased it into place over her hot, wet pussy. Breathing in the strong scent of her arousal as her hand slid into place over his head, opening his mouth to taste her, making her catch her breath. Kissing her there, sucking on her there, lapping at her copious, tangy juices.

Imagining this gorgeous creature had stripped off for the photographer completely, flaunting herself in front of him on a bed, stroking herself, rubbing her pussy.

'Maybe he would have been so turned on, he'd have to take out his big cock...'

Dixon groaned at the image she inspired in his mind as Jenni now stood and took a couple of steps upward, before holding out her hand to urge him to follow her to the bedroom. She retrieved her hand when he reached for it, however, and then she was scampering up the staircase, completely naked, forcing him to give chase.

When they got into the bedroom, they were both already panting and breaking a sweat.

'Next time...' she said, climbing onto the bed and posing for him, as though the photographer was still here, except that this time there was nothing in the way of her gorgeous, exposed pussy. '...Next time... maybe *you* could take the pictures while he gets to fuck me?'

He could hardly believe that Jenni would say such a thing. Jenni, who had always been such a good girl. But he couldn't deny how much it turned him on, how hard it got him, how hungry it made him to bury his face in her soaking pussy one last time before pushing himself up to drive his granite-hard manhood deep inside her.

'Oh God...' she cried, and as he held her and thrust into her, he wondered what this would be like if the photographer were still present.

Could he get this hard with another guy in the room? Another guy with his cock out?

What if it was like the bathroom, where you just couldn't pee when there was another guy standing at the urinal next to you?

What if they progressed with this strange adventure, and Dixon couldn't perform?

It was embarrassing enough thinking of the way another guy might judge him for allowing his wife to do such a thing.

Then came the day when Dixon was heading down to attend a lunch meeting with a new client, and Gaines stepped into the elevator — accompanied by the attractive brunette intern, Samantha.

The young woman gave Dixon a polite nod-and-smile and then stood primly by Gaines's side as the elevator doors sealed them all in, as though she was now his personal property.

Gaines simply gave Dixon a huge shit-eating grin and said, 'Top of the morning to you, my friend,' as though he had an ounce of Irish in him.

It struck Dixon that he hadn't really spoken to his business partner since getting back from Seattle and all that business with Gilderoy-Suffolk. He'd assumed Gaines had been avoiding him ever since that deal had turned into such a mess.

'You're looking chirpy this morning,' Dixon said as the elevator started to descend.

He assumed, from the air of smugness that lingered about Gaines, that he had well and truly owned Samantha in bed by now. The guy probably still had the intern's lipstick smeared all over his dick. Dixon wondered how long it would be before he tired of her — and arrange for her law school to quietly transfer her to a school in Wyoming or Idaho or some such place.

But Gaines replied, 'We're off to Seattle. I do so love the Pacific Northwest.'

That took Dixon a little by surprise.

'Seattle?'

The coincidence that Gaines would be going to Seattle was too great.

Dixon said, 'Gilderoy-Suffolk?'

Gaines nodded. 'Gilderoy-Suffolk.'

‘I thought we got all that resolved. They cut 40,000 jobs, terminated the port project.’ Dixon felt a touch of nausea return to his stomach as he remembered what they’d done to that company to shape it up for sale. ‘You said we’d sell it.’

‘A sensible man knows to double-check everything,’ Gaines said. ‘That’s what I’ve been doing this morning.’

‘And?’

‘And, that development permit for the port project just came through.’

‘You’re kidding?’

‘I’m not, my friend.’

Dixon hated that Gaines had taken over the deal — but he didn’t miss the stress of that one. One thing everything with Jenni had taught him was that sometimes, the stress of work just wasn’t worth it. At the same time, he felt a little burst of pride deep inside — that his deal had, finally, come through.

As the elevator continued to descend toward street level, Gaines glanced at Dixon via the elevator’s mirrored wall and gave him a funny little flick of his eyes.

What?

Dixon’s forehead creased in mild confusion, but then Gaines made it more obvious, flicking his eyes upward, urging Dixon to look.

He was helpless against the forces of curiosity. He looked.

The ceiling was mirrored, like the walls. And looking upward, Dixon saw that he could gaze right down Samantha’s shirt. He glanced back at Gaines and gave him an eye-roll. If he didn’t know the man as well as he did, he might have been surprised at how juvenile, how sophomoric Gaines was to get him to look down the young woman’s shirt like that.

Gaines was shameless, of course — if anything, his grin widened at Dixon’s response.

Dixon glanced over at Samantha without the aid of the ceiling, hoping she hadn’t caught him looking up at the view down her shirt. But as he did so, he found the pert brunette looking back at him, catching his eye, and breaking into an undeniably flirtatious smile.

Dixon looked away again, feeling a hot jolt of shame and surprise in his chest. Was she still interested in seducing him? Even though she had already bagged Gaines?

The elevator stopped a few floors further down. When the doors opened, it was Samantha — and only Samantha — who wished them both a good rest-of-the-morning, and then walked briskly away.

‘Look at that,’ Gaines said, staring after her as she went. There could be no doubting what he was referring to: Samantha’s gray skirt seemed to reach only a few inches down her thighs. It was so tight around her posterior that it looked as though there were merely two peaches in there.

‘You’re a bad, bad man,’ Dixon said, and he wasn’t joking, although that was how Gaines took it.

‘You’re not tempted at all, buddy?’

Dixon turned to actually look at his business partner. Gaines looked serious.

‘Aren’t *you* — ?’ he asked, as the elevator doors finally closed.

Gaines laughed. ‘*No*... Might’ve made you think so... I mean, you know. Thought it might challenge you to reach out and *take her*... but I wouldn’t steal from you, buddy. You know that, right?’

As the elevator dropped again, Dixon felt genuinely surprised that Gaines had some small amount of principle under that perma-tan. But there had been a time when he had genuinely liked the guy. They had been best friends for so many years.

‘She’s not for me,’ he said firmly.

Gaines sighed. ‘Buddy... no one would *know*...’

Dixon felt the sudden need for a change of strategy with Gaines. He said, ‘You don’t understand how it is between Jenni and me... even after all this time...’

‘Seriously?’

Dixon nodded, smiled.

‘I mean, she’s a *fine*-looking woman...’ Gaines said, and in the mirrored wall, Dixon could almost have sworn he saw the guy blush. What was that about?

‘You have *no idea*,’ Dixon laughed. ‘I mean... last night... when I got home... she was wearing this *Wonder Woman* outfit...’

‘The original or the reboot?’

‘The *reboot*...’ Dixon felt the warm flush of victory inside — Gaines looked somewhat stunned. ‘And she’s not even a brunette...’

‘So you two still...’ Gaines was in shock. He couldn’t understand how a relationship — particularly a sexual one — with a woman could last much more than six months.

‘All the time,’ Dixon nodded. ‘I mean, she’s like some kind of *goddess* between the sheets...’

That silenced Gaines completely. The elevator opened, and Dixon stepped out into the building’s entrance lobby, and Gaines was left standing there, frozen to the spot, until the elevator doors closed on him

again. Dixon felt triumphant as he strode out to the street and climbed into the waiting limousine.

All through his lunch meeting, Dixon kept thinking about Gaines. So much so that a couple of times, he'd missed something the new client had said, and had had to ask for clarification.

Gaines had surprised him.

He'd misjudged the guy. Not only his assumption that Gaines would make a move on that pretty intern, but also the way he had dealt with the Gilderoy-Suffolk deal. After everything had happened, and they'd spent all that time with the board working on reshaping the deal, Dixon had thought they were out of Gilderoy-Suffolk for good.

Gaines had offered to take the deal off Dixon's hands to ensure the final arrangements were tied up. Dixon had decided it wasn't worth the stress of continuing — he had other priorities in his life now.

He would have assumed his business partner would have simply sold their position in the company, and recouped whatever funds were still available. But now Gaines was on his way to Seattle to discuss the next stage of the major port project, now that a critical permit had been awarded by the City.

He must have been following the project closely since taking it on.

It was surprisingly efficient of him.

And maybe Dixon had made wrong assumptions about him in recent years.

On his way back to the office after a decent enough lunch meeting, Dixon decided that he needed to start questioning some of his assumptions in life. It wasn't just in business. There was also his relationship with Jenni — he couldn't afford to get lazy and just lapse into easy assumptions.

A sensible man knows to double-check everything.

That was what Gaines had said.

It suddenly gave Dixon an idea.

'Villiers,' he said, leaning forward in the limousine. 'Can you take me back to that place on Lexington? Just down from Bloomingdale's?'

The salesperson on the shop floor couldn't quite understand what he wanted.

'You already started your Experience, Mr. Dixon,' he said, wiping a bead of nervous sweat from his forehead. 'Why have you come back?'

'I told you: I want you to give me a re-test.'

'A re-test?'

'I want you to double-check everything.'

There was a long wait while the salesperson fetched his manager. Then Dixon had to explain everything all over again to the manager.

'You know there's a helpline you can call if you're having difficulties with your adventure?' the manager said from behind a tablet.

'I don't need *help*, I need to double-check things,' Dixon insisted. 'I can't very well do that over the phone, can I? Your assessment equipment is here, right? Upstairs?'

'Uh... well... yes...'

Dixon sighed at their lack of comprehension. He didn't want to start mentioning how much he'd paid their company for the privilege of their unconventional marriage counseling service, but it was in the six figures.

Thankfully, however, just before he had to start pulling out his accounts, the store manager consulted with someone via her headset, and then a familiar face finally emerged: Patrick Clayton.

'Mr. Dixon,' he said, smiling ear-to-ear as though Dixon had returned to present him with a Nobel Prize, or whatever the equivalent was for relationship counseling.

'Mr. Clayton. I'm worried there's been some kind of mistake in the formulation of my Experience,' he said.

'And you want to double-check everything,' the Marriage 2.0 technician nodded, sounding as though Dixon's demand was both perfectly rational and surprisingly common, even if it was neither.

'I was... in a bad way when you tested me the other day,' he said. 'I'm concerned it may have... skewed the results.'

Clayton chuckled. 'I can fully understand your concern, Mr. Dixon. Our process does factor in influences like anxiety or depression... but there's no reason why we couldn't give things another little check... just to be on the safe side, right?'

Dixon felt enormous relief at being taken seriously.

There was no waiting this time. No sitting in the waiting area that looked like an airport terminal. No checking the screens to see which room he needed to go to when his appointment time was near.

Clayton led him through various hallways that seemed to be designated for staff or emergencies rather than clients. Then they went up in an elevator.

Eventually, they arrived in an assessment room similar to the one Dixon had visited before.

‘Please, do take a seat,’ Clayton said, indicating the assessment chair Dixon felt very familiar with.

An assistant came into the room and began setting up the equipment to measure Dixon’s brain responses. Once again, as the device was put into place over his head, Dixon got the sense that he was in a hair salon, about to have his hair washed and dried by this strange machine.

‘So, Mr. Dixon. Your Experience has already started — has there been any change in your relationship so far?’

Clayton was perched on a stool in front of a computer screen, tapping away at a control panel that wasn’t exactly a simple keyboard — it had various tracker balls and buttons, dials and switches on it along with a standard keyboard. It seemed to Dixon like the equipment the sonographer had used to scan Jenni when she’d been pregnant.

‘Uh... yeah, some.’

‘For the better?’

‘I’d say so. Jenni and I are having regular...’ he looked up at Clayton’s assistant, a young man who gave off the vibes of some kind of heavy metal singer trapped in a clinical white coat.

‘Oh, Michael’s part of my team,’ Clayton reassured Dixon. ‘You don’t need to worry about disclosing secrets in his presence.’

Dixon smiled a silent greeting at the assistant, who responded in kind.

‘So you’re enjoying regular sexual activity again?’ Clayton prompted him.

‘Uh-huh,’ Dixon nodded. ‘I guess it was a surprise... the gift that my wife received in my name...’

Reading something off his screen, Clayton said, ‘A marital dating membership, is that right?’

‘Yeah. Ashley Madison.’

Dixon glanced up at Michael, fearing that the assistant would be amused at hearing that his Experience had involved Jenni getting a membership for the Ashley Madison website.

‘And to you, that didn’t seem quite right?’ Clayton asked him, showing no trace of amusement or surprise, or any particular emotion.

‘No. I mean — who would want their wife to be a member of a website like that? But I couldn’t deny I’d given her the gift; I couldn’t tell her it was a mistake, she would have probably found out I was doing this program.’

‘I completely understand,’ Clayton said earnestly.

‘I’m guessing there was some kind of mix-up...’

‘Well, I have to say, it’s never happened before. Our system is usually very effective at reading your tastes and ascertaining your desires, Mr. Dixon, even if you weren’t certain of them yourself.’

‘I’m sure it’s very good...’

‘But you say your sexual activity with your wife has improved since you gave her this gift?’

Dixon sighed. He could hardly deny that. ‘Well, obviously, she feels I’ve given her the green light to start seeing other guys... and she’s even been out on a date with one...’

‘Ah, okay. So that’s a problem?’

‘A guy’s not supposed to just let his wife *cheat on him*.’

Dixon recalled how it had felt for Jenni to be out on her first date with Tom. How he had felt about her when she’d returned. How much he’d wanted her. He also remembered how it had been when that photographer had been taking pictures of her, and he’d been tempted to ask for some slightly risqué images at the end of the shoot.

He said, ‘Look, I appreciate that maybe guys are wired so that if their woman looks like leaving him for another man, their libido might get going in a big way — you know, to try to win her back. And I get that it feels good for a guy when his libido does kick in — it feels like he’s turned on by *whatever’s* causing that, right?’

‘Of course.’

‘But that’s not the same as actively wanting your wife to *cheat* on you, is it?’

‘It can be very complicated,’ Clayton smiled sympathetically. ‘I appreciate how confusing all this can be. And naturally, various factors could be at work here, in terms of enhancing your desire for your wife...’

‘Exactly,’ Dixon nodded, feeling some satisfaction that his point was being validated. ‘I mean, they encouraged me to secretly watch my wife getting undressed... And then when she went on that date, she was naturally going to be pretty excited... And if she’s getting in the mood, that’s going to be a turn-on for me...’

‘Perhaps it had nothing to do with the possibility that another man would sleep with your wife,’ Clayton agreed.

‘Anyone would have acted like I did,’ Dixon insisted.

Clayton nodded. ‘Well, I can promise you, we can run a full assessment and make double-sure that what happens during your Experience is the correct path for you specifically.’

Dixon felt a real sense of optimism.

And then they were running the assessment all over again.

It started slowly, but gradually picked up until it felt like he was riding another exhausting rollercoaster ride — or perhaps undergoing some kind of illegal interrogation by a CIA rendition team.

But at least this time, he knew what he was up against. This time, he knew what it was all about — and he wanted the perfect Experience at the end of it.

What would that correct Experience entail?

Perhaps more of that voyeurism stuff. That had been hot. Watching Jenni via those secret cameras, checking her out as she stripped off, as she enjoyed some personal time.

Perhaps some kind of romantic getaway to a far-flung location, where the twins would be cared for perfectly well while Frank and Jenni were given space to play.

Dixon forced himself to think of his wife and how he had felt while watching her undress. He tried to lock in the kind of thoughts and feelings that might show the Marriage 2.0 machine the kind of thing he wanted his Experience to involve.

Was he trying to trick the machine? Would that really help the process divert his Experience to a more accurate pathway?

However, as his assessment progressed to the most intensive stretch of the process, he found that a significant proportion of what was being thrown his way involved Jenni spending time with other men. There were even images that could only have come from Jenni’s date night with Tom, in which Dixon could see how they had been with each other. How much Jenni had clearly enjoyed spending time with him. How obviously enchanted he was with her.

How did they get this material?

Then there were scenes in which a couple had sex, and while neither of their faces was shown, the woman looked very similar to Jenni in terms of her body type and her hairstyle, while the man resembled Tom very closely.

It felt as though Dixon was watching his wife cheat on him. As the couple sighed and moaned and cried out with sexual bliss, even the voices sounded like Jenni and her date.

And as much as he tried to suppress his responses to this imagery, Dixon couldn't prevent his manhood from thickening up, his heart from racing, his body temperature rising.

Damn it, it wasn't supposed to be like this!

This time, at least, they allowed him to take a shower afterward.

The showers were down in the basement, where there was a fully functional gym, swimming pool, games room — complete with dozens of vintage and modern arcade games, pool tables, and even a four-lane bowling alley and a large cafeteria.

Clayton wagon hand to give him the tour. He seemed too senior to be a tour guide, but was undoubtedly making extra sure that a high-paying client was happy with the service.

'It's like a resort down here,' Dixon said as they walked past the extensive swimming pool.

'We have a lot of staff involved in producing the various Experiences we arrange,' Clayton explained. 'And when they're not performing, we like to keep them happy — and healthy.'

'Of course.'

Dixon was impressed. It almost made him want to work for the company. But this was increasingly how it was with Silicon Valley, and Marriage 2.0 seemed to Dixon like an extension of Silicon Valley, even if the head office was in NYC. There was competition in the marketplace when it came to attracting qualified employees these days.

'I thought you said you use artificial intelligence systems to organize all these Experiences for people,' he said.

Clayton smiled. 'Our artificial intelligence systems devise suitable scenarios for our clients, yes. But to enact these scenarios in real life, we need very real people to perform the required roles.'

'They're like actors performing in a movie?'

‘Precisely.’

Dixon was surprised. But then, a beat later, he was surprised at his surprise. Of course Marriage 2.0 would need employees to act out specific roles to make client Experiences work. How else would it happen?

He said, ‘So Tom... the guy my wife found through Ashley Madison, the guy who went on a first date with her... he was one of your performers?’

Clayton chuckled. ‘He may have been. Or he may have been simply another Ashley Madison member. I’m not really at liberty to give you that kind of information.’

Dixon nodded. ‘Of course. Sure.’

Strangely, Dixon felt comforted by the notion that Tom, Jenni’s date on that particular night, had been a Marriage 2.0 ‘performer’. He wasn’t sure why, though.

‘Well, here you are,’ Clayton said, showing him into a private bathroom complete with a shower. ‘You’ll have everything you need in here — when you’re done, I’ll meet you over in the cafeteria.’

He felt so much better after a good, hot shower, and changed into a fresh set of clothes. The clothes were high quality, too — but then Bloomingdale’s wasn’t so far away.

Dixon wandered into the cafeteria feeling confident that his second visit to Marriage 2.0 had not been wasted. He was confident that his second assessment would discover where his Experience had been going wrong, and set him on the right course.

After fetching a frothy, but nicely strong cup of coffee, he perched at one of the empty benches to wait for Clayton. And it wasn’t more than five minutes before he glanced at the cafeteria entrance to see the familiar lanky form of the Marriage 2.0 official wandering toward him, carrying a folder stuffed with paperwork.

‘Well, I have your results, Mr. Dixon,’ he said, a mildly troubled expression on his thin face as he took a seat across the table from Dixon.

‘Okay?’

Clayton sighed. ‘I’m afraid they rather confirm what we found the first time around.’

‘You’re kidding?’

‘Look,’ the man said, fishing out a sheet of paper from his folder and placing it in front of Dixon. ‘You can see the numbers are off the charts for the visual stimulus, the altruistic drivers, and compersion...’

‘Uh... the what, what, and *what*?’

Clayton gave a little nod, as though silently reminding himself that he was speaking with a client, not a trained colleague. ‘This one... relates to voyeurism,’ he said in a quiet voice, his eyes darting around to ensure they were not being overheard. ‘*Altruism*... that’s behavior that benefits others at your own expense.

‘*Compersion* — well, that’s when you actually feel pleasure because someone else is feeling pleasure. Like a parent might feel when their toddler is having fun, or in your case — ’

The man stopped in case he was overheard revealing that Dixon was turned on by his wife dating other men.

Dixon asked, ‘And there’s no way your technology could be making some kind of mistake? Not factoring something in... something because I’m not exactly your normal kind of guy...’

Dixon wondered if his wealth and success in business might categorize him as unusual for the Marriage 2.0 system. However, from what he’d seen of the retail area, the program attracted all sorts.

But Clayton shook his head.

‘Are you saying you’ve had no response at all to your adventure?’ the senior technician asked him.

‘That’s not what I’m saying.’

‘I mean, watching your wife with those cameras... seeing how she is when she’s been talking to other men on the website... seeing her kiss

that guy at the end of her date at the Fat Frog?’

‘Poodle,’ Dixon corrected him. ‘Le Fat Poodle.’

‘Poodle, of course.’

It was kind of creepy that Clayton knew about all that — and yet, it shouldn’t have surprised Dixon. Everything was set up by Marriage 2.0, wasn’t it? And they had artificial intelligence systems monitoring every outcome, apparently, so that the continuing adventure could respond to whatever happened along the way, and the ultimate strategy remained on track.

‘And what about with the photographer?’ Clayton asked.

Now, this made Dixon gasp. ‘That was *you*?’ he hissed.

‘Well, not *me*... Oh, you mean *us*? Yes, Mr. Dixon, you shouldn’t be terribly surprised that the photographer was one of ours...’

For one of the first times since all this had really started, Dixon found himself genuinely astonished.

How the hell had they engineered that situation? He and Jenni had talked about her getting back into the real estate business entirely separate from anything related to the Marriage 2.0 adventure. The photographer had been hired directly because Jenni had to build herself a website. Then, Dixon’s sudden desire for Jenni to start taking her clothes off while the photographer took more pictures had been entirely spur-of-the-moment.

There was no way that could have been set up by Marriage 2.0.

Clayton read the amazement and consternation imprinted in Dixon’s face and attempted a reassuring smile. ‘It’s unsettling, isn’t it?’ he conceded. ‘Finding out how much of... everything... is the result of our technology, rather than things simply happening, come what may?’

‘Unsettling?’ Dixon said. ‘I’m not sure that word does it justice.’

‘Look, you want to take this conversation upstairs?’ Clayton offered.

Dixon shook his head. He didn’t feel like trudging all the way back to Clayton’s office just to finish this conversation.

The man nodded and explained, ‘Everything you do within the Experience — everything that happens — simply steers the program one way or another. If something happens which *wasn’t* expressly planned for by the program, the program can often respond... to provide fresh opportunities to explore your own personal desires.’

‘So if I didn’t want my wife to...’ now it was Dixon’s turn to glance around them to make sure they were not being overheard, ‘...*sleep* with other guys... and I actively did something to stop it... would the program always drag Jenni and me back into that kind of situation?’

‘I couldn’t say for certain,’ Clayton said, rubbing his chin thoughtfully. ‘I mean, you have other desires; nobody only has a single fantasy. But in your case, the numbers... well, the impulse is strong for you. The motivation to have your wife... well, you know. It makes the likelihood that the system would want to steer you back to that kind of outcome... well, I’m not going to say *inevitable*, but... close to.’

‘Jesus.’

‘You can always stop the adventure.’

‘But if I wanted to try this again... even if I didn’t do this again, you’re saying secretly I’d always want to do this kind of thing?’ Dixon felt so downhearted, almost as though a doctor had given him a terminal diagnosis.

Clayton was apologetic. ‘I’m sorry,’ he said. ‘We have seen this kind of thing before. I just haven’t really seen it in a case like this. Sometimes, people just can’t bring together their subconscious desires with their conscious mindset, even their personal values. Actually, don’t quote me on this, but we almost got sued — ’

‘Sued?’

Clayton chuckled. ‘This guy... let’s just say he was rather... narrow-minded regarding certain diversity issues...’

‘He was some kind of bigot?’

Clayton gave a little sigh. ‘I can’t reveal the details, of course, for confidentiality reasons, but simply to say that after we tested him and his wife *rigorously*, his subsequent Experience involved a very tasteful and discreet opportunity for him to experience physical relations with a very good-looking young man...’

Dixon burst into laughter. ‘You pushed a homophobe into having an affair with another man?’

‘Well...’ Clayton tilted his head as though fearful that someone would whack him with something. ‘We try not to be *judgmental* here at Marriage 2.0, of course... often there’s a lot of pressure from our community around us, from society...’

‘And you think it’s merely *peer pressure* that means I can’t handle the whole... cuckolding... thing?’ Dixon said, and felt a burst of shame that he might be in the same class as a homophobe.

Clayton took a deep breath. ‘I mean, you have to admit, even the word seems a little... awful. Doesn’t it? Like you’re trying to clear your throat of something unsavory that you ate.’

‘I don’t go by what society tells me I should do,’ Dixon insisted. He’d never liked being accused of being a follower rather than a leader.

He was someone who broke the mold, not someone obsessive about the latest trends.

Clayton nodded. 'Of course. But... I don't know... I guess what I'm trying to say is... why don't you try it?'

It was Dixon's turn to take a deep breath. He thought of the homophobe guy, the guy who probably had a real taste for sex with other men, if only he could get around his inherent view that homosexuality was wrong.

He thought about the photographer, and how he had felt as Jenni had started shedding her clothes in front of him. He hadn't hated the idea of the guy getting to see his wife naked. And when, later, Jenni had teased him with mental images of the photographer taking pictures of her masturbating... or the photographer getting to fuck her instead of her husband... it had been seriously hot.

'I don't like...' he said, trying to frame his feelings on the matter without being at all close-minded. 'I'm not comfortable with... being there. When another guy gets his... you know...'

Dixon gave another visual sweep of the area to check that they were safe from prying eyes or interested ears. The place was busy, yet people seemed to generally give him and Clayton a wide berth.

'...When a guy gets his clothes off... and I'm there watching...'

Jesus. Now who was sounding like a goddamn homophobe?

But Dixon wasn't afraid of the possibility that he might enjoy homosexual relations — that simply didn't enter into his mind. It was the awkwardness of being involved in something intimate while another man was also involved. He couldn't stand even the slightest possibility that the other guy might look at him and, even silently, judge him for what he was doing.

Clayton nodded, trying to show that he understood perfectly. 'You know, you don't have to be there when — '

'No,' Dixon sighed, worried that Clayton might now change things so that Dixon would have to fly off to Japan for four weeks while Jenni got busy with half the men in Old Greenwich. 'No, it's not that... I mean... I kind of want to *be there*... I want to see...'

Clayton nodded. 'That whole voyeuristic side of your...'

Dixon agreed. 'I don't want to forsake my wife when it happens,' he said. 'I just don't want the guy to really know I'm there.'

Clayton sniffed, and straightened his papers before putting them back in his folder.

‘I think I can get the indices in your profile adjusted,’ he said positively. ‘I think we might just be able to factor that into your adventure, Mr. Dixon.’

‘Great.’

Dixon felt some relief, although he also felt a fairly hefty dose of uncertainty — he hadn’t exactly done what he’d come here to achieve today. He hadn’t stopped the adventure from arranging for Jenni to sleep with other men. But he had made it clear that he wanted to be with Jenni, somehow, while possibly avoiding the awkwardness of being judged a loser by one of Jenni’s new male friends.

Then they were both on their feet, and Clayton said, ‘Come on — I’ll show you out. We very rarely bring clients down here, and there’s absolutely no signage pointing you back to the street.’

‘Thank you,’ Dixon said as they began walking out of the cafeteria.

‘You know, Mr. Dixon, we can arrange for you to speak to one of our specialist advisors if ever you find your adventure getting truly out of hand.’

‘Oh, really?’

‘Yeah. It can be helpful to simply talk with someone, you know? Even just to get your concerns off your chest.’

‘Sounds like conventional marital therapy,’ Dixon laughed.

Clayton laughed as well, recognizing the little dig at Marriage 2.0’s attempts to disrupt the conventions in marital counseling. ‘You know, we can even arrange for someone you know — a friend, neighbor, whatever kind of person you’re comfortable with — to help you talk through any concerns you’re having...’

Dixon thought of Phoebe visiting him the night Jenni’d had her date with Tom in Le Fat Poodle. Why did he get the funny little tingling sensation that Phoebe was somehow set up to help coach him through Jenni’s first actual date? But he didn’t raise that thought with Clayton. If Phoebe was already properly part of this adventure, then the staged nature of his whole life was so pervasive that he just didn’t want to even think about it.

And then, they were just walking toward the elevators in the central plaza of this enormous basement level, when Dixon glanced across and saw, to his complete shock, the familiar pert features of the brunette intern Gaines had been trying to persuade him to seduce.

Samantha.

Dixon gasped.

‘Everything okay?’ Clayton said.

‘Uh... so everyone down here right now... they’re *all* employees?’ Dixon quickly gestured over toward Samantha, who looked simply stunning in skin-tight blue-and-black lycra workout clothes. Her pretty face was somewhat rosy from her recent exercise. She seemed to be heading from the gym to the cafeteria, but thankfully that meant she wasn’t looking in Dixon’s direction.

Clayton smiled. ‘Well, a lot of them are *performers*, of course. We have some retail staff, as you’ve seen. Client liaison staff, such as myself. Some tech people, naturally. A smattering of management...’

‘Performers?’

Clayton smiled as the elevator doors closed on them, and they began to rise slowly toward the ground level. ‘It’s not all artificial intelligence, our adventures,’ he laughed. ‘I’m afraid there has to be a certain... physicality to what our clients experience. Often, that means we need... performers.’

Dixon sucked in his breath.

So what the hell was Samantha, a Marriage 2.0 performer? So, what was she doing working at Bradley, Dixon and Gaines? Surely she couldn’t be part of Dixon’s adventure? He’d met her before he’d even thought of trying out Marriage 2.0. He didn’t ask Clayton specifically about Samantha. He let the guy show him out, and then called Villiers to ask him to come pick him up, to take him home to Connecticut.

But he was damn sure going to talk to Samantha and find out what she was up to.

Dixon couldn’t get Samantha out of his head on the ride up to Old Greenwich. He found himself mulling over the possibilities.

Was she at Bradley, Dixon and Gaines for the benefit of somebody else? Could it simply be a coincidence that she was there as an intern while also working for Marriage 2.0??

Of course, there were lots of people using the Marriage 2.0 service, from what Dixon had seen during his visit. The place looked like a goddamn Apple Store, for goodness’ sake, and Dixon knew how popular Apple Stores were. He had plenty of clients investing in the company.

So chances were, somebody else at Bradley, Dixon and Gaines could be using Marriage 2.0 as well, right?

He also considered the possibility that Samantha might be working for Marriage 2.0 part-time, as some kind of college job. She might not be actively working for the company while interning at Bradley, Dixon and Gaines — if she was, then she would be *insanely* busy — but she might still have the right to use the staff facilities at Marriage 2.0.

And why wouldn't she? The facilities there were incredible for staff. Loads of students needed jobs to fund themselves through college these days, right? And why wouldn't you work for Marriage 2.0 if you were as attractive as Samantha? It had to beat working at the GAP.

But the closer Dixon got to home, the theory that really stuck out for him, which made some kind of sense to him even if it kind of made his skin crawl, was that Gaines was the one using Marriage 2.0. That Samantha was there, ultimately, for the benefit of Gaines.

Gaines had been with him when he'd first encountered the pretty brunette intern, hadn't he? He'd practically given her to Dixon as some kind of attempt to tempt him into agreeing that it was time to move on from Jenni, to find a second wife. Had that all been some kind of ruse to get Dixon involved in a Marriage 2.0 adventure?

The trouble was, the theory broke down precisely because Gaines wasn't in a relationship just now. It had been a while since the wild and care-free fourth marriage to Zara at that Elvis chapel in Vegas, at which Dixon had been the only guest, and Best Man.

Zara had been nice. Distraught when things had, inevitably, collapsed with Gaines after six months. Dixon had quietly helped her get a lawyer capable of getting a few million out of Gaines, enough to set her up with a completely new life in San Francisco. But ever since that, Gaines had been acting the playboy, dating randomly and frequently.

You didn't use Marriage 2.0 if you weren't in a serious relationship, did you? So how could Samantha be a part of Gaines's Marriage 2.0 adventure?

Surely the man wasn't trying to restore one of his previous marriages? That would go against his entire philosophy.

He was late, again, by the time he arrived home. The kids were already in bed. He'd texted Jenni, of course, to let her know what time he expected to be home, and she was completely fine about it. Nothing unusual, him being late home from work.

These days, he knew she had something else to distract herself from the fact that he was late home from work. She had all that work preparing to launch herself into the real estate business again. And, oh, there was that small business of playing the dating game through Ashley Madison.

As he arrived home, he felt the tickle of apprehension and even anxiety in his chest, and it came from vaguely hoping she was actually using Ashley Madison just now, rather than continuing to work on her real estate stuff.

Well, Clayton *had* confirmed that he was turned on by the thought of Jenni dating. And that mild disappointment had been somewhat tempered by Dixon's growing feeling that if he opened his mind to the possibilities, he shouldn't feel embarrassed at what his adventure was turning out to be.

He wasn't like that goddamn homophobe, was he? So stuck in his own intolerance that he couldn't accept who he was, fundamentally, under the surface?

No, he was a good guy. Broad-minded. Tolerant. In fact, tolerant wasn't even a good word, because it implied that there was something 'bad' that you had to 'tolerate'. He was accepting. He was inclusive. And when he shed the old clothes of embarrassment and shame, he had to admit that the prospect of Jenni actually doing something, actually going as far as *fucking another man*... well, it was a thrilling thought.

Jesus.

Still terrifying, though.

So what was the harm in letting this adventure play out? Nobody needed to know about it except Jenni and himself.

It was ten o'clock when Dixon watched Villiers driving away and then entered the house. All was quiet. He couldn't even hear the TV from the family room. Had Jenni gone to bed already? Perhaps she was tired — all that work she was now doing on top of her usual parenting duties. Even with Ophelia to help with the kids, the change in her routine would be somewhat tiring.

He thought about heading into the office for an hour or two to get ahead on the next day's work. But he felt the fatigue in his frame from that afternoon's assessment at Marriage 2.0. To lie down in bed right now seemed more tempting to him than slumping down in front of a computer screen to look at the numbers ahead of the morning meeting.

He crept upstairs, poked his head in the door of the kids' room to check on them, before padding silently down the hallway toward the

primary bedroom. Outside the primary bedroom, he stopped in his tracks.

The bedroom door was slightly ajar. Out in the dark hallway, he had a good view into the bedroom, which he only realized when he saw Jenni step right in view, wearing nothing but a pair of black thigh-high stockings and a black suspender belt, which she was now attaching to the stockings.

Dixon caught his breath.

He was instantly hard. She was stunning.

Bathed in soft light from the bedside lamps, her long, sandy hair fell to her waist as she fastened the straps from the suspender belt to the tops of her stockings. Dixon ran his eyes down her trim figure, indulging in the sight of her bare breasts, her stiff little nipples, her toned stomach.

He just about managed to stifle a gasp when her hands moved so she could fasten the straps over her other thigh, and he saw that she had lost the usual soft golden fuzz over her mound — her pussy was now completely hairless.

God. She'd never done that before. Mind you, she'd never worn stockings like this before. It looked simply scandalous. His hard-on throbbed.

He didn't move a muscle as he watched her finish fitting her stockings, and reach for something on the bed — a pair of black lacy panties. She hadn't seen him lurking out there, clearly. He watched her lift a leg to step into her panties — which were mostly sheer, and had the kind of effortless elegance that made them appear expensive — and saw that she was wearing black, strappy, high-heeled shoes. Again, expensive-looking.

Jesus.

Why would she be dressing in such insanely hot lingerie at 10pm at night? She knew he was on his way home, didn't she?

He watched Jenni gently pulling her panties into place, covering her astoundingly hairless pussy. She turned to see how they fit at the back. She was looking at herself in the mirror — trying on these clothes, rather than simply dressing in them, he thought. The panties were almost g-strings, definitely not the usual kind of underwear she would wear. There was nothing to cover any of her shapely rear, just a tiny triangle of sheer material at the apex of her cheeks.

She tugged gently at her panties, and at one of her stockings, until she was happy things were where they were supposed to be. Then she turned back to face the mirror — and her concealed husband — and reached for a matching black lace bra.

Was this all for his benefit?

He found himself thinking of his visit to Marriage 2.0 again, and of his desire to amend his adventure so that Jenni wasn't required to date other men. Could they turn this thing into a more straightforward voyeuristic adventure? Have him simply watch his wife, now and again, engaged in erotic scenarios like this one.

Was it mere coincidence that he would arrive home right now, to find his wife almost naked, with the opportunity to watch her slowly dressing in the most glamorous, classy lingerie? He watched Jenni run her hands over her chest, cupping her breasts, to ensure the bra was perfectly in place. He remembered how she had looked stripping off in front of the photographer — a man who had been sent by Marriage 2.0, it turned out. There were no coincidences in these adventures.

But how did they arrange for her to be trying on lingerie right now? It wasn't as though she had the Marriage 2.0 app on her phone. It wasn't as though they could send her little notifications telling her it was time to make sure her sexy new underwear fit properly?

Perhaps they had couriered over this special sexy outfit just before Dixon had turned up? They could have included a note in with the clothes asking her to try them on just at the moment her husband was arriving home.

At the same time, as he watched her turn again to check out her underwear at the back, and then reach for something else — a dress — that dark little corner of his mind was hoping that she was trying on this sexy outfit because she was planning on wearing it at her next date. Perhaps it signified that she was ready for her next date to progress to a new, exciting stage.

Was she planning on wearing this for another man?

God, he actually hoped so.

And where was the harm in that? If they were all consenting. If nobody else found out. If she returned to her husband afterward to share details on how the date had worked out.

The dress was gold, silk, or satin, and only just seemed to cover her underwear and the tops of her stockings. It had a wrap front, and had the kind of shimmering gold effect that brought to mind Cleopatra. It was undoubtedly the kind of thing the newspapers might term risqué, although its long sleeves made it avoid appearing to be sexy nightwear. However, it certainly seemed like a special dress for a date, rather than for some smart evening event she might attend on her husband's arm.

He watched her turn again to check out her butt in that dress. She even slowly pulled up the hem of the dress to reveal her panties — was she imagining someone pushing up her dress to peek at what she had on underneath? Was she imagining her husband? Or her date?

Dixon watched her turn back, slowly, to face the mirror again, as well as him. Now, with the hem of her dress lifted, her other hand slipped between her legs, patting — then pressing — the lacy front of her black panties. After a moment or two, her hand moved away again, sweeping over her body, pulling the wrap style front of her dress open so that her bra was exposed. It looked to Dixon as though she was putting on a show for somebody — or practicing putting on a show.

Preparing for her date.

He watched her free hand slip down between her legs again, but this time delving under the semi-sheer black lace of her panties. She stroked her bare pussy. Was she wondering at how strange it felt? Her mound completely smooth, her pussy free of any fuzz to frame it.

Was she imagining showing it off to her date?

Dixon felt the increasingly familiar powerful arousal at the thought of sweet Jenni transgressing her wedding vows. He also felt the fear and the shame. But who else knew this was going on? He could have an open mind about this, he was sure.

Jenni was standing in front of the mirror, stroking her pussy, the luxurious black lace of her panties stretching over her fingers as she explored her folds. Her body moved sensually in response to her touch and made it look almost like she was dancing to unheard music.

Then, when she seemed completely happy with how those sexy clothes fit her, she sat on the edge of the bed. Dixon had to move in the dark hallway so that he could continue to watch her, but then there she was, perched on the edge of the mattress, spreading her legs wide, her pussy framed by stockings and suspender belt, covered by the black lace of her panties.

Dixon pressed his hand against his hardness as he watched her hand slip beneath her panties again, gently stroking. Her other hand pulled her dress open over her chest so that much of her bra was revealed, and now she could caress her breasts, cup them, fondle them, all while she continued to strum her sweet pussy.

‘Hey,’ he said softly as he entered the room, no longer able to remain outside.

‘Hey,’ she replied, not flinching or covering herself through embarrassment. She stayed as she was, her thighs parted, underwear exposed, and her hands grinding against erogenous zones — though her pretty mouth did grow into a mischievous smile.

‘You look *nice*,’ he said, taking a seat beside her on the bed, somewhat taken aback at what he was seeing — close up, now — even

though he had been watching her from the hallway for some time. ‘*Very nice.*’

She laughed and lifted her nearest leg to place it over his lap, no doubt feeling how hard he was.

‘I have a date lined up for tomorrow night,’ she said. ‘Tom. You remember him? I was wondering whether I might be bold enough to wear something like this.’

His cock jumped a few times at the thought of her wearing such clothes for a date.

‘Well, I guess *somebody* likes that idea,’ she grinned, flicking her eyes briefly down to his crotch to indicate that she had felt his response.

Dixon ran a hand gently up her inner thigh, his heart rate quickening all the time, his breathing deepening as he inhaled the scent of her perfume, and the hint of her arousal. His fingers reached the edge of her panties, her flesh burning hot there, her skin so very soft and smooth, unfamiliar to him now she was shaved.

‘You... shaved it?’ he said quietly, his hand moving to cover her panties, even while her hand was underneath the lace.

‘Waxed,’ she smiled.

‘For your date?’

He was shocked. She took in his expression and smirked, enjoying how she could make him react.

She said, ‘Phoebe told me guys like it that way these days... I mean... it’s been a while since I dated anyone else...’

‘*Phoebe?*’

He tugged on her panties, stretched the lace as he pulled it out of the way, wanting to see her pussy in all its full waxed glory. She teased him by keeping her hand there, her middle finger dipping into her slit.

‘Yeah,’ Jenni said, almost casually. ‘She even took me to have it done at her usual place...’

‘Wow,’ he drew in his breath as her fingers pulled back just enough for him to see more, though still blocking his full view as she traced little circles around her clit. Then she went back to the full caress, slipping two fingers inside herself as she tilted her head back and moaned.

For a moment or two, he just watched her touching herself. One of her hands squeezed her breasts while the other alternatively danced circles around her pussy and thrust her fingers inside it. He even stroked his hardness through his pants while he sat watching her.

Then he grew impatient, and his hand swept up her inner thigh again, this time dislodging hers from her pussy.

‘So,’ he said, trying to act calm as his fingers explored her insanely smooth mound, the soft flower of her pussy. ‘If you’re thinking about wearing this kind of outfit for your date, and you’ve waxed... are you thinking you’ll do something *really* bad this time?’

‘Oh yes...’ she gasped, and he wasn’t sure she was answering him, or simply responding to his fingers tracing the same circles over her pussy that she had been.

‘You think you might... *fuck* him?’

She looked up at him sharply, though not angrily. Her eyes connected with his, and she was assessing him, working out exactly how he was feeling about all this — whether he was asking about her next date out of lust or fear.

She sat up, still gazing into his eyes, but pressing herself up against him, her legs moving together again. ‘It’s what you want, isn’t it?’ she said, gravely serious.

He could hardly believe it, but in a perfectly conscious state of mind, he said, ‘Yes. It’s what I want.’

He perceived a tiny, fraction-of-a-second glint of pure shock in her green eyes, as though it was still the most surprising thing, her devoted husband actively wanting her to have full sex with another man. But then her cautious expression broke into a sweet smile, full of affection and love, amazed and thrilled that he would want this, that he would want to give her this experience.

He reached up to cradle her head and bring her in for a warm, passionate kiss on her mouth. As he tasted her lips and breathed in her gentle fragrance, he felt her hands move to his belt, working to unfasten it along with his fly.

Their kiss broke, and she urged him back, so she could pull down his pants and his underwear. He helped her, and then her fingers curled around his stiff shaft, and she began to stroke it.

‘Mmm... it really does turn you on, doesn’t it?’ she breathed.

‘Uh-huh.’

‘Thinking about me being a bad girl. Going out with another guy... bringing him home... tearing off his clothes so I can *fuck* him...’

She continued to pump and squeeze his hardness. He sat up to pull her in for another kiss, and his own hand slipped between her thighs again, to feel again how wet she was at the thought of being unfaithful. He slipped a finger inside her hairless pussy, which she had spent so much time and effort preparing for her infidelity.

After a while, both her hands were on his cock, and he couldn't reach between her thighs anymore. She kissed him and jacked his cock, and he found himself imagining that her lips had already been stretched around another man's manhood.

'Are we really going to do this?' he said to her quietly, in a way seeking confirmation from himself as much as her.

'I think we *have* to,' she smiled, standing up in front of him, holding up her gold shimmery dress so that he could tug down her panties.

'My *God*...'

She pushed him back on the bed and climbed onto him, her gorgeous form adorned by that gold dress, her bra, the black stockings and suspenders, her high-heeled shoes. She straddled him and pressed her mouth to his, and as she sucked on his tongue, she reached to position his cock at her soaking, searing-hot entrance.

She sank down on him, and it felt just incredible. Sitting up to ride him, he ran his eyes down her sensational figure. She peeled off her dress to give him a better view, and then she kissed him again, stroking his face, pulling her breasts free of the black lace bra so that he could suck on them some more.

The sex had never been this good, had it? Sex generally hadn't been this good.

She had tempered the familiarity with sexy new clothes, with a waxing session. But it was more than just the surface: there was a new attitude, a new atmosphere between them. And it was undoubtedly because they knew she was going to sleep with another man.

They were dispelling the easy rut in which they had gotten stuck after she'd fallen pregnant — his seeing her as the mother of his kids, rather than the lover he had dated and then married. The introduction of a new man to their arrangement — new *men*, since she was still communicating with other guys through the Ashley Madison website, and certainly hadn't spoken of limiting herself to a single extra-marital companion — had turned her back into a sexual being in his eyes, as well as hers.

And now he rolled her over and thrust himself against her, between her legs, piercing her slippery pussy again with his impressively large pole.

He was sucking on her perky tits, which he'd learned to ignore while she'd been breastfeeding, then he was sucking on her pussy, and not because it was some quid-pro-quo for her having given him a blowjob. He ate her because it turned him on, because it was intimate and filthy,

rubbing his face against her soaking sex, and it made her moan like nothing else.

She went down on him, and she wasn't just trying to please him, to show him she could be a good girlfriend, a good wife. She was turned on by handling his cock, touching his cock, slipping his cock inside her mouth.

Perhaps she was thinking that she might soon get to experience another, different cock, just like this.

She fucked him again, and he took her from behind as she went on all fours, and it went on and on, like some kind of workout in Heaven, both of them panting and moaning and sweating and *coming*.

Coming until their bed was such a mess, they had to go sleep in one of the guest bedrooms.

And the crazy thing was, this wasn't the peak of their adventure. The old Dixon might have thought, *well, here we are, so hot for each other again, fucking for long hours into the night, it must be job done, adventure over, thanks for everything*. But *this* Dixon, the new Dixon, the Dixon with the broad mind and open mentality, realized that it was all reliant on the adventure continuing — and the next step was Jenni meeting another man for sex.

All day, the next day, he was nervous. He woke up nervous. He got out of the shower nervous, he left the house nervous, he got to the office nervous. He could hardly keep his thoughts straight all day.

He'd never been this nervous before. Jesus, not even when he'd been chasing his first million.

It was the day of Jenni's date.

That was all he could think about. Was he making a huge mistake? If so, it would be big, alright — the biggest mistake of his life. Was he being lulled into some daydream that was going to turn into a nightmare?

Was Marriage 2.0 calculating that the best thing for him, in the long run, was to lose his wife? He had gone in there alone, without bringing Jenni for them to assess, for them to devise an adventure for them *both* to share. This was his adventure, alone. It might not be good for *their* relationship, only for *his* relationship. And his perfect relationship might not be with Jenni, at least according to Marriage 2.0's artificial intelligence systems.

He said aloud, ‘What are the chances there’s one perfect person out there for you, when you could only ever get to meet a tiny fraction of the eight billion people in this world?’

‘Uh... what was that, sir?’

Dixon looked up from his desk. Mrs. Hawkes was standing at the door, the report for the investment fund IQW in her hand, which he had requested earlier that morning.

‘Oh, nothing,’ he said, offering her a dismissive smile, and taking a sip of water as though his need for a drink might explain his strange outburst.

He thanked his secretary for the report and waited until she was back out of the door before considering his little dilemma again.

Chances were that, technically, Jenni was not his soulmate, was not ‘The One,’ because statistically, how could she be? So, was there a danger that Marriage 2.0 had decided there was someone else out there better for him? That there was a *better relationship* available for him? That upgrading his relationship meant *finding someone else*?

Maybe Marriage 2.0 thought the kindest way for him to drop Jenni would be to allow her to run off with someone else?

It hurt him inside to think of losing her. He felt intense little stabbing pains in his heart.

What if he could persuade Jenni to go to Marriage 2.0 to be assessed herself? Was there any way to begin their adventures afresh, with his wife appropriately involved? Perhaps that would mean they didn’t end up going down this bizarre direction in which she was dating other men — and destined to sleep with one of them *tonight*.

He thought about going back to the Lexington Avenue headquarters of Marriage 2.0, this time taking Jenni with him.

Then he remembered who he’d seen there during his second visit.

Dixon pulled his laptop computer close, and logged into the company intranet. He located the phone number he needed and picked up the phone sitting on the corner of his desk.

‘Stevens. Is Stevens there?’ he said. ‘Okay, so who is heading up HR these days? Kestra. That old chestnut? Okay. Listen, it’s Frank Dixon here. Get him to give me a call, would you?’

He put the phone down, and sat back in his oversized leather office chair, taking in one deep breath, two deep breaths, then a third.

Then there was a buzz from the phone. He picked it up again. ‘I have Mr. Kestra on the line for you,’ Mrs. Hawkes said curtly.

‘Thank you, Mrs. Hawkes. Put him through.’

He had the good folks down at HR send him up the resume of a certain Samantha Bryant. After that, he had Mrs. Hawkes send for Samantha herself. And within fifteen minutes, she was standing dutifully in Dixon's office, in front of his desk.

'You wanted to see me, Mr. Dixon?'

Her polite yet seductive stance was just effortless. Did she think he'd finally caved, and called her up to his office for some kind of office affair?

'I was just looking through your resume, Ms. Bryant,' he said, acting casual, leaning back in his chair. She seemed mildly surprised, but delighted, at his revelation. 'Very impressive, from what I could see.'

'Thank you, sir.'

'Some might say *too* impressive.'

She looked a little confused at that.

'I called your professor, Professor Barnes,' Dixon went on. 'He was *very* complimentary.' The pretty brunette smiled. 'Then I called the faculty. They've never heard of a Professor Roger Barnes. At least, not among their staff.'

Samantha Bryant, whoever she was, caught her breath. 'I'm sure there's been some kind of mistake, sir...'

Dixon nodded. He breathed. He *paused*.

Then he said, 'I know you work for Marriage 2.0, Samantha. Is that your real name? You don't need to deny it.'

She looked distinctly crestfallen. 'How did you know?'

'I saw you there. You were leaving the gym, going into the staff cafeteria.'

She gave a little nod and looked down at her shoes as though expecting him to give her a death sentence.

'So you're a performer, is that right? What is your mission, Samantha? What do they have you doing here at Bradley, Dixon, and Gaines?'

'I... can't tell you. Sir.'

'You know who I am?' he said, a hint of menace in his voice. 'I can make a few phone calls, and you'll never be able to work again. For this company, Marriage 2.0, or anyone else...'

Samantha looked genuinely frightened. So much so that he almost instantly regretted his threat.

She glanced around the room, appearing to consider her options.

Dixon sighed. 'Are you worried they're listening in right now? Don't be. I regularly have this room swept for bugs, in case any of our rivals

decide to get fresh with us. We're on our own right here.'

She shook her head and mouthed the words, *they're listening right now*.

Dixon felt a cold stab of fear. Who were these guys, that they could get listening equipment into his office?

Then Samantha said clearly, obviously knowing that her bosses at Marriage 2.0 were listening: 'If I tell you anything I'm not supposed to, it could spoil your... your adventure, sir.'

She put her finger in her ear, and for a moment, Dixon thought she must have some kind of ear infection or something — but then she produced a tiny little earpiece that had been secreted within her ear. She handed him the tiny little device to examine.

Dixon looked at the thing. It was just a tiny piece of black plastic — shaped to fit in her ear canal, where it would not be seen by anyone. He couldn't see any kind of distinguishing mark that might reveal anything about it. He guessed it had a microphone in it and a radio communication device to feed Samantha information.

He dropped the thing into his glass of water.

Samantha gasped.

'There,' Dixon said. 'Now we can talk freely.'

The brunette looked less than happy. 'I'll get *fired*...'

'You're an actor, is that it?'

She nodded.

'I'll get you a job somewhere else,' he said. 'You know we finance movies? It can be quite a good investment vehicle if the tax incentives are right...' That got her interest. Dixon said, 'So tell me: you *are* working as part of my Experience, aren't you?'

'Yes, sir.'

Well, that came as some minor relief. What had Dixon been most frightened of? That she was part of an adventure for Gaines — that he had joined the Marriage 2.0 program, even though he wasn't currently in a relationship. He'd worried that Gaines was so desperately keen to get Dixon to seduce this Samantha Bryant, that it might all be part of his secret adventure. That Gaines's secret fantasy was breaking up Dixon's marriage.

But there was one thing that didn't add up.

'Hang on,' he said. 'When you first arrived at Bradley, Dixon, and Gaines... when we first met...'

'Yes, sir?'

'Were you working as part of my Experience back then?'

‘Of course, sir.’

He scratched his head. But that had been *before* he’d even signed up for the Marriage 2.0 service. He said, ‘Did you know I only went to Marriage 2.0 and signed up to the program after I’d already met you? You were already working here at this company before I joined...’

Now it was Samantha’s turn to look confused. ‘But that’s *impossible*, sir.’

‘Did they tell you that you were working on *my* Experience before you came to act as an intern in this company?’

She said, ‘It was called the Dixon Experience, sir. But they don’t tell us much before we start. I assumed when I met you that it was *your* adventure I was working on, sir.’

‘Interesting,’ he nodded gently. ‘But it couldn’t have been my Experience back then. What was your role as far as you knew? You were supposed to try and, what, seduce me? Was that it? Get me interested in a little... something... to break up my marriage?’

‘I don’t know, sir,’ she said. ‘They just feed us with lines as we go along. They had me flirt with you. Gave me the lines to do it — but I didn’t know how far it was supposed to go.’

‘Jesus. How many of these adventures have you worked on so far at Marriage 2.0?’

She shrugged. ‘This is my third one. The others were... fairly straightforward.’

‘And your work on these adventures... has it included... that is to say... do you have to — ?’

‘There have been a couple of sex scenes, sir, yes,’ she said. ‘If that’s what you’re asking.’

Good god. She spoke of it as though she had simply been doing scenes for a movie. A performance. Rather than actually engaging in sex work. Sleeping with a client for money.

‘You *slept* with guys?’

‘My character did, in the Experiences,’ she said, correcting him.

‘So... have they told you to do anything with me? While you’re interning here?’

She looked at him, considering what to tell him. Then she gave a slight shake of her head, as though she was telling herself there was no longer any point in keeping the truth from him. ‘My active role is done, sir, on this adventure,’ she said. ‘Unless things change and they need to call me in again...’

‘*Active* role. What does that mean?’

She glanced around the room as though worried there might still be a bug or two around. Then she said, 'I just have to maintain my current role... working here at this company as an intern... until this particular adventure is completed. Keep my head down. You know — just in case you, or anyone else involved in your life, gets suspicious that I'm suddenly not around anymore.'

'So now your active role is over... you can't say anything about the Dixon Adventure? Where it's ultimately leading to?'

'No, sir.'

Dixon sighed again. He could hardly complain that Marriage 2.0 was using actors to help drive forward their adventures. That was the point, wasn't it? They were manipulating reality in order to get people — couples — into situations that ultimately changed their relationships. Upgraded them, supposedly.

He told Samantha she could go, and then just as she reached the door, added, 'Look... if they do get rid of you... let me know, will you? I'm not kidding; I have connections in Hollywood. I could get you something better.'

She smiled, grateful, and then went on her way.

Dixon wondered if he was being unnecessarily inquisitive about the Marriage 2.0 process, digging into Samantha's apparent role in all this. After all, mentally, he had come to accept that his adventure was going to involve Jenni having an affair, wasn't he? What was there left to worry about?

And yet it bugged him that Samantha Bryant had apparently been working on his Experience before Dixon had even decided to go to Marriage 2.0 to actually *have* an Experience.

So here they were.

Actually, Dixon had arrived at the apartment first, driving straight over to Dutch Street after work, picking up the package from the concierge in the lobby. He had waited until he was sealed in the privacy of their little pied-à-terre before he opened the box.

The first wicked little shiver of excitement swept through him as he laid eyes on the lingerie he had purchased online for his wife to wear for her date with another man.

Her date with *Tom*.

He had time to lay the clothes out on the bed for her, then take a deep breath and really get his head around what was happening here.

And then here was Jenni, fresh from meeting with her banker to set up the business structures she would need for her real estate venture. She wore a chic periwinkle-blue button-down shirt and a dark blue skirt that was just a skipped heartbeat too short. It made Dixon hope her banker had gotten a good eyeful.

'Hey,' she said, her pretty face breaking into a broad smile on seeing him seated in the armchair by the windows. She had a small black leather bag with her, which she dropped onto the bed.

'Hey,' he said. 'Meeting go well?'

'Of course,' she said, wandering over to the bed to view the little scraps of black and jade lace laid out over the bedsheets. 'Did you get these for me?' she giggled.

'Of course.'

Dixon fought against the butterflies stirring in his stomach.

'You're so sweet,' she said, checking out one of the black nylon stockings. Then she took a breath and brushed a strand of her sandy hair

back behind an ear before saying softly, 'So... are you *sure* you'll be okay with this?'

He felt a surge of butterflies trying to take control of his body.

'I'm sure,' he said, feeling his manhood thickening as he sat there in the armchair.

'I mean, you haven't even met him...'

'I trust your judgment,' he smiled. Thinking, *I'm not sure I ever want to meet him. I'm not sure I could cope with that.* 'The question is, are you sure?'

She giggled again. Something Jenni really didn't do, usually. She was a little breathless, as well. Blushing faintly, as though she was somewhat startled that this was really, actually, happening. Nervous. Somehow, it reassured him to see that she was somewhat apprehensive about all this, too.

'I'm pretty sure,' she said, slowly wandering around the room. 'I mean... I've met him twice now, including that first coffee.'

Dixon wasn't going to mention the fact that he hadn't really known about that coffee she'd had with the guy. He wasn't going to complain, not now.

'He's so hot...' she giggled again. 'I'm so *excited*. I used to dream about guys like that when I was in high school... and maybe in college.'

Dixon laughed. 'You didn't dream about finance geeks like me?'

She laughed too. 'I can't say I knew much about finance geeks like you back then,' she said. 'They didn't feature them much on the cover of *Teen Vogue* or *Cosmo* or *Seventeen*.'

'I probably wasn't much to look at back then, anyway,' he said.

Jenni glanced at her watch and then turned to face him as she started to unfasten the buttons on her shirt. 'Well, I guess I should thank you for letting me do this,' she said, smiling warmly.

'You don't have to thank me,' he said, his heart rate picking up as he realized she was going to peel off her clothes in front of him. What had he been expecting? Probably he had expected her to take her brand new lingerie and go to change in the bathroom.

'You want to watch me get ready?' she asked him, leaving her shirt half-unbuttoned in order to stoop to remove her stylish but flat shoes.

'Uh-huh,' he said.

'Okay,' she breathed, pushing down her skirt to reveal white satin panties. 'So exciting...'

Then she was back to unfastening the buttons on her shirt, and he was watching as every single one popped open. The atmosphere was

electric in there already. And the date hadn't even started.

'Does it feel strange, watching me getting ready to fuck another guy?' she asked, offering him a mischievous smile.

'Strange...' he nodded.

'In a good way?' she pulled open her shirt to expose her white bra.

'Uh-huh.'

She laughed, lifting both hands to brush her hair back over her shoulders, thereby giving him a superlative view of her body in nothing but her elegant white satin underwear. She turned before removing her bra, giving him the full 360 view. He noticed that she was gaining more and more confidence in showing off for him.

Then she turned back to reveal her bare breasts, so pale but perky, peaked by small, stiff pink nipples.

She was slow to remove her panties, enjoying the feeling of having his eyes languishing all over her body.

She leaned over the bed, telling him she really liked the underwear he'd bought for her, that it was so pretty. His attention was on her cute butt, and as she turned again to perch on the edge of the mattress to pull on her black stockings, he was interested in just how hard her nipples were.

She was really excited.

'They fit nicely,' she said, pulling the stockings into place, one by one. Flashing him a gorgeous view between her thighs as she did so. 'You like me wearing stockings?'

'You look incredible.'

She smirked, partly self-conscious and unaccustomed to so much attention from him, but nevertheless delighted and thrilled at him watching her and getting excited about how she looked. She clearly enjoyed being watched. She enjoyed turning him on as he watched her — though she still had that slight air of awkwardness, not yet fully confident in how she looked from every angle. Not yet entirely accustomed to his outright adoration.

She put on her bra next, jade green with black trim, lacy but sheer enough to show her nipples. Then she reached for her suspender belt and slung it around her waist before standing up to fasten it, and then connect the straps to her stockings. She seemed to like having something to do while he watched her — it distracted her from the awkwardness of her exhibitionist inexperience.

'You know I have a date on Saturday, as well?' she said, as though she'd figured that conversation might also distract from her self-

consciousness.

‘With this guy? With Tom?’ he asked her, his cock throbbing in response to her announcement.

‘No. Jonathan.’

He chuckled. ‘How many guys are you dating right now?’ But he was so stoked to hear she had a date with someone else as well. Somehow, the idea that she might play the field was reassuring, making this seem more about the sex than about finding a special someone with whom to forge an emotional connection.

‘I don’t know... I’ve been talking to a few guys...’ she grinned, blushing. Then she blurted out, ‘It’s so hard to choose — there are so many guys on that website that contacted me...’

She stooped to step into her panties — a tiny scrap of matching black and jade green, the lace so sheer it was almost totally transparent. He was so fired up to see her like that. To hear that she was dating ‘a few’ guys rather than just Tom. He was so hard for her.

The frustrating thing, of course, was that he couldn’t give in to his burning lust right now and take her right there on the bed. She was someone else’s tonight.

‘...Why, would you prefer it if I only saw one guy?’

He shook his head. ‘I just want you to have fun, honey. The more, the merrier — you know, so long as you’re safe.’

‘I have condoms in my bag,’ she giggled as she pulled her panties into place. ‘Isn’t that weird?’

They hadn’t used condoms since they were first dating, after which she’d gone on the pill. It was oddly arousing to think of Jenni having to buy them, to take them on her date. To use them.

‘How do I look?’ she said with a grin, giving him a slow twirl.

‘Amazing.’

‘You like it?’

‘Oh, yes.’

‘You think he’ll like it?’

‘Unless he’s blind,’ they both chuckled. ‘And even if he was — ’

There was a beeping sound from her bag, which made her jump. She was still nervous, then. She retrieved her phone and squealed with delight. ‘He’ll be here in ten minutes to pick me up,’ she said.

Ten minutes. Dixon’s manhood swelled and pulsated, and yet he felt generally terrified.

‘You know I love you, don’t you?’ she said earnestly. Could she read the terror on his face?

‘Of course,’ he said, trying to appear calm.

‘And as soon as I’m done with him,’ she said, moving to the closet, ‘I’ll be with you again. Yours.’

‘Mm-hmm,’ he nodded.

As soon as she’s done. As soon as she’s been fucked by the other guy.

She was pulling on blue jeans — smart, designer, skin-tight, and yet merely blue jeans, pulled on over the top of her scandalously sexy underwear.

‘You’ll be okay, won’t you?’ she said, hopping to get the jeans in place and fasten the fly button, they were so tight. ‘While I’m with him...?’

‘Oh, sure.’

Dixon looked at her pretty face as she pulled on a fairly plain white top, thinking *the next time I see you, you’ll be an adulteress*. Or was it ‘adulterer’ these days for women, too? The gender-neutral approach, like how the stars of stage and screen were all called ‘actors’ these days, rather than actors and actresses.

The next time I see you, you will have had another man between your legs, another man’s cock inside your sex.

She put a pale gray jacket on over the top of her white top, and then pulled out a pair of pointed black leather boots that went up quite far on her calves. It was an elegant look, though not dressy. Clothes for a date with a guy she did not yet know all that well, on an evening when she wasn’t entirely sure what they would be doing.

‘Do I look okay?’ she said, presenting herself.

‘Better than okay.’

He watched her do her makeup, put on her perfume. She looked so good. She might have been mistaken for a 25-year-old.

Then she checked her bag — showed him the little box of condoms she had ready, which nearly made him come in his pants like some uncontrolled teenager — and she was ready. Dixon pulled himself up to his feet, which he didn’t want to do because of a particular situation in his pants, but could not avoid if he wanted to kiss her goodbye.

She was giggling, noticing the bulge in his pants. Ah well. She kissed him sweetly, and her hands sprawled all over it, reveling in the physical proof that he was on board for this, that he wanted her to actually do it.

Then, with a nervous little wave, she was out of the front door and away.

Jenni was on her way to commit adultery.

Now what? For a while, he sat there, not moving. He just stayed in the apartment. This was where they would come back, afterward. Assuming all went well during dinner, Jenni would bring him back here. They would fuck on this bed.

Dixon felt a little shiver of fear and excitement saunter through his frame.

It was really happening. Hard to believe, almost. But he hadn't given much thought to what he was supposed to do all evening. The assumption was, he supposed, that he would leave this apartment. Find something to do in the city. Eventually, Jenni would be done with her lover, and then she would call him, and he would return to her.

It wasn't like he could go home. Ophelia was taking care of the kids, and she wasn't expecting him home. There might be questions about why he was home, while Jenni was not.

He pulled himself up from the chair. He supposed it was his job to tidy up the apartment, make it ready for when Jenni and Tom came here. Not that Tom would be suspicious — he knew she was married; they were both using Ashley Madison to arrange an affair, after all. But Dixon still took the framed photographs of himself and Jenni and quietly put them in a drawer. And before leaving, he tidied away the clothes she'd just changed out of — slipping those little white satin panties into his pocket.

Then he was out the door, down the elevator, wishing the concierge a pleasant evening on the way out. Did the guy wonder why he and Jenni had exited separately? But he was paid not to judge.

Dixon wandered out onto the street. He felt a little strange in having nowhere to go and nobody to take him there. He walked down Fulton, to DeLury Square. Midtown Comics was open — it was until 8pm. So that's where Dixon was until 8pm, his attention buried in tales of colorful superheroes and despicable villains. When the place was closed, he wandered further down the street toward the East River, and ducked into the small McDonald's.

How long had it been since he'd had a Big Mac? It wasn't as good as he remembered.

When he was finishing up, his phone was buzzing. A message from Marriage 2.0. He raised his eyebrows — he hadn't been expecting instructions from them.

Marriage 2.0: Take a cab to Macy's before 9.30pm.

Macy's. What was supposed to happen in Macy's? Was he meant to go shopping for something? More fancy lingerie for one of Jenni's dates? If so, why did he need to go to Macy's? There had to be places closer than that. If this was part of his adventure with Jenni, did it mean something would happen in Macy's?

Would Jenni be there with Tom?

Despite all the questions, Dixon walked up toward Broadway to catch a yellow cab to head straight over to the large department store on Herald Square. He might have doubts and concerns about what would happen in Macy's, but instructions from Marriage 2.0 seemed to turn out okay, so he would comply.

Perhaps they were simply giving him something to occupy his mind while Jenni dated — and then fucked — Tom. Something simple like shopping for sexy underwear for his wife to show off on her next date.

It was nine o'clock by the time he set foot in the establishment that proclaimed itself — on a giant red banner on the corner of Herald and 34th — to be the 'world's largest store.' But there were no further instructions from his Marriage 2.0 app for now.

He went inside and began wandering about.

Was he supposed to buy perfume?

Was he supposed to buy lingerie?

Some kind of sexy dress that she could wear at a nightclub with someone?

He kept an eye on the time, watching as his Rolex Oyster ticked closer to 9.30. Riding the wooden escalators between floors. He also kept an eye on his phone — surely there would be another message telling him whereabouts in the store to be at 9.30? It was the world's largest store, for crying out loud, as long as you quietly forgot about the Shinsegae that opened in South Korea in 2009. Yeah, he had time to Google Macy's claim while he was strolling around its brightly-lit floors.

'What the hell are you doing here?'

It was 9.25 and 43 seconds, and he was wandering through the women's dresses on the fourth floor when he heard that familiar voice. Just the voice he really didn't want to hear right now.

Gaines.

'Hey, Marty,' he smiled. 'It's Jenni's birthday coming up... so, you know...'

Gaines scratched his head. 'But you have... assistants to do that for you, right? Personal shoppers...?'

The man was blushing slightly, a little sweat on his forehead. He looked, Dixon thought, as though he'd just been caught with his hands in the cookie jar.

Dixon smiled, trying to act calm, though he was terrified he would miss his window for whatever Marriage 2.0 had planned. 'So what are *you* here for?' he asked his long-time business partner. Could he call the guy his 'friend'? It hadn't felt like that for a while, sadly.

He was curious about Gaines being there. It felt like a nasty coincidence. And Dixon didn't really believe in coincidences, particularly when he was right in the middle of an adventure devised by Marriage 2.0.

Surely Gaines couldn't be part of all this?

'I've been seeing this girl who works on the perfume counter...'

'Seriously?' Dixon laughed. 'I feel like I've heard of that story before... the billionaire and the shopgirl. Should I start calling you 'Christian Gray?'

'Don't.'

'Or is this more of a King and I kind of deal?'

'The chick in that movie was a teacher,' Gaines corrected him, although Dixon liked that he didn't correct him about the 'king' part. Then he said, 'Look: you can laugh, buddy, but you should see her. She should be a model.'

'And I'm sure that's why she's dating *you*,' Dixon chuckled.

'What do I care? She's twenty years old, and she has a pussy as tight as your asshole,' Gaines slapped Dixon on the back like they were still bros in Dartmouth.

Dixon joked, 'So rare that they're tight when you have such a small —',

'Hey, buddy, you know *that's* not true.'

Gaines was looking all around them as they walked toward the women's shoes. While he was looking away, Dixon took the opportunity to briefly glance at his phone. Still no messages from Marriage 2.0.

Dixon said, 'Uh... so you realize that the perfume department is down on the ground floor? Right by the entrance?'

'Her colleagues said she was up here today,' he said. 'Who knows? Maybe she got a promotion.'

Jesus. It was way past 9.30 now. Where was he supposed to be? Dixon jumped as a loud announcement rang around the store's tannoy system.

‘Will shoppers please note that the store closes in 15 minutes. Please make your way to your nearest sales point to make your purchase.’

Gaines sighed, a little pissed at his date for giving him the runaround, no doubt. He glanced at Dixon, ‘You gonna buy anything, buddy? ’Cause... you know... now’s your chance.’

Dixon said, ‘So why are you meeting her at her workplace? You couldn’t send a car for her?’

Gaines gave a little shifty eye-roll. Then he huffed and said, ‘Okay. So she has this... little kink, you might say. She wants me to be here at closing time... so we can go do it on the beds up on Floor 9.’

Dixon burst into laughter. ‘You’re going to fuck her in *Macy’s*?’

‘I don’t know. She has this thing about large department stores.’

‘You could probably afford to get one to actually let you take her shopping after closing time, couldn’t you?’

‘I think... doing it on the sly is supposed to be half the fun.’

It really was getting near to closing time. Dixon was getting increasingly nervous. Where was he supposed to be? Was this going to end up in some bizarre, nightmarish situation where he was shepherded into watching Gaines, of all people, banging a 20-year-old shop assistant?

The thought did not particularly turn him on. Actually, it somewhat suggested to Dixon that he wasn’t simply a voyeur. Whatever his personal kink was, it appeared to involve Jenni at its heart.

A thought flashed through his mind. Oh, Jesus. That was not a good thought.

The trouble was, there seemed to be too many coincidences going on. Dixon’s mind started trying to link up the loose ends, leading to the thought that *Jenni* might be the ‘20-year-old shop assistant’ that Gaines believed he was here to fuck after hours. It was a shocking thought — quite made the ground shake under his feet.

‘You okay, buddy?’ Gaines said.

‘Yeah, yeah, fine.’

He started formulating reasons why it could not possibly be true: Gaines had met Jenni often enough, especially in the early days before they were married. Gaines had been his Best Man at their wedding, for Christ’s sake. He couldn’t mistake Jenni for a 20-year-old stranger. He couldn’t believe her to be 20, for a start. Maybe a 25-year-old, just about.

The scary thought was that you could pose as just about anyone online. What if Jenni had been talking to Gaines via Ashley Madison and had made him believe she was a 20-year-old shop girl?

‘You need a sit-down, old man?’ Gaines said.

‘No, I’m okay.’

True enough, Dixon was breathing a little deeply. Shock was taking hold of his system.

Surely Marriage 2.0 wouldn’t engineer such a scenario? Jenni sleeping with Gaines, of all people...

The trouble was that Marriage 2.0 had already shown that it was more than capable of taking this adventure in directions Dixon did not like, making him feel uncomfortable along the way. Sure, ultimately, it had all been sexually exciting to him so far...

Dixon groaned. He was hard as a rock. He couldn’t get the image of Gaines meeting up with Jenni somewhere in this store after closing time, taking him up to one of the beds in the furniture department or in the bedding department, and letting him fuck the living daylights out of her.

How could that be such a turn-on? Jesus, he was messed up.

‘I could call someone if you like,’ Gaines was saying. He seemed genuinely concerned. Dixon was almost touched.

Then Dixon stopped in his tracks. Gaines did likewise, but seemed confused about why. Then, he also saw what Dixon had spotted.

Jenni had just stepped off one of the elevators. Dixon was one hundred percent certain it was her — she was still wearing the same outfit, the gray jacket, white top, blue jeans, and black boots. Carrying her black bag over her shoulder. A dark-haired guy wearing dark slacks, a white shirt, and a dark gray jacket stepped off the elevator, too. Jenni glanced at him and smiled.

And then the two of them held hands — like they were dating.

Dixon shoved Gaines hard, pushing his business partner out of the way behind a waist-high shelving unit bearing women’s sports shoes. He hissed at him to get down, while dropping into a crouch himself.

‘What the — ?’ Gaines was saying, all wide-eyed with astonishment.

Carefully, they both edged upward to peer over the shoes on display on the top of the shelving unit. Dixon felt mild relief sweep through his system — because neither Jenni nor her date had seen him or Gaines. Jenni was clearly on a date with the dark-haired guy whose hand she was holding, which meant she wasn’t here to bang Gaines.

They were walking together, occasionally looking at some of the dresses along their way. Dixon thought they might be too far away to have spotted him and Gaines diving behind this rack of shoes — but also, it was pretty clear their attention was more on each other than the shop around them.

Dixon loved watching how Jenni walked with him. She seemed so feminine, so graceful. She was being flirtatious with every molecule of her body. And it was so obvious how happy and excited she was.

‘What the hell’s going on?’ Gaines hissed beside him.

Seeing him this close, Tom seemed to be about 30-ish, perhaps even late twenties. It was slightly less startling when Dixon remembered that his wife was younger than him — but there was still an unexpectedly thrilling sense that this young stud could really give Jenni a heck of a ride.

Tom was about Jenni’s height, and appeared likable enough in a button-down shirt and dark pants. He wasn’t exactly male model material; he seemed very *normal* — but he was in shape, and had a certain charm.

Jenni seemed happy to take his arm as they went. If this was Jenni’s first sexual experience outside their marriage, perhaps she was purposefully going for a guy who made her feel comfortable, rather than someone who resembled a porn star. Or maybe, when she talked to guys on the Ashley Madison website, the ones who looked like your prototypical jock stud muffin, they weren’t able to type the kind of messages that would get her interested in an actual date.

‘That’s *Jenni*,’ Gaines hissed. ‘What the fuck is she doing with — ?’

Dixon groaned. This was just the wrong moment for Gaines to be around. He started mentally formulating a story about Jenni’s cousin being in town, saying, ‘No, wait — ’

But then, as they watched, Jenni stepped closer to her date, her hand moving to his chest as though she was going to unfasten one of his shirt buttons. Tom put a hand on her thigh as she moved against him, and then they were together. His hand moved around to cup her behind, and her hands were draped over his shoulders, and her face was up against his, and she was kissing him...

Gaines gave him a little nod and a smile, as though he’d figured out what was going on already.

‘*She’s cheating on you*,’ he said, as though he believed that it ought to be Dixon cheating on his wife in the natural order of things.

Dixon didn’t know what to say. In many respects, the guy was right. He held his finger up to his lips to demand silence. Jenni’s hands moved to Tom’s face, and their kiss became passionate, tongues and all. Jesus. Dixon was stiff as a board, at just the worst time.

Gaines’s grin broadened. ‘You’re not going to take some pictures? Oh... you must have a PI around here, right?’

The guy thought this was all about him trying to get a pain-free divorce out of Jenni. For now, the story would have to do.

‘Uh... something like that...’

They watched Tom press his hands against Jenni's breasts, touching her through her white top. She turned briefly to drop her bag on a nearby display table full of scarves, and went back to making out with her date like they were full-on high schoolers fooling about under the bleachers.

Dixon was so turned on. It was such a shame Gaines had to be present.

'Good man,' Gaines hissed, rubbing his hands together. The guy had such a hard-on for Dixon's marriage to be in trouble. What, did he think they could be single guys again, going out on the town together, hunting for tail? Turning back the clock to their youth...

Dixon shushed him again.

They watched Jenni break apart from Tom, smiling blissfully. She removed his jacket, saying something to him they could not hear, and then simply tossed the garment down on the floor. Wasn't she worried they would be caught?

Gaines was silent now. Watching Jenni as she french-kissed her date, as Tom fondled her breasts, right there between the women's dresses and the women's shoes. Dixon quietly enjoyed how his old friend was looking at her — not with that shit-eating smile amused that Dixon's marriage was collapsing before their very eyes. There was lust in Gaines's eyes, envy. His silence spoke of a long-harbored desire for Dixon's wife. Like he'd always wanted her, but she'd always been the one woman he could never have.

Dixon kind of liked how he so clearly wanted her.

Now it was Jenni's turn to remove her jacket, which also ended up on the floor. Then there was a quiet gasp from both men hiding among the Jimmy Choos and the Guccis and the Gianvito Rossis — as they watched Jenni slowly kneel down in front of her date, her hands at his waist.

'My *God*...' Gaines whispered as they watched her unfasten the dark-haired man's belt and pull down his pants. And it wasn't Gaines taunting Dixon because his wife was unfaithful; Gaines was obviously taken aback at how bold and beautiful Jenni was, though she was grasping a stranger's hard cock right out in the open like this.

Dixon felt all kinds of emotions flooding through his body as he watched his wife take the guy's dick in her hands, then duck down to lick it from the base to the tip. It was such an incredible thrill. But strangely, having Gaines there to watch her with him only made the excitement more powerful.

Why could that be?

Jenni took her date's cock in her mouth, closing her eyes as though it was the most pleasurable experience. The guy had a sizable appendage; she had to stretch her lips around it. She was delighted with it, however, as she started bobbing on it while squeezing and pumping the massive shaft in her hand.

Jesus.

Jenni — his Jenni — sucking on another man's dick. And loving every minute of it.

Who could have thought she could be so wicked? Gaines certainly hadn't thought so. He looked totally dumbfounded as he watched her, his eyes wide, his mouth open.

Jenni gazed up at her date as she licked around the top of his cock, and then she grabbed his butt with her spare hand, brushed her long, golden hair back over her shoulder, and forced as much of his length into her throat as she could.

'Jesus,' Gaines breathed, echoing Dixon's thoughts.

She was doing things with her date that Dixon simply didn't recognize. She'd never gone down on him for this long. She'd never sucked on his balls, her hand pumping his shaft. She'd never gotten that kind of length of his cock down her throat.

They watched her grin up at Tom, and then her fingers were working on his shirt buttons while she continued to inhale his cock. His shirt fell open to reveal a toned chest, a fine set of abs. Tom, whoever he was, was no stranger to the gym, though he wasn't into bodybuilding.

And then Jenni was really going at him, her face flushed, perspiration beginning to show on her forehead. And Tom flinched, spasmed, and hunched over, groaning as he quite clearly came down her throat.

Dixon could hear her moaning, almost purring like the proverbial cat that got the cream, as she worked to swallow every ounce of her date's come. One last spurt escaped her pretty lips when she finally pulled back, a drop running down her chin, falling onto her chest. But she wiped it up with a finger, sucking on it with a devilish grin as she gazed up at Tom, who was standing straight again, recovering.

'Jesus, Joseph and Mary *Fucking* Poppins,' Gaines whispered.

Dixon wondered vaguely why he hadn't gone to find his 20-year-old shop girl with the tight pussy. It was way past closing time now.

But neither Gaines nor Dixon moved an inch as they watched Tom lean down to kiss Jenni firmly on the mouth, as she told him something that appeared to be how much she loved sucking his cock, and then gave the aforementioned cock one last long lick from base to tip. Both Gaines

and Dixon were frozen right where they knelt, as Tom held Jenni's hands and helped her up.

The two lovers embraced again for another sweet kiss, which ended only when Tom ducked down to pull up his pants.

Dixon and Gaines only moved after they had seen Jenni and Tom reach for their jackets and walk merrily off toward the nearest elevator.

Finally, they stood up, and Gaines said breathlessly, 'Hey — once the divorce is all done and dusted... you wouldn't mind it if I... you know... *spent a little time with Jenni?*'

Dixon felt the dueling emotions of pride and disgust. He gave his business partner one hell of an eye-roll, said, '*Seriously?*'

And then he walked off.

'Hey, I was kidding!' he heard Gaines calling out from behind him. 'I was *kidding*, man! *Hey!*'

But his outrage was a suitable excuse for Dixon to get the hell away from Gaines.

He had to apologize on his way out, mumbling something about getting lost in the luggage department on Floor 9. The security guard who let him out onto Herald Square didn't seem in the slightest bit annoyed — or even surprised — that he was late getting out of there.

It almost made Dixon suspect that he was in on the whole thing. Perhaps Marriage 2.0 had paid Macy's a little money to allow that entire thing to go on.

Out on the street, he felt his phone buzzing in his pocket. Seriously? Now? There was, of course, a message from you-know-who.

Marriage 2.0: Time to get back to 19 Dutch.

Dixon hailed a cab, and quickly hopped inside when one stopped for him, barking the address at the driver as though he was ordering him to 'follow that car.'

19 Dutch. There could only be one thing that was happening at 19 Dutch. Jenni was taking Tom back to their apartment for full sex.

Jesus H Christ.

As the cab pulled away from the curbside, Dixon took one last look at Macy's, and spotted Gaines emerging from the front entrance, looking somewhat dazed and confused. Shaken, in fact. He glanced around

Herald Square in complete bewilderment, as though he had inexplicably traveled in time, and now couldn't believe where he had ended up.

Then the cab was away from there. Dixon had so much running through his mind. Marriage 2.0 had, somehow, got him in precisely the right place to watch Jenni fool around with her date in Macy's. How had they managed it? He had turned up at the right time, sure. He'd wandered throughout the store — and then Gaines had stopped him right there on Floor 4 to ask what he was doing there.

Was Gaines in on this whole thing? Gaines had delayed him just long enough for him to be in the right place when Jenni came out of that elevator with her date. Gaines had said he was there to meet a 20-year-old shopgirl. Was the shopgirl a Marriage 2.0 performer? Or the person who had told Gaines that she was up on Floor 4? Or all of them?

He felt paranoia seizing hold of him — what was real in all this, and what was not? It was hard to distinguish.

From the way Gaines had looked, coming out of the entrance of Macy's after all that, Dixon felt reasonably confident that he hadn't been part of the whole Marriage 2.0 adventure strategy — at least not directly. But had the people — or the artificial intelligence — at Marriage 2.0 simply used him as a pawn in their plans?

It all seemed like too much coincidence that he happened to be there.

Tom had to be a Marriage 2.0 performer, didn't he? Dixon felt it was the only way to get everything lined up. Tom must have had one of those tiny earpieces in his ear, and when he was told where Dixon was at that moment, he had taken Jenni to the relevant floor so that Dixon could watch Jenni go down on him.

It made sense. It made a hell of a lot more sense than the fact that Samantha had been involved in all this before Dixon had even decided to use the Marriage 2.0 service.

Gaines was a complication, of course. It was a strange little erotic bonus that he'd been there to watch Jenni sucking Tom's cock, and it had been so obvious how much Gaines had wanted her. But now he would be sure that Dixon would be splitting up with Jenni. It might take some challenging conversation to explain why he was not.

At least Gaines didn't know that Dixon *wanted* Jenni to cheat on him. That he got off on it. That would be too complicated.

19 Dutch. Dixon had to hope that his cab had dropped him off at the apartment building first. He assumed it had. He wasn't simply being led by Fate here. This was all being directed by the clever technology at

Marriage 2.0. Of course he would arrive first. He would arrive and go up to the apartment, and — what? Hide in the closet? Behind the curtain.

Because surely, he was here at this time because he was going to watch Jenni with Tom? He'd seen her suck the man's cock. How else did you top that?

He nodded a quick greeting to the concierge and then headed up to the appropriate floor for their apartment. His heart was pounding. The big question currently doing the rounds in his head was simply — what if he got caught? What if Tom opened the closet, and there he was? Would the guy simply laugh and close the closet again, carry on fucking his wife? If the guy was a Marriage 2.0 performer, did it matter?

Surely he wasn't there to openly watch his wife fucking another man? He'd been so clear with Clayton that such a situation would be unacceptable.

As he wandered down the hallway toward their apartment, there was another buzz from his phone. He felt a little tingle of hope — was he getting instructions on where to hide?

Marriage 2.0: Go into Apartment 23J.

Dixon paused. 23J? That was the apartment next door to theirs. Breathing a little more deeply, he walked on — past the front door to his own apartment — and on to 23J. What was going on? He didn't even know who lived in apartment 23J. He'd never met any of his neighbors, he stayed at this place too sporadically.

Another deep breath. He knocked on the door of 23J. There was no reply. Confused, he tried the door handle.

It opened.

Dixon glanced either side down the hallway. Was he supposed to wait for Jenni to finish with Tom in the apartment next door? Perhaps he would even be able to hear them fucking. God. His heart was beating faster and faster. He went inside apartment 23J. It was similar to his own place, except that his apartment was a corner apartment.

'Hello?'

Did anyone live here? It seemed to be empty, although furnished. The lights were all on, even the bedside lamps. Like a hotel suite ready to be occupied. There was nothing in the fridge in the kitchen, nothing in the cupboards. Had they rented this place just to give him somewhere to be while Jenni slept with Tom? To allow him to hear everything that went on, live? If so, he was beginning to understand why the program had cost him \$100,000.

He wandered through the living/dining room to the bedroom. It had to share the same wall with the bedroom in his apartment — were the walls thin enough for him to listen to Jenni having fun with her date? His heart was beating ferociously fast now. He glanced at his watch. Would Jenni and Tom be arriving soon? It didn't take this long to drive down from Midtown. Had Marriage 2.0 somehow directed them onto the subway so they'd take longer?

Perching down on the bed, he was feeling a slight hunger pang, and wondered if he might have time to dial out for pizza before Jenni was finished with her date. Then, suddenly, all the lights in the apartment went out. He was left in semi-darkness, only lit by the thin light coming in through the floor-to-ceiling windows — the lights of the city outside.

'What the — ?' he said, trying to remember where the fuse box was in his own apartment, since it would most likely be in the same place in this one.

But then, as he rose from the bed, he turned and saw the most bizarre thing. At first, he thought the wallpaper spread across the wall behind the bed must be mirrored, somehow. Even though it looked like perfectly normal wallpaper in the full light, when the lights were off, somehow he saw a reflection of everything in the bedroom, across the entire wall of the room. But as his eyes got a little more used to the dimmer light, and the sight before him, he realized that it couldn't be a mirror he was looking at.

Firstly, as he looked at the wall, the 'reflected' bedroom he saw was not quite laid out exactly like this one. The bed was in the right place, but there was an armchair in the corner of the room he was looking at, but not in this one. The bedside lamps were different.

And he himself was not present in the 'reflection' he could see through the bedroom wall.

When he saw a light switched on beyond the bedroom door, he suddenly realized this wasn't a mirror at all. It was a screen. He was looking through the wall into the bedroom of his own apartment. The whole wall was one giant window.

He gasped as he saw the bedroom door in his apartment open, and Jenni walk through, wearing that white top and her jeans, though not her jacket or boots. Tom walked in after her, and Dixon dropped to the floor at the end of the bed in sheer terror, as he assumed they would be able to see him, too, and would perhaps want to know why he was in there watching them, and why their bedroom wall had turned into a window at some point during the evening.

But when he pulled his head back over the top of the mattress, he could see that Tom and Jenni were acting as though there was nothing at all out of the ordinary about their bedroom. Tom had his shirt undone, and the two of them were talking and flirting, and it was clear what was going to happen between them.

Could they really not see through the wall, as he could?

Dixon picked himself up off the floor. He cautiously stepped toward the wall between the two bedrooms. Was it a one-way window? A one-way mirror, like they had in police interview rooms so the witness could identify the suspect without revealing their identities?

It was incredible.

He could watch his wife seduce another man, and neither of them would see him enjoying the exhilarating show.

Dixon sat on the bed beside the bedside table, watching as Tom sat down in the armchair in the corner by the windows. Jenni walked in front of the young man, peeling off her white top to reveal her bare stomach and the black and jade green lacy bra Dixon had gotten for her date.

It was insane. It seemed like Dixon was in the same room with them — but they had no idea he was there.

Jenni threw her top at Tom, smiling and giggling, and then started unfastening her jeans. Wow. She looked so beautiful.

This was just sensational.

Jenni turned to face the wall, away from Tom, toward her husband, before pulling down her jeans. She was showing off her butt in the sexy matching g-string, framed by her stockings and suspenders. At the same time, it looked to Dixon as though she was showing off her cleavage to her husband.

Tom looked impressed by what he saw. Dixon enjoyed seeing the lust on the guy's face.

Now she wiggled out of her skin-tight jeans, slowly dragging them down to her ankles to expose her shapely legs, still facing away from her date. She stepped out of her jeans and then continued to stand there, flaunting herself to him, almost seeming to slowly dance for him, tugging on the waistband of her panties to tease him.

Tom shuffled to the edge of the armchair, apparently torn between the desire to take her right there and then or sit back and enjoy the show.

Jenni turned to face her date, still gently stirring her hips left and right in that slow dance, and Tom stayed put as he watched her slip off her bra, releasing her gorgeous breasts. Another slow twirl, and she was facing away from the dark-haired stranger as she slowly tugged her

panties down over her shapely behind, before allowing them to drop down her thighs, off her legs to the floor.

She was so confident, dancing for him. It was so sexy.

Then Tom stepped up behind her, unable to resist her temptation any longer. He kissed her shoulder, and she turned her head to kiss his mouth, then he bent down to take her cute butt in both hands and kiss along the small of her back.

Dixon could hardly believe what he was seeing. They were both so close to him, but apparently had no idea he was there. He could go up to the wall and place his hands on it, right against where Jenni had her hands on their side of the wall, as Tom kissed her shoulder and slid his hands over her bare pussy. And though there was no microphone providing full sound, he could hear Jenni moaning through the wall as her lover touched her.

Jenni turned to face Tom, to kiss him on the mouth and begin unfastening the buttons on his shirt — and at his fly.

Dixon caught a delectable view of her rear. But this was not a giant television screen he was staring at, it was a window pane — even though somehow it was disguised when Jenni and Tom saw it. Dixon could step to the side, and look around his wife to see her fingers gripping the other man's hard cock, his hands on her tits.

They kissed, mouth-to-mouth, sucking on each other's lips and tongues, and as she pumped his shaft, Dixon stepped to the other side of his wife and saw that Tom had his fingers between her thighs, stroking her bare pussy.

'Oh... oh... *oh*...' he heard his wife gasping, and thought Tom must have his fingers attached to her clit.

Dixon perched on the bed and now pulled out his own cock. He knew he'd have to be careful — he was already highly aroused, and it would be far too easy for him to make himself come quickly, so that he might not appreciate the rest of the show in the next bedroom. But he had to have some physical response to what he was seeing.

He began to stroke his shaft while watching Jenni turn away from her date once again, presenting her rear as though she wanted him to fuck her like that, up against the wall.

At first, though, the dark-haired man sank to his knees, his hands grabbing hold of Jenni's behind, pulling apart her cheeks. Dixon couldn't see around her body well enough to catch the guy's mouth, but it was clear as he sank his face between her cheeks that he was eating her from behind. Dixon got to watch the delightful sight of his wife's face as she

gasped and moaned in pleasure, closing her eyes and opening her mouth, tilting her head back in sheer ecstasy.

It was as erotic to watch Jenni's response to her lover as it was to watch the actual explicit details of their coupling. The way she smiled, the way she moaned, the way she gasped for breath. The way she seemed to melt when his tongue sank into her pussy, and when his fingers entered her.

She seemed to change her demeanor as he finally hauled himself to his feet, and removed his pants completely. She turned to look back at him, glancing at his cock as he rolled a condom down its entire length, her eyes flashing with fire. Then he was directing the tip of his cock between her thighs, and toward her entrance, and easing forward.

Jenni closed her eyes, and her jaw dropped. She looked as though she couldn't believe what was happening — and almost as though she was in severe pain all of a sudden.

Dixon nearly came on seeing it, realizing that this man was now entering his wife.

Jenni was crossing that line, the actual boundary into infidelity. Now, there could be no Clinton-esque fudging of definitions as to whether foreplay was really part of sex. This other man was now inside Dixon's wife, thrusting his big, hard dick into her freshly-waxed, soaking wet pussy.

Dixon gasped himself as he contemplated this moment, this *event*. One era had ended, and another had begun.

His wife was unfaithful. Wicked, sexy, *unbelievably* gorgeous, and a bona fide *adulteress*. Albeit with her husband's consent.

He watched her facing him, her palms flat on the wall between them, supporting her jiggling body while the dark-haired stranger jerked his hips and thrust his big cock into her again and again.

My wife is cheating on me. My wife is fucking someone else.

He felt surprised at how he felt. He'd always feared that it would come to this point and he would realize the folly of his ways, he would see the vulnerability of their marriage, he would recognize in her eyes the desire of his wife to leave him, feel the fear and the jealousy associated with losing her. But there was only pure adrenalized excitement. His hand squeezed his hardness, and it felt like there was nothing but his hardness, nothing else registering any other feelings.

He watched his wife's body rocking, her breasts shuddering, her sandy hair swaying, her face screwed up as she coped with powerful feelings sweeping through her frame. Dixon had never wanted her more.

He watched them move to the bed, with Jenni on top, riding him while still facing the wall and her husband. When she sat up, Dixon could see the other man's cock sinking into her bare pussy. He heard her through the wall, gasping for breath, riding him so quickly, so roughly, it was almost as though she was riding a champion racehorse in the Kentucky Derby.

She looked so hot, still wearing her stockings and suspenders.

Strangely as he watched her, Dixon felt the confusing desire for Gaines to be there to watch as well. To show his old business partner just how hot Jenni could be, to prove to him just what an incredible experience it was to watch her, let alone to get to actually fuck her.

To prove Gaines wrong to doubt their marriage. To ridicule his theory that a gifted businessman could only reach the pinnacle of success by trading his wife in for a younger model every few years.

If only Gaines was here to see Jenni fucking this guy in her stockings and suspenders, giving him the ride of his life. Jenni, so sexy as she fucked this stud like a goddess, until he was just about ready to explode. Jenni setting the bar for all Tom's future sexual partners, making him doubt he would ever sleep with another woman and not find himself thinking about fucking Jenni instead.

Jenni, lying beside him as they both recovered their breath, curling up against him with her hand on his hard dick, peeling off the condom. Jenni, kissing his mouth as she pumped his bare cock, her hand accelerating as she progressed, until his balls contracted and his shaft jerked, and he was shooting trails of cream all over her smooth skin, her stomach, her breasts, her upper arm, her face.

Dixon tried to dispel Gaines from his mind. Gaines wasn't part of this. Gaines wasn't part of his adventure.

Afterward, they were both smiling. Jenni sat up, seeming slightly self-conscious all of a sudden, slightly awkward — perhaps because the sex was over now, and now came the uncertainty about what Tom's intentions were, did he stay longer, hope for another round, or did he head straight for the door?

Perhaps she was just self-conscious because she had his sticky come all over her face and chest.

Dixon watched as the two of them talked, about what he did not know since he couldn't hear. And Jenni seemed to relax a little, as though Tom had reassured her about something. He had the air of somebody who had done this before. Jenni had the air of someone who had never been unfaithful before, never dreamed she might be someday. And now it had actually happened, she was feeling a mixture of fear and excitement.

Tom ran his hand over her body, avoiding the parts that were obviously dripping with his cream. He parted her legs and gazed at her bare pussy, as though he was trying to keep it in his memory until the next time he had the opportunity to cheat on his wife.

Jenni smiled, enjoying his attention, and wiped some of his cream from her face with a finger before slipping that finger into her mouth.

Laughing, flirting, she brushed her hair back out of her face, and grazed her finger over her breasts — before, again, slipping that finger into her mouth with a mischievous grin. Tom stroked her inner thigh, smiling, talking about something. They kissed, mouth-to-mouth. Were they going to wait for more?

But then Jenni pulled herself up again, her face and chest slightly pink with that post-coital glow of efforts exerted and pleasures experienced. Tom shifted slightly to allow her to shuffle to the edge of the mattress and stand up.

Dixon found his heart thumping hard again, perhaps at the thought that Tom would be leaving soon, that he would get to go in there and take Jenni himself.

As Tom started reaching for his clothes in the bedroom, Jenni ambled through to the bathroom. Dixon, in apartment 23J, saw the lights come on in the en-suite there, and nearly panicked. Jesus — had they changed the layout of this place so they now shared a bathroom? No, they definitely had not. When he went to the en-suite doorway, he saw that, incredibly, he was able to see through the bathroom wall into the bathroom next door.

He could watch Jenni walk through to start the bath running as though there was only glass dividing the two apartments — and yet it was clear Jenni could not see back into this apartment.

With the bathwater running, Jenni turned to the mirror behind the sink — facing Dixon as she gazed at herself. She smiled, as though she was getting her head around what she had just done, that she was a married woman who had taken a lover. She quietly stroked a finger along one of her breasts, feeling the stickiness of her lover's come, before putting her finger in her mouth again, tasting Tom's emissions.

Dixon felt a little ripple of pleasure at how clear it was that Jenni had enjoyed her experience.

He watched her stroking her skin — on her stomach, her breasts, her upper chest — rubbing the cream into her soft skin. She leaned back slightly, running her hands through her hair as though to brush out the tangles, the dampness of the perspiration of sex, despite having just rubbed her lover's come into her skin. It was like she was utterly saturated in her infidelity.

How much did he want to hold her in his arms right now? He was craving her like he'd never craved anything before in his life.

She stooped, and seemed to be about to remove her stockings and suspender belt, but the bathroom door opened, and she was interrupted, looking up sharply to find Tom leaning in the doorway. He was already dressed again, although his shirt was only half-buttoned.

He was telling her that he was going — she gave a little mock-pout to suggest he was sad it was time for him to leave, but accepting that he needed to. No doubt he had to get back to his everyday life, his wife, or whatever. Jenni smiled, and touched his chin with one finger as she said something, before that finger guided him in for a kiss.

Dixon felt his hardness throbbing, his stomach churning a little. There was some affection between them, but he told himself it was only because they had just had sex. It was difficult to completely detach sex from emotion. You had sex, and it was only natural that the body would translate that as being a romantic activity. It didn't mean she *loved* him.

Back in the bedroom, Tom picked up his jacket, and his wallet, and then something from the bed that Dixon couldn't quite ascertain until he held it up to her. Jenni's panties. She took them from him, twirled them in her fingers, and then tucked them in his inside jacket pocket. He smirked, and Dixon thought how dangerous it might be for the guy to return home with another woman's underwear in his pocket. Unless he really was simply a Marriage 2.0 performer, and not a real Ashley Madison user himself.

Then Jenni was escorting her lover to the front door, and once they were outside the bedroom, Dixon could no longer see them.

He went to the front door to listen, even though he couldn't see anything through the peephole. He heard the sound of the neighboring front door opening, and the murmur of Jenni and Tom's voices. They talked a little on the threshold, and Dixon could hear his wife laughing again, flirtatiously. Talking about their next date? She clearly wasn't

afraid to be seen by anyone out in the hallway. Or was she hiding behind the door? She wasn't exactly wearing much.

Dixon caught his breath when he saw Tom walk past the peephole, and then double back on himself after remembering which way the elevators were. He waited — one heartbeat, two heartbeats. But then, super cautious, he went back to the bedroom to double-check what he could see. He watched Jenni walk back through to the bathroom, switch off the flow of the water into the bath, and then turn to look at herself again in the mirror, taking a deep breath as though to settle herself.

She looked stunning, absolutely stunning. Jennifer Lawley Dixon, freshly fucked — and by another man.

When she stooped to start taking off her stockings, Dixon bolted from that other bathroom, and rushed for the front door. Tom had to be gone by now. Two steps took him from apartment 23J to apartment 23H. Four touches of the keypad opened the door for him.

When he stepped through the front door into the small apartment, he was hit instantly by the smell of sex. Jesus. Musky, earthy, with hints of her perfume and his cologne, it was his semen and her pussy, and the joining of two sweaty bodies. And there was that slight sharpness of spermicide and latex that came from the condom.

Dixon could feel his heart thumping away hard in his chest, adrenaline blazing its way through all of his blood vessels. His sweet wife had just committed adultery. He could hardly believe how turned on he was.

'Hey!'

She had heard the front door close behind him, and here she was in the bedroom doorway, wearing one of the silky white bathrobes that were always hanging up on the hook behind the bathroom door. Pleased to see him, but self-conscious because she'd just had sex with someone else.

'Hey,' he said.

'I was going to call you,' she said, hovering there, uncertain whether to go to him or not.

'And here I am,' he said, smiling.

He took a step toward her, and she looked unexpectedly wary.

'I was going to take a bath while I waited for you,' she said.

'But now you don't need to,' he said, approaching her.

‘I just... just finished with Tom...’ she said, warning him. ‘You... want me to take a shower or something?’

He scooped her into his arms and pulled her in to kiss her mouth. She tasted of wine, and of another man. Dixon sucked on her mouth and drew in a deep breath of her unfamiliar, post-coital scent. The smell of adultery. God, it was unbelievably thrilling.

Jenni seemed to pause, waiting while he kissed her for him to suddenly stop and demand that she shower, or bathe, or go for a complete spa day to get clean from her evening of extramarital sex. When he didn’t object in the slightest — and in fact, only kissed her more and more passionately, more and more hungrily, as he responded to her unclean form, she began to open up to him, to kiss him back, to enjoy their kiss.

As he kissed her, Dixon ran his hand down her body, feeling the soft satin of the bathrobe against her skin. His hand dipped between her thighs, where he felt her intense heat through the thin fabric.

‘Oh *honey*...’ she moaned, as he stroked her pussy through the satin, which quickly became drenched with her wetness.

Her own hand moved to his crotch, feeling out the bulge down there, confirming how hard he was for her, how aroused he was about her infidelity.

He slipped off her bathrobe, and then he had his hands on her bare breasts, cupping her, fondling her, feeling the slight lingering stickiness of her clammy skin, yet more direct evidence of her infidelity. Wow.

‘You’re not... horrified, then?’ she said.

‘Oh no,’ he said quickly. ‘Not at all.’

‘You’re not... disgusted... that your wife was just unfaithful?’

He put one hand behind her head, leaned in for another tender kiss. So soft, so sweet, so strange after he’d watched these lips stretching around another man’s cock. But he wasn’t repulsed by her at all. Quite the reverse. His hand dropped back down to between her legs, sweeping over her hairless mound, slipping in the copious oils of her arousal before his fingers dipped into the hot, slick folds of her pussy.

She gasped as he touched her there, and moaned as his touch turned into a caress, a thrust, a penetration. She leaned back against the bedroom doorway as he pushed his fingers inside her, as he began to stroke the inside of her juicy pussy with the tips of his fingers.

This pussy was an adulterous pussy.

So unbelievably sexy.

‘Oh honey... honey... *honey*...’ she said, breathlessly, her body gently writhing in response to his fingers, the smell of sex in the air intensifying.

Dixon dropped to his knees, his hands moving to her hips to hold her while he gazed upon the stunning beauty of her adulterous sex. He tilted forward, his lips pressing against her hot flesh, opening to allow his tongue to emerge and sample her flavor. She gasped again, her hand moving to his head as he began to taste her, pushing his tongue as far inside her as he could reach, sliding it along her slippery folds, pressing it up against her clit.

She leaned back further, as he gripped her thighs and ate her ravenously.

‘Oh God... Oh God... Oh my God...’

When she seemed close to collapsing, he allowed her to move to the bed, guiding her down on her back, parting her legs so that he could kneel down and resume feasting on her delicious sex. She came, hard, as he lapped at her juices, both her hands pressing at his head, clamping him to her, her hips gently gyrating before her climax made her jerk and shudder and flinch.

Then she was pulling his clothes off, slumping down onto the floor in front of him to take his hard cock in her hands, and in her mouth.

Saying things to him like, ‘You’re so hard...’

And, ‘I love your cock so much...’

Her mouth felt so good, but his legs were shaking like jello, so he pulled away, laying on the bed. She came after him, kneeling over him, retaking hold of his shaft, her tongue swirling around the tip of his cock.

‘Were you waiting for me?’ she asked, pulling her hair over to the other side of her head so that he could see her face while she sucked on his cock. ‘Were you waiting outside while I was with Tom?’

He could see why she might assume he’d been lurking in the hallway outside the door.

But for now, he could only grunt and moan.

‘Could you hear me with him?’ she asked him in between mouthfuls.

‘Uh-huh,’ he managed to say.

‘You enjoyed it?’

‘Uh-huh.’

‘Hearing me fucking Tom...’ She glanced up at him, smiling at how he was responding to her words. ‘It was so *exciting*,’ she said. ‘Knowing all night that I was going to take him back to the apartment for sex... coming back here... tearing off each other’s clothes...’

She lifted off him and swung her leg over to straddle his waist.

‘How long were you here?’ she asked him. ‘How much did you hear?’

‘Everything,’ he said, and she gave him the biggest, brightest smile.

She was going to sit on his cock, but he lifted her whole body, making her squeal until her knees were over his shoulders, and her pussy was over his face. He pulled her down on his mouth, flicking his tongue over her soaking groove, tasting her tangy wetness again, that hint of artificial sharpness in her flavor making him quiver a little, since he knew it was from the condom.

This sweet pussy had been stretched wide by another man’s cock.

It felt so wrong, that she’d been tarnished by another man, and yet that wrongness somehow made Dixon’s arousal all the stronger. The whole thing was riddled with wrongness — Tom getting to have his wife, spending all evening with her, fucking her to high heaven. Dixon reclaiming her while she was still freshly fucked.

‘Oh honey...’ she cried, gently rocking over him, grinding her pussy against his mouth.

He couldn’t get enough of her pussy. When they’d dated, he’d occasionally gone down on her, of course. But he’d never been into it. It was merely something he’d done as payback when she’d gone down on him. Now she was his unfaithful wife, he felt obsessed with it.

It was something about being there, so close. You couldn’t get closer than that, rubbing your face right up against her drenched pussy, wedging your mouth against her slit, slipping your tongue inside her.

As with their first kiss since she’d been with Tom, Jenni started off cautious, uncertain why he wanted to go down on her like this, so soon after she’d been with another man, unsure why he’d want to do so at all, since she couldn’t personally understand that delight of going down on a woman. But as with that earlier kiss, after a while she’d come to see that this was what he wanted. She’d opened up, relaxed, started to properly enjoy it, and after a little while had come to realize that he enjoyed this, that it was part of his ritual of taking her back, of making her his again, claiming her.

She rode his face, and glanced back past her waist to see how hard he was while he lapped at her sex. And that made her come yet again.

Only when she came down from that rapturous high was it time for her to move herself back down to straddle his waist — and insert the tip of his hard cock into her swollen pussy.

He held her tight and thrust up into her sweet sex, and he kissed her mouth. She didn't seem to object to the taste of her pussy on his lips. She smirked, as though it was all part and parcel of this crazy experience of theirs. This crazy adventure.

He wanted to laugh and tell her how incredible it had been, watching her with her lover, getting to see everything as though he was in the same room. He wanted to tell her about the insane apartment next door, the fact that you could look in here and see everything through the wall.

But he still couldn't tell her about Marriage 2.0. He was still embarrassed that he had needed to go to that company to help improve their relationship and kick-start their sex life again.

He rolled her over, thrust into her from on top, pressing his face against her neck, breathing in huge lungfuls of that strange scent, the cocktail of her perfume and Tom's cologne, of sweat and come. He turned her onto all fours, and fucked her from behind, the sweat dripping from his body as he pounded her, and she cried and whimpered like a wounded animal.

It was raw, animalistic, powerfully physical sex, almost verging on rough sex — he had never wanted her so much, and now that he had her, he was driven to take her hard and fast, with a furious passion.

She was shocked, it seemed, all the way through. In the same way that she had transformed into a goddess in his eyes by her adultery, and her newfound self-confidence, he seemed to have turned into a titan in her eyes, a giant, a hero among men.

When it finally came time for him to come, she pulled away from him and took his hardness in her hands, wanting his cream in her mouth, wanting to taste his come. She knelt down over him and took his cock deep in her mouth, and then as he felt the wave of ecstasy surge through his system, and his body began to jerk, she was there ready, gazing into his eyes as he finally shot into her mouth, and she swallowed and swallowed and swallowed, not letting a drop escape.

They both grinned and laughed, and collapsed back on the bed together, feeling like partners in crime.

He loved what it did to her. She was happier than ever, all the time. Confident. She loved attracting attention; she dressed to impress — sexy, revealing, particularly when they were out together, at the Club, or some soirée somewhere, a dinner party.

But even during the day, these days, she had turned into a real yummy mummy. Turning dads' heads when it was drop-off or pick-up time at daycare, or when the twins were at a birthday party with their little buddies, or out at some activity.

Her new confidence even had benefits for her real estate business when she started it up in earnest. Her self-belief, her swagger. Her formal, yet rather glamorous, dress sense. Her flirtatiousness with clients.

She was slow to get to actual dates, but she did a lot of fooling around online, mainly through Ashley Madison. Looking for guys, teasing them. Teasing her husband about the guys she was looking at. At first, they just rode the extreme high that came following her night with Tom. For so long after that, they just wanted to be with each other. Dixon took his wife over and over and over, remembering how it had been watching her sleeping with Tom, taking Tom's substantial cock.

Cheating on her husband.

Then there was guy #2, who worked in finance. Apparently, he was single, though he was using Ashley Madison to meet married women, which appealed to Jenni even though she never had guilt about being some kind of homewrecker. If they were on Ashley Madison already, then it wasn't her fault they were cheating. This guy was fit, attractive, and turned her on like crazy when they were chatting.

Dixon would get home each evening — arriving home reasonably early these days since he had such motivation — to find her warmed up and ready to go.

She arranged to meet up with the guy at a bar fairly close to the apartment on Dutch Street. Dixon went to watch the meeting, sitting at a distance to catch the sight of his pretty wife in a revealing red bandage dress having a rendezvous with a handsome stranger.

But he didn't show up.

It wasn't a complete loss, even so. There was the thrill of being with her as she prepared for her date, watching her getting ready to sleep with another man. There was the excitement of watching her in a crowded bar as various men gawped at her, stared at her chest, her butt, wishing she was theirs. And some of them hit on her, their interest feeding into her self-confidence and enhancing her desirability.

He even thought she might take one of those guys back with her to the apartment, but then after a while, she came to find her husband and said softly, 'Let's get out of here.'

He hid his face as they left, because there was a possibility some of those guys might recognize him, since he was occasionally featured in newspapers. Still, he felt the eyes in the room envious of him as he accompanied her out of that place. She was just stunning.

Then they went for a walk, vaguely down toward Battery Park, enjoying the emptiness of the Financial District now that the commuters had all gone home.

They passed a giant billboard featuring an advertisement for Marriage 2.0, and Dixon finally felt bold enough to open up to her.

'Would you be upset if I told you I signed up for that service?'

She looked at him, startled at first, then broke into a surprised, curious smile. 'Upset? No.'

He nodded, relieved. 'I just... you know... it wasn't because we weren't doing good together... I just... you know... thought maybe they could help... get us both back in the *groove*, you know?'

'In the *groove*?' she giggled. 'Is *that* what they're calling it these days?'

'You know what I mean... we weren't exactly having much sex...'

'*Any* sex, from what I remember...'

'*Any* sex,' he nodded.

But she was smiling and looking wholly relaxed about it all. She said, 'So that's where the whole... purple envelope came from?'

He nodded again, bashfully, flushing slightly at the revelation that he hadn't got her that particular gift himself.

She grinned. 'You know that was one of the most exciting things ever? And when you told me how much you wanted me to try it... you'd

really thought about it... that you really thought it would be good for me...’

She pulled him in for a kiss, her hands cradling his head as she smooched him, her lips so warm, so sweet, her crisp, exotic perfume tickling his libido. He found himself lifting up the hem of her dress, his hands sweeping over her gorgeous derriere, slipping down to take in her thighs, and remind himself that she was wearing stockings again.

‘Mmm...’ she purred, one of her hands finding the bulge in his pants, giving it a squeeze.

There was a noise behind them. A whoop. Drunken cheering. Dixon felt his stomach drop with fear. There was a group of young guys walking along on the other side of the narrow street, murmuring and laughing. Inebriated, they seemed to be on their way between bars. All of them wearing suits, their shirts now untucked, their ties now unfastened or loose. They cheered because they saw Jenni in her stockings, her dress shoved up to her waist.

Dixon flushed with embarrassment. And yet Jenni stepped back from her husband, smiling, giggling, and making no move to fix her dress.

She received another cheer, and loved every moment. She turned and pushed out her butt, giving them an impish, impudent display of her cheeks, her thong. She danced for them, brushed her hand through her long, golden blonde hair.

She twirled around her husband as though he was a pole on stage at a gentlemen’s club.

Dixon was terrified that the young men would come over, that they would take Jenni’s display as some kind of invitation. To touch her. Or worse. But they simply cheered again, and moved on, laughing, talking, whooping.

‘You’re *crazy*,’ Dixon told his wife.

Jenni gave a wild whoop of her own, her voice echoing among the towers flanking their street. She slipped her breasts free of her bra, and sidled up to him, beaming ear-to-ear.

‘You’ll get *arrested*.’

‘You love it,’ she said, and his erection tended to agree with her.

She took hold of him, kissed him, and his hands smothered her bared breasts, fingers finding her stiff nipples.

Then he was dutifully pulling her dress back down, covering her up.

‘You’re no fun,’ she pouted.

‘You don’t think they have CCTV around here?’ he laughed as her thrilled expression turned to horrified surprise. But then she was

laughing again, helping him pull her dress back into place, slinging an arm around him so they could walk on.

‘We should go back to the apartment,’ she said.

‘Already? The night is young!’ Dixon declared, putting his arm around her shoulders, leaning into her to kiss her forehead.

‘I’m all tingly down there,’ she said. ‘Don’t you want some of that?’

‘Mmm... maybe,’ he said, laughing. ‘You really get off on being watched, huh?’

‘Are you kidding?’ she grinned, and as they walked, she slipped the straps of her dress off her shoulders and rolled it down to expose her bra again.

He was looking around, up the street and down, fearful that other people would see her, but she didn’t seem to fear anybody. She slipped her breasts free of confinement again, ran her hands over them, flaunting them. Dancing in the street.

‘We could find another bar,’ Dixon said, wanting to get her inside as soon as possible in case the police were en route, called by some CCTV operator who spotted a public indecency offense.

‘You just want me to pick up some guy,’ she said, grinning, amused at how nervy and panicky she was making him with her exposure. She made it worse by pulling the hem of her dress upward so that her stockings and panties were revealed. ‘You want me to take a guy home and *fuck* him...’

She put a hand on his cheek, affectionate, teasing.

He kissed her briefly, between glances this way and that, checking for blue flashing lights. She reached out and groped his hard cock through his clothing. God. She was walking down the street like a model on a catwalk, daring Fate to make another group of young guys come along and catch her.

Dixon saw, or merely thought he saw, someone else walking toward them. He pulled her into a doorway, wondering if she had been sitting at that bar waiting for her date for longer than he realized. That she’d had more drinks than he’d realized, stronger alcohol. He kissed her again, tasting the alcohol on her sweet lips, and attempted to shield her from public view with his own body.

God, he was pretty horny himself. As he kissed her, he couldn’t resist touching her, his hand gliding down over her breasts, between her legs.

She was soaking wet.

‘I think I need a change of underwear if we’re going to another bar,’ she joked.

‘You could just take it off,’ he suggested.

She gave him a wicked grin.

Dixon felt a buzzing vibration in his pocket. It caught him by surprise — he put his hand in his pocket and found his phone there, brought it out. It was almost instinct to look at it and check for messages.

Jenni laughed, amused that even now, in this situation, he would check his phone for a message from work.

But Dixon felt his whole body go cold. It wasn’t a message from work. It was a notification from the Marriage 2.0 app.

Marriage 2.0: Congratulations — Your next adventure is starting.

What?

His ‘next’ adventure?

Was this the next adventure? Standing with Jenni in the middle of this street, all her underwear exposed?

‘Who the hell’s working at this time of night to send you a message?’ she said, but she didn’t seem annoyed.

‘I don’t care,’ he said, and as though trying to prove he wasn’t distracted by his phone, he ducked down and clamped his mouth over one of her breasts, finding the nipple to suck on.

‘Mmm...’ she tilted her head back, but her moan turned into a giggle at the craziness of what they were doing.

There was another buzzing from Dixon’s pocket.

‘Jeez,’ he said, reaching in to grab his phone again so he could switch it off.

Another notification from Marriage 2.0. Already?

Marriage 2.0: Suggest taking home the next guy who comes along so your wife can fuck him.

‘What is it?’ Jenni asked him.

He realized he’d been looking at the phone, somewhat stunned at what it said.

‘Oh... uh... nothing. It’s not important.’

‘Are you sure?’

‘Sure,’ he said, kissing her again. He felt his hardness throbbing, his heart rate going through the roof.

Was he really going to suggest that to her?

But then, almost without his conscious control, he found that his lips were moving, and breath was coming out of his throat to help form words: ‘The next guy who comes along — we should invite him home with us so you can have some fun with him.’

It was almost like an out-of-body experience. The kind of thing you hear about, sometimes, when people have died on the operating table and then been brought back to life by the defibrillator. Like he was standing beside himself, a third party watching himself suggesting to his wife that she fuck the next man who came along that street.

‘And you think *I’m* crazy?’ she giggled, her face seeming to light up after his suggestion.

He regretted what he’d said to her as soon as he heard it come from his mouth — but it wasn’t the kind of thing he could take back. And his whole body pulsed with strange, dark excitement at the possibility they’d even consider doing such a thing.

He kissed her and thought perhaps she’d consider it a joke suggestion. Or that they’d now wander home and wouldn’t pass anybody on the way.

Only then there were the sounds of footsteps coming along the road. Their kiss ended, and Jenni was gazing at her husband with blazing eyes.

‘What if the next guy who comes along isn’t interested?’ she asked him.

‘Are you kidding?’ Dixon said, meaning to ask her if she was kidding about really being willing to sleep with the next guy to come along. But it came out as though he was suggesting she couldn’t be serious that anybody could fail to be interested in her, looking like this.

He tried to pull her into another kiss, pressing her against the building to cover her up as much as possible as the man approached. He saw only that the guy was wearing a suit — a smart one at that, with nothing untucked or loose or out of place. However, his kiss fell on her cheek as she turned her head to the other man.

‘Well, *hello* there,’ she said, clearly in the silent street.

‘Uh... hi,’ the other man said.

‘Well, I guess *you’re* the next man who comes along, then,’ Jenni said, sounding oddly sober all of a sudden. ‘What would you do if I asked you to sleep with me?’

Dixon felt his cock throbbing like crazy. He turned his head and froze.

Gaines was standing there.

Jenni had just propositioned Gaines for sex.

Jenni was standing in the street with her dress hiked up to expose her stockings, suspenders, and panties, while her straps were pulled down to reveal her bra, though Dixon had managed to slip her breasts back inside it.

She was looking at Gaines with a sly, seductive grin.

Gaines looked astonished. But at the same time, he looked like somebody had just offered him Aladdin's magic lamp.

'What the — ' he said.

'*Jesus,*' Dixon said.

He couldn't believe this. And yet his cock was so hard, straining at his pants as he watched his long-time business partner, lapsed best friend, and current antagonist gazing upon his underdressed wife with unconcealed glee.

It was just ridiculous. It was too big a coincidence for Dixon to handle. How could Gaines just happen to be wandering down this particular street, at this particular time at night, just when he'd been instructed to suggest that Jenni bed the very next man to walk along?

'You've always wanted her,' Dixon said to the other man. It came out of his mouth like some kind of invitation, but he'd simply been considering the issues here, trying to work out what, exactly, was going on.

'What are you — ?' to Gaines's credit, he wasn't simply stepping up to Jenni to carry her away to some sordid motel room. He was confused that Jenni would say such a thing, and he was confused that Dixon wasn't enraged and shocked and upset that she would say such a thing.

Maybe the man did have a few principles left.

Jenni looked at Dixon with a mischievous smirk — did she really think she might end up sleeping with Gaines? Then she said quietly to him, 'What?'

He got the feeling she was teasing him. All the same, Dixon had this feeling of pure horror and blazing arousal all swirling around inside him. His dick was throbbing like crazy.

'What are you doing here this time of night?' Dixon asked Gaines, his arm moving across Jenni's breasts as though to cover them from the other man's view, but then he saw the envious way Gaines was looking at him, and he cupped her breasts instead, as though teasing the guy. He was teasing the guy. He liked this feeling — that he had it all, everything Gaines wanted. Jenni.

He'd never realized that Gaines might have carried a torch all these years for Jenni. But from the expression on his stunned face, it was kind

of obvious.

'I... I was with Samantha,' Gaines said. Things seemed to click in Dixon's mind. Samantha had been used one more time to get all the pieces of this adventure in place. To get Gaines where he was supposed to be. 'We were having dinner...'

'Early to be ending a date,' Dixon said.

'She told me I was too old for her,' Gaines said, oddly unafraid about revealing his dating failure.

Jenni giggled, and pulled away from her husband with a mischievous smirk, before stepping over toward Gaines, pulling down her dress, but flirtatiously brushing a hand through her hair. 'You're not too old for me, Marty,' she said.

Dixon felt the jealousy flare up inside his chest. She was teasing them both now. She loved it. The attention she was getting from both men. She stood against him, put her hands delicately on his chest, and turned to Dixon as though to plead with her husband to let her have Gaines.

Dixon felt his paranoia start ringing bells inside his head.

What if Jenni had always carried a torch for Gaines?

Women did go for Gaines. They always had. He had that devilish quality, that inexplicably innate charm that meant that though they could all tell he was probably a bastard, they all wanted him nevertheless. Was he a challenge to them? Or merely the promise of no-strings, no-holds-barred crazy wild sex?

Jenni seemed highly amused that Dixon had suggested she sleep with the next man who came along, and that next man had turned out to be Gaines. But was it more than just amusement?

Dixon had a dark, shocking thought.

He said to Gaines, 'You know I signed up to Marriage 2.0?'

Gaines looked baffled. 'What? You did what?'

'Marriage 2.0,' Dixon said.

'It's this weird marital therapy program,' Jenni explained to Gaines, gazing up at him with adoring eyes, which made Dixon's insides squirm.

'But you know that already,' Dixon told Gaines.

'What?'

Gaines still looked confused, mystified. The guy's acting skills were impressive.

'When did you sign up?' he asked him.

'Uh... why would I sign up for *marital therapy*?'

‘I don’t know,’ Dixon said. ‘But I signed up to it on my own. I assume you did, too. Samantha Bryant — did you know she’s one of them? One of their... *performers*. She came to our firm to pretend to be an intern before I even thought about signing up for Marriage 2.0.’

‘She’s... *fake*?’ Gaines seemed genuinely surprised.

‘An actress. Actor. Whatever. She acts. And she was acting as an intern *before* I signed up to Marriage 2.0 — so she wasn’t there for *my* program.’

Jenni looked a little confused, too, now.

Dixon said, ‘So did they tell you what your secret fantasy is? Is it something to do with stealing my wife?’

Gaines looked truly aghast. Pale, even. You couldn’t fake that, surely. Dixon was genuinely surprised at how the guy reacted to his accusation.

‘Honey, it’s *my* adventure,’ Jenni suddenly said.

Dixon froze to the spot, and felt his jaw virtually hit the ground.

Jenni shrugged. ‘I thought I was losing you to work,’ she said. ‘There were ads in Town and Country Magazine for this program. It said we could... you know... improve our relationship.’

Gaines produced an uncertain smile. ‘Sounds like you two have some talking to do,’ he said.

But Jenni looked up at him and said, ‘Wait, Marty. Please.’ As though she really was offering to sleep with him. Dixon felt his jealousy simmering and his erection raging.

‘I was too embarrassed to come to you and suggest we go there,’ Jenni said to her husband. ‘But the sales guy on the phone said I could come in and be assessed... and then they could find a way to persuade you to join the program later. You know, confidentially.’

‘They sent Samantha to persuade me to sign up for the program?’

‘Wait, so she really *was* fake?’ Gaines said, apparently relieved, as though it gave him a free pass as far as failing to seduce a member of the opposite sex went. His reputation was reset to the full Hugh Hefner.

Dixon muttered to himself, ‘It was so goddamn subtle.’ He slowly walked over to Jenni, who wasn’t leaving Gaines’s side. ‘So all this time, I thought this was my adventure. And I was too embarrassed to tell you I was doing it... and all the time, I’ve been part of *your* adventure?’

Jenni smiled apologetically. ‘I think technically it’s all *our* adventure,’ she said.

Gaines said, ‘I don’t know what the hell’s going on, but I feel like all of us could do with a drink right now.’

They began walking, but not toward a bar — Dixon realized they were all returning to the apartment, and nobody was questioning it. It just seemed like the natural thing to do.

They explained Marriage 2.0 to Gaines, who seemed remarkably sensible about the whole thing — not the sneering, baying, taunting aged frat boy that Dixon would have expected, belittling him for what he had done. Actually, Gaines seemed interested in the whole Marriage 2.0 proposition.

To Dixon's complete surprise, Gaines said, 'If this kind of thing had been around 15 years ago...'

'You would have used it?' Jenni asked him, surprised as her husband was about Gaines's reaction.

'Olivia...' Gaines said and gave an odd little sigh, the kind of sigh that was very un-Gaines.

'*Olivia?*' Dixon prompted him, surprised that it was Gaines's second wife who was on his mind as he thought about the prospect of using Marriage 2.0.

Now Gaines gave a longer, full-out sigh. 'Olivia was... well, unbelievable,' he said. 'I mean... Wendy was a *mistake*, if I was brutally honest, but Olivia... God. I was a fucking idiot.'

'Aww...' Jenni put her arm around him, gave him a little squeeze as they walked.

She was walking with him as though they were the couple, not she and Dixon.

'So what happened with you guys?' Gaines asked them.

It seemed so surreal. He was suddenly their friend, Dixon's friend again. The enmity of countless irritations that had built up between them over years of working together seemed to have dissipated.

But Jenni spoke before Dixon could get a word in. She said, ‘They tested me — you know, medical tests, intelligence tests, personality tests. They had this thing that went over my head and supposedly monitored my brain waves while making me think about all these weird, kind-of-erotic situations...’

‘God,’ Gaines said.

‘And then after that... they told me I’d have to wait, and when I was ready, my adventure would begin.’

‘When *you* were ready?’ Dixon asked her, thinking that they’d told him to wait until *they* were ready for his adventure to start.

Jenni grinned, ‘And it was quite a wait... but I don’t know... I kind of had this little warm feeling inside... that things were going to get better... that the adventure would start... and then something would happen... and the two of us would want to... you know... have sex again...’

Gaines glanced over at Dixon and gave him a teasing little smirk — and that was the old Gaines. Playful, insolent.

Jenni gave him a little dig with her elbow as they walked, to make him pay attention. ‘Then one day, I got this little message on their app... *your adventure is starting.*’

‘So what happened?’ Gaines asked her.

‘I got these instructions... messages via the app. Encouraging me to wear more revealing clothes... I guess Frank did seem to start noticing me more. It felt nice... I guessed that perhaps they’d managed to persuade him to sign up to the service too... and then one night... he gave me this really fancy envelope for an anniversary gift...’

‘*They* gave me the envelope to give to her,’ Dixon admitted, flushing at the embarrassment that he had not bought her wedding anniversary gift himself.

‘What was it?’ Gaines asked.

Jenni giggled and looked at her husband. ‘Do you want to tell him?’

They were entering Dutch Street now, nearing the entrance to the apartment building.

Dixon sighed. Well, they could hardly keep anything a secret from Gaines now. He said, ‘It was a membership for Ashley Madison.’

Gaines laughed. ‘*Seriously?*’

‘Seriously.’

‘You got your wife a membership for a website that specializes in marital affairs?’

Dixon said, 'I told you — they got it for her. They just told *me* to give it to her. And I was too embarrassed that I hadn't been the one to buy her anniversary gift, so I pretended I knew what I was doing buying her that present.'

'Aww, *honey*...' Jenni smiled at him, though still clutching Gaines.

'And my instructions said I was supposed to warn her she might be surprised by the present, but that she should give it a chance, and that I'd thought a lot about giving it to her...'

Gaines chuckled. 'You didn't know what it was... but you were encouraging her to use it, all the same. And not to feel guilt about using it.'

'And I had to tell her I wanted to know all about it... you know... how she got on using it...'

Gaines laughed. 'Sounds like you were well and truly taken for a ride, my friend.'

Jenni smiled. 'The thing is, when they test you... they discover your secret desires. Fantasies even you didn't know you had.'

'Okay... so that was your fantasy, buddy? For your wife to cheat on you?'

Dixon shrugged. He could hardly deny it after what had happened with Tom. But then they were going into the apartment building, giving the concierge a polite greeting as they went by, and so conversation stopped until they were in the elevator and the doors were closed.

Then Jenni said, 'I didn't open the envelope straight away, anyway. I was supposed to wait until our actual anniversary. Frank gave me the envelope a few days before, because he was going away —'

'To Gilderoy-Suffolk,' Gaines nodded. Dixon was mildly surprised that Gaines remembered the date of his wedding anniversary — and it must have been because he remembered what time of year the wedding itself had been.

'But anyway... after Frank gave me that envelope and told me to wait to open it... I went to use the gym... he went to have his supper... then after that... I went upstairs to change. And Frank... watched me.'

'He watched you change?' Gaines said as the elevator arrived at floor 23. His tone suggested that he was surprised Dixon hadn't *always* watched his wife getting changed, since he was married to her.

'You knew about that?' Dixon was astounded.

Jenni grinned as they stepped out into the hallway. 'They put cameras in all of our rooms,' she said, and when Dixon reacted to that revelation, too, she said, 'I *know*... but it was part of our adventure...'

She let them into the apartment. The place had been cleaned up since the last time they'd been here. It no longer reeked of sex. But Dixon still got that dark, wicked vibe from the memory of watching Jenni seducing Tom in here.

When the front door closed again, Jenni continued, 'And then after you flew to Seattle, I got this little message, and I could watch this video clip of you *watching* me that night... and it was so *hot*... and then it was our anniversary, so I could open the envelope...'

'So what did he do when he found out it was a membership for Ashley Madison?' Gaines asked with a grin.

'I didn't find out straight away,' Dixon said, reaching into the kitchen cupboard for glasses.

'You didn't tell him what it was?' Gaines asked Jenni.

'I didn't say what it was... I assumed he knew,' she said. 'And... you know... it was weird. Awkward. But then when we talked on FaceTime while he was in Seattle... he was telling me it was alright, that he wanted me to use it and enjoy it... and everything was going to be okay...'

'I was trying to get her to tell me what the damn *gift* was.' Dixon was pouring them shots of vodka by now. They were beyond the point where wine would suffice. 'I was saying things to sound like I knew what it was, hoping she'd just blurt out the name...'

'You couldn't just ask her what it was?' Gaines accepted his drink, amused at Dixon drinking his own, before quickly pouring a second for himself.

'I told you: I didn't want her to find out I didn't actually buy the present for her.'

Jenni said, 'Anyway... I had to talk to my friend Phoebe about it. I knew she'd used Ashley Madison before...'

'You must introduce us,' Gaines joked.

Jenni grinned. 'Phoebe told me some guys... get off on the idea that their wife is cheating.'

Gaines spluttered. 'Seriously?'

Dixon felt embarrassed.

Jenni shrugged. 'So... I went on Ashley Madison... put together my profile. It was so weird. But so sexy, because I was sure Frank was one of those guys Phoebe was talking about. Everything he said about wanting me to do it, to tell him all about what happened when I did use it...'

What a set-up, Dixon thought. I never stood a chance.

‘And it made me so horny... as soon as I joined Ashley Madison, all these guys flooded my inbox with messages... I guess they don’t have so many women on that kind of website... and it was so hot thinking about dating them... and that Frank wanted me to... and wanted me to tell him about it.’

‘God,’ Gaines said. They moved to the living room area, and Jenni pointedly sat with Gaines on the sofa, while Dixon slumped into the armchair opposite. Gaines asked Jenni, ‘So did you do it? Did you date someone?’ His tone made the word *date* sound like *cheat*.

Did you cheat on your husband, Jenni?

Jenni grinned. ‘You know, it was a long build-up. I did what they told me... I’m guessing Frank did, too.’

Dixon nodded, slurped his vodka, which sent fire down his throat, but at least seemed to take the edge off his humiliation.

‘They sent me little video clips of Frank in Seattle... he was watching me via the cameras around our house...’

‘Watching you change?’ Gaines joked.

‘Change... and other stuff too,’ she said. Kind of embarrassing, but at the same time, the way she was talking about sexual things in front of Gaines was also oddly exciting. ‘You know how horny I got while answering messages from guys on Ashley Madison... and then when they sent me clips of Frank watching me... it was like a vicious circle...’

Gaines sipped his drink. ‘So *you* were watching *her* watching *you* watching her watching...’

‘An infinite loop,’ Dixon said.

‘Okay... but you actually met someone from Ashley Madison?’ Gaines asked Jenni.

‘I did.’

‘And?’

‘I slept with him.’

‘Jesus. And you were okay with this?’ Gaines asked Dixon.

Dixon shrugged. ‘I guess by then... there was no doubt...’

Gaines grinned and held up his glass to toast Dixon. ‘I guess it was a secret fantasy, then, huh? So tonight... you really would have slept with the first guy to come along?’

Jenni looked at her husband. ‘I would have,’ she said, rising to her feet. ‘And I still might...’

Dixon felt himself being torn apart inside. And yet, when it came down to it, he was turned on like never before.

He gave Jenni a tiny little nod, more like admitting his desire than really giving her permission for something.

Gaines had always wanted her. And now he was going to get her.

But it was exciting, if he only opened his mind to it. This was what he was supposed to do. What *they* were supposed to do. Marriage 2.0 had assessed both their mentalities, and mapped their minds. It had determined what their adventure would be. This wasn't Jenni running away to cheat on him with his best friend. This was an Experience for both of them.

Gaines had always belittled Dixon for sticking to his first marriage, and now he was going to show Gaines exactly why he had stuck with it. Why he was right and Gaines had always been wrong.

Jenni took Gaines's hands and pulled him up to his feet. He glanced over at Dixon, just astonished, but not objecting. Dixon raised his glass in a silent toast to his old friend.

Jenni put her hands on Gaines's chest, then reached up to kiss his mouth. Dixon felt his stomach fold up. After a little kiss, Jenni turned to look at her husband, to check his reaction, and perhaps gain his approval, offering him a wicked little grin. Dixon liked how she looked at him. Unexpectedly, it made him feel that they were the real couple here, and that Gaines was merely a toy for them to play with.

He sat still and watched.

Jenni helped Gaines remove his jacket. Then she peeled off her dress, revealing her lingerie, those stockings. Her sheer thong.

Dixon took a deep breath. It was nothing Gaines hadn't already seen in the street. Jenni glanced over at her husband again, biting her bottom lip. Dixon loved it. She kissed Gaines on the mouth, then looked over at him again. Gaines was kissing her neck, his hands groping her behind.

He was so hard. He didn't feel able to whip out his manhood in front of Gaines, however.

Jenni unfastened the buttons on Gaines's shirt. She opened it and licked the man's waxed chest — again, giving Dixon a mischievous little grin after doing so. It was so erotic — she was putting on a show for him. Gaines was merely a prop. And yet Gaines was so clearly desperate to do this with her. He stroked her hair, he reached for her breasts, but he left her very much in control.

Dixon got the idea that this wasn't the usual display Gaines put on for a woman when they slept together. But because Dixon was here,

watching, the dynamic was different. Jenni was in control. Jenni kissed him, Jenni pulled off his shirt, Jenni licked him and groped him, all while frequently checking out how her husband responded while he watched her.

She was so sexy. Her wedding ring glinting as her fingers worked to release Gaines from his belt, and then his pants.

Dixon caught his breath as the man's hard cock sprang free, Jenni's hand almost instantly around its base, her eyes fixed on its shaft, and then her tongue, too. Gaines didn't seem to have a hair on his body below his chin. And now Jenni had her lips on his cock. And then his cock inside her mouth.

Jesus. Jenni was sucking on Martin Gaines's cock. And Dixon was right there, watching. He could smell the other man's cologne, along with Jenni's captivating fragrance. He could hear the wet sounds of her mouth slurping on the man's big cock. Gaines didn't look over at him, but he enjoyed hearing Gaines moan in response to Jenni's mouth. It brought home how well he was showing her off, cemented the idea that Gaines would always want her, and she would always be Dixon's.

Jenni licked his cock, and then turned her head to glance at her husband while she did it. So hot.

'Do you like watching it?' she asked him.

He gave her a little smile, as much as he felt comfortable sharing, with Gaines there. 'Oh yes,' he said softly.

She was licking him, going down on him, sucking him, and yet the emphasis seemed more on entertaining her husband than her lover. It wasn't long before the entertainment required more. Something stronger. She rose to her feet, and communicated to Gaines with her eyes. He seemed to know what she wanted.

Gaines stepped behind her — between Dixon and Jenni — and she let him peel down her panties. Then she stepped out of them, and went down on all fours there on the sofa. Her hairless pussy was completely exposed to both men. Dixon could smell her arousal in the air.

Dixon was surprised as his friend turned his head to look over — seeking his approval for this monumental step. Dixon raised his glass again, in another silent toast. Gaines looked completely serious — there wasn't a hint of taunting, of teasing, of trying to humiliate him. And then, as Dixon took a huge gulp of fiery alcohol, Gaines knelt on the sofa behind Jenni.

Dixon gasped as he watched his old friend steer his hard cock to Jenni's glistening pink pussy. The tip of the man's cock nudged up

against her soft pink folds... and then eased inside her.

Jesus. *Jesus.*

‘Ohhhh...’

Jenni moaned as Gaines filled her with his cock. She moaned, and turned her head to look over at her husband. Now that Gaines was facing away from him, he felt able to show her the bulge in his pants, and stroke himself through his clothes. It seemed to spur Jenni on, and her moaning grew louder as Gaines began to thrust into her, his pace accelerating.

‘Oh, that’s *good*...’

It was all wrong. Watching Marty Gaines fucking Jenni. And yet once again, there was that feeling that the wrongness of the situation only made it more erotic. And the power of knowing that it was Gaines with whom Jenni was cheating... it felt like descending a steep drop on the world’s most dangerous rollercoaster.

Jenni was so wet. He could see it on her pussy, and on Gaines’s cock as it repeatedly plunged inside her. Perspiration was beginning to break out on her flushed face.

‘Fuck... God... *fuck*... oh *Jesus*...’

She was so hot. Dixon wanted her so badly, it was insane. She looked over at her husband and moaned, bit her lip, gripped the sofa cushion under her, and tensed up her face as Gaines slammed his big dick into her.

She turned onto her back, and still managed to open her legs so that Dixon could watch that huge cock repeatedly sinking into her pussy. It was easier this way for her to watch her husband, and now her hand was between her legs, tracing circles around her clit while Gaines fucked her.

‘Oh *Frank*... honey... he’s *fucking* me... *he’s fucking me*...’

Again, as her eyes remained connected with his, it seemed like Jenni and her husband were the only real people involved in this arrangement — Gaines was just some kind of sex toy, almost some kind of robot or replicant.

Dixon watched her usher Gaines down onto the sofa, sitting facing Dixon, and then she sat in his lap, sliding his big cock inside her pussy. She bounced on the man’s cock while gazing over at her husband, all flushed and sweaty and dripping moisture from her pussy, thrilled at her husband for wanting to watch this, grateful that he would allow her to fuck who she chose.

‘Can you see his cock inside me, honey...?’

And with that, Gaines was done. Prematurely, Dixon would have said. Jenni was too hot for him to handle. He was deep inside her, and

then it was as though an atom bomb had gone off inside him. He looked to be mildly disappointed that it had arrived so early — and yet, he could not resist the power of his orgasm.

Dixon realized with some concern that Gaines was entirely unencumbered by any kind of contraceptive, and now it was too late to prevent the fact that he was shooting off his cream deep inside Jenni's eager pussy. At the same time, there was something strangely exhilarating about it.

It was that old chestnut: sperm competition.

Dixon was watching the would-be alpha male of the group mating with the most prime female — and it made him want to claim the female as his own, as the true alpha, dislodging the pretender's sperm.

'Oh, *Frank*...honey... he's coming *inside* me...'

Jenni flashed her husband a wicked grin as she felt the other man shooting thick loads of come deep inside her.

There was no threat of pregnancy, really, considering her birth control. And Gaines was clean, wasn't he? The man was anal about his health.

Jenni and her husband both sat, contented, as Gaines dressed himself, joking to his friend, 'I'm not ever doing this with you, if you were wondering.'

'Oh no, no,' Dixon smiled.

'But this...' he signaled Jenni and himself. 'This was good. Weird, but good.'

Jenni laughed. 'You know this won't ever happen again, Marty,' she said, but there was a flirtatious glint in her eye.

'You don't believe that,' Gaines said. Dixon felt his heart tremble.

Jenni stood up to give Gaines one more kiss, but then she sat as Dixon escorted his friend to the front door.

'This... kind of thing. It *really*... gets you going?' Gaines asked him quietly at the door.

Dixon smiled. 'I can't deny it,' he said. 'But you know... if you were to track down Olivia... and take her to Marriage 2.0 yourself... they'd figure out how you two would work best together. It probably wouldn't be anything like this...'

Gaines nodded. 'You think she'd ever take me back?'

Dixon said, 'You'll need to grovel.'

'Yes.'

'*Really* grovel. But hey, maybe that's your secret fantasy?'

And then it was just them again.

Jenni and Frank in an apartment that reeked of sex.

She had moved to the bedroom, to the bed. She lay waiting for him, a little sparkle of perspiration still on her face and neck, her hair damp from the effort of recent sex. She had the glow of sexual satisfaction, and yet the fire of lust was bright in her eyes. She was still breathing hard from the exertion of fucking Gaines, her breasts rising and falling, her nipples so hard pushing through the sheer material of her bra.

‘You enjoy that, honey?’ she asked.

‘Oh, man,’ he said.

Her legs were wide, and he could see how wet she was — another man had been just there, moments before, lying between her thighs on that sofa. Her thighs were still slick from sweat and come. Her entire hairless mound was wet, her pussy, soaking, her pussy lips swollen and red and slightly parted.

‘Did you like that I fucked Marty?’ she said.

‘I can’t believe you did it.’

‘You know he’s teased me for years about running away with him.’

‘You know he never joked about that, don’t you?’

Oh God, he could see Gaines’s pearly white come starting to seep out of her sex. Her pussy was full of another man’s come — and that man was Gaines.

Dixon nearly came right there and then. He had to hold for a beat or two, concentrate on breathing. Spend some time peeling off his clothes.

Jenni gave him a ‘come hither’ look, holding up a hand for him to take. His heart pounding, he climbed onto the bed, pulled himself between her legs, feeling the strange heat and stickiness of her thighs, the clamminess of her skin.

He lay over her, the air thick with the scent of sex, his hard cock touching against her sticky, wet pussy, his chest pushing against her breasts, his mouth finding hers. She tasted strange. She tasted of a woman who had just sucked another man’s cock.

And then he was inside her, his manhood slipping inside her so very easily, because she was so very wet. He just sank into her, up to the hilt, filling her in one movement. Her pussy so unbelievably hot, clamping around his shaft, and so wet. Slippery with another man’s come.

It was a shock. He wasn’t quite prepared for the tidal wave of emotion that surged over him. Jenni was full of his best friend’s come. It

was different than the experience had been when she'd had sex with Tom, who might even have been nothing more than a Marriage 2.0 performer. Tom, who had used a condom.

It took a moment, and Jenni was glancing at him with a concerned look on her face. But then he was kissing her dirty mouth again, knowing that she was his, that she wasn't going to run off with Gaines or anybody else.

And then he was moving his hips, thrusting into her, pumping his hard cock in her well-used pussy, lubricated by another man's cream. She was already primed, she was already prepared, and so her own orgasm was not far away. And anyway, she'd already had a hell of a ride, there wasn't any pressure on her husband to perform, to give her an orgasm.

And, of course, without pressure on him to perform, he could relax and actually perform.

It felt incredible, fucking his gorgeous, dirty, adulterous wife. Burying his cock inside her, plunging it in her, again and again, as though he was using it to pump out the other man's seed. It was so filthy, so wrong, so nasty. And Jenni couldn't get enough.

She rolled over, and he entered her from behind, almost smothering her under him, his arms embracing her possessively, making her his.

And then he was coming, too, and it felt like the most incredible high he had ever experienced. He was shaking and shivering and yelling as the wave of sheer pleasure tore through his body. This was the most amazing experience. You couldn't get drugs that gave you a more potent high than this.

Afterward, they just lay there panting for what seemed like hours.

Jenni said, 'If you're wondering... I think it's better with you.'

Dixon grinned. 'Don't you think I have the advantage when you've already been with someone else before me?'

She laughed. 'But that will *always* give you the advantage, honey.'

Then, a few quiet moments later, she said, 'I did like his cock, though.'

GLENN AND EMILY

PLEASE DO NOT BE ALARMED...

They were on their way home from Date Night. Technically, it was *still* Date Night; Date Night was not over.

Glenn would be expected to put out tonight, even though he wasn't feeling much like it. This week, he was the designated driver, so he hadn't been drinking. For God's sake, he'd sat through a whole opera that night and hadn't had anything more substantial than diet coke.

They'd been arguing again. On the way there, while they'd found their seats, during the intermission, and afterward. They'd been trying not to argue recently because, during couples therapy, Glenn had finally realized that every single time they argued, he seemed to lose more sexual interest in Emily.

But it was so easy to fall into an argument with her. After six months of marriage, he'd stopped swallowing his pride every time she criticized him. After nine months, he'd started being bold enough to criticize her. Neither seemed particularly helpful in making their relationship work.

These days, their attempts to avoid arguing led simply to frosty moments. Cold looks. Quiet sighs. Eye-rolls. It could all be just as hurtful as open and vocal arguments. Tonight, it had boiled over a little.

They were sitting in a frosty atmosphere in the car, driving home to Sudbury, Massachusetts. Tonight's disagreement had centered on the fact they were going to see opera music at all. Emily felt hurt that he didn't seem 100% enthusiastic about the prospect of going to see Verdi's Aida. He had insisted he was looking forward to it, but she hadn't believed him — offense caused on both sides.

Glenn had attempted an apology at one point, blaming tiredness and stress. She'd asked why he was stressed when she was the one who did most of the kids stuff, the really stressful part of life, whereas he spent

most of his life working. He'd made up something at work that he said was causing him sleepless nights.

He'd kept it to himself that what most gave him stress was the prospect of Date Night coming round again when he would be expected to get hard and do his husbandly duty. And if he couldn't, he might expect another lash from her tongue — and that would have the consequence of leaching yet more sexual desire out of his love for her.

It was a vicious circle, failing in the bedroom with Emily.

She hadn't believed him about being stressed at work.

'You always say it's your dream job. Everything about it is great. It's why you work such ridiculously long hours.'

He only worked long hours when it was her turn to put the kids to bed, he reminded her. But when you spend all day with the kids, and then it's your turn to get them to sleep, it's easy to feel like your partner isn't doing enough. Even though your partner's working all day, and it's fair to split up the evening's childcare between you.

He couldn't tell her about the stress of trying to make himself sexually attracted to her each week. She'd never understood. She'd get offended — of course she'd get offended. It had nothing to do with how she looked — she was perfectly attractive physically, no problem there. In fact, his go-to strategy on weeks where they hadn't had a recent argument was to imagine she was some other redhead — if he didn't look at her face too closely, he might get through it.

It was all about respect. She sapped his self-respect every time they argued. It was how she won. But it made him resent her, it made him bitter. It lost him any sexual desire he might have been able to build up since the previous argument.

And now, as they headed along the Mass Pike out of Boston, they were arguing about Marriage 2.0.

They'd done everything to try and repair their marriage. These days, it seemed to be mainly about the kids — neither of them wanted their kids to be Divorce Kids, to have to split their time between seeing Dad and seeing Mom. They didn't want Joshua and Silas to feel they lived in a broken home. They'd both hit 40, and so many of their friends were already divorced with kids — friends they'd seen married, friends they'd never believed would ever split up. So Glenn and Emily had tried couples therapy, marriage counseling, extra vacations, city breaks, a weekly Date Night, extra sleep, regular sex. Even religion. And they'd tried that new fad, Marriage 2.0. The one that people seemed to write

about in the Boston Globe every other god-damn week, even though you had to go down to New York to actually register.

Well, they'd gone down to register and be assessed. It had taken all day. But what had they gotten out of it, other than a colossal invoice?

Tonight, Glenn had simply said something about waiting for Marriage 2.0 to help them, and Emily had felt certain he was Using That Tone on her again. That he was criticizing her because she had been the one to point out the latest feature in the *Boston Globe* — or was it the *Herald*? And it had been her who had suggested this was one more thing they could try.

After Glenn had managed to persuade her he hadn't been Using That Tone on her at all and was genuinely hopeful that the 'adventure' they'd paid Marriage 2.0 to arrange would happen soon and that it would truly 'upgrade' their relationship.

Then Emily had said, 'Claire and Robert had to wait six weeks for theirs to start. And when it did, they were on vacation in Rome.'

'Should we be trying to go on vacation, then?' he had said, trying out a smile for size.

'It's not about where you are or what you're doing. You can't *trigger* an adventure,' she said. 'We're supposed to wait, and when it's the right time, it'll happen.'

He nodded. She smiled, perhaps taking it as a small victory that he agreed with her. That she was correct, and he couldn't deny that. But he noticed that she did look nice when she smiled. Could he hold onto that feeling until they got home? Enough to make love to her that evening without having to think of some porn actress he might have seen?

He did love her. He told himself it was true, and he did usually believe it. Why else would he keep doing this? Why else would he be so optimistic that some kind of jolt to their relationship — an adventure from Marriage 2.0, say — could get them going again. Like a bump start when your car battery is dead. Then you only had to drive around a while, and your battery would be charged up again. Ready to start the car all by itself.

She was wearing a lovely dress tonight. It was black, tight, with little straps and a neckline low enough to show off her pale cleavage. He remembered feeling an odd little buzz while they were walking around the Opera House as he spotted other guys' eyes dropping to check out Emily's rack. *They wanted to fuck her*, he told himself, *but I'm the one that gets to take her home to fuck tonight*. It made him feel good about

himself despite their ongoing argument. He wondered if he could use a thought like that to help get him hard when the moment actually came.

She was also wearing makeup — including red, red lipstick — and a lovely perfume he'd never smelled before. She was making a real effort for once, and that did help him feel good about himself — that he was worth her effort — and another little boost to his libido.

Was it time to try Viagra? He'd never wanted to admit to Emily that he had some kind of erectile problem. He didn't, did he? He got hard looking at porn quickly enough. Of course, he was also terrified of seeing a doctor and confessing to having erectile problems. And the doctor might say, is there no way you can get an erection? And he might be forced to admit that, sure, pornography will do the trick.

'Why don't you watch pornography with your wife?' the doctor might suggest.

'You've clearly never met my wife,' he would say.

Good God. What would Emily say if she knew he occasionally reviewed the offerings on Pornhub or Youporn, or whatever? Maybe that would be the end of their marriage.

Maybe the doctor would even refuse to let him have Viagra because he could, technically, get an erection. Particularly if some other woman was involved. Could you get the stuff without seeing a doctor and without ending up with some black market fake that ended up giving you a stroke?

Now they were turning off the Mass Pike, at the Framingham exit, for the drive up to Sudbury. Glenn was trying to glance over at his wife, ogle her cleavage, and get himself into the right mood so they'd be ready to go when they got home. Damn. He was already having to imagine things to get his cock to even respond. He tried remembering that little smile she'd given him earlier. The way those guys at the opera had stared at her tits through that dress. He couldn't feel guilty if what he pictured involved her, could he?

He was looking over at her dress, noticing that one of her thin straps had slipped off her shoulder and might lead to her dress slipping sufficiently for her nipple to become visible. How had he not noticed she wasn't wearing a bra tonight? And then, from behind them came a flashing blue and red light, illuminating the interior of their SUV.

'Oh God, it's the cops,' Emily said, flashing the kind of eye roll that instantly robbed her husband of any faint erection he'd managed to build up. Her eyes blamed him for their getting stopped.

What have you done now?

Glenn pulled over dutifully by the side of the road, and the police cruiser slowed to a stop ominously behind.

‘I wasn’t going too fast,’ he said.

‘You’re sure? It’s 35 around here. It seems really slow when you’ve just been on the interstate.’

‘I *was* sticking to the speed limit,’ he insisted, his insides crawling with snakes, now, his body trembling with fear. Why so afraid? It wasn’t like he’d killed anybody. He’d always been afraid of the cops. It probably didn’t help that there was always some item on the news about a police officer getting the wrong end of the stick and ending up pulling a gun on somebody.

Glenn wound down his window as he saw the dark shape of a cop approaching in his mirror. The guy stepped beside his door, and then Glenn was almost blinded by the flashlight suddenly beaming straight at his face.

‘Stay in the vehicle, please, sir,’ the cop said, loudly and with the authority that comes with the uniform.

‘Of course, officer,’ Glenn said, slightly confused since he’d shown no signs of trying to exit the vehicle.

‘Put your hands right there, where I can see them, on the wheel.’

The cop was big, like a giant bear, though Glenn couldn’t see much of him because of the flashlight. What was he doing? There was a long pause. He could hear the cop breathing. Glenn glanced down, out of the light. Jesus, that uniform was intimidating.

‘Can I ask — ?’ Glenn tried asking what he had done wrong.

‘You will speak when spoken to, sir,’ the cop said curtly but forcefully.

Another long pause. Glenn just focused on breathing. What was the worst that could happen? He wasn’t going to get a record just by breaking a speed limit.

The cop said something quietly, and the sound of static, and the small beep, made Glenn suppose he was talking into a radio. Then, the man said a little louder, ‘SUV. License plate...’ and he sauntered around to the back of the vehicle to check the plate, his heavy boots making a crunching sound on the roadside gravel.

Eventually, he returned to Glenn’s window. ‘Can I have your license and registration, please, sir?’

Glenn glanced across at Emily, who scrambled to find the required documents in the glove box and hand them to him. She looked alarmed, pale, even with her complexion. There was no longer any hint that she

blamed him for anything. She was simply on edge, feeling helpless, terrified.

The cop slowly examined the paperwork.

So slowly, in fact, that Emily felt emboldened enough to lean over her husband's lap and ask quietly, 'Can we ask why you've stopped us, officer?'

But the cop seemed to ignore her. She glanced at Glenn, and he shrugged. What could they do?

At last, the cop handed back the papers. He said, 'Have you been drinking tonight, sir?'

Glenn felt his pounding heart skip a beat. 'No sir,' he said quickly. 'Not at all.'

The cop paused, sniffed. 'Can you get out of the vehicle, please, sir?'

Glenn felt a little annoyed, despite his continuing fear. 'Look,' he said, opening the car door. 'There must have been some mistake. I wasn't *weaving* or anything — '

'Out of the car, *sir*.'

Glenn felt his dignity being shredded. He climbed out of the SUV double-quick, though he held himself back from complaining that he had been getting out of the car, he didn't need the guy to shout.

'I was driving perfectly well...' he said quietly.

'I'm going to ask you to walk along this white line, sir.' Glenn took a few steps forward, and the cop added, 'When *I say so*, sir.'

Glenn stopped. Was the guy simply having fun? Getting off on his own authority? Obsessed with the power of his uniform?

'I *haven't* been drinking,' he said, his voice getting shrill with outrage and fear. 'I *swear*. You can breathalyze me if you want.'

The cop seemed to be writing something on a clipboard. Filling in some kind of report on this? Citing him? For what?

'Seriously, man. I've been drinking diet coke all night.'

'Officer, it's me who's been drinking,' Emily said, walking around the front of the SUV now, so pale in the headlights. 'If you smelled anything in our car... it was me. But I wasn't driving.'

The cop looked over at Emily. She'd fixed the strap on her dress, but she still looked hot by the light of the police cruiser's headlamps. Her lipstick was so bright. Her dress so tight. Glenn felt that same light buzz he'd felt at the Opera House when other guys were checking out his wife — only now, it was a big, brutish cop checking her out.

'Is there somebody you can call to come collect you and your vehicle tonight, sir?' the cop asked Glenn.

Emily wailed, 'You *can't* believe he's been drinking, officer?'

'Ma'am, I am not talking to you,' the cop said assertively.

'My husband hasn't done *anything* wrong.'

'Ma'am, I am *not talking* to you.'

'No, no, this isn't *right*,' Emily continued, and Glenn just wanted her to stop, to shut up and get back in the car, but he was too terrified to say anything, and she'd been drinking, and maybe she'd get angry at him, too. At least, right now, her anger was directed at the cop.

'Okay, you have a bad attitude, Ma'am,' the cop said and suddenly waved his finger at Emily.

Then he grabbed her by the upper arms, walked her toward the police cruiser, and Glenn just about had all the oxygen sucked out of his body in shock. What the hell was going on?

'Hands on the hood, right there,' the man said, making Emily bend over the cruiser by the nearside headlamp. The man's gun was visible in the black leather holster on his belt. Glenn shivered. Jesus. Was this one of those awful events that ended up on the local news?

Now he was patting her down.

'I just need to make sure you don't have anything sharp, anything I might need to worry about,' he said. Glenn was horrified. Of course she didn't have anything sharp. You could see she didn't have anything sharp. Her dress was skin-tight, for God's sake.

He was feeling her up.

Glenn felt the conflicting feelings of outrage, fear, and arousal.

Emily was just standing there, leaning over the hood of the car, letting him spread his hands all over her hips, her thighs, her waist, her arms, *her breasts*.

The cop didn't even have a partner. Wasn't there some law that said cops always had to have partners? Precisely so they couldn't go rogue like this and start abusing their authority?

'I'm just going through the proper procedures,' the cop was telling Emily, who seemed to be complaining quietly, though not trying to escape or object physically.

'You are kidding me right now,' she said as he pressed her head down on the hood.

Glenn shivered. What was he supposed to do? Call the police? Pull out his phone and ask Google for the number of a lawyer? He did pull out his phone. He started recording what was going on with the video app. Horrified, terrified, shaking with helpless anger, he figured at least if

he got some of this on video, it would provide robust evidence for a legal complaint against the police.

‘Now you’re getting pretty *personal*, officer, don’t you think?’ Emily said, sounding strangely calm as the cop slid his hand up her inner thighs, as though there might be any way she could conceal a weapon up there, like on some Lara Croft-style thigh holsters, without it being evident through Emily’s dress.

Glenn thought to pan down to get a shot of the police cruiser’s license plate, which might help identify the officer if there was any denial from the police. He picked up the cop’s own flashlight from the hood in order to get a good enough shot of the license plate.

When he turned back, Emily was grinning up at the cop, and Glenn felt terrified that the cool air had somehow made the alcohol go to his wife’s head. That she was being insolent to the man now, goading him into making their situation worse.

The cop turned around and saw Glenn shooting a video. He said, ‘You can film this, sir. But now I have her for attempting to bribe an officer of the law.’

Emily sniggered. ‘Oh, come on. All I said was, maybe I could make you *happy* in some way... and we could make all this... go away...’

Glenn was horrified all over again. His heart kept getting jolts of intense heat that could not be good for it. What was she saying?

The cop stood her up. Did she have handcuffs on? *Jesus*. Glenn shone the flashlight on her, and there was the silver glint of cuffs on her wrists. The cop walked her away from her husband toward one of the rear doors of the cruiser. Was he arresting her? But he turned her toward him, away from the car. He had his hands on her face. Was the guy not done pawing her?

Glenn breathed. He had to concentrate on ensuring he was getting all this on video.

What was he doing? Trying to assert himself over her? Make her stop being insolent? He was putting his hands around her neck... Glenn jumped forward, his whole body feeling cold with panic.

But Emily was *smiling*.

Glenn ventured forward some more. The cop said, nearly shouting, ‘Keep back, sir. This doesn’t concern you.’

Glenn looked around. They were in the middle of nowhere. No houses, no cars. No one to hear if he started screaming for help.

The police officer pulled the straps of Emily’s dress down off her shoulders. To Glenn’s surprise, horror, and — if he could admit it —

strange excitement, he forced the thin black material down until Emily's small, pale breasts were revealed. Her pink nipples were exposed — and hard.

The officer was fondling her, even squeezing her nipples between his thumbs and forefingers. Glenn tried to scream at the guy, but his throat was too dry to make more than a croak.

Then, even worse, the cop pulled Emily to him and planted his mouth on hers, and there was the wet sound of a kiss. Oh God, Oh God, Oh God. This was no longer harassment; this was sexual assault. But why wasn't Emily trying to pull away from him?

Was she trying to defuse tensions by *actually doing something with the cop*? Did she think flashing her breasts at him and letting him make out with her would somehow get him back in his police cruiser and then on their merry way home without any kind of citation?

Or else she was too drunk to know what was really going on.

He stepped forward again, almost close enough to put his hand on the cop's shoulder.

'Emily — ' he said, but Emily glanced at him and smiled.

'It's *okay, honey*,' she said, and he had no idea what she meant, but she didn't sound terrified anymore.

The cop turned her around to face the cruiser again, and he was taking her handcuffs off. Glenn found himself relaxing. Was it all over? Had Emily struck some kind of an arrangement with the cop? A little kiss, a feel-up of her breasts, and he'd let them go?

Relaxing, he noticed that he had a massive erection right now. Absolutely colossal, in fact. He didn't remember the last time he'd been this hard. God, talk about inappropriate. Talk about getting an erection at just the wrong time. Why couldn't he get this hard in the bedroom with Emily? Then there wouldn't be any problems in their marriage. Well, hardly any.

Maybe he could somehow sustain it until they got home. Think about that cop manhandling his wife, pulling down her dress, touching up her bare breasts. Kissing her on the mouth.

Glenn directed the flashlight back to his wife. She was free of handcuffs now, but she remained facing the cruiser, hands over the trunk. Submissive. The cop stood behind her and put his hands on her behind. Slapped it, in fact. Glenn was confused.

'You are a bad girl, aren't you?' the cop said, pulling her against him.

Emily moaned as he slapped her behind again.

Now what was he doing? Tugging on her dress. Pulling it down past her stomach, revealing more of her pale body, her waist, her pale pink lacy thong. He gave her another little slap as she stood there with her dress bunched around her thighs, and Emily just stood there, a mischievous smirk on her face.

Horrified and aroused in almost equal measure, Glenn remembered to train the video camera of his smartphone on them. Would it hurt their case if Emily seemed somehow willing through this part? They could say she was simply drunk. Drunk did not equal consent.

Another slap. Then the cop dragged her dress down to her ankles and fondled her butt, over and under her panties. She shook her hair out of her face and turned to try to watch him. She seemed so willing.

Glenn felt frozen to the spot.

The cop peeled down her panties now, and Emily wasn't saying anything. She simply stood there, pressed against the police car, letting him put his hands on her bare ass, slide one hand between her legs.

He was touching her there. Touching her pussy.

Glenn wanted to stop the man. He wanted to be a hero. But he was brutally embarrassed at the scale of the erection he was sporting. And Emily seemed to be enjoying herself. Glenn was confused. Surely it wasn't consent if she was drunk?

How much had she had to drink tonight? He remembered one, two, maybe three glasses of wine. Was that drunk enough to act this way with a stranger?

The cop stroked her pussy, and even sank a finger inside her. Glenn could see everything by the light of that powerful flashlight. Emily was standing there, up against the police cruiser, and he was fingering her. She was wet — Glenn could hear it as the guy thrust his finger into her again and again. She was wet, she was closing her eyes, she was moaning quietly. It looked consensual.

But this was his wife. His wife, who would be horrified by the idea that he would look at pornography. Who never did anything in bed but the missionary position. Who never had sex unless it was on the bed. *She was letting this cop finger her pussy.*

And Glenn was just frozen there, apparently excited by the sight of it happening. That stupid pride of his, he *liked* the fact that this cop really *wanted* his wife. The cop sank into a crouch, pulling apart Emily's pale buttocks, and now he launched forward, pressing his face against her butt, clamping his mouth against her pussy.

Emily just held onto the car and twisted to gaze down at the man as he ate her pussy, making wet kissing noises as he sucked on her, as he slurped on her juices. She closed her eyes and moaned, apparently in ecstasy. Glenn was so aroused by the sight of her like this. She was *enjoying it*. She was being fucked by another man, outside, where anyone could catch them. And she was *enjoying it*.

And Glenn was enjoying it too. He had no idea why, but he didn't care too much why. He was hard as a rock, and Emily was being so un-Emily, so *naughty*, it was seriously hot.

The whole atmosphere had changed. It no longer felt like they were in trouble. The cop pulled open his belt, and Glenn just hoped he wasn't going to stop now. He watched the guy whip out a huge, long, powerful dick and slide it slowly into Emily from behind.

And Emily didn't object at all. In fact, she seemed to enjoy every minute, closing her eyes and groaning softly in pleasure. She made little grunt noises, little gasps as the cop started pounding her, her butt jiggling with each thrust, the pale flesh of her buttocks now pink from the slaps he'd given her earlier.

'God, you're so tight,' the cop said as he fucked her. 'You're so wet...'

And she just moaned, and Glenn wished he had three hands so he could hold the video camera, the flashlight, and his own dick.

After a while, the cop pulled away and let Emily turn around. She dropped into a crouching position, and now as he pulled her hair out of her face, she was taking the man's huge cock in her hands, stretching her lips around it, sucking on him for all she was worth.

'Oh, that feels good...' the cop said calmly.

Glenn couldn't believe that he was watching another man sticking his big cock into Emily's mouth. And she was loving every moment.

Why wasn't he feeling jealous? Because he really wasn't.

Emily was back on her feet in a short time, and the cop was fucking her from behind, up against the cruiser again. Properly taking her like they were animals. She clambered onto the hood of the car, and he fucked her like that. Glenn could almost picture her as the wife he remembered, lying on her back on the bed doing the missionary style.

But she was different tonight.

Back on her feet, the cop plowing into her from behind, their preferred position, it seemed. And Emily was coming. God damn it. Glenn remembered it from their dating days and the early days of their marriage. The guy was coming too, grunting and shaking and letting

loose inside her — Glenn couldn't believe another guy was coming inside his wife. And yet he wasn't stopping it.

It was weirdly exciting.

Then the cop was pulling up his slacks, re-fastening his belt, straightening his uniform while Emily could only stand there clutching her clothes, kind of shocked but also clearly feeling good about what had just happened.

'Good night, sir. Ma'am,' the cop said, sounding strangely formal. Then he was in his car, backing up, pulling out, soaring away up the road with his engine barely ticking over.

Emily looked at Glenn. It was almost as though she'd forgotten he was there. Suddenly, she was aware of everything. Embarrassed. Horrified. Realizing that her husband had seen everything.

'You okay?'

She held her dress and her panties against her stomach. 'I... I'm so sorry...' she said. 'I couldn't... I couldn't help it...'

He stepped up to her. 'Are you okay?'

'Yes. Y-yes. I'm... fine.'

'Can you walk?'

'Yes.'

'Do we need to... get you to a hospital?'

'No,' she wrinkled her face as though she couldn't understand why he might suggest a hospital.

'I know you're drunk,' he said, holding her, trying to reassure her.

'I'm not drunk,' she said, and she did sound sober. Sharp, rational. 'I just... well, you know how it is...'

He kissed her, and it was meant to be just a brief peck on the lips, reassuring. But then one, or other, or perhaps both of them, suddenly got into it, and they were kissing for ages, sucking on each other's lips, pressing up against each other. Glenn could smell the cop's cologne on her. He could, he suspected, even smell the guy's sweat, the guy's dick on her. Taste it in her mouth. It was weird, but somehow it proved that he had not imagined what he'd just seen. It proved that Emily had just been a very, very bad girl.

It proved how hot she was.

'Let's... get you home,' he said, breathless at last as their kiss finally ended. He helped her around to her side of the SUV, opened her door for her, and helped her up onto the passenger seat.

He was still hard. Rock hard.

On the way home, Emily leaned over to double-check if she had really felt that when they'd kissed, or whether she'd imagined it, or whether — as the old adage went — he merely had something in his pocket. When she discovered it was real — and harder than she could remember ever seeing it before — she was laughing and pulling out her phone, and showing him the app.

Marriage 2.0 had sent her a notification just before the cop had pulled them over.

Marriage 2.0: *Your adventure is starting. Do not be alarmed by anything that happens tonight.*

MELISSA AND ADAM

Who first came up with the idea to sign up for Marriage 2.0? Both of them, perhaps. Or at least, that's the version they remembered.

They had both seen ads or commercials in various locations — magazines, cable TV shows, and a fairly lengthy one in the movie theater when they went to see the latest Marvel superheroes flick together. The commercials showed many couples having fun with each other and enjoying life because of the program.

It seemed fun, and they both knew they needed something to spark their romance after the grueling process of IVF, which had so far failed to take after four long cycles.

Maybe Melissa dug her elbow into Adam's side while they were watching the commercial in the AMC theater on 19th St., but when she did, he was already glancing at her with a question in his eyes.

Should we try this?

Why not? It seemed like it might be fun. They were both scared of the possibility that they might need some kind of marriage counseling. That usually meant the end, right? That divorce was imminent. They were both scared even to talk about it with each other.

And yet Marriage 2.0 seemed to make sense when they saw the commercials.

They *did* need to upgrade their relationship.

They needed to see their marriage as the best thing that was going on in their lives. They still loved each other. It was just that they'd been through tough times recently, and it had snuffed out that spark they had for each other, completely dispelling any passion.

They needed something to take their minds off the IVF, the miscarriage.

Whoever it was that got the idea first was probably irrelevant. What was true, after they went to get tested at the facility on Lexington Avenue, was that Melissa was the one whose 'Experience' began first.

She was all smiley and buzzing with energy as she showed Adam the app on her phone, and the message that stated pretty simply:

Marriage 2.0: Congratulations, your adventure is starting.

When he'd seen that Melissa's Experience was starting, Adam had been confused why the Marriage 2.0 app on his own phone showed no such message.

In the status section of the app, it still told him to 'please wait for your adventure to begin.'

Had there been some kind of glitch?

That was what they thought at first. They were married, they had been tested together, so surely they would have the same Experience, right? So it should begin at the same time for both of them?

'Have they told you anything else?' Adam asked Melissa as she went into the bedroom to change out of her work clothes.

'No, nothing else,' she said, then corrected herself, 'Oh. Yes, there was one thing.'

'What's that?'

She leaned out of the door and smirked at him as he sat forlornly on the couch. 'I'm not supposed to tell you about *any* instructions they send me.'

Adam felt his stomach sink. *Seriously?*

'But why?'

'I have no idea,' she'd said from the bedroom, and he had moved so he could see her standing in front of the closet in her plain white bra and panties, looking for something to wear.

'You're *going out* tonight?' he said, drawing his conclusion from the fact that she wouldn't have to search through their closet to find things to wear for hanging out at home in the evening.

'*I'm not supposed to tell you,*' she stressed, with a flash of her dark eyes.

The mystery intrigued him, especially now that he knew her Marriage 2.0 Experience had apparently started already, while his had not.

‘I can *see* that you’re going out, though,’ he said. ‘You’re going out without me?’

He put on a hurt expression and milked her guilt for all it was worth.

She sighed at that. ‘Okay. Look, I’m not supposed to say anything. But I’m only going for drinks with the girls. Nothing really scandalous. Ashley, Francine, Olivia.’

He nodded. ‘You haven’t seen those guys in a while.’

‘They’re all dropping kids like bunny rabbits,’ Melissa sighed, then tried to hide her disappointment that they could not follow suit. ‘This is the first night in *months* they’ve been able to do.’

She ended up pulling on a pair of skinny blue jeans, a black top, and her old leather jacket. A fairly casual look, but still quite chic for a simple drink or two with the girls.

‘And Marriage 2.0 told you to go on this night out?’

He had to ask. It was too much of a coincidence that her Experience had started, and suddenly she was going out without him for the first time in months.

‘I told you, *I’m not supposed to say anything.*’

She flashed her eyes at him again, but then giggled, which seemed to confirm that Marriage 2.0 had told her to organize this social evening.

‘Oh,’ he said.

‘Look, it’s just going to be a bit of fun,’ she said, tugging on her black top as though it didn’t fit her to her liking. ‘Maybe Marriage 2.0 believes I need some time with the girls for a change. You know — to let my hair down.’

‘Maybe,’ he said, relaxing a little. It seemed logical that an assessment of their relationship might conclude that they needed a little more space and more time socializing with others.

But why hadn’t he been told to go out for a few evening drinks with *his* friends?

Adam watched Melissa putting on her makeup out of the corner of his eye, while ostensibly lounging on their couch. She looked happy to be going out like this. It made him feel quite nice, that she was happy.

Maybe that was the point?

Maybe he’d get his night out another night.

He breathed. He even smiled. He liked that she was cheerfully readying herself for a night out with her friends from college. This was just what she needed.

It made him think they should have known that this kind of thing was what they needed. Before they’d gone and lost an entire afternoon

registering with Marriage 2.0.

A little space away from each other and their tiny apartment. A little boost of self-confidence always came when they spent time with their friends, friends they'd known for ages.

Why did she need so much makeup, though — and perfume?

It made him realize how long it had been since he'd seen her dressed up like this. She looked good. Better than good, she looked great. He guessed that she was simply making sure she didn't look out of place at a city bar this time of night. It was merely his primordial instincts feeding a kind of paranoia that made him think about how other guys at the bar would respond to the sight of her looking like that.

He didn't mention his paranoia, though, of course. He simply kissed her on the cheek before she headed out the door, letting it lie.

As soon as she was gone, though, he moved to double-check whether his adventure might have started, too, and if not, why.

Alone in the apartment, he switched his phone off and on again, restarting the Marriage 2.0 app.

Still nothing.

He checked their website, which also advised him to *'Please wait for your Experience to begin.'*

He even called the Marriage 2.0 helpline and spoke to a friendly female operator who had checked the database and confirmed that his Experience was yet to begin.

He had to sit back and trust that it was simply the requirement that they have separate nights out, on different nights, and chance had decided that Melissa's should be first.

They both needed their social lives to be rebooted. That was all this was.

But the next night, Adam wasn't going out with his friends.

Nor the night after.

The following Thursday night, Melissa went out for another evening with her college buddies while Adam stayed home.

He started phoning various old college friends, some of whom he hadn't seen for upwards of a year. But they were all busy. The kids. Their work. Various social obligations from their new suburban social circles. Too few of his friends had stayed in the city.

So he was left in, while Melissa started going out regularly.

Then it was happening every week.

Every Thursday night, she would come home from work, change, and then go out for a night out with the girls — while he stayed where he was. There were occasional evenings where the guys from the office would agree to a drink after work, but that was rare. They, too, were mostly suburbanites. Commuting suburbanites with houses in Jersey, or Connecticut, or Up State.

Adam felt lousy.

But hey, Melissa was showing signs of happiness and improved self-confidence. Maybe that was all that mattered.

They had sex, sometimes, when she came home from her nights out, and even on other nights sometimes. Maybe things were getting better, after all.

Was *this* their adventure?

Well, he'd take it. There *had* been a noticeable improvement in her general mood. But why had they tested Adam so extensively, including his sexual preferences, if he wasn't really going to be directly involved in any 'Experience'?

Then one Thursday evening, Adam felt his phone buzzing as Melissa came in from work to change so she could go out with her friends again.

He pulled out the phone to find a message on the Marriage 2.0 app.

Marriage 2.0: *Congratulations, your Experience is starting! Please keep any instructions we send you confidential. Do not share details with your wife.*

Well, this left him scratching his chin.

He wasn't exactly an expert, but he assumed one of the first things marriage counseling therapists would say to couples would be not to keep secrets from each other. To maintain open communication channels between husband and wife.

How was it supposed to strengthen their relationship if he wasn't allowed to talk to Melissa about his adventure? About *their* adventures?

Were they to have *separate* Experiences?

Sitting on the couch, pondering, Adam assumed that he would soon be ordered out to a bar somewhere to share an evening with his friends.

Which friends, exactly, was a bit of a mystery since he hadn't found any with availability much before September. Perhaps he would be introduced to new friends?

He and Melissa would work on building their own individual social lives — and then, as their 'Experience' progressed, things between them might be rekindled. Perhaps he and Melissa would be encouraged to start dating again, as though they were single, rather than married to each other. He'd read about couples forcing themselves to 'date' in order to keep the passion alive.

They would get a complete social reboot.

Adam sat on the couch, waiting for another message from Marriage 2.0 while Melissa finished getting ready for her night out. He was excited merely from the fact that he'd had confirmation that his own Experience had started. What was going to happen? How would it all start?

Even if it did turn out that he simply needed to make a few new friends before focusing on improving things in the bedroom with Melissa, it was exciting to think something might happen.

His heart rate had even picked up.

He nearly jumped out of his skin when there was another buzz on his phone, and another message came in via the app.

Marriage 2.0: *Go get a drink of juice from the kitchen.*

What?

He almost burst out laughing — and only managed to control himself by remembering that if Melissa asked what he was laughing about, he wouldn't be able to tell her, which would be awkward. He was supposed to keep all this to himself, right?

But what on Earth was this damn thing doing, telling him to go get a drink from the kitchen?

Did Melissa get this kind of instruction when her Experience had started?

Perhaps it was just warming him up — getting him used to receiving instructions from the app.

He gave a silent groan and launched himself up from the couch, shuffling over to the kitchen area of their open-plan kitchen-dining-living-room before reaching into a cupboard for a glass, and then into the refrigerator for the juice. His phone buzzed again while he was pouring the juice.

Marriage 2.0: *Take a look through the window.*

Huh?

He glanced out of the kitchen window — and caught his breath.

He could see Melissa in the bedroom, getting changed.

The fact that you could see into their bedroom from their kitchen was something they'd discussed when they'd first looked around the apartment. It was one of the quirks of this tiny apartment in the East Village that had made it affordable for them. And at the time, they'd agreed with the real estate agent that privacy wasn't a problem when you were looking into your own bedroom like this.

Now, Adam stood at the kitchen counter sipping his ice-cold juice, watching his beautiful wife checking herself out in the mirror. She was wearing a black lacy bodysuit with a high leg and a thong back — very racy. Certainly a little too risqué for a simple evening out with the girls.

And not the kind of thing Melissa would wear for work.

What was she doing?

Was she planning a surprise for him? Maybe she was planning on a special night of passionate sex when she returned home from her night out?

Adam felt his manhood thicken while he watched her. It seemed that from this angle, she couldn't see him watching her through the kitchen window. They'd never noticed that when they'd been buying the apartment.

Was this what Marriage 2.0 wanted? For him to spy on his wife?

For him to spoil the surprise she obviously had planned for him on her return from the usual Thursday girls' night out?

Still, it was exciting to think she might have been shopping for some sexy lingerie. She hadn't even done that when they'd been trying so hard to conceive.

He watched her stoop to reach for something in one of her bottom drawers. She had her back to him, and she moved with the poise of a dancer — though it had been some years since she'd last taken a dance class.

She did look good. Long, slender legs, a hint of muscles showing in her thighs, shapely behind shown off nicely by the thong back of her underwear.

She reached for the black item on the bed, and he quickly saw that it was a stocking. She wore hose often enough for work, but this was a thigh-high stocking. Lace-topped.

She lifted her leg and began rolling it over her feet, her toes supporting herself on the edge of the mattress. Rolled it up her thighs,

stretching the lace band in place at the top. Then she slowly pulled the matching stocking on her other leg. It made her look *overtly* sexual.

She was wearing stockings for him? God. He'd never imagined she'd do that — he'd always assumed she didn't see the point.

But here she was.

This was what *pornstars* wore. There was no reason for wearing stockings like this, except to arouse.

He was so hard, watching her. She was so sexy, though he felt he hadn't recognized that in years. And yet... along with the thrill of seeing her like this, of anticipating that the end of the night would see her stripping off for him to show off this outfit... something about it was troubling him.

Why was she putting stockings on for a night out with the girls?

He glanced at the message that Marriage 2.0 had sent him about looking through the kitchen window, and it occurred to him that watching Melissa dressing up in seriously sexy lingerie was part of their Experience. It was a reassuring thought.

This was just part of their Experience.

It didn't matter that she was going out for the evening without him. Just that he saw what she was wearing when she went out. It would leave him longing for her all evening — so that by the time she returned, he would be desperate to sleep with her.

He could see the logic in it all. It was incredible that Marriage 2.0 knew precisely where he needed to be to watch Melissa dressing like this. But then, it had sophisticated technology, right? Artificial intelligence systems.

Melissa was reaching into the closet now. Pulling out a little black dress — with an emphasis on the word 'little.'

Of course they had given Marriage 2.0 their address. And if you typed their address into Google, it brought up the website for the building they lived in. There were often apartments in the building available for sale — and when apartments were available, the details would be on Zillow, or [Realtor.com](https://www.realtor.com), or whatever. Since most of the apartments in this building were of fairly standardized design, Adam could conceive how Marriage 2.0 might work out exactly where he should stand in their apartment while Melissa changed.

She was stepping into the dress, pulling it up her body, smoothing it into place. It was much shorter than anything Melissa would usually wear, particularly for a casual night out with friends. The hem of her dress only just covered the lace tops of her stockings.

Again, Adam watched her checking herself out in the mirror. She tested the dress to make sure it *did* just about cover her stockings. Based on the woman he knew, he assumed she would decide the dress didn't work. It was too short, there was far too much risk of it riding up to provide a glimpse of her stockings. She'd reach into the closet for a different dress.

But she didn't.

Instead, she found herself some shoes — black, high-heeled shoes. Apparently, she was happy with the dress. *God damn it*. As she was putting on her shoes, she bent over, and the dress rode up so high on her thighs that he received a view of her stocking tops and her delicious behind. Enough to remind him that she was wearing thong underwear.

He was shocked. Turned on, too, but shocked.

Now, as she did her final pre-flight checks in front of that full-length mirror, Adam found himself wandering slowly into the bedroom.

'Oh, hey, honey,' she said, brushing her long, black hair out of her face, pulling it together into a ponytail.

'You look amazing,' he said.

She smiled. 'Ashley wants us to go out to a nightclub,' she said, knowing that the dress warranted some kind of explanation, though it was clear she didn't know he'd seen her underwear.

'Should be fun.'

'Thought I'd better wear something a little more... *glam*. You know how it is.'

He nodded, although he wanted to say that she'd never worn anything quite that *glam* while he'd known her — even when they'd been dating, and they'd gone to nightclubs together.

He handed her the little black purse she had sitting on the edge of the bed.

'Thanks,' she smiled, and now she was stretching the neckline of the dress upward in some vain attempt to minimize the cleavage on show. 'Actually, I'm in a bit of a rush.'

'Oh, okay.'

'What?' she smiled. Feeling guilty? 'You don't like the dress?'

'Oh, I *like* it...'

She laughed. 'It's just a dress. It's warm in those nightclubs...'

'Right.'

She leaned in to kiss him, and he breathed in an all-new perfume. Nice. Sweet. Exotic. Designed to make men notice her from across a room.

Adam's cock throbbed in his pants.

He figured this was all part of Marriage 2.0 working to amplify his desire for her. He could roll with that.

'Don't wait up. I might be home a little late,' she said, kissing him again. Her kiss was warm, affectionate, reassuring — and seemed to promise him something would happen on her return.

He watched her leave, gave her a little wave from the doorstep. Stayed there until she'd gone around the corner to the elevators, his analyst's brain working on the problem.

He was curious.

Suspicious?

He was also turned on. Was Marriage 2.0 trying to make him jealous? Making him notice her, desire her, by engineering some vague suspicions that she might be going out with her friends to a nightclub to dance with other men. And maybe make him think she'd be tempted to fool around with one of them.

But Melissa wasn't the type to *cheat*.

She'd always been a fiercely loyal wife, while her generally conservative upbringing had made the idea of a broken marriage anathema.

As the evening progressed, he felt increasingly sure that Marriage 2.0 was purposefully playing the jealousy card. It was a logical way to drive a man's desire in a woman, wasn't it? Some might even say it was cliché. The stuff of Hollywood romcoms.

It reminded him of the articles his sister always used to read while they were in high school and college. *How to Keep Your Man*, *How to Make Him Crazy About You* and *Five Ways To Ensure He Never Leaves You*, things like that. Make him jealous, and he'll want you more and more, they used to say in those magazines.

And yet Adam wasn't, strictly speaking, *jealous*, was he?

Sure, there was an underlying tension within him. Waiting for her to come back, lounging around the apartment. He couldn't stop thinking about her. About what she might be up to. But that wasn't jealousy, was it?

The strange thing was, part of him hoped she really was attracting attention from other men. Making other men desire her. Perhaps even that she would dance with other men.

That wasn't jealousy, was it?

It was definitely building up his desire for her, though. All credit to Marriage 2.0 — what they were doing was clearly working.

It made him feel reassured. Whatever happened, it was part of the program. It was designed to strengthen their relationship.

Would it be that easy?

As he waited for her, Adam couldn't help trying to work out how their Experience was being put together. He sat there watching NCIS on the TV, taking in nothing of what was happening in the world of Naval criminal investigation. He thought about how Marriage 2.0 must have told Melissa what to wear tonight, might even have suggested she check that her new outfit fit properly using their bedroom mirror.

They had positioned her so that Adam could watch her dress.

God, but they'd really been playing the long game. It had been weeks since she'd started going out regularly with her friends again.

Still, you had to hand it to them. It might be a cheap trick, but it seemed to be working for Adam tonight.

Later, still unable to do much other than think about what Melissa might be doing on her night out, Adam wandered aimlessly into their bedroom. He caught the lingering whiff of her new perfume, and, after a brief search, found the bottle in the bathroom. 'Captivating,' it was called.

It looked expensive. Imported.

Back in the bedroom, he casually glanced through her drawers. Along with underwear he recognized, there was plenty he didn't. New items. Sexy items.

He fished out a little white lace thong. Then an even tinier black silky g-string. Wow. He put it to his nose and smelled the clean scent remaining from the laundry detergent. Did that mean she'd worn these already? They'd been washed.

She hadn't worn them for *him*.

His heart stepped up a gear, beating twice as fast. In amongst the hose, he found thigh-high stockings. Sexy as hell.

Was this Marriage 2.0 messing with him?

Perhaps Melissa had started her 'Experience' so much earlier than him just so she could get all this shopping in. Did she actually wear any of this stuff, or was it all a prop for their Experience? Did she wear it at work? On nights out with her college buddies? He had heard that sometimes wearing sexy underwear made a woman *feel* sexy, more

confident. That it might improve her career by fostering a general confidence boost, even if she never showed it to anyone else.

He calmly sifted through a few of her other drawers, not really knowing what he was looking for. Was he invading her privacy? A little. But it wasn't as though any of these drawers were locked.

He opened the little drawer in her bedside table, and his heart froze.

There was a little box of Trojan-brand condoms just sitting there toward the back. Where the Gideon bible might be if you were staying at a hotel.

What was she doing with a box of condoms?

They had been trying for a baby. They had been going through IVF. Why would she ever need condoms for sex with her husband?

The answer was, of course, she wouldn't. She'd never mentioned condoms to him — not once.

Adam felt his heart pounding against his chest wall as he picked the box up. The condoms were supposed to be 'Ultra Thin for Ultra Stimulation.' Box of three. He opened it and found only one condom remaining.

That made him gasp, audibly.

Suddenly every breath he took in seemed to be cold, like the temperature in the apartment had suddenly dropped ten degrees.

Had she actually cheated on him? Or was this merely Marriage 2.0 continuing to mess with him?

He was trembling. And yet, at the same time, he was hard as a rock.

If this was Marriage 2.0 trying to play the jealousy game, it was working. He was clearly being made to feel so insecure at the possibility that Melissa might be tempted by some other guy that his subconscious was making him sexually aroused.

Was that how the jealousy thing worked?

For Melissa, if he was jealous it would no doubt demonstrate his love for her, and that would reinforce her feelings for him. It might even fire her libido, knowing how much he wanted her because of all this.

But why were these suspicions getting Adam hard?

After another sit-down, he felt a little calmer.

He was pretty sure she wouldn't actually cheat. Marriage 2.0 wouldn't set anything up like that, would it? She was just toying with

him. This was some kind of role-play thing to get him all revved up.

It was all calculated by the Marriage 2.0 program. Melissa was only doing what she'd been told to do by a program they'd both signed up for — and all this was based on extensive tests of their preferences.

So even if she danced with other men in a nightclub somewhere, it wasn't Melissa's fault.

Whatever happened, it was all *consensual* — on both their parts.

That night, Adam was in bed and asleep before Melissa came home.

His dreams were filled with thoughts and images from that evening: watching his beautiful wife changing into secret, sexy lingerie that was far too provocative for a simple night out with the girls; her drawer full of new underwear; the box of condoms stowed in her bedside table.

His dreams were blended into a sense that Melissa had been very, very wicked — and that it was all his fault because he had agreed to sign up for Marriage 2.0.

Marriage 2.0, that new kind of marital therapy program, which must be behind Melissa's infidelity, if that was what it was.

Marriage 2.0, which had tested them both and had developed their Experience based on their own personal sexual preferences and fantasies — whether they had been aware of them before testing, or not.

When Melissa came home, and he was awoken by the sound of the front door opening and closing, Adam was lying in bed with the most monumental erection.

It took him a moment to return to full consciousness — and a moment for him to realize that most of what he had been dreaming of was not merely a dream — it had really happened.

Was Melissa cheating on him?

Had she been told to do it?

Why did it turn him on so much?

Here was Melissa, walking into their apartment in those high-heeled shoes. *Click-clack, click-clack*. And here she was, appearing in the doorway. There was enough light coming in from the city, and the street lighting outside, to reveal her. She was wearing the same outfit she had gone out in.

‘Hey sweetie,’ she said, smiling but perhaps slightly surprised. ‘I didn’t think you’d still be awake.’

‘Hey,’ he said, trying not to sound suspicious or excited or any of the other mixture of emotions he was feeling. Then he offered her a little white lie, ‘I couldn’t really sleep.’

She slipped off her shoes, and brushed her long, straight black hair out of her face before stepping into the room.

‘I’m sorry I’m so late... it was Ashley’s birthday... so... you know how it is...’

Adam pulled back the bedsheets and pulled himself out of bed, craving her. Well, if this was Marriage 2.0 manipulating him to desire her like this, then so be it. He felt kind of obligated to go with the flow.

‘We were having such fun. I couldn’t believe it when I saw it was past midnight...’

He pulled her to him and kissed her mouth, surprising her with his demanding attitude. Her lips were soft, warm, sweet. But kissing her was somewhat surprising.

He expected a hint of wine or liquor on her lips as he tasted them — and instead, he got the gentle mint flavor of chewing gum... or toothpaste. And as he kissed her, he breathed her in, and while the scent of her perfume was expected, the fresh shampoo smell from her hair was not.

He realized he probably wouldn’t have noticed it if he hadn’t already been suspicious.

Where was that slightly stale scent from a night out? The hint of perspiration from dancing at a nightclub, or even from walking between venues. The subtle smell of cigarette smoke, liquor, the characteristic odors from a night out? Melissa was just a little too fresh.

He could envisage that she might have reapplied her makeup and her perfume before returning home, but how did she still smell of shampoo? And he wouldn’t have said it was her usual brand of shampoo.

She moaned and seemed to melt into the kiss, kissing him right back, her hands trailing over his body, as his own kisses wandered down her soft neck.

Her skin was just too clean. It was as though she had recently stepped out of the shower. And yet, even the most eccentric nightclubs in the city didn’t have shower facilities.

Had they gone back to one of her friends’ apartments? Ashley lived in Chelsea, not so far away. It wasn’t so strange that they would go back there to chill at the end of a night out.

But why would Melissa feel the need to take a shower before coming home?

Adam felt horror and dread brewing inside him, flaring out of his burning suspicions. And yet he was also strangely excited. The adrenaline was pumping through his system.

His manhood was still hard as a rock — something it didn't take Melissa long to discover.

She squealed as her hand brushed over it.

'Oh my *God...*' she breathed. 'Is this really for *me*?'

She broke apart from him, a dry grin spreading across her face. Her hand returned to his hardness, her fingers splaying over the massive bulge in his sweatpants.

'Uh-huh,' he said, smiling despite his tangle of feelings inside.

Melissa glanced down to check that her hands were not deceiving her. Adam enjoyed how her eyes widened, and her jaw dropped.

'You missed me *this much*?'

Well, it had been a while since he'd been this hard.

Was he turned on by *jealousy*?

But how could it be jealousy if it made him feel good?

Melissa let out a little delighted laugh as she gripped hold of his hard-on. Adam vaguely wondered if she thought him stupid for not realizing she had been cheating on him. He felt that little itch to correct her — he wasn't stupid, he simply needed time to untangle the feelings he had regarding her cheating.

Right now, his main feeling was pure, unadulterated sexual arousal.

Melissa didn't need much of a prompt to figure out what he needed in this moment. She was sinking to her knees now, her hands on the waistband of his sweatpants, tugging them down.

There was a hunger in her that he hadn't seen for a while.

He was confused why she'd be so horny for him if she'd been sleeping with someone else. Was she merely acting, to cover up her crimes?

'You've been at the club all this time?' he asked her.

She gazed up and beamed ear-to-ear as she slowly drew his sweatpants and boxers down to unveil the full extent of his erection.

‘I told you... it was Ashley’s birthday... we were celebrating,’ she said, still marveling at the size of his hard-on. ‘Things just got a little out of hand.’

She let his cock nudge up against her face as she pulled his clothes down the rest of the way, and ushered him to step out of them.

‘You had a good time?’

She grinned, ‘Yeah... well, you know... when the four of us get together... *beware*.’

She slid one hand over his balls, and the base of his cock, stroking its tip with her cheeks, apparently unable to take her eyes off it.

‘Mmm...’ she said, almost purring. ‘You’re in the mood tonight, honey!’

Her tongue flicked out, and then she was tracing it along the underside of his cock, swirling it around his tip as though his whole manhood was made of ice cream. She moaned as she took the tip inside her hot mouth, and sank down on it, her pretty brown eyes gazing up at him, registering his reaction.

She’d never been particularly into oral sex, he would have said. And yet here she was, exploring his dick with her mouth as though she’d never been allowed to touch one before.

‘Mmm... your cock is so *hard*,’ she murmured in between sucking on him.

He noticed that he could watch her in the full-length mirror beside them. Wow. He couldn’t see much of himself — just his legs and crotch — but Melissa was in full view, and because it was from a different angle, it seemed almost as though she was sucking on someone else’s cock.

Had she sucked on someone else’s cock earlier tonight? Or any other night since they’d started this Experience of theirs?

Even thinking about the possibility fired up the jealousy inside him, if that was what it was that made his stomach flutter and churn, his limbs tingle, his hairs rise up on end — and, of course, his cock throb.

How could jealousy feel so good?

‘Mmm...’ she grinned, noticing his cock pulsating in her hands. ‘What’s gotten you all fired up tonight?’

Had Marriage 2.0 told her to cheat on him? Was that why she wasn’t allowed to tell him about anything they instructed her to do?

Was his secret fantasy a cheating wife?

He could think of no other explanation for her having showered before returning home at 1am. And yet, at the same time, he wasn’t

putting much effort into coming up with an alternative theory. Almost as though he *wanted* her to have cheated.

She had cheated. Another man had fucked her tonight. And now, the knowledge of it drove Adam's jealousy crazy — and that made him so unbelievably horny.

And here he was having his cock sucked by his cheating wife, and it was insanely hot.

He glanced at her in the mirror. Did she have her other hand tucked between her legs? Was she *getting off* on sucking his cock?

That would be a first.

'You were with your friends *all night*?' he asked her now, as though he wanted to stir his own jealousy, that getting the suspicion out there would fire things up even more.

'I told you, honey,' she said between mouthfuls, 'it was Ashley's birthday. We were celebrating.'

He put his hands on her head, showing her the best rhythm, and it was like he was fucking her face. She seemed to like it.

'You're wearing *stockings*?' he said, since he could see in the mirror that her dress was riding up — the consequence of her hand being down there, touching herself while she sucked on him. He could see a band of flesh between the top of her stocking and the bottom of her dress.

'Mmm-hmm,' she confirmed, continuing sucking on the tip of his cock for a moment, squeezing his shaft with both her hands now.

Then she gazed up at him and smiled, saying, 'I was *told to*, honey. I mean... I'm not supposed to say anything to you, am I? But I assume it was because when I got home... *you might like it*...'

Why did he feel vaguely disappointed that she might have been told to wear stockings *for him*?

Was she telling the truth about that?

What if she'd been told to lie about this?

Melissa gave his cock one last lick as though she couldn't do without its flavor, then slowly pulled herself onto her feet, standing in front of him. Saying, 'Why, *is* it something you like, honey?'

She dragged up the hem of her dress to give him a flash of her legs in those stockings, flaunting herself in them.

'I do,' he said, 'but you could wear them for me any time. Doesn't have to be on a night when you're going out to a nightclub...'

She smiled, and now she was slipping the straps of her dress off her shoulders, pushing the thing down to reveal the black lace of her

bodysuit, the high arches over her hips, the narrow band of material between her legs.

‘Are you *jealous*, honey?’ she grinned, dropping her dress to stand proudly in her sexy lingerie. ‘Is *that* what all this is about?’

‘I was watching when you put that on. I saw you through the kitchen window.’

She smiled, enjoying knowing that he’d watched her dressing up in her scandalous lingerie.

He said, ‘You dressed in sexy underwear... and then you went out to a *nightclub*...’

There was a glimmer of amusement — and excitement — in her eyes as she approached the bed.

‘Have you been jealous, thinking about me *all night*?’

She leaned over him, her silky black hair coursing over his thigh and hips before brushing it back so she could kiss his hard cock one more time.

‘Ohh...’ he moaned as she slipped the end of his manhood inside her hot mouth and sucked.

Had it all been a set-up?

She’d dressed up in sexy underwear merely to give him the impression she was going out to a nightclub to be sinful. She’d had him imagine she might be seducing other men, perhaps even picking some guy up, going back to his place. Doing things that meant she needed to shower before returning home to her husband. But maybe she’d faked it all.

There was something reassuring in that.

Marriage 2.0 had set it all up. True enough, it had piqued his interest. It had made him see his wife in a new light. It had stirred his desire for Melissa. The program was working as it was supposed to work.

But now, he felt disappointment that it was all merely a set-up.

Strangely, that threatened to take the edge off his arousal right now.

Melissa pulled back from his cock and glanced up at him. ‘What did you think I was *doing* all night?’ she said softly, teasing him with her eyes as she stood up again.

‘I’m a *good* girl. You know that,’ she added innocently, before resuming her duties sucking his cock.

Why did he so want to believe she had gone off with a guy from the nightclub. Perhaps checked into a city hotel somewhere. Thinking about that got his pulse racing again, got the adrenaline flowing.

What if there hadn’t been a night out with the girls at all?

What if she'd started an affair with somebody from work?

She hadn't met up with her friends. She hadn't been rebuilding her social circle over the past weeks. She'd been seeing someone. Flirting. Dating. Going back to his place.

Fucking.

Cheating.

Now that made him hard. Hard as a fucking rock.

Adam sat up and opened his eyes wide at the realization that he really *wanted* his wife to cheat on him. He wanted her to be unfaithful.

It was insane.

But it was also insanely *hot*.

Melissa looked up from between his legs. She'd noticed his cock getting supremely hard again.

'You're *so* fired up tonight,' she said, in awe. Then she added, 'Maybe I *like* making you jealous...'

He said, 'Tell me what happened at the nightclub.'

But she replied, 'I'm *not supposed to tell you*.'

Now he was making himself jealous again, his arousal was flaring up again.

He trusted Melissa, didn't he? Anything she did, she was doing at the behest of Marriage 2.0. So even if she was cheating on him, he couldn't exactly blame her, he couldn't fault her. They had both consented to do as Marriage 2.0 instructed them during their adventures, or press the 'STOP' button if they really objected to what was happening.

Melissa turned around to flaunt her cute butt — and that scandalous thong back of her bodysuit, bending away from him to push herself back over his lap. He pushed up his cock to touch it between her buttocks, making her moan again. She giggled, then reached behind to stretch the material aside, allowing him to touch the tip of his cock against her pussy. She was so hot down there, so wet already.

She moaned again and pressed herself down on his lap, taking his cock inside her beautifully tight, wet pussy. She gasped as he filled her, purring as she took it all in until she was seated on his lap, wiggling her hips with him inside her.

Then she was groaning as she began to bounce up and down on him, starting up a thrusting motion, though all he had to do was sit there.

‘Oh... God... your cock is *so* fucking hard, honey...’

He watched his cock sinking into her, and found himself thinking that she’d done this already tonight, with someone else. He was goading himself with mental images of her cheating on him.

The thing was, he liked being this hard for her. He was proud. She clearly enjoyed it. And it wasn’t so hard to make himself feel a little jealousy. It was better than Viagra.

‘Oh... fuck... fuck... ah... oh yeah...’

Her sighs and moans became panting, whimpers. Was he making her come already? Wow.

‘Oh *fuck*...’

She was shaking on him, quivering. And then her moans came back down in pitch, her motion slowed. Had she come already?

She stood up and turned around. ‘I like it when you’re jealous, honey,’ she said.

He rose to his feet too, kissed her, tempted to deny he was simply jealous. As though he needed to protect his masculinity. Ordinarily, perhaps he would have piped up. But now, there seemed little point in denying that he was jealous. Or that it made him hard like nothing else.

She grinned and took a step back, a step to the side, closer to the bed. She flicked the straps of her bodysuit off her shoulders and peeled it down to reveal her bare breasts, her dark, stiff little nipples.

‘You haven’t fucked me like *that* in ages...’

He said firmly, ‘You dress like a *slut*... you go out to a nightclub until way past midnight...’

She pulled her hair back, out of her face, off her shoulder, and then lay back on the bed, parting her stocking-clad legs, pulling aside the band of black lace again to expose her glistening pussy.

‘And you thought what?’ she said, stroking her pussy with her fingers. ‘That I was out dancing with other guys at the nightclub?’

He stood in front of her, pushing his hard cock down to rest against her pussy.

‘Did you think I went *home* with one of them?’ she said, breathing heavily, holding her underwear aside to give him easy access.

‘Did you think I’ve been *cheating* on you?’

Then he slipped his cock back inside her, eliciting a groan from her mouth.

‘Oh yeah...’ she moaned as he held her stocking-clad thighs and began to thrust into her. ‘Oh my *God*...’

He loved how alive she seemed, how bright and excited her face was, how wide her eyes seemed, the way she was so surprised and impressed at him as he thrust into her again and again with his hard-to-the-max cock.

‘What’s gotten *into* you?’ she said, gasping for breath, writhing around under him, her breasts heaving. ‘Is this because you think I’ve been... fucking someone else?’

And he couldn’t help it when she said that, he was throbbing inside her, fighting to avoid coming early.

She giggled briefly, but then he was fucking her so forcefully that she just had to lie back and pant for breath. He pulled back, so tempted to ask her why she had smelled so shower-fresh when she’d gotten home after a full night out. Insinuating that she *had* cheated.

But now she turned around to present her rear to him again, this time with her lying on the bed. And he just wanted to fuck her, hard, like some kind of animal. Had she cheated? Part of him wished she had. He pulled her underwear aside and plunged his cock back into her, making her yell, ‘Oh *yes*...’

It wasn’t long before he was shooting thick jets of come deep inside her.

Thinking, as they collapsed in bed together, panting for oxygen and drifting off to sleep, that he preferred to trust her. But admitting to himself that it had been fun to be jealous of her, to imagine she had been away being a naughty girl.

The following Thursday, Adam was home late from work after a meeting involving a team out on the West Coast ended up running well past seven. He didn't usually mind working late — his company allowed flexible hours, so if you worked late into the evening, you could come in a little later the following day.

But Thursday night was Melissa's regular night for going out with her friends — or, as Adam had come to believe, her regular date night with whomever it was she had started an affair.

He felt a little aggrieved to arrive home only to find that she had gone already — and this time, he had not been able to lurk by the kitchen window and spy on her getting dressed in sexy lingerie for her night out.

Nevertheless, she had gone out. That was the important thing. And of that, he had no doubt. Getting in through the front door of their little apartment in the Village, he could still detect a faint trace of her date perfume in the air.

In the bedroom, she hadn't entirely closed the bottom drawer of her dresser properly — the drawer that held her new collection of elegant and highly erotic lingerie. It hadn't been that way this morning. To Adam, it confirmed that she must be wearing something special in terms of her underwear.

Her office attire from that day was heaped in the laundry basket. He remembered her putting the outfit on that morning — the pale blue shirt, black pencil skirt, plain white bra. He picked up her matching white panties and found they were still warm and damp.

She must have left not so long ago.

She must have been a little aroused before she'd gone. Thinking of what — her lover?

Adam pressed the soft cotton against his nose and inhaled her spicy scent. He could hardly believe she was actually cheating on him. It was so wicked. And so unlike the loyal woman he'd married.

And yet, it turned him on like nothing had before.

He couldn't blame her — she was doing what she was told by Marriage 2.0, right? And Marriage 2.0 knew precisely what turned him on, which was why they were making her do it.

Melissa was cheating on him — and yet she hadn't broken their trust, because all this was part of a marital counseling service they had both agreed to use.

Adam breathed in the aroma of her arousal and, with his spare hand, gently stroked his hardness through his pants. If he'd been a typical husband, and she'd been a typical wife, he would probably have been distraught right now. He would have been angrily pulling her clothes out of the closet, tossing them out the window in a jealous rage.

But he had no reason to be angry at her. She was doing what she was supposed to do.

She was out having fun, enjoying a night out with a little male attention that did not come from her over-familiar husband. Adam liked to think that she was having fun. That she was excited about meeting a new guy, spending time with him, receiving his compliments and his roaming eyes, and ending up in bed with him.

Adam liked to think of her being wicked with another man.

Adam liked to think of someone else kissing her mouth, holding her breasts, lying between her thighs, and sliding his big dick inside her soaking wet pussy.

She was blameless, but that didn't mean she wasn't naughty.

It felt strange, enjoying her infidelity. He didn't entirely understand why it did turn him on so much. But he wasn't going to deny it or pretend to himself that it was something else.

It was like eating a delicious cream cake, knowing it was sugar-free, fat-free, calorie-free.

But at that particular moment, he was shaken out of his sexual stupor by the bleep-bleep of his phone. A text message had come in. From you-know-who.

Marriage 2.0: Answer the phone.

He looked blankly at it. Answer the phone? What phone? What on Earth did they mean? Had something gone wrong with the program?

Then, a moment later, the phone rang in his hands. He almost dropped it from surprise. He didn't recognize the number — and usually

would have declined the call, assuming it was some kind of robocaller demanding he get in touch with a debt collector or vote for such-and-such a candidate, or sign up for a new broadband plan. But after that text message, he had to answer it.

‘Hello?’

‘Adam! It’s Carson!’

It took him a moment to register the name and the voice. Of course. Carson, his old college buddy.

‘Uh... hey, Carson, how’s it going?’

‘You still going out tonight? It turns out I *am* available!’

He remembered calling all his friends the other week — trying to restart his own social life, since Melissa had apparently restarted hers. Back before he knew she was simply having an affair.

Well, now he felt like Carson had caught him on the hop. He felt he could hardly turn the guy down — that would be a slap in his face, after he’d been so keen to persuade Carson to get a drink together for old times’ sake.

‘Uh... that’s great! You fancy a drink or two? Would be *great* to catch up!’ He said.

Well, Melissa would be out for a while, anyway. And perhaps he needed a little distraction from the knowledge that she was probably out fucking someone else.

‘Hell yeah. You guys still in the Village? We should hit the Half Pint...’

And why not? Back to the old haunt from their NYU days.

‘Eight o’clock?’

Eight o’clock. Adam was there, but Carson was not. Ten minutes later, he still wasn’t there. Another phone call.

‘Jesus, you wouldn’t believe it. One of those damn bike messengers slammed into my taxi. Cops need me to stick around, give them a statement.’

Adam sighed, but he didn’t mind so much. He got himself a craft beer and a table in the back, and checked up on the Mets on his phone.

He just couldn’t bring himself to feel bad on a night when Melissa was out being sexy as hell. He could wait forever and a day if it meant thinking about what his gorgeous wife might be up to.

He was just finishing his drink when Carson sent him an apologetic text message saying that the bike messenger was pressing charges against his taxi driver, and the cops wanted him to go down to the Precinct for a more detailed interview.

Adam sent back a message saying he'd wait, not to worry. Then he headed to the bar for a second beer.

Before he got halfway to the bar, he froze in his tracks.

At the bar, a dark-haired woman wearing a breathtakingly short dress turned her head to smile flirtatiously at the tall man standing beside her — and Adam saw that it was Melissa.

He caught his breath and took a step back, a jolt of shock shooting through his heart.

It was undoubtedly her. And yet the way she looked at the guy was not an expression Adam recognized from his wife. She gave him a quick, barely-perceptible up-and-down glance as though to size him up as a possible suitor — and then flashed him a devilishly wicked smile.

Adam couldn't hear them talk, but it was easy to guess what kind of thing they were saying.

'Hi, I'm Melissa.'

'Hi. I'm Dan.'

Dan. Chad. Ben. Tom. Could have been anything. Tall, blond, blue eyes, and the poise of a quarterback. The kind of guy who would have had his pick of the girls in high school and college.

'Nice to meet you, Melissa.'

Adam took another step back, his heart starting to thump like a toddler with a new drum.

Jesus. It was really her. She was wearing fishnet stockings, for God's sake. Her dress looked like someone had sprayed it on her — and run out of paint before finishing.

She was casually fiddling with one of her earrings as she spoke to him, and it made her look strangely girlish, almost submissive, and undeniably open to something happening with this stranger at the bar.

It wasn't the kind of body language he'd ever seen from Melissa — even when they'd first met.

Now she was playing with her hair, subtly drawing his eyes to her long, jet-black locks, getting him to admire the feline lines of her cheek along the way. Nodding at whatever he was saying as though giving him consent for wherever he wanted this to go.

Giving him the kind of look that said she was fascinated by him, thrilled by him, open to him.

Adam stumbled a little as he returned to his seat, making it look as though he was still checking the baseball stats.

He was hard as a rock, sitting there, watching Melissa letting her new friend get close, brush a hand against her bare forearm as he regaled her of some anecdote to impress her.

But this wasn't some guy from work. This wasn't an old flame she'd run into.

Melissa wasn't having an affair. She was meeting a stranger in a bar.

Adam felt his erect cock throbbing within his pants.

He had to look away from the whole flirtation thing for a moment — as though it was too rich for him, too powerful all at once. Too sweet. He had to calm down, he was going to have a damn heart attack.

Everyone else in the bar was oblivious to what was going on. Chatting, drinking, laughing, nodding, conversing. Many of them were on the young side — this was still a haunt for NYU folks.

No one even noticed the hot chick at the bar hitting on the stud former football star.

Of course they didn't. It was nothing out of the ordinary — just a girl interested in a guy. They looked good for each other. They were both pretty fine-looking human beings.

It wasn't as though either of them was wearing a wedding ring.

Adam was transfixed — though he tried his best to conceal the fact that he was watching them from across the room.

Any ordinary husband would be incensed, enraged, on his feet, dragging his wife away from the bar before he could even take another breath. But Adam was *excited* by seeing her with him. He *wanted* this seduction to go well.

But why should he feel bad? He was here because Marriage 2.0 wanted him to be here, right?

He probably wouldn't have answered Carson's call unless Marriage 2.0 had told him to — it must have been his friend's office number, a number he didn't have in his contacts.

Melissa had been told to do this. Adam had been told to be here to watch it. Neither of them was in the wrong — this was an Experience. A perfectly calibrated adventure that would drive them both wild for each other.

Adam caught his breath again as he saw Melissa put a hand on the quarterback's shoulder, pawing him through his thin, tight t-shirt as though overtly checking out the goods. Assessing his athletic qualities. Evaluating his potential as a lover.

‘Somebody sitting here?’

Adam looked up. A young woman in a floral print dress — pretty, bookish, lovely eyes under her black-rimmed glasses, plenty of freckles — was standing over him, arching her back to make sure he noticed her cleavage.

‘Uh... no...’ he said.

God, she would have been just his type when he was in college. Except she probably would have been more interested in other guys. Older guys. Oh.

Adam felt himself blushing as she made herself comfortable in the seat opposite him, flashing him a smile that said she was interested in more than just a place to temporarily rest her bones.

The glint in her eye said she was intrigued by him. Why couldn’t this have happened to him back in college?

But now he wasn’t interested. He felt a little bad for her. He also felt a little guilty about letting her sit here — though it struck him that if Melissa was currently at the bar flirting with a guy she might even sleep with, he shouldn’t feel guilty about sitting with a woman who was not his wife.

‘So you live around here?’ the young woman asked. Her hair was dark, but he could see a hint of red in the light.

God, he would have liked her in college.

‘Uh... yeah, not far.’

He almost forgot to look back toward the bar — and when he did, he was startled to find the spot where Melissa had been hitting on the blond studmuffin empty of either of them.

A rapid swiveling of the eyeballs, and he caught sight of his ravishing wife leading her suitor by the hand out of the bar.

‘Uh... sorry... got to go,’ he said to the pouting young woman at his table.

And as he fled the scene, he heard her calling out after him, ‘You want my number?’

His heart was racing as he emerged onto the street; he felt a rising sense of panic. It didn’t seem entirely logical — what was he afraid of? He wanted this, didn’t he? Melissa looked like she was getting lucky tonight.

But he couldn’t suppress the powerful anxiety.

Looking up and down the street, he couldn’t see them. Where were they going?

Then he caught sight of the ex-quarterback getting into a taxi on the street corner. Was Melissa already in there with him? She had to be, right? She wasn't anywhere else out here.

Where were they going?

He thought about trying to get a cab himself. *Follow that taxi!* But this wasn't the movies. There weren't any taxis available — only a couple within sight, and they all had their lights off.

Adam sighed, texted Carson to say he hoped it was going all right with the police, but he was going to head home now, maybe they could reschedule.

Then he wandered home, shuffling along on a cocktail of emotions — disappointment that he didn't get to see Melissa with her evening's date anymore, excitement that she might be doing something wicked with him later, apprehension that she might not make it home all night. Fear, perhaps, that she would like the football stud so much she wouldn't come back to her husband.

Hope that she would make it home soon after fucking the guy.

She wasn't home by midnight.

Adam started to worry. Had he been a complete idiot, knowing she was out at night on her own? She wasn't with friends, she was dating a stranger. Had they met on Tinder, on some kind of dating app?

She'd been told to do this by Marriage 2.0. They wouldn't ask her to do something that wasn't safe, would they?

Was the stranger she'd met even real? Perhaps he was an actor, someone sent to meet her by Marriage 2.0, someone performing a role. Perhaps Melissa wouldn't even fuck him — she just pretended to flirt with him at that bar, because Adam was there.

Adam had been asked to be there by Carson, in a phone call Marriage 2.0 had prompted him to take.

Was Carson even real? Marriage 2.0 could have pretended to be one of his old college buddies, no problem.

Maybe Melissa wasn't cheating at all. She'd been faking it all along. She went out on Thursday nights and went shopping, or to the movies, or something. Perhaps she did even meet up with friends occasionally.

But he'd been led to believe she had been hitting the bars, meeting up with strangers from Tinder. Sleeping with men as though she was single.

Adam lay awake for a while, feeling disappointed at the prospect that their whole Marriage 2.0 Experience had been fake — a fake designed to get the two of them passionate about each other again.

But if all of it was fake, and Melissa had been pretending to cheat on him, how would that persuade Melissa to rekindle her desire for him?

Where did her excitement come from if she was having to fake all this? How was her passion for sex renewed if she had to pretend to cheat on her husband?

Adam lay there in bed, tossing and turning, staring at the ceiling, thinking that Melissa couldn't possibly be pretending to cheat on him. The only rational explanation was that she was genuinely being told by Marriage 2.0 that she could flirt with — and sleep with — other men. And in her eyes, it would be okay if Marriage 2.0 told her to do it because it was all part of the program. They had both agreed to do the program. The program was based on both of their personal preferences and sexual fantasies.

She would assume she was doing this because it would get them both interested in each other again.

She would feel all of it was consensual on his part as well as hers.

Even if she was the most loyal wife, why would she hold back from enjoying the thrill of extramarital sex if she was confident it was all okay with her husband?

He wasn't sure what time it was when he heard the front door open. Its hinges needed oiling.

The sound of the front door closing again roused him from the shallow sleep he had slipped into after so much time dwelling on the same thoughts and logical progressions.

Now the critical question in his mind came into sharp focus: had she cheated tonight? Or had she merely pretended?

He turned onto his side, facing away from the bedroom door, lying the way he usually did when he slept. He didn't want her to think he'd been having trouble sleeping, he didn't want her to believe he'd been having concerns about her being out so late.

But he was listening intently as she came into the room.

He heard her hesitate as she crossed the threshold of the bedroom, as she first laid eyes on her husband again. She paused for a few moments.

What was she doing? Was she worried that he'd know what she'd been doing? Perhaps that he'd detect the scent of shampoo in her hair, the telltale soapy cleanliness of a recent shower at somebody else's place.

She crept into the room. It was a cool night, the noisy air conditioner in the window was switched off, so he could hear her breathing — and she sounded nervous.

Had she cheated?

Had she fucked that tall, gym-toned quarterback guy?

Adam tried not to move, not to react to the thoughts now whirling around his head again — though his manhood was certainly responding, filling with blood, thickening, stiffening.

He heard the silky soft sounds of her removing her clothes as quietly as she could.

He felt her peel back the sheet as carefully as possible, trying her utmost not to disturb him.

Was she hoping he remained asleep until the morning, that he would wake with no idea what time she'd finally made it back home?

He felt the mattress depressed as she climbed into bed and slid in beside him.

He quietly breathed in and detected her scent — but to his surprise, it wasn't the uplifting floral notes of a freshly-showered woman he smelled. There was still a hint of her perfume in the aroma that now filled his lungs — but it was blended with the earthy musk of an active female. A *sexually* active female.

It took him a few moments to really get his head around the scent.

The smell of sex.

He subtly savored her unusual scent as she lay down and pulled the sheet back into place over herself. It wasn't the gentle funky of a sweaty workout at the gym — though sweat was undoubtedly part of it. There was the unmistakable spice of female arousal there, but there was also something wholly unfamiliar to his experience.

It took him a few moments to realize it was cologne, a cologne he would never be caught dead using. Cologne and the smell of a man.

You couldn't fake this.

Melissa had cheated on him. This time, she hadn't showered after doing so.

Adam's heart was pumping so fast and so hard, it was a wonder the whole bed wasn't shaking. The longer he lay there, the more certain he was that she'd done it. And the more certain he was that she'd done it,

the more excited he was — and the more he wanted to physically take Melissa, reclaim her for himself.

Was it too late to initiate something with her? Would she be too worn out after fucking a tall, blond stranger all night?

A faint smile spread across his face. She couldn't *admit* to being worn out by too much sex.

He slowly turned over onto his back as though her return had roused him from sleep. He turned toward her. She was facing away from him, her shoulders bare — was she lying there naked? She didn't usually sleep in the nude.

He stared at her for a few moments, taking in the delectable lines of the back of her neck and her shoulders, inhaling that strange, unfamiliar scent — in awe that she might have actually slept with another man that night.

He was just burning up inside, desperate to start something with her.

Would she know he knew she'd cheated? Would she think him pathetic for allowing it, for *enjoying* it?

Maybe the safest thing would be to just let her sleep. Pretend to be asleep himself. Let it go.

But then Melissa slowly turned onto her back, then onto her side to face him, her dark eyes connecting with his.

'You were out late,' he said quietly.

She nodded. 'Uh-huh.'

Was she regretting whatever happened? He could see her thinking, processing what had gone on that night, perhaps pondering whether she should tell him.

He smiled. 'You had a good time?'

She smiled. Nodded.

He tugged on the sheet, and it fell away from her to reveal her full nakedness. She was breathtakingly beautiful in the dim light. The scent of sex on her strengthened, saturating the air around them. She could sense it, and though she tried to hide it, he could tell she was suddenly afraid.

He breathed her in, savoring her infidelity.

Then he leaned in to kiss her, gently but tenderly, with warm love and affection. She seemed uncertain about it at first, but as he persisted, her resistance seemed to melt — and then his kiss flared into heated desire.

As she gave in to his kiss, he felt her hand brush against his throbbing manhood — again, uncertain at first. Feeling how hard he was for her, she gasped and pulled away from their kiss.

‘I missed you,’ he said, smiling.

Her pretty face broke into pure delight.

‘I missed you,’ she said, her hand finding his, guiding it between her thighs, showing him how wet she was.

Now it was his turn to gasp, as he felt the wetness of a woman who had already enjoyed sex that evening. Full sex, with another man.

She seemed to think he’d believe she was simply so very wet for him, that she wanted him so badly. Let her think that. Let her think whatever. He wanted her so badly that he didn’t mind what she thought of him.

‘Hey — !’ she squealed as he turned her onto her back, and kissed his way over her chest, past her stiff nipples, and down her flat stomach.

But she could hardly stop him. She couldn’t tell him not to do that, because she’d already had sex with someone else.

He could sense her apprehension as he moved between her thighs, though she couldn’t stop him. She moaned as he kissed her down there, but her entire body was tense, as though she was prepared to flee the moment he realized another man had been there before him.

And yet, as he settled there and pressed his mouth against her freshly-fucked pussy, groaning with contentment at her wickedly tangy flavor, she seemed to relax into it.

God, it was just incredible. Another man had squeezed his massive cock into her here, drawing out her sighs and moans as he penetrated her most intimate place.

His beautiful wife was the most thrilling adventure he’d ever known.

All week, he could hardly take his hands off her. It seemed that Melissa felt the same way about Adam, too.

When they got home from work, they would greet each other with a kiss, and invariably, it would turn into something — on the couch, or in the bedroom.

They'd end up making love, quickly, passionately, urgently, until that desperation for each other was satiated. Only afterward would they remember they needed to eat something for dinner.

She made Adam hard the moment he saw her. He couldn't detach her presence from the constant thought that she was cheating on him. He couldn't see her without remembering how it had felt to watch her flirting with the blond guy at the bar. How she had been when she'd returned from her evening of illicit extramarital sex.

It didn't matter if he got home from work first, or if she did. The moment he laid eyes on her, he had to take her in his arms, breathe her in, taste her lips, crush her chest against his. And when he did that, she opened herself to him, melting into his embrace, kissing him back with the same feverish desire.

It was wild.

It felt like validation for their decision to go to Marriage 2.0. It felt like they'd turned a real corner in their relationship. Sex was no longer the chore it had been while they'd been trying to conceive. And their excitement steadily built through each week to the Thursday when Melissa went out on her 'girls' night out.'

Was this the solution to their problems? Melissa would get to go out once a week and bang other guys? And Adam would know she was doing it, even though she seemed to believe it was secret from him, that she was *cheating* on him.

She was cheating on him, and yet it wasn't really cheating, was it? He wanted her to do this. And Marriage 2.0 was telling her to do this. He didn't need to be jealous or angry about it, he could simply enjoy it.

Usually, adultery would destroy a relationship. How could a husband ever trust his wife again if she went behind his back and fucked someone else?

But this was all consensual. Melissa wasn't being malicious, she was doing as she was told. It was all part of the program.

No trust was being broken.

The following Thursday, Adam was late home from work again — it was a busy time of year.

Melissa was already gone by the time he arrived home, but there was evidence that she'd been there, changed out of her work clothes, and had gone out again. The smell of her new perfume still lingered in the air throughout their little apartment. Her work clothes were heaped in the laundry pile in the bedroom — including her underwear.

His cock was hard, smelling that perfume. It throbbed as he saw the discarded panties he knew she'd worn to work.

Had she changed into sexy lingerie again? It was proof she wasn't going out with her friends, she was going out to meet someone. A guy.

The box of condoms in her bedside table drawer was now empty, but there was now another one in there, a larger container. It gave him a real thrill to see more evidence of her secret wickedness.

But it made him wonder what Melissa thought was going on with him. She was being given the chance to sleep with other guys — there was no question that would be exciting for her. But did she honestly believe he didn't know what she was doing? The last time she'd come home late on a Thursday night, the stench of sex, and of another man, had been all over her. She'd done nothing to conceal it.

Did she know her cheating turned him on?

She had to. Why else, in her mind, would he be suddenly so interested in sex again? Nothing else had changed in their relationship other than her Thursday night adventures.

Adam pressed Melissa's panties up to his nose. They were still a little damp, and there was no mistaking the scent of her arousal. Even before getting out of her work clothes, she'd been excited about tonight. He felt

a strong urge to pull out his cock and relieve the tension that had been building inside him — but he resisted the temptation.

He wanted to save himself for when she got back.

Somehow, he had to keep calm and wait. He flipped on the TV, ordered pizza. He even cracked open his laptop and looked at the latest numbers his source at FedEx had sent him just before the earnings call the following day. Made some notes. Jotted down some questions he would want to put to Fred Smith, or Raj Subramaniam, or whoever else was on the call.

All the while, he was watching the clock slowly plodding on toward 9pm, 10pm, 11pm.

How late would she be out tonight? Should he simply go to bed again? She'd come back to him when she was ready.

11.30.

His phone buzzed. Stupidly, he thought it might be Graham or Barnaby, over at Linas. Because they often rang him before the FedEx call to see if he had the raw numbers yet. But it wasn't Graham or Barnaby looking for the company results. It was a message from Marriage 2.0.

Adam's heartbeat paused momentarily.

He opened the message.

Marriage 2.0: *There is a black Prius downstairs waiting for you from Uber. Get into it.*

It startled him. Over the past week, he'd gotten the feeling that their sexual problems had been solved. The program had been a success. Melissa would occasionally cheat on him, and Adam would enjoy knowing she was being unfaithful.

He'd assumed their Marriage 2.0 program was done. Over.

But now, it seemed, it wasn't.

Adam leaped to his feet, grabbing his wallet and keys on his way out of the apartment. His heart was pounding faster than ever, and he was a little breathless on the way down the stairs. And, sure enough, the car was waiting for him out on the street.

Well, it wasn't difficult to book an Uber in this day and age.

'Hi, I'm Adam?' he said as he climbed into the car.

The driver simply gave him a little nod, and then they were pulling away from the curb, driving west, and then north up to East 14th, and then west again all the way to Chelsea.

What was he doing? Where were they going?

His heart was beating sharply, anxious, as he mentally searched for some kind of explanation.

In Chelsea, the Uber car halted in the middle of a relatively innocuous residential street, and then parallel-parked into a rare space. Adam waited a moment or two, figuring they might be early for whatever it was Marriage 2.0 was taking him.

Adam pulled out his phone to see if there had been another message. Nothing.

When he looked up again, he watched in stunned silence as the Uber driver switched off the engine, unbuckled his seatbelt, and got out of the car.

‘Uh... we’re stopping here?’ Adam asked, but the driver ignored him, closing his door behind him.

Adam unfastened his own seatbelt and reached for the handle of his own door. The door did not open.

‘Fuck,’ he hissed, tugging on the door handle to no avail.

The fucker had just left him here. Locked in.

‘Hey!’ Adam yelled.

What the fuck was going on? Where were they?

He glanced all around. There wasn’t anyone out on the street. It was a fairly quiet neighborhood — cars parked on one side, ash trees dotted along the curb providing a kind of ceiling for this street of tidy brownstones.

‘Help!’ he yelled. ‘Heeeeelp!’

After a while, he tried to calm himself down. Breathed deeply. This was all part of the program, he told himself. This was Marriage 2.0. He was having an adventure, that was all. He didn’t need to panic — an explanation for all of this would emerge in time.

He waited.

To distract himself from the sense of claustrophobia he got from being locked in this vehicle, he thought about what Melissa might be up to. Had she met another stranger at a bar? Or perhaps she was seeing the same guy from last time?

What if she met someone she genuinely liked? What if she started seeing another guy regularly?

Adam felt a flicker of insecurity and fear as he considered the possibility of Melissa forming some kind of long-term connection with a man she dated. What if the guy was charming, wealthy, seriously good in bed?

Despite the fear, the thought of Melissa being with someone else made Adam rock-hard as he sat in the otherwise empty Uber.

Marriage 2.0 would never engineer an Experience in which Melissa decided to leave him for someone else. Not permanently. He had to trust that. They had signed up for a program to strengthen their relationship, not wreck it.

Strangely, though, the sense of anxiety and fear surrounding Melissa's Thursday night adventures only made Adam feel increasingly turned on.

He waited twenty minutes, gazing at the screen of his phone. He could have called somebody — a friend, Finn, Melissa. He could have called the police, for God's sake. He could have called Uber to complain about their service.

But he trusted that this was all part of the Experience.

He waited.

A yellow taxi pulled up across the street. A young man got out. Late twenties, probably. Snappy dresser. Adam thought about hammering on his window, calling out to the guy for help. But then his heart stopped as he saw the highly familiar form of Melissa climb out of the taxi, too.

It was definitely her. There could be no mistake, even this late at night, in a neighborhood where the streetlight was filtered through the trees.

'Oh Jesus, Oh Jesus, Oh Jesus,' Adam murmured as he saw the man link up with her on the sidewalk, then escort her up five steps to the front door of the nearest brownstone.

The guy even had his arm around her waist as they went up the steps.

Who was he? Someone she'd met that night? Or someone she'd known for a while? Someone from work? He was obviously doing okay if he could afford an apartment around here.

Melissa had looked so sexy in the little dress. She'd seemed so excited when she got out of the car — anticipating going to bed with that guy. Adam loved seeing her like that. Surprisingly, he felt a strange sense of pride that this other guy — this athletic, stylishly-dressed, affluent younger guy — was so keen to take her to bed. Yet she was *his* wife.

He watched them go inside, trembling a little.

What was he supposed to do? Was tonight's adventure simply the act of watching Melissa go back to another man's place? To know for sure she was cheating on him?

He had to admit, it was a thrill, even this much.

He peered at his phone. No new messages.

Tick tick, tick tick. How long would it take them to fall into bed together? Would there be coffee and small talk first? A glass or two of wine and some chit-chat? Or were they pulling off each other's clothes the moment the front door closed behind them?

Adam tried to keep calm. His chest was rising and falling with fairly heavy breathing. He counted his heartbeats. Ten. Twenty. Thirty.

What would Melissa think if she knew he was here, waiting outside?

It was getting quite warm in the car, all sealed in. He tried the door handle again, and this time it opened. Well, that was a relief. He climbed out of the car. It was a humid night, but it felt good to breathe in the warm air, free of confinement.

He supposed they'd wanted to keep him in the car while Melissa arrived and went inside with her date. But what now? Was he supposed to just go home?

Just keep breathing.

He wandered down the street a little way, more to stretch his legs than anything. His erection wasn't subsiding. What was Melissa doing at this moment? Were they having a drink, chilling, chatting some more? Or were they making out already, stripping off, fucking?

He was teetering on the edge of deciding to go home. To request his own Uber vehicle back, or search for a taxi. But then his phone was buzzing, vibrating in his hands.

He didn't recognize the number calling him — but he answered it anyway. Something was going on, so he figured perhaps someone from Marriage 2.0 was calling him to let him know what he was supposed to be doing.

For a moment, though, he jammed the phone against his ear, and there was nothing on the other end of the line.

He was about to hang up, but then he heard the unmistakably wet sound of two people kissing.

His heart skipped a beat.

He stopped still on the sidewalk, listening intently.

He heard a soft rustle, which could have been the wind, though his gut feeling was that it might very well be the gentle sounds of clothes being stripped off.

There wasn't any wind in this street, anyway. The air was utterly still.

Now he heard a quiet moan. Two people moaning, in fact. Two people who were strongly aroused and impatient to release their pent-up lust.

Adam's cock stiffened to full attention again.

He went back to the car. It was still unlocked. Better to get in off the street, he figured.

Seated in the back of the vehicle, he put the call onto speaker, and rested the phone on the seat beside him as he listened to the couple making out, touching each other, getting naked. The early stages of foreplay. And, of course, his initial assumption was that he was listening to Melissa and her date. However, it would be easy to fake something like this.

The more it went on, though, the more he felt it was Melissa.

What else would she be doing in there with a guy she just picked up at a bar, or via Tinder? She wasn't simply going through his record collection while sipping a glass of Chardonnay.

Adam stroked his cock through his pants while he listened. He wanted to believe he was listening to his wife and her lover. She was really doing it. She was cheating on him. She wasn't pretending to sleep with someone just to make him jealous.

He heard her whispering, 'Yeah... oh yeah...' and it sounded like Melissa, like someone was exploring her breasts with his mouth.

Was she naked? Was he naked?

The couple went quiet, briefly, and then the woman moaned.

'Oh my *God*...'

Adam felt his cock throbbing, so erect it almost hurt. It sounded so much like Melissa. The way she was moaning... did he have a finger inside her?

'Oh, *God*...'

They went quiet again momentarily, then there was more kissing. The rustle of pants being pulled down. Another kiss, a few sighs... and a low grunt from him told Adam in unmistakable terms that Melissa had taken her lover's manhood in her mouth.

It was shocking and yet intensely thrilling to hear the wet sounds of her lips on the man's cock, his grunts of pleasure, her little moans of

excitement.

Then she said, 'I love your cock... you have such a beautiful cock...'

And there could be no doubting it now. It was Melissa that Adam was hearing, bobbing up and down on another man's cock, moaning through the excitement of handling fresh cock, the thrill of pleasuring a man who had no marital obligation to respond well to her, of making the guy groan like that, helpless before her.

It went on for a long while. Melissa never did this very much with her husband. And yet here, she couldn't get enough.

Then, finally, the pair of them parted, gasping for air. Had the guy come in her mouth? But they weren't stopping. They were moving, panting. And, after a few moments, Melissa gave a loud gasp and started moaning as though... as though the guy was going down on her.

'Yes... yes... oh my *God*...'

He was listening to another guy sucking on his wife's pussy, and she sounded very wet.

'Oh... huh... huh... oh my God...'

Adam envied the guy. And yet she was Adam's wife. He could march in there at any time and demand what was his, right?

Melissa's panting was getting louder, and her moans were more like cries, shouts, yells. She was gasping, squealing, almost screaming.

'Oh, *shit*... oh my God... oh Jesus...'

Adam had never heard anything like it. She was going wild. She'd never been like this with him before. Perhaps it was the situation — she knew she was cheating on her husband, she knew she was being a bad girl. She was reveling in it.

'Come here...' he heard her hiss, and suddenly Adam's heart was pounding quicker and quicker.

Was she about to fuck the guy?

Adam heard the rustle of bodies moving on a bed, and more heavy breathing. The guy whispered a quick, *fuck yeah*... and then Melissa was uttering the kind of slow, deep moan that came from the guy's cock sliding into her soaking pussy.

'Oh yeah... oh... oh... oh yeah... oh... oh... oh my God...'

The breathing, the movement, the moans, it all aligned into a single, slow, and deliberate rhythm at the kind of pace that confirmed that they were fucking, had just started. And if Adam would put money on it, he would have said *she* was riding *him*.

'Oh fuck... fuck... fuck...'

There was the sound of bodies crashing together, but it was her bouncing up and down on him, Adam believed, rather than him pounding into her. But then, the rhythm accelerated, and got to the stage where he couldn't tell who was on top of who. They were just fucking, unmistakably fucking, and really going at it.

Grunting, groaning, gasping for breath, their bodies slapping against each other as the man's big dick thrust over and over into her eager, adulterous pussy.

Then, '*Fuck... yes... fuck... oh... shit...*'

Was she coming *again*?

After a while, it was difficult to determine exactly what they were doing or in what position they were doing it, though the wet sounds of penetrative sex seemed to be a constant.

Adam listened for a full hour, riveted. Touching himself, though afraid to let himself go completely — he didn't want to make a mess in somebody else's car. Reluctant to even pull his cock out into the open to properly jack off to the sounds of his wife being unfaithful. He didn't want some bystander on the street catching him.

Nevertheless, it seemed like the most incredible hour of his life.

It was just fundamentally stunning to him. *Melissa* was cheating on him. *Melissa* was *cheating*. It was stunning. And his own sexual response to the evidence could no longer be denied.

Melissa was cheating, and it turned Adam on like crazy.

It got so intense he was on the verge of throwing caution to the wind and whipping his dick out right there and then. But then everything suddenly went silent, or as silent as a night in the city could be with the hum of distant traffic, the occasional roar of an engine, a far-off emergency siren.

Had the sex finished?

What now?

Adam felt a stab of panic. Was she done for the night? Was she going to suddenly head home? What would she think if she got home and Adam hadn't made it back before her?

What was the fastest way home from here? Uber? He could run back to 8th Avenue, see if he could grab a yellow cab. How would *Melissa* get back? Probably Uber. She could book it, and come straight down, hop in.

He could text her to say he'd gone out for drinks with people after work. That he hadn't thought they'd all stay out so long.

He was about to do so when another message came in from Marriage 2.0.

Marriage 2.0: The code is 3259.

What the hell did that mean?

He felt like he'd missed something. He felt a little stupid. They wouldn't send him instructions he wouldn't understand, would they?

He looked to the front of the Uber car. Could you type in some kind of code somewhere and start the car? Could he drive himself home? The driver seemed to have simply abandoned the vehicle. But there was nowhere to input a code. It was a fairly ordinary Prius, and not a particularly new one at that.

He searched through the Marriage 2.0 app. There was nothing here that needed a code.

Adam sighed and slumped back in his seat. Marriage 2.0 wasn't supposed to be an intelligence test, was it?

Why would they have sent him a code, now? Had Melissa set up a code on her mobile phone, and Marriage 2.0 wanted him to have access to it when she returned home? Perhaps she had taken pictures, or even recorded video of her infidelity. Adam's manhood thickened again at the thought of that. But iPhones used a six-figure security code these days, didn't they? So it couldn't be a code to get into Melissa's phone.

He glanced across the street at the building in which Melissa was — he hoped — still within. His heart jumped a little as he saw the metal keypad beside the front door.

No... surely not?

But it was the only thing his tired mind could think of that might require a code like the one he'd been sent.

Heart pounding, he got out of the car and crossed the street. He could hardly believe he was doing this. What would he do if the code worked, if he gained access to the apartment where Melissa was sleeping with another man?

As he approached the door of the building and that cold, metal keypad, the question was, what did Marriage 2.0 intend for him to do?

He took a deep breath and typed in the code, 3259. There was a little click, a little high-pitched buzz, and then a louder click from the door as it was unlocked.

God.

Adam pushed on the door, and it actually swung open to admit him to the tidy little entrance hallway. He stepped inside. Now what?

He walked up the stairs, though he had no idea where he was going, or what he'd find when he got there. He had no idea what he was supposed to do. His phone buzzed in his pants pocket. Another message.

Marriage 2.0: Third floor.

Uncanny. Were they watching him? Were there cameras in this building? But he had bigger things to consider. He climbed. Second floor. He kept his feet light on the terra-cotta tiled steps, shuffling at a minimum, trying to be as silent as possible. He didn't know what he was supposed to be doing, but he was keeping his options open. Perhaps he was only supposed to spy through the keyhole or something. Maybe the program only needed him to confirm, with his own eyes, that his wife had been unfaithful.

Third floor. With one apartment per floor in this building, there could be no doubt as to which place Melissa was in. Adam's heart seemed to be beating in his throat, he could feel every pulse. He stooped, peered through the keyhole.

The door opened as he touched it.

Adam nearly jumped out of his skin. Was he supposed to go in?

His mind reeled.

If he stayed out here, there would always be the possibility that Melissa had not been cheating on him for real — that, somehow, it had all been faked. If he stepped into this apartment, and perhaps even caught his wife in the act of being unfaithful, there would be no turning back.

This would confirm her infidelity.

And perhaps it meant she would know for sure that he knew she had been cheating on him.

It reminded him of the choice offered to Neo in *The Matrix*.

You take the blue pill, the story ends, you wake up in your bed and believe whatever you want to believe. You take the red pill, you stay in Wonderland, and I show you how deep the rabbit hole goes...

Adam took a deep breath and stepped into the apartment.

The apartment wasn't much different from the places Adam had lived in as a college student at NYU, except that someone had spent money on the place. He slipped inside the front door to find dark hardwood floors, well-lit interiors, and bright paint on the walls that wasn't cracked or stained. Stainless steel appliances and white marble counters in the little kitchen just past the entrance.

As soon as he heard the soft moans coming from the bedroom, he stopped thinking about how it might have been for him to be a wealthy college student.

Three steps past the kitchen into an unexpectedly spacious living room, there was a half-open doorway off to the right where he could see the bed.

And he could see parts of two people on the bed — two people who were unmistakably naked, and unmistakably in the middle of having hot, sweaty sex.

Adam felt his rock-hard cock straining to escape his tight pants. Throbbing with each moan that escaped the lips of the woman in the bedroom.

The woman who sounded distinctly like Melissa.

Was it really her?

His heart was thumping so hard it hurt a little. His breathing was getting so deep it was getting close to gasping — and yet it seemed difficult to get enough oxygen in this faintly humid air that smelled of perspiration and perfume and the palpable funk of intense and prolonged sexual intercourse.

'Oh yes... yes... just like that... God...'

Her soft voice raised the hairs on the back of his neck. He took two more steps closer to the bedroom door, thanking the heavens that

whoever had refurbished this apartment had put in floors that did not creak.

Melissa was having sex with another man. Right there in the bedroom, yards away.

The confirmation of his wife's infidelity was just stunning — it felt like someone plunging a fist into his chest before pulling out all his organs — despite the fact that he had been almost entirely sure of it before coming into this apartment.

But here she was, on all fours, wearing lacy scarlet lingerie — the color of scandal — while a man knelt behind her and plunged his huge, hard, glistening cock repeatedly into her soaking pussy. The blond guy Adam had seen her flirting with in the bar, the guy who looked like he might have been a college quarterback a few years ago.

Melissa was wearing a black blindfold — but while it obscured part of her face, there was no doubt it was her.

His wife was cheating on him. He could see her doing it. It was the most terrible, and most wonderful thing he had ever seen.

How could she do this to him?

Answer: she had been told to by Marriage 2.0.

Did that make it okay?

Adam was shaking as he stood there watching. Adrenaline was blazing around his body, through every blood vessel.

He'd fantasized about this very thing happening. He'd hardly stopped thinking about it since the possibility had emerged, and yet he was surprised by the sheer intensity of the cocktail of emotions he was now feeling.

He stepped closer still, so that he could hear the wet, slurpy sounds of the man's colossal dick thrusting into Melissa's dripping pussy, and breathe in the thick musky scent of red-hot sex.

He felt relatively safe watching because of Melissa's blindfold, and the fact that the man fucking her was facing away from the door. He could even get close enough to see the man's impressive cock penetrating Melissa's eager pussy, her scarlet thong pulled to the side to allow access.

'Oh, Jesus... Jesus... Jesus, that feels so good...' she was moaning, sounding astonished at what he was doing to her.

As though she'd never had it so good.

Adam felt a tickle of jealousy, and for a moment or two, a knock to his sense of pride — she'd never complained about how it was with him. He'd never been bad at sex, had he?

And yet, strangely, after a few moments of feeling crestfallen while watching this gym-toned hunk slamming his massive cock into Melissa, Adam seemed to move *beyond* the jealousy.

He loved that Melissa was getting to experience sex like this. The way she gasped and moaned and buried her head in the mattress while this godlike man pounded her.

The way she wailed because the pleasure was so incredible.

Adam might not be at this kind of pornstar level when it came to sex, but he could let her find it in another man's bed. And if it meant she was happy when she returned to him, what did it matter whether he was as good in bed? They could still enjoy intimacy together.

And what he had with Melissa was different from this raw, rough, powerful fucking. She loved him.

The bottom line was that this was all part of the program. It couldn't damage their relationship — it was all calibrated to strengthen their marriage.

This was Marriage 2.0. Better than conventional marriage. All new and improved.

'Oh fuck... oh fuck... oh *fuck*...'

Adam leaned against the doorway. Melissa and her lover were really working it. It was like CrossFit training or something, they were really pumping hard — their muscles firing over and over, their bodies rocking, their flesh flushing, their skins glistening with perspiration.

It was just like they were at the gym. His wife was being worked out by a personal trainer.

Sex was just a form of exercise you happened to find pleasurable, right?

As Adam watched, the man pulled Melissa over so that he was still fucking her from behind, but they were both lying on their sides. Adam stepped back as the two of them were now facing the doorway. Although Melissa still had her blindfold firmly in place, and her lover's gaze was blocked by her body, Adam still felt more vulnerable.

But he couldn't pull back entirely. Couldn't tear his eyes away from the sight of his beautiful wife getting plowed. Her lover held one of her legs up, so Adam could see everything — Melissa's pussy so exposed as that huge shaft pumped at her from behind.

In that position, it seemed almost staged for Adam's benefit — so that he could watch everything.

Only when the man turned Melissa onto her back, and then lay between her thighs to enter her again, missionary-style, did Adam start to

feel confident that the guy knew he was there.

It was the way he held her legs open as he fucked her, the angle they were lying as he thrust into her. It was like a porn shoot, only Adam was the camera. He got the best angle to see the guy's hardness sinking into his wife's juicy pussy.

Adam started to feel more confident about being there, and less afraid of being caught by the man fucking his wife.

And strangely, he didn't feel remotely freaked out when the guy glanced over toward him and smiled.

Adam smiled back at him, for goodness' sake.

It seemed crazy.

He watched the guy withdraw from her for a few moments, peel off her soaking-wet panties, and casually toss them over to Adam.

Adam stood there in the doorway, feeling like he was in some kind of lucid dream. Pressing his wife's drenched underwear to his face, inhaling a chestful of her spicy scent while another man allowed him to watch him forcefully fucking her.

The most unexpected thing was the intense feeling of love he felt for his wife. How could that be, when she was cheating on him right in front of his eyes? And yet, he loved that she was so into it, that she was so sexy, that another guy was so hard for her. He loved that she wasn't the conventional loyal wife who would settle for less than incredible sex. He loved that after tough times, they'd gone to Marriage 2.0 to work on their relationship, and now she was doing something that turned him on like absolute crazy.

It wasn't logical to feel love like this. It wasn't quote-unquote normal. But he couldn't deny it.

Melissa's lover turned to him again and offered another encouraging smile as he continued sliding that big, wet dick inside her. Then he flicked his head, nodding toward an armchair sitting in the corner of the room. Suggesting that Adam sit and make himself comfortable while he watched his wife cheating.

It was so ludicrous, it almost seemed funny. But Adam shrugged, and nodded, and smiled back — and took the chair.

Why did he love her so much more because of this? Because she clearly loved this man's big dick — she was moaning about it now as he plunged it into her.

'Oh, it feels so good... oh it feels too good... your big cock... you fill me up... oh... so good...'

Adam watched them change position so that Melissa climbed on top, riding her lover, who had encouraged her to face her husband while she did so. She was just magnificent. The graceful lines of her body, the tensing of her muscles as she worked her pussy on that monumental shaft, the perspiration that glistened on her skin, and mussed her long, black hair.

Adam had been stroking his hardness through his pants, but now gave in to the temptation to unzip his fly and release his erection. Melissa couldn't see, and her lover was lying on his back, not looking this way.

He held his cock in his hands and stroked it while his wife's wet pussy pumped another man's dick.

'Oh... oh... oh... oh my God... oh my God...'

Then she was trembling as she rode him — he'd never seen her do that before. She was shaking like she was caught in an earthquake, moaning as the energy of her climax shook her.

While her orgasm was still ongoing, Adam watched as her lover grabbed hold of her with both arms, and hauled her onto the bed before entering her again from behind, though her body was flat to the mattress.

It wasn't long before his whole body tensed up, and Adam could tell it was the end.

Adam stood, heading for the exit, fearing that Melissa would see him once everything was over. But as he carefully edged toward the door, her lover turned to look at him, and seemed to get the impression that Adam wanted to see this finale up close.

The man shifted so Adam could see his big dick plunging into Melissa. He tensed up again, pushing himself over the edge, and Adam felt a strange fascination to see him come inside his wife.

Melissa was moaning, 'Come for me... come for me... come inside me... please come inside me...'

And that in itself almost made Adam come himself.

But then he was watching Melissa's lover give the kind of grunt that could mean only one thing — another man was coming inside Adam's wife.

Adam had to hold onto the wall to brace himself. Melissa reacted with clear delight as this stranger emptied himself inside her, clutching her waist as he rammed that massive tool into her a final few times while shooting his cream deep within her pussy.

The thought crossed his mind — what if he got her pregnant?

Melissa wouldn't be so foolish as to let another man fuck her bareback, not without some kind of birth control. But the thought was disturbing in a whole new way.

Adam had frozen to the spot, watching this man firing his cream into his wife, then slowly withdraw, a last few jets of come splashing over her bare behind.

He only shook from his daze when the man passed by him in the doorway, patting him on the shoulder, murmuring to him that he was a 'lucky guy.'

He was just stunned at what he'd seen — and thrilled.

But as he stood there processing the tangled mixture of feelings from watching his wife cheat on him, he was too slow to react to Melissa turning onto her back to remove her blindfold.

'Adam!'

She squealed his name, startled, shocked, horrified. She grabbed the sodden bedsheets to hide her nakedness, as though it might somehow shield her from his discovering her infidelity.

'Hey,' he said, not knowing what to say, feeling confused — aroused, yet fearful, excited, and somewhat embarrassed.

'What are you... doing here?'

God, she looked good, her face glowing from sexual satisfaction, her smooth skin shiny from perspiration, her hair messed up in a manner that screamed *sex*.

'I was told to come here.'

It was all he could think of to say. It was the truth, after all. It wasn't exactly *his* fault he was here, that he had discovered her fucking someone else, that he had watched her cheat on him.

It was all part of the program.

Somehow, that was what put the icing on the cake for him: there was nothing to blame either of them for, it was all arranged. It was Marriage 2.0. This was their personal sexual fantasies made real, in a manner that suited them both.

Melissa was still shocked and a little upset, however, and Adam felt a little sorry for making her feel that way.

'I thought you... I mean... I didn't think... I mean, I *assumed*...' she stammered, blushing furiously.

‘It’s — ’ he was about to tell her it was all okay, that he knew she was only doing this because she’d been told to. That *it was their adventure*.

But she interrupted him, blurting out, ‘*They set me up!*’ before breaking down into huge sobs, her face screwed up as the tears began to roll down her cheeks.

‘No, no, it’s not like that,’ he said, taking a step toward her, though not really knowing what to do.

She sat up, pushing herself back against the pillows, knees drawn up under her chin, crying like they’d just shot Bambi’s mom.

‘It’s okay... it’s all just part of the program...’

Yet now he felt embarrassed. What if she thought ill of him, because he had been turned on knowing she was cheating on him, that he had been acquiescent to it all, that he had willingly — eagerly — watched another man take her?

‘They... told me... every step of the way... the messages...’ Melissa blubbered, her elbows planted on her knees now, her hands sweeping into her hair. ‘I guess I assumed... *you* were doing it *too*...’

That made him splutter a bit. ‘*You* thought *I* was cheating?’

He realized, as soon as it came out of his mouth, that it sounded pretty negative. And using that word, ‘cheating,’ was somewhat more judgmental about her recent behavior than he really wanted it to be. He didn’t blame her, after all. But he said it, and he couldn’t take it back, and it made her cry more so that he couldn’t even make himself heard enough to correct himself and calm her down.

‘I thought this whole thing... was supposed to be... based on our secret fantasies,’ she said, in between huge, gasping sobs, although she was beginning to pull herself together a little so that she could make some sense with what she was saying.

‘I think it was...’ he said, trying to be reassuring, but he wasn’t entirely sure she was listening to him.

‘...I mean, maybe it got the test results mixed up... or made some mistakes... you know... interpreting our feelings...’

‘I don’t think...’ he said, perching on the bed beside her. But she really wasn’t listening.

‘...But now... I mean... how could *divorce* be one of our fantasies?’

Her use of the ‘D’ word shocked him. How could she have jumped so far ahead as to start thinking about their relationship ending? She had always tried to think too many steps ahead.

‘I don’t think *divorce* is part of this adventure,’ he said, and for the first time since first seeing him there, it seemed that she took in what he

said.

‘But they’ve set me up... and now they’ve brought you here...’

He shook his head. ‘I... I...’ he was searching for the right words. ‘I’ve known... for a while... that you’ve been... you know, seeing someone else.’

She just looked across at him, surprised, confused.

‘I mean... it was a *surprise*, to start with,’ he said.

‘They *told* you about this?’

He could see on her face that the facts just didn’t compute for her. She couldn’t understand why he might have known about her affair and not said anything. Also, that their sex life had actually picked up since she’d been having her Experience. How could that be the case if he’d known all along?

‘They gave me enough clues,’ he said, trying to act calm.

‘And *you* haven’t been... seeing anyone?’ she asked, putting her hand over her mouth as though it might help her hide from him.

‘Of course not,’ he said. ‘Why would I need to see anyone else?’

‘I assumed they were telling you to do the same kind of thing,’ she said, sounding afraid but also somewhat relieved, as though her one big fear in life had been neutralized. ‘I assumed Marriage 2.0 was saying we needed a little... break from each other... sexually.... now and again...’

‘You did?’

It did seem entirely logical that Marriage 2.0 might be getting him to do precisely the same as her.

‘At first,’ she said, her sobs mostly gone now, ‘the thought that you would just go off and... you know... see someone else... made me all the more resolute to sleep with Carl...’

Carl. The man’s name. Adam felt his manhood throb. God, she was so sexy. Melissa, his wife, had been fucking a man named Carl.

‘But I never did,’ he said.

‘It made me kind of sick, thinking that you were seeing someone else,’ she said, even managing a faltering little smile, happy that he had proven himself the faithful husband, despite the opportunity to stray.

But then her face wrinkled again, and the tears were back, and she sobbed, ‘It’s so *unfair*...’ Then sorrow turned to anger, and she said, ‘We have to go back there, to Marriage 2.0. We have to tell them they were *wrong*...’

‘No, no,’ he said, putting a hand gently on her knee, trying to calm her down. Trying to get the truth out. ‘It’s not your fault...’

‘God damn right, it’s not my *fault*.’ But then the tears were back again, and she was shaking and crying and nodding her head and shoulders backward and forward, as though she was one of those bobbing head dog figures people put on their car dashboards.

Adam climbed onto the bed, stretched over to kiss the top of her head.

‘You don’t understand,’ he said. ‘I think they were *right* about me...’

‘I can’t lose you, honey,’ she said, ‘I *can’t lose you*...’

‘No, you’re not listening.’

‘I thought all this was supposed to be *good* for our marriage.’

‘It still could be.’

He kissed her cheek, tasting the slight saltiness of perspiration, smelling the dampness of her hair.

‘I think if you can find your way to forgive me...’ she said, her breathing all broken and staccato, as her diaphragm attempted to regain its pre-crying rhythm.

Adam put his hand across her knees, over both her hands, and the other arm around her shoulders, and squeezed her. ‘I think,’ he said, ‘I’ve discovered that it... turns me on... when you’re unfaithful.’

She looked up, her eyes locking on his sharply. ‘*What?*’

‘Ever since this started,’ he said, ‘and you were coming back from your nights out freshly showered...’

She looked at him again, surprised. Realizing how stupid she had been, and how observant he had been, because, of course nobody takes a shower before coming home from a straightforward night out drinking in bars and clubs.

‘...Ever since I figured it out,’ he said earnestly, at last believing he had her full attention, ‘I’ve been grappling with what it all means. Because I knew *you* would never cheat on me. Not ordinarily. But if Marriage 2.0 told you to... and they told me this was our Experience. And then thinking about you going out there... meeting someone else... being so... *naughty*... it made me hard as a rock.’

She raised an eyebrow, bemused, surprised, but also somewhat intrigued. ‘That was why you were so...?’ she asked him, alluding to how horny he always was when she came home from those wicked nights out.

He nodded. Smiled. ‘I was terrified, too. I mean, you know, you were having sex with someone else. What if you liked it better with him?’

‘Oh no...’ she said, but soon realized he didn’t need reassurance.

‘But I trusted you,’ he said. ‘And I knew this was our adventure.’

She nodded, breathed, the deep breaths of relief and gratitude.

He leaned in again, touched his forehead to hers, the tip of his nose to hers, gazing into her eyes. He could smell her perfume, and the other guy's cologne. He could smell cock. It was weirdly fascinating, strangely exhilarating.

'It turns you *on*...?' she said.

He kissed her lips, tasting the familiar sweetness, but also something else. Alcohol. Another man. Christ, it seemed so wrong — and yet as evidence of her infidelity, it was *so damn arousing*.

She kissed him back, and it seemed to help calm her down.

'You're crazy, you know that?' she said after a while.

'Yeah, I got that,' he grinned sheepishly.

Then she offered him the brightest smile yet. And he felt the unexpected recognition that Marriage 2.0 was doing exactly what it was supposed to: strengthening their bond.

'So, what now?' she said. 'I mean... I need to take a shower...'

Adam surprised himself, saying assertively, 'No, you don't.'

She looked at him, her forehead wrinkling with puzzlement.

He only urged her back, to lie there before him, and kissed his way down her neck, her chest, her stomach. He parted her thighs and lay between them, indulging in the strong smell of sex that pervaded her flesh, as he inched his way down over her mound to her pussy.

Melissa looked down at him, confused, but Adam felt an urge to take what he wanted, to claim what was his. And perhaps, he felt compelled to prove himself — that he was truly turned on by her infidelity, and that all this had improved their sex life.

He gazed upon her bare pussy, just stunned. There wasn't a hair on it anymore. She'd shaved it for Carl. She'd never done that for her husband. Adam lifted one of her legs, improving his access, and she rested her foot on the counter to hold it in that position.

He kissed her there, just beside her flushed pussy lips, breathing in that dark, wicked scent from between her legs, tasting the salt on her skin.

'What are you — ?' she said, but she wasn't preventing him from doing anything.

'I've told you,' he said, lashing her behind with his tongue, wanting to just eat her up so badly. 'It turns me on... what you've been up to...'

He ran his hand up the inside of her leg, her thigh, feeling a little shiver of excitement at how clammy her skin was, and then again as his hand wedged between her upper thighs and he felt how wet she was. He

pressed the tip of his thumb against her searing pussy, his whole body seeming to ripple with electricity at the thought that she'd just finished fucking somebody, Carl.

The guy's cock had been deep inside this very pussy.

He ducked down, wedged his face against her behind, between her cheeks, his tongue reaching for her soaking pussy. Breathing her in, and now, tasting her juicy sex.

'Oh *God...*' she groaned, confused but so turned on herself by his clear interest.

She lay back, wearing only that bright scarlet bra now, along with her black thigh-high stockings that gently brushed against him as he feasted on her.

'Honey...?' she said, asking him if he was sure about this.

Then, 'Oh my *God...*' she breathed as he began lapping at her juicy sex, tasting the weird, unfamiliar flavor of a wife corrupted by another man.

She moaned, her breathing quickly deepening as he sucked on her tainted pussy, as though his choice to go down on her like this proved his truthfulness when he said he was turned on by her infidelity — and that proof was the hottest thing she'd ever known.

Adam gazed up her exquisite body as she began writhing over him, her curves undulating and her breathing rapidly becoming panting. He'd never been so turned on going down on a woman before. Never been so thrilled to devour pussy, and it was because this pussy was so swollen, so red, so wet after being penetrated so vigorously by another man's big, hard cock. Something he had witnessed in the flesh.

'Oh yeah... yeah... oh... *please...*'

She seemed to forget herself; she seemed to let go of any tension, any fears she might have had about their marriage. She put her hands on his head and pulled his mouth firmly against her sex, grinding against him, spreading her wetness over his whole face.

He tasted her lover on her, of course. But it didn't bother him. It all blended in with her own juices, it was merely the taste of their adulterous sex, the flavor of her wickedness, the nectar of Adam's fantasy made real.

She came on his mouth — shaking and shivering, crying out as she clamped his head between her thighs so hard it almost hurt.

But then he was up, hard, ready to make her his entirely again.

He urged her onto her front, gazing at her delicious rear as she lifted her hips, presenting herself for him.

He remembered how Carl had taken her like this. But now it was his turn. He sank into her, making her squeal with delight, though he was smaller than her earlier lover. He slid inside her so easily, the way oiled by another man's come. It felt incredible, for both of them.

Then he was thrusting into her, plunging his own manhood into Melissa's well-used, well-stretched, dripping pussy, just *consuming* her adulterous body while she panted and cursed and wailed breathlessly.

After that, she was riding him, her bra cast aside, her breasts bouncing and her muscles flexing and her hair flailing all over the place as she fucked him, her body still sweaty and sticky from fucking the other guy.

They went in the shower, with Melissa pressing her hands up against the tiles while he fucked her. After she came like that, they slowed. Things became more affectionate, more intimate, and they were washing each other. At the same time, she continued to give attention to his hard cock even while they soaped up and attempted to get clean.

Then he was in her mouth, gazing down at her as she sucked on him, so much more deeply than she had before, like she'd picked up tips on killer blowjobs from her affair. Adam was gazing down at her, appreciating how beautiful she was and how hot it was that she must have done this with Carl, too, earlier that night.

Then he was grunting as the most powerful orgasm exploded throughout his body, and he was pumping his cream into her mouth, with Melissa swallowing only too willingly — again, something she had avoided before all this had happened to them.

And afterward came the wondering about where Carl had gone.

Fresh from the shower, dressed again, they realized that they hadn't really thought about Melissa's lover since the moment Melissa had lifted her blindfold. But this was his apartment, right?

Only, emerging from the bedroom, there was no sign of him.

'But this is his apartment?' Adam said.

Melissa said, 'I thought — '

Adam opened the closet in the bedroom. It was empty, apart from a couple of coat hangers. Likewise, the chest of drawers — empty. Bedside

tables — empty drawers.

‘We never spent much time in this place,’ Melissa said, pulling on her clothes. ‘You know... got back here pretty late, didn’t do much apart from — well, you know — ’

‘Fucking,’ Adam grinned, walking up behind her, his arms encircling her, his hands sliding down between her legs. She was wet again, already. He gently slipped a finger under her panties, dipped its tip in her moisture.

She wriggled free, laughing, but they were both ready to go at it again. Only curiosity kept them exploring the rest of the apartment, finding the bathroom drawers and cupboards empty, the clutter on the counter mere window-dressing. The kitchen cupboards were all bare, with two wine glasses sitting out in case of need, and a bottle of chilled wine lying in an otherwise empty refrigerator.

‘It’s all fake,’ Adam said.

‘He doesn’t live here at all,’ Melissa agreed.

‘Who was he?’

‘A trader, I thought. Finance guy. I met him through Tinder, using an account Marriage 2.0 set up for me.’

‘A trader, huh?’

‘But you know, when I asked him about those steel tariffs... and whether the Fed would cool it on the interest rates... you know, he kind of just looked blankly at me. Changed the subject.’

‘You think he was fake, too?’

‘You think they’d get an actor to start an affair with me?’

Adam shrugged. ‘It worked, didn’t it?’

She smiled, beautifully.

AFTERWORD

The original idea for this book came back in 2015, when I was re-watching one of my favorite movies, the hugely underrated David Fincher thriller, *The Game*. If you haven't seen it, then go watch it, you'll love it.

It made me wonder whether the whole hotwife/wife-sharing thing could be turned into some kind of a game.

And this actually translated into two different stories. The first became my novel *The Game*, published in December 2015. In that story, a husband and wife created their own game in which she would have an affair, or even several affairs, but wouldn't directly tell him about it—instead, she left him clues so that he could discover and monitor her erotic adventures with other men.

I enjoyed writing that story, although I'm not a hundred percent sure that I did the idea justice.

My second idea that stemmed from the David Fincher movie was that some kind of semi-mysterious agency, a new kind of marriage therapy service, could create adventures for married couples in which they would get to try out their secret sex fantasies in order to re-kindle their desire for each other and strengthen their relationships.

I think this concept also owes its existence to various stories written by Philip K Dick (for example, *We Can Remember It For You Wholesale*, the tale that became the movie *Total Recall*), and various stories within the Netflix show *Black Mirror* have also helped flavor the final book, not least giving me the idea that it could involve the stories of multiple couples, rather than just a single set of characters, as an anthology series.

The Frank and Jenni story, though, is an idea spun out of Fincher's *The Game*, with a billionaire signing up to the program to have an adventure that might somehow sort out the problems in his life. In my

story, however, Frank is much more of a family man, and his marriage is not already broken beyond repair.

With the Marriage 2.0 service, you could probably have all kinds of sexual adventures based on your own personal preferences—whatever floats your boat. For me, and I assume, much of my readership, the idea of sharing spouses, hotwives, and swinging type situations appeal, so that's the kind of stories I've developed here. In theory, though, there could be all kinds of situations, even monogamous adventures where husbands and wives aren't encouraged to stray, but could explore other desires, like dominance and submission, perhaps, or role-play, or some kind of fetish.

But deploying the Marriage 2.0 idea in this hotwife sub-genre means that the responsibility for driving forward the fantasy of wife-sharing or swinging is no longer saddled with either the husband or the wife. We get to explore a neutral balance to the fantasy. It's the central agency, Marriage 2.0, that gets the blame for everything. Since the

adventures are based on a 'scientific' assessment of the spouses' sexual desires, and they've all agreed to abide by the findings of the agency, it's all consensual. So there's no breach of trust if the wife (or husband) is instructed to actually have an affair, or something like that.

This, for me, deals with some of the key pitfalls of consensual infidelity in real life. The anxious first step for a husband in deciding to share his fantasy with his wife. The wife's fears that her husband simply wants to trip her up so he can cheat as well, guilt-free. The concern that the husband or wife won't be able to cope with the pressures of the fantasy becoming a reality. The potential for the wife's date to go wrong: will the guy turn up? Will there be chemistry?

All these issues, and more, can be resolved by placing blame or responsibility at the door of Marriage 2.0. You can have all of the pleasures of the fantasy without the potential problems. Sounds good, right?

That doesn't necessarily mean the characters won't still have personal anxieties along the way—we're only human, we're always going to worry about something. And maybe things could go wrong (who knows what will happen in Season Two?)—we're all familiar with even the most clever modern technology having bugs or glitches. Self-driving cars, for example, that manage to crash.

But wouldn't it be nice if there was some kind of app for married people to create real adventures for them to spice up their sex lives? Like Tinder for single people, or Grindr for LGBTQ people.

Sure, there's Ashley Madison, but that site and those like it are designed for spouses to use behind their partners' backs, to genuinely *cheat*. It's designed for one person to use individually, and meet other people for adulterous purposes. It's not a neutral service where both sides of a couple can attend for the purpose of strengthening their relationship, where they might not get involved in adultery (but if they both want it, maybe they will).

What's needed is a service that protects the trust in a relationship while allowing the couple to explore their desires. Perhaps there's an Elon Musk or a Mark Zuckerberg out there to start something like this. In the mean time, there's Marriage 2.0.

I hope you've enjoyed the book. What kind of story would you want to see in Season Two?

As usual, my thanks to you for reading, and also much gratitude to my team of editors and beta-readers—Anjali, Dan, Gary, Nick and Robert—who have ironed out the kinks (but not the *kinky*) and the inconsistencies. Thanks, also, to Kenny Wright, with whom I have discussed all these ideas ever since they first began emerging way back in 2015.

Now, go leave a review wherever you bought this book, so you can persuade others to read this story, too!

Until the next time,

Max Sebastian,

London, June 30, 2017

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

Max Sebastian is the Amazon-bestselling author of *The Madeleine Trilogy*, *What's Mine is Yours* and *A Lockdown Affair*.

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when she comes
back from her date.

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